

伪像报告

须尾俱全



虚伪聚钱®

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Chapter 1 — Mai Minghe: I Want to Pick More Daisies

When Mai Minghe woke, the room was dim and dark, and the light seeping in beneath the curtains was still the light of night.

She was a light sleeper, waking several times each night, but tonight the reason was different. A small, hard sound had pulled her from sleep, rising out of the steady "whooo—whooo" of the background noise that filled the room.

What was making that noise?

She was groggy with sleep, her mind slow to catch up.

The metallic scraping and clinking went on, until finally there came a sharp snap—the lock tumbled—and the door was pushed open with a long, creaking "squeeeak." The hinges had gone years without oiling; stiff and dry as an old person's joints, they sliced a sharp wound through the silent night.

Oh. Someone had broken in.

If her mother ever found out, there was no telling what kind of scolding was in store—a young woman living alone, and she couldn't even think to prop a chair against the door at night?

Her mother had always been uneasy about the world: checking the gas four or five times before leaving the house, peering into the back seat before getting into a car, never once letting her return a stranger's nod or smile.

Mai Minghe had always thought her mother was a bit too anxious—but here she was, someone actually breaking through her front door tonight.

The sounds that followed were hard to make out, but vaguely, a figure moved inside. Through the crack under the door, a beam of light swept back and forth—a flashlight.

Unfamiliar footsteps padded softly around the living room, occasionally drawing out a creak, and Mai Minghe knew: that was the wooden floorboard just outside the kitchen. A pipe had burst one year, and the boards there had warped from the soaking, ever since voicing their shrill complaints underfoot.

Having a burglar was actually a rather unusual thing.

She closed her eyes again and listened carefully to the burglar's movements.

He opened the door to the next room first—a very small, narrow room that had never really been used. It had once been painted as a nursery, then briefly served as a study, then been converted into a wardrobe room, yet not one of those purposes had ever truly been fulfilled; now it was simply a dusty storage room piled with clutter.

One glance would be enough to see that the room was heaped with nothing but junk, not worth rifling through—and sure enough, the footsteps retreated almost immediately, and the door was shut with a dull thud.

Honestly, if you searched the whole building, you'd probably struggle to find anything of real value.

Things did go missing often enough in this low-rent apartment building; once, when Mai Minghe hadn't latched her door properly, she came home to find a pair of ankle boots gone from the shoe rack by the entrance—it had infuriated her enough to knock on every neighbor's door, but nothing came of it. Still, lost things were one matter; it was rare for an outside burglar to actually pick a lock and go to all this trouble over people with so little to their name.

How funny—such a trivial thing, and she remembered it so clearly. Those boots had been calfskin, a smooth, polished brown, sharp-looking; she had never managed to find a pair she liked as well after that.

Whatever he wanted to take, let him take it—she didn't have anything worth making a fuss over anyway.

The burglar made his way to the bedroom doorway, pushed the door open, and the flashlight swept in, finding Mai Minghe at once.

The harsh white light pressed through her eyelids and lit up her face, yet she remained perfectly still, keeping her eyes shut, feigning sleep.

An unfamiliar voice let out a surprised "Huh?" as though actually taken aback.

Mai Minghe held herself still and kept quiet.

The burglar's footsteps thumped into the room; he circled around the bedroom, didn't even open the nightstand drawer, and went back out again.

Stealing things so carelessly—what could he possibly hope to find? Mai Minghe almost felt anxious on his behalf. You had to have a little patience in whatever you did, a willingness to see things through properly.

A minute or two passed, and he came back in, stopping at the side of Mai Minghe's bed; the warm, living breath of another person hovered in the air just above her.

"Hey," a man's voice said, and a hand gave Mai Minghe's bony shoulder a nudge. "Hey, wake up."

There didn't seem to be much point pretending to sleep any longer.

Why wake her up? If he was looking for something valuable, couldn't he just look for himself? Not only was he stealing things, he was being lazy about it too—people these days, honestly.

Mai Minghe opened her eyes. A dark silhouette was hunched over her at the bedside, looming above her head.

The flashlight was angled down along the edge of the bed, so the burglar's face was lost in shadow; at the rim of the light, she could just make out a pale throat, the Adam's apple rising and falling with each word.

"Don't be afraid, I just want to ask you something. Is there someone here by the name of Mai Minghe?"

"...That's me. Do we know each other?"

The man drew a breath and straightened up, taking in the shape beneath the covers.

"You—you're her?" He seemed unwilling to believe it, and raised the flashlight to sweep it over Mai Minghe's face several more times, without any ceremony.

She hadn't looked in a mirror for a long time and had no idea what she looked like now—certainly nothing good.

"What is it?" she asked quietly.

The man stood there with his mouth half open, as though still digesting something.

He didn't want her to be Mai Minghe—that much she could see; because he immediately asked again, as if she might not have heard him clearly: "Mai—the 'mai' in wild wheat. Mai—Ming—He."

"It's me," Mai Minghe said with a faint smile. "There's no one else."

The man stared at her.

After a few seconds, he asked: "Old lady, how old are you?"

How old was she? Even Mai Minghe had to stop and think.

She couldn't remember, from some year onward, how old she was—sometimes she even mistook herself for a young girl.

A year per year of age: it didn't sound like much, yet those years were like snowflakes falling thick and countless, each one an infinitesimal moment; without her noticing, they had accumulated into a lifetime.

Scoop up a handful of snow, and you don't know when it fell. A passage of life rises to the surface, and she has forgotten how long ago it came from.

The social worker had said that at her age—eighty-six—Mai Minghe's mind was still fairly clear, unlike some elderly people...

"Eighty-six?" Mai Minghe asked the social worker in her memory. "You must be mistaken. I'm not nearly that old."

The room fell quiet again, and the steady "whooo—whooo" of background noise rose once more.

The burglar seemed to notice it only now. He pointed at the small plastic tube inserted in Mai Minghe's nose and asked, "Is that... are you on oxygen?"

"Hm?" Mai Minghe sometimes forgot. "Oh, yes. It's quite a nuisance."

The burglar let out a sigh. He set the flashlight down on the edge of the bed, its beam casting a circle of light on the opposite wall, splitting the room—cutting out a bright ring of warmth, and leaving the rest to dim, heavy darkness.

"Look at me, I forgot to ask. Would you like some tea?" said Mai Minghe. It had been so long since anyone had visited that she had quite forgotten to be a host. "It's hard for me to get up... there's tea and biscuits in the kitchen, please help yourself."

The burglar shifted uncomfortably, as though he hadn't expected this turn of events.

"No, I'm fine," he said, hesitating a moment before adding: "But... would you like some? I can bring it to you."

Mai Minghe declined and thanked him; host and burglar exchanged polite pleasantries for a little while.

The burglar clasped his hands together and stared at the television in the corner of the room for a long moment before asking it: "Your health isn't good?"

"I'm quite all right—I can still get out of bed and walk on my own."

"...What about meals? Does a son or daughter come to bring you food?"

"I don't have any children," she said with a small smile. "And I don't eat much—anything simple will do... the social worker brings me vegetables and eggs now and then."

"A social worker? Do you have no family in Blackmoor City?"

"I'm used to it," Mai Minghe said. "I never had many relatives or friends to begin with, and they've all died before me. Dear, would you like to watch television?"

The burglar seemed to find the question absurd. He was silent for a moment, then suddenly took out his phone and glanced at it, and walked quickly out of the room.

"Hello?"

So he was taking a call.

"Yes, I've found her... no, I haven't done it yet." The burglar paused here, faltering. "The thing is—did you know she's an old woman? Eighty-six years old. That wasn't in the file."

The reply from the other end was brief, because the burglar spoke again almost immediately.

"Yes," the burglar said, not bothering to lower his voice—perhaps he felt there was no need. "But... does it have to be hers? She's not the only one with a passage. And besides, we don't even know what her passage is like... taking it would be hard on a young person—what about her? What if she can't hold on and dies?"

The person on the phone was very displeased; even Mai Minghe seemed to catch the faint sound of a raised voice.

The burglar bore it in silence for a time, and at last, like a student admitting a mistake, said: "No... I understand. I'm sorry. I'll get it."

Mai Minghe sometimes startled herself at the sight of her own hands.

Thick, wrinkled skin, layer upon layer draped over each bone, blue veins and blood vessels standing out in ridges, almost cold to the touch—nothing like the hands she remembered as her own. They belonged to two different people.

With that hand that seemed not to belong to her, she fumbled beneath the covers for a moment and found the pendant resting on her chest, closing her fingers tightly around it.

This time, the burglar came in and spoke at once: "I'm sorry, old lady. I need to take something from you."

She could just make him out now—he had a bright, regular sort of face, somewhere in his twenties or thirties, still young; if you didn't know, you'd never think him capable of harm.

"What would you like?" Mai Minghe asked. "I don't have much use for things anymore—take them. There's a silver brooch in the drawer..."

"No, I don't want valuables," the burglar interrupted. "I need to take something from your body."

"Is it an organ?" Mai Minghe asked, curious. Her organs hardly seemed worth taking.

"No, no, stop asking. You wouldn't understand even if I explained."

"Then... will I die?" Mai Minghe asked. "You said so just now."

The burglar was caught off guard; he went still for two seconds before saying, "I don't know... possibly."

Mai Minghe quietly studied the cracks in the ceiling for a while.

"If you need to take it, take it," she said softly. "It's just... before you do, could you grant me one wish?"

At some point the burglar had come to stand beside her.

"What wish?"

"I used to work at a library. The pay was very little, but I loved the library—I was happy there... Once, when my shift ended, one of the librarians told me there was an old book they were retiring; it hadn't sold at the clearance price, so they gave it to me to take home and read."

The burglar rested a hand on her pillow.

At his feet was a dark, bulky shape—some kind of machine—that seemed to have been brought in at some point without her noticing; Mai Minghe was only seeing it now.

"I looked, and it was a poetry anthology; I flipped through it idly when I got home," Mai Minghe murmured. "I read a little, put the book down, and later even lost track of where it went. But somehow... these past few years, I keep thinking back to one poem that was in it."

"Which poem?"

"You young people—don't you all have those... smart telephones?"

"Smartphones," the burglar corrected.

If she had a grandchild, she might have been corrected just like this.

"They say you can find anything on them?"

"...More or less."

"Could you look up that poem for me?" Mai Minghe asked. "I want to hear it one more time."

The burglar looked down at her, and something in his expression shifted—a sudden unease. He pulled a tissue from the nightstand box and pressed it into her hand. While Mai Minghe stared at it blankly, not understanding, he said: "All right, stop crying. I'll find it for you. Do you remember the title?"

She was crying?

So even at this age, she could not accept death.

Or perhaps it was that, even at this age, she had not yet had the chance to truly live.

"It's called... something with Daisy in the title." Mai Minghe deliberately left out half the title.

Smartphones held a great deal, but searching for a poem was no easy matter—and daisy was such a common image in poetry—so it took a good while, as she expected.

After finding several poems that weren't right one after another, the burglar finally lost patience: "Old lady, if you don't remember the name, that's not my fault. I still have to get back and hand in the job—you—"

"I've remembered," Mai Minghe said quickly.

This young man who had come to take something from her—he was likely the last person in her life who could let her hear a poem one more time.

Even if she could no longer put it off—even if she had to face death—it would still be a good thing to hear a little more poetry first.

"I Shall Pick More Daisies'... I think that's what it's called."

The young man glanced at her, said nothing, and tapped his fingers across the screen a few times.

This time, he quickly found the poem that Mai Minghe had kept returning to.

"I found a read-aloud video for you," he said, setting the phone on the edge of the bed.

In the quiet room thick with the smell of medicine and decay, the advertisement before the video burst cheerfully to life, announcing a deal at Little Caesars Pizza.

"The ad's almost done—you just listen. You listen while I work."

He bent down and pulled a tube from the dark, squat machine.

...If I had my life to live over,

I would try to make more mistakes.

I would relax.

I would be more limber.

I would be sillier than I have been this trip.

Mai Minghe felt the side of her face grow damp.

She had spent her whole life in anxious calculation, just as her parents had. During wartime inflation, she painstakingly rationed every meal; in peacetime, she kept a household ledger every week. When she was a child, her family ran a small shop, and no matter how desperately she wanted to, she never once dared to steal a single candy from the shelves.

As she grew older she came to many crossroads thick with wildflowers, but she never set foot in them.

People are strange—everyone knows they only have this one life, yet every single day is lived as though there is infinite time left, as though it can all be done again.

The thief lifted the blanket and pressed a cool tube against Mai Minghe's chest, and she dimly realized that the thing looked rather like an old-fashioned vacuum cleaner.

"What's this?" The thief picked up the pendant at her chest, glanced at it, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to answer, pushed it aside from the mouth of the tube. Young people generally didn't recognize it—had no idea what the thing was for.

Lucky for her that he didn't.

Amid the poem, he pressed the mouth of the tube against Mai Minghe's bony chest. He switched on the machine, and a low hum unlike anything she had ever heard slowly spiraled through the room.

...If I had my life to live over, I would travel lighter than I have. I would start barefoot earlier in the spring and stay that way later in the fall.

If I had my life to live over, I would go barefoot through the long springs and autumns.

I would play hooky more.

I wouldn't make such good grades, except by accident.

I would ride on more merry-go-rounds.

I would pick more daisies.

In the final instant that the darkness of death closed over Mai Minghe, she faintly heard the front door of the apartment burst open, and hurried footsteps and voices came rushing in together.

Carried to term for years, and at last delivered a homely child...

"I Shall Pick More Daisies" is a real poem. The poet wrote it when she was eighty-five—one year younger than my daughter. The inspiration wasn't actually the poem itself; it was only after I'd started writing that I suddenly remembered it and thought it fit perfectly.

My, it's been so long since I've updated or rambled on like this—I'm almost embarrassed, and I'm not quite sure what to say.

Thank you for coming back.

Chapter 2: Mai Minghe Rescued from Hallucination?

"You live alone,"

the social worker unfolded a small brochure to show her and said, "If you fall, no one would know—it's too dangerous. Best to get one you can wear around your neck; it won't get in the way. What do you think?"

That was many years ago now.

Mai Minghe still remembered that brochure. The product's name was blunt and to the point: "Life Alert."

The image showed a white-haired woman collapsed on the floor, with two lines of small text: "Help! I've fallen and I can't get up!"

Her older cousin had shattered her pelvis in her eighties and never got out of bed again; once you're bedridden, your days are numbered.

What year had she passed? Mai Minghe couldn't remember anymore.

The legs that had once carried her leaping onto rooftops and running wild—in the blink of an eye, even getting out of bed now required guarding against their betrayal.

The body that had followed her all her life had slowly become something foreign; she was like a stiff wheel turning slower and slower with each revolution, powerless to stop it.

"The Emergency Response System is available twenty-four hours a day, every day of the year," the social worker explained, worried she couldn't make out the text on the brochure. "No matter what the emergency, one press and someone will come... let me see—oh, they promise a maximum response time of thirty minutes, and there are participating hospitals nearby."

Mai Minghe took the brochure and studied the pictures for a moment.

She had scraped and saved every penny her whole life, but now money had suddenly lost its weight; prices were nothing but curved little symbols.

"I'll take this one," she said, pointing to the third model. "This one's the nicest-looking. Like a pendant on a necklace."

The social worker let out a laugh. "Great—it'll look lovely on you, I'm sure."

Though it looked nothing like a necklace, she wore it like one anyway; she'd been wearing it that way for years, and the first time she ever pressed the Life Alert was the night the thief walked into her living room to make a phone call.

The thief probably hadn't expected that the "necklace" on her chest was an alarm—the young and the old live in two worlds that are nearly sealed off from each other; unless you have regular reason to deal with elderly people, few know what their lives look like, let alone what things they see and use day to day.

Starting from when she'd made the thief hunt for the poem... she'd tried every trick she could think of, and had bought herself more than ten minutes by now.

No one had come yet, and she was on the verge of losing consciousness.

For some reason, the cold tube defied gravity—it stood straight upright on her chest with no one holding it. The machine hummed steadily, the sound of the poem grew more and more distant, and she sank into wave after wave of dizzy darkness, going deeper and deeper.

From the depths of that darkness, fragments of hallucination floated up like the shards of a dream.

Strange—they say that when a person is dying, they see the memories of their whole life; but all Mai Minghe saw was another version of herself, a tube connected to her chest just the same, walking step by step toward the television, then suddenly lunging forward and crashing into the screen.

She was startled by her own actions, and dimly heard a dull, wet sound from somewhere inside her chest.

With eyes half-open and half-closed, hallucination and reality overlapped; her hallucinated self slammed into the old television in the corner of the room again and again, and the screen erupted into spider-web cracks each time.

The hallucination was finally shattered by a sharp shout—an unfamiliar, low, rough voice called out: "What are you doing? Who are you?"

Mai Minghe jolted, and her eyes opened slightly.

Through her blurred vision, she saw an ink-black, lustrous tube standing upright on her chest—it seemed more alive than she was, pressing down on her with a heavy weight and pinning her to the bed.

The next moment, the tube vanished.

The thief snatched the tube behind his back, and despite his panic, kept his wits about him; he turned the question on the two people who had just burst into the bedroom: "Who are you? Why are you suddenly barging into my grandmother's house?"

Two people strode briskly in through the doorway, switched on the lights, and drove out the night; the room blazed white and bright, revealing a bedroom filled with decay, the smell of medicine, cracks in the walls, and the steady whoosh of an oxygen machine.

They were both wearing blue-and-white uniforms—nurse aides.

"Your grandmother?"

The male nurse aide looked at Mai Minghe, then turned a skeptical eye on the thief. "Her? She's your grandmother?"

"I'm two generations mixed—it doesn't show." The thief seemed to realize the difference in their skin tones and ethnicity, and reacted quickly. "Look, I have dark hair. Who are you people?"

"We're emergency-response nurse aides; we came because we received an alert signal—we thought she had an emergency." The other, a woman's voice, explained. "According to our records, she lives alone."

The thief had already composed himself completely.

"Yes," he said, giving Mai Minghe's arm a gentle pat as if to reassure her, and then addressed the nurse aides: "You responded very quickly—thank you for coming so fast. But there's been a small misunderstanding. I'm in Blackmoor City on a business trip and I'm staying with my grandmother for the time being. She's getting on in years, her mind isn't always clear, and she forgot I was coming—she probably thought I was a stranger and triggered the alert. She's fine."

The female nurse aide walked to the bedside, lifted Mai Minghe's eyelids, examined her, and asked softly, "Ma'am, are you all right?"

Mai Minghe opened her mouth to say something, but only the faintest breath passed between her lips. The female nurse aide had seen this many times before and was not surprised that she couldn't speak; she began listening to her heartbeat.

"Would you mind showing me some identification?" the male nurse aide asked the thief, still a little uncertain.

"Of course," the thief said, and right in front of the nurse aides, coolly and openly kicked the black machine with the tube attached to it under Mai Minghe's bed, muttering as he did so: "Why is the vacuum cleaner sitting there...? One moment—I'll go to the next room for my wallet. My driver's license is in it."

The bed she was lying on now was a hospital-style care bed with four wheels; the space underneath was empty and just right for storing things.

"Oh, my phone—" the thief had only taken a couple of steps before he turned back, smiled at the female nurse aide who was still examining Mai Minghe, and said: "I almost forgot. My grandmother sometimes gets frightened for no reason; I have to play poetry or music for her to calm her down."

The female nurse aide's gaze crossed over Mai Minghe to sweep over the phone screen, and her expression relaxed another degree.

Mai Minghe thought: a thief who breaks in and plays poetry for the homeowner—who would believe that if you told them? It looked far more like a devoted grandchild.

Since she was still alive, that meant the thief hadn't yet managed to take whatever was inside her, right?

Right—otherwise he wouldn't still be here playing the dutiful grandson.

Though if the nurse aides had come a few minutes later, he would have succeeded.

No one knew that death had just been sitting right beside her, leaning over and gazing down at her; she had never been this close to death before, and this was the first time she had ever had a dying hallucination...

That's right—the television!

Even Mai Minghe herself hadn't expected it, but the moment she thought of the hallucination just now, a sudden urge arose out of nowhere: she wanted to roll out of bed and go touch the television.

She had to get over there—had to get over there and look, quickly...

Driven by wave after wave of urgency crashing through her, Mai Minghe was so anxious she nearly cried out.

The dark, black television screen had become the only thing in the world with any weight to it—it pressed heavily into her field of vision and drew her toward it; the room, the nurse aides, and the thief were about as substantial as sheets of paper, and seemed on the verge of floating away.

Mai Minghe strained to lift her hand toward the television.

"Ma'am, what's the matter? What do you need?" The female nurse aide followed the direction of her raised hand, turned to look, and asked, "Do you want to watch TV?"

The door to the storage room next door opened and closed again, as if the thief had actually gone in to retrieve something. He had just returned as the female nurse aide spoke, handing his ID to the male nurse aide; the latter looked it over, and when he spoke again, both his tone and his posture had eased.

Mai Minghe let out a sound from her nose—a syllable of negation—but kept her hand pointing at the television.

"I'll turn it on for you," the female nurse aide said; though puzzled, she was kind about it, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to respond, switched the television on.

The television was replaying a daytime news commentary program; the host was going over and over the sudden death of Blackmoor City magnate Wellesley from the day before, recounting his business triumphs and charitable works.

"No... no." Mai Minghe finally found her voice again, which was a quiet relief—good, she could speak; her strength was coming back.

The thief quickly swept his gaze over her.

He immediately turned back to the male nurse aide, picking up the thread of what he'd been saying: "...My grandmother is getting on in years—the more confused her mind gets, the more stubborn she becomes. There's no family in Blackmoor City who can look after her..."

Such a young age, and already spinning one lie after another.

Telling them this person wasn't her grandson would probably do no good. An ordinary thief wouldn't stay on the scene to negotiate; from the nurse aides' perspective, between him being a thief and her being a senile old woman, she was the more likely candidate.

Never mind that—the television was more important and more urgent than him right now.

"Help me... help me over there." Mai Minghe pointed at the television and said quietly to the female nurse aide: "Please."

The thief glanced at her again, then looked at the television.

Before he could get a word in, the male nurse aide's question pulled away his attention: "When we arrived, you were hunched over holding a tube—what were you doing?"

"You don't have to go over there—you can watch it from here." The female nurse aide was a little hesitant.

The thief was explaining: "My grandmother cried out in the middle of the night and woke me up; I came to check on her and found the vacuum cleaner hose had fallen onto the bed."

"Please," Mai Minghe gripped the female nurse aide's hand tightly, fixed her eyes on those brown eyes, and begged: "Help me over there. Please. I... I just want to sit there for a moment."

She was coming across more and more like a muddled old woman.

"All right, I'll help you." The female nurse aide gave in. "Can you get up?"

"Yes, yes."

The thief glanced at Mai Minghe once more and, seemingly out of concern, came over on his own initiative to support her—also conveniently extricating himself from the male nurse aide's questioning. "Grandma, what do you want to go over there for? You can take a look, but then you have to come back and sleep, all right?"

Mai Minghe ignored him. He seemed like such a decent-looking young man—what on earth was he doing?

With both of them supporting her, she shuffled unsteadily to the television set; her own pale, ghostly half-reflection floated on the screen, then disappeared as the broadcast cut to footage of the Wellesley Family Estate.

She understood now.

So there really had been a reason for the hallucination after all, Mai Minghe thought.

No wonder she had felt such urgency to come over—well, she should have thought of it sooner; at her age, her mind really wasn't what it used to be.

"I'll get a chair," the female nurse aide said, and let go of Mai Minghe.

That left only the thief holding her. He held her thin, dried-up arm in a loose, light grip, as if he didn't dare exert any force.

"If everything's all right, then we'll be on our way." The male nurse aide stood in the doorway and asked the thief, "Can you get her back to bed on your own in a bit?"

The thief exhaled in relief. He nodded repeatedly and said, "Of course—sorry for making you come all the way out here..."

While he was speaking, Mai Minghe suddenly pulled her arm free, let her body fall backward, and toppled toward the television screen.

She should have thought of it sooner—her hallucination had been telling her how to save herself.

If she fell against the television right in front of the nurse aides, they would have no choice but to send her to the hospital—no matter what the thief claimed to be, right? At the hospital, with plenty of people around, she would be safe.

From the corner of her eye she saw the thief's head snap toward her, but he was a beat too slow and couldn't make it in time; Mai Minghe heard the dull, heavy crack of her skull against the television, and then the room erupted with startled cries and the sound of rushing footsteps.

The female social worker seemed to call out something from very far away, but Mai Minghe couldn't make out the words—

"Where did she go?"

Posted yesterday

but I didn't expect to actually start the book

It's only two chapters—no rush to collect on that debt yet, let's wait and see; what if the later chapters aren't good? Qidian doesn't do refunds on tips, you know.

The same goes for 95, 秋水不染尘, 相声福晋, 绾瑾, 颖佑, 西下有木名栗, 039追女娲? , 卡夫卡, and everyone else—are you all angel investors? I'm flattered and terrified...

Full disclosure: the book launches on the 12th, and I have to leave town on the 14th... My stockpile of advance chapters definitely won't survive the combination of travel chaos and bonus-chapter donations—looks like I'll be pecking away at the keyboard on the plane again.

PS: I saw some readers asking why this is posted on the male-frequency channel when it's a strong-female-lead feature. The editors have their reasons, actually—a large portion of male-frequency readers are women who don't visit the female-frequency side, so a strong-female-lead feature on the male channel is meant to draw them in; think of it as poaching readers for the female channel's benefit (?).

Chapter 3: The Sweet Illusion in Mai Minghe's Hospital Ward

As the world spun around her, Mai Minghe instinctively grabbed at a white shape nearby, but still couldn't steady herself—she stumbled and sat down hard on the ice-cold tile floor, letting out a hoarse groan.

This is bad. Could she have broken a bone?

The pain blurred her vision completely, and she couldn't even tell which bone it was that might be the death of her—one single fall was all it took to shatter her, scatter her into pieces across the floor.

After a fall like this, the nurse aide should have taken her to the hospital no matter what; yet as she caught her breath, the nurse aide who should have come rushing never appeared, and no one asked if she was all right.

What was going on?

Mai Minghe narrowed her eyes and looked carefully, and couldn't help but freeze.

...This wasn't her room.

The room was dim and murky; by the thin sliver of white light seeping in under the door, she could vaguely make out that it was a very large space. In front of her and behind her stood an empty narrow bed on either side, and what she had grabbed turned out to be a corner of a bed sheet.

She let go of the sheet and looked left and right.

A row of wheeled care beds, each with a small bedside cabinet, each with a curtain divider—this was clearly a hospital ward. She had been hospitalized several times before and could recognize one at a glance.

How strange.

How had she ended up in a hospital ward? The nurse aides must have brought her here, right?

But how could she have completely forgotten the whole process of being sent to the hospital? It was as if it had never happened—as if a black hole had opened up in her memory.

Mai Minghe suppressed her panic and pain, and no matter how hard she tried to think, the last moment she could recall was still slamming into the television; she remembered the world tilting in the midst of searing pain, and then the next second, she had fallen onto the hospital ward floor.

It was as though she had fallen straight from her home into the hospital—but that was impossible.

Had she lost consciousness at the time and forgotten because of that?

"Is anyone there?" Mai Minghe called out in a hoarse voice. "Nurse? I've fallen..."

In the cold, silent ward, her cry for help was like a chip of broken ice slowly sinking into a cold river, as if it had never existed.

Whether from pain or cold, she trembled uncontrollably in waves. If this went on, something would surely go wrong—she had to call the nurse quickly. Right, there was usually a call bell at the head of the hospital bed.

Mai Minghe struggled to push herself upright, trying to stand, but the pain in her leg bones wouldn't allow it; her hands and feet went limp and weightless, and she slipped, nearly falling again.

There was nothing else for it—she had no choice but to crawl inch by inch toward the bedside cabinet, prop herself against its edge, stretch her arm out as hard as she could, and just barely graze the call bell button with her fingertips.

"If I were you, I wouldn't press that."

The man's voice came out of nowhere and sent a jolt through Mai Minghe's chest; her blood rushed up as though it might burst her brain.

She steadied herself through the dizziness and turned her head toward the sound, only then noticing that there was another bed behind her.

The bed curtain was drawn, but not all the way—a pair of feet belonging to the patient in the adjacent bed were visible.

Those feet were bare, nothing on them at all, snow-white as if dusted with heavy powder, the toes curled ever so slightly, not moving at all.

Mai Minghe couldn't help but feel a rush of relief—thank goodness, there was someone else in the room.

"Are you—are you also a patient here?" she asked, still breathless as she spoke; even as she spoke, she reached toward the call bell again.

"You really want to call the nurse?" the patient behind the curtain asked in return.

"Yes... I've fallen and I have no choice but to call."

For something minor, she wouldn't bother the nurses in the middle of the night if she could help it—Mai Minghe actually understood the adjacent patient's concern.

She pressed the call bell, and not a single sound rang out in the room.

"There, you went and pressed it anyway."

The patient in the adjacent bed knew all the same, and laughed—a stiff, flat laugh, as though each contraction of the diaphragm were deliberate and conscious, every segment precisely equal in length.

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and slowly slid down to sit on the floor, her entire body sinking into exhausted helplessness; but she quietly stole a glance at the curtain from the corner of her eye.

"Won't listen to advice... people really do get more stubborn as they get older. I was saying it for your own good."

"What... do you mean?"

The other person laughed again, two stiff and measured bursts, but gave no answer.

Something felt off, though she couldn't say exactly why.

Mai Minghe was still hesitating over whether to ask again when a deafeningly loud broadcast suddenly tore through the dead-silent corridor outside—an electronic female voice blared and echoed, reverberating through the ward door: "Room three, bed 03, calling nurse. Room three, bed 03, calling nurse!"

The broadcast gave her a fright, and a terrible jolt burst through her chest; she pressed one hand tightly over her heart—relieved that someone was coming, yet unable to stop a creeping unease from rising.

...Strange—normally, after pressing the call bell, would a broadcast go off? This loud, in the middle of the night—weren't they afraid of disturbing people's rest?

Could this be some new rule at hospitals these days?

The broadcast stopped.

In the silent room, for a moment there was nothing but Mai Minghe's trembling breaths.

"Please be advised," the broadcast suddenly blared again at the same staggering volume, startling her once more: "A figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at Room Three within five seconds. Countdown: five—four—three—"

Mai Minghe froze.

She must have been going deaf and blind, mishearing things—otherwise why would she think the broadcast had said "a figure disguised as a nurse"?

The patient in the adjacent bed began to chuckle again, the laughter chopped into segments.

"What the broadcast just said..."

Before Mai Minghe could finish the question, there came a sudden bang—the ward door was slammed hard into the wall, the ear-splitting crash making her chest tighten with a deep, dull ache.

As the ward door flew open, white light from the corridor poured in; standing in that white light was a thin, elongated, extremely tall dark shape, its head cut off by the doorframe above.

The shadow rotated its right shoulder, stepped forward with its right foot—as though its joints were misaligned and stiff—and lurched crookedly one step through the doorway, its head still left outside.

That could not possibly be a nurse.

The thought sharpened the radiating pain pulsing outward from her left chest in waves, her entire left arm as though someone had seized the tendons and was pulling them free; soon she felt herself unable to breathe.

"Oh? It's one of those?"

The patient in the adjacent bed began to laugh with rhythmic contractions of the chest, the snow-white feet beyond the curtain still utterly motionless.

"Say you're unlucky, and yet what came isn't a Resident; say you're lucky, and yet... at this exact moment, you've gone and had a heart attack—so you still won't make it out alive."

The shadow rotated its left shoulder, stepped forward with its left foot, its head swaying and scraping along the wall as it entered; angling its body, it took another step toward bed three.

From far beyond the wide-open door, someone bellowed in fury: "Who's closest?... Get to Room Three now and cut them off! Don't let whoever pressed that bell escape—the nerve, stealing our things!"

...What was happening?

Would she survive this day?

The shadow was backlit, and no matter how much Mai Minghe squinted, she couldn't make out its face. It walked with both arms and legs on the same side swinging together, and though it seemed to take only two or three steps, it had already reached the foot of the bed, trapping her between the two beds.

She wanted to ask who it was, but she could no longer speak.

Someone was sprinting down the corridor toward her, the pounding footsteps growing louder and louder until she could almost feel the floor shaking; the shadow paid no heed to the noise outside and swayed steadily closer until it loomed directly before Mai Minghe.

Was this... a person? she wondered dimly, at the edge of death. That couldn't be, could it?

Before she could understand, this life of hers was about to reach its end.

The shadow slowly bent down toward her.

Though her consciousness was fading, Mai Minghe finally saw clearly the first face she had encountered since entering this hospital.

Beneath a mass of wild dark hair, what extended from the neck was an oval, smooth, hard mirror-surface. Below the mirror, there was nothing but darkness.

It was not a person wearing a mirror over their face.

Where a face should have been, there was not the slightest contour of features or bone—only a mirror in its place, grown out from the surrounding flesh, angled directly at Mai Minghe.

Her aged, withered face was reflected in the mirror, and in that moment, it was as though the one bending down toward her was Mai Minghe herself.

Was she inside a dream right now? A mirror for a face, a heart attack—it was all a dream, surely.

Before dying, she had actually seen something so... extraordinary.

Dream or reality, this was at least the first time in her life she had glimpsed something beyond the ordinary—and it would be the last.

Mai Minghe made no expression, yet the old face in the mirror smiled faintly, the way a person smiles when they have reached a point of helplessness and have no other choice.

The reflection of her opened its mouth, lips parting and closing, speaking soundlessly to the Mai Minghe outside the mirror.

If I could live again...

I would ride the merry-go-round to my heart's content,

I would go everywhere, try everything,

...I would pick more daisies.

Mai Minghe could not move at all—whether her mind had been stilled by some outside force, or whether her old, exhausted heart, on the verge of sleep, could simply no longer be roused.

The lips in the mirror grew more and more indistinct, harder and harder to read; the shadow continued drawing slowly closer, and finally enveloped her completely.

...If you were given the chance to begin again, what would you do with it to make this new life worthwhile?

The thick, tangled, coarse black hair pressed against Mai Minghe's forehead; she was submerged in dense darkness, unable to see anything. Two arms, grotesquely long, wound around her body again and again, pulling tighter and tighter, until it felt as though the bones inside her would be snapped one by one—

"Let go of me,"

Just as the breath in her chest was about to be cut off, Mai Minghe finally struggled and shoved with both hands—but she met no resistance as she had expected, and her hands pushed

through empty air.

She quickly steadied herself and scrambled up from the floor, only then realizing that there was nothing before her at all—the shadow had vanished.

Wait...

It dawned on Mai Minghe belatedly.

She had just jumped to her feet—easily, cleanly, without any difficulty at all?

Mai Minghe raised a hand and pressed it to her chest; the pain was as though it had never existed, and from deep within, there came a steady, familiar rhythm.

Her hands... seemed a little different.

Mai Minghe raised both hands and found that the skin was full and smooth, the nails clear and lustrous, without a single fold of excess wrinkled skin. She lowered her head and stared blankly at what showed below the hem of her pajama pants—a pair of legs, evenly fleshed, fair and strong.

She had to have gone mad.

Youth, it turned out, was a sweet illusion—fierce and full to bursting, so overwhelming it left one at a loss.

For a moment she forgot everything, and frantically explored her own body: her fingers plunged into thick, abundant hair; her arms and thighs had the firm muscles she had long been without; her back had straightened, her height risen... Mai Minghe let out a breathless "ha" of a laugh, her voice trembling.

A clear, young voice she hadn't heard in at least several decades flowed into the cold air of the ward.

From the other side of decay, darkness, and ash, she had somehow been released—born into the world a second time—but wait, was any of this real?

"In here!"

A sharp shout rang out at the doorway, and Mai Minghe jolted upright, lifting her head.

Her vision was no longer clouded and grey; even in the dim light, she could clearly see a man burst in through the door, his face filled with deep wariness.

"There's a woman in here, but I don't see the Artifact."

The man fixed his eyes on Mai Minghe and called out to his companions behind him, then snapped at her: "Which House are you a Hunter for? You've got the item on you, don't you? You have the nerve to steal the Artifact Mr. Wellesley wants?"

"What?" Mai Minghe asked blankly, her mind a tangled mess of confusion—the man's question, rambling as nonsense, had to seep through the cracks of that tangle before even a little of it could reach her.

The man was about to step inside when his eyes swept to something beside her and he stopped dead in his tracks.

"Get in here, all of you," he called to those outside the door. "There's a Resident in Room Three!"

A Resident? What was he talking about?

From that brief glance just now, it seemed like there was something in the room—not far from her at all.

Mai Minghe turned his gaze in a daze and found that the originally empty Bed No. 3 beside her had its curtain drawn at some point.

The curtain wasn't fully closed, revealing a pair of feet so snow-white they looked as though they'd been dusted with powder; the toes were splayed out to either side, frozen still, not moving at all.

...Huh? Wasn't he on the bed next to her just now?

When had he moved over to Bed No. 3?

"Calling you 'old lady' wouldn't be right anymore," the patient behind the curtain said with a laugh. "I should be calling you 'young lady' now. Young lady, what you just got your hands on is a rare and wonderful thing. How about letting me take a look?"

I'm boarding a flight today—the pressure to update has kicked in, so I'll have to write on the plane. I just hope whoever sits next to me isn't one of those screen-peekers. One time I was writing an apocalypse story on a plane, and the guy one seat over suddenly grew five centimeters of neck, like a crane, and twisted it all the way over to ask me: "You writing a novel? What's it about?"

Makes you wonder if nearsightedness really isn't widespread enough.

(Why do I keep catching flights and going on long trips—truly an unsolvable mystery…)

Chapter 4: Mai Minghe Seizes a Second Life

By any reasonable logic, three to five tall, built, hostile strangers pouring in through the door should have been the most alarming threat, right?

No matter how you looked at it, they were still more dangerous than a patient lying in a hospital bed.

And yet, somehow, Mai Minghe couldn't help but fix her gaze on the pair of white feet peeking out from behind the curtain. Her heartbeat thundered in her ears like rolling drums; her palms were cold and clammy—and she couldn't spare so much as a glance for the strangers.

She was wedged between the Bed 03 patient and Bed 02, with the bedside cabinet and wall at her back. The path ahead was blocked by the intruders, and there was no way out.

She stole another glance at the patient in the next bed.

Compared to when she had first seen them, the feet looked slightly different now—she couldn't say exactly how—but looking at them now triggered something instinctive, something biological, a revulsion so deep she almost wanted to open her mouth and heave out everything: the sight before her eyes, the air she'd breathed that had touched those feet, along with every organ in her body.

Looking up again, she could tell the strangers might be feeling the same way: for all their ferocious swagger when they'd barged in, their eyes were now drifting upward, not one of them willing to lower their gaze to the feet on the bed—at a glance, they looked exactly like a group of blind men who had all just taken off their dark glasses at the same moment.

Mai Minghe wiped her nose.

Perhaps terror and tension had wound too tight, and her nervous system was seeking release; perhaps the return of youth carried an intoxicating, surging magic that even fear couldn't dispel; or perhaps it was simply that the people across from her looked too comical—whatever the reason, she suddenly couldn't hold it in, and burst out laughing.

"How did you manage that?"

She stifled her laughter, not wanting those people to think she belonged in a psychiatric ward. She turned to the patient in the next bed and said: "I don't know why, but one look at you and my

guts start churning. You'd make a great side job here at the hospital—stomach-pumping."

The red-haired man who seemed to be the leader didn't say a word, but the expression on his face said everything about what he thought of Mai Minghe—not quite right in the head.

"Miss,"

the male voice from behind the curtain was like a bag of stones clogged with thick phlegm—hearing it was indescribably unpleasant. "This is your first time in the Nest, isn't it?"

Since just moments ago, Mai Minghe had heard a string of incomprehensible terms: a figure disguised as a nurse, Hunters, Artifacts... and now another one had been added—the Nest.

"This isn't a hospital?" Mai Minghe asked.

Though it was a question, she already had the answer clear as a mirror in her mind: of course this wasn't a hospital.

She had somehow ended up in this place called the "Nest"; and that "somehow," it seemed, had a great deal to do with her falling onto the television set.

"But it is a hospital—why wouldn't it be?" the patient behind the curtain answered, in a tone that was almost friendly. "A hospital inside the Nest is still a hospital."

Mai Minghe stalled for time, thinking as she spoke: "You say this is the Nest, but you don't look much like a chicken to me."

The red-haired man let out a sound through his nose—something he'd tried and failed to suppress—and covered it with a cough.

"Doesn't even know what the Nest is," one of the people by the door muttered to a companion in a low voice. "Really is her first time in. No wonder she's still in her pajamas."

"But if it's her first time here, how could she have gotten hold of an Artifact?" another murmured.

"Wait and see," the red-haired man instructed. "Be ready—if she can't hold on, we'll have to take it from the Resident."

As they spoke, they treated Mai Minghe as though she barely existed—or rather, as though she were something that was about to cease to exist very soon.

In the span of just a minute or two, far too many incomprehensible things had happened; right now, Mai Minghe could only hold tightly to two facts.

First, after entering the Nest, she had regained her youth. Second, the thing that had restored her youth seemed to be the objective both parties were after.

Even knowing nothing else, she knew that she was like a child carrying a fortune through a busy marketplace—more like a ghost market—and that was not a good position to be in.

Behind the curtain, there was dead silence; two bare feet, pale-blue and white, rested with their toes hooked over the footrail of the bed.

"What do you want?" Mai Minghe stared at the feet behind the curtain and asked, knowing full well the answer. "How about this—you tell me what's going on, and I'll give you whatever you want. Nice and peaceful, wouldn't that be better?"

The patient behind the curtain considered for two seconds.

"Feel around on your body," his voice had calmed somewhat—less painful to listen to than before—though he still refused to explain further, only saying: "You should be able to feel something. Take it off and give it to me."

Mai Minghe reached her hand inside her pajamas and felt along her back and lower abdomen; the moment she touched it, she flinched.

Slightly raised, ice-cold, band-like things wound around her torso in layer after layer—to the touch, it was exactly like a great snake coiled around her body.

Right—that dark shadowy arm from earlier had seemed to wrap around her just like this, in ring after ring.

"Found it, haven't you," the patient in the next bed suddenly hissed, mucus churning in his throat. "Give it to me."

Mai Minghe traced the edge of the "snake-band" and felt that it seemed deeply reluctant to separate from her skin; she would have to use some force to wedge her fingertips between the band and her flesh.

"Alright, alright, I know, I'll give it to you." It could indeed be removed—she lifted her hand, and had already peeled the "snake-band" up slightly.

She thought of another question.

"I had a heart attack just now, and it only stopped after this thing appeared. Once I take it off, will the attack come back?"

"For someone your age, your mind works fast. I don't think so. What it reversed was aging, not illness—the illness disappearing was merely a side effect, and doesn't necessarily come back along with the aging."

The patient in the next bed's voice was thick and viscous. "Of course, I could be wrong—but besides being optimistic, you have no other choice. Now then, take it off."

As he said, she had no other choice.

"Fortunately, I've always been an optimist." Mai Minghe let out a breath, first peeling the "snake-band" away from her lower abdomen, then following it all the way around to her back, working it off her body bit by bit.

The tail of the pitch-black "snake-band" slipped softly out from her pajamas and hung suspended in the air, swaying gently back and forth, as though it were alive.

"Wait—don't give it to him," the red-haired man suddenly barked, stepping forward and spreading both hands wide. "Give it to me—if it comes for me, it'll leave you alone!"

He used the pronoun "it"?

The thought flashed through Mai Minghe's mind; she had no time to dwell on it, but she had already realized this was a lifeline—in this brief sliver of an opening, she might be able to escape the ward and get out alive. Mai Minghe seized the moment and immediately shouted to the red-haired man: "Catch!"

She swung her arm and pulled a dark shape from behind her back, hurling it toward his raised hands.

It may have been her imagination, but Mai Minghe could have sworn that for one fleeting instant, the patient behind the curtain in the next bed was also drawn away for a split second of distraction.

With a smack, the dark shape landed in the red-haired man's hands at the very same moment Mai Minghe seized her chance: she rolled across Bed 02 and dropped to the ground on the other side—the body of a young person was truly so strong, agile, and balanced; the movement was smooth and effortless, so exhilarating that for one brief instant she nearly forgot she was fleeing for her life.

The dark shape, soft and puffed-up, was nestled between two hands, surrounded by a ring of faces staring intently at it.

"A pillow?"

The red-haired man blinked in surprise once he saw what it was, then flung the pillow—which Mai Minghe had taken from Bed 02—onto the floor, and snapped: "Do you want to die at a Resident's hands?"

Mai Minghe had no time to reply; she had only just found her footing when she turned her head and found that the patient had followed—the curtain around Bed 02 had been drawn shut.

But not fully.

The curtain seemed to have been pulled a little wider; at some point, a pair of lower legs had extended out from it, the two knees pressed tightly together, bending over the edge of the bed and hanging down.

The patient in the next bed was lying flat, with only their legs lowered—that in itself was not strange; what was strange was that those bare feet, pale-blue and bloodless, planted flat on the floor, had rotated a full turn at the ankle and were now facing directly toward Mai Minghe.

This felt too much like an absurd dream; if she were to open her eyes in the next moment and wake up in a hospital bed, Mai Minghe would not have been at all surprised.

"Get back,"

the red-haired man said, his face taut, retreating further from Bed 02 along with the others behind him.

It was as though even the air was slowly tightening, thinning out; as though they were wild animals long accustomed to these surroundings, and had sensed the danger one step before Mai Minghe, who understood nothing.

She thought for a moment, then asked the patient in the next bed: "Did you come into the hospital for a broken ankle?"

As she spoke, Mai Minghe had a vague sense of something pulling at her waist.

"Or... you really aren't human?" She called out to the red-haired man: "Hey, young man—if it's not human, what is it? Really a chicken?"

Everything was so unbelievable that she found she'd lost her capacity for shock, and simply wanted to understand what was happening—after all, no one can keep startling themselves too frequently.

The red-haired man didn't answer her.

He and the others behind him were all staring at the lower legs dangling from beside Bed 02 and at the floor, as though Mai Minghe had already been erased from the situation—she just didn't know it yet.

The curtain rustled with a soft shushing sound; someone was slowly drawing it open.

Mai Minghe did not want to see what lay behind the curtain—it couldn't be anything good.

She quickly lowered her head again; when her gaze fell on the pair of feet before her, she noticed that the patient in the next bed's left foot had, at some point, stepped forward.

Though she herself hadn't moved at all, her own left foot had also stepped forward.

Like two old acquaintances reuniting, walking toward each other.

No wonder it felt like something was pulling at her waist...

Strange—why was it that simply seeing the other's feet caused her own feet to move beyond her control, mirroring the other's movements—no, this was not the time for puzzling and reflection.

Even with her head lowered, she could sense from the corner of her eye that the curtain had been drawn open.

On Bed 02 beside her, a long human-shaped shadow lay dimly on the mattress.

Mai Minghe drew a deep breath.

If this had been the Mai Minghe of before, she might have chosen to keep the peace and put self-preservation first, handing the "snake-band" over to it; the first time you're alive, you're always afraid that one wrong move will lead to irreversible, unbearable consequences and make this life a miserable one.

Later, when she had grown old, she found that her decades of life had been filled with nothing but loneliness, regret, and wishes long past their expiry date—not much of a good life after all. Opportunities no longer came calling, and she had run out of strength.

This "snake-band" could be the last great adventure in her eighty-six years of life; but it could also be the first choice of her life yet to come.

She wanted to try.

Mai Minghe knew that pressing the call button would not break the dead silence in the room with any sound.

"Ward Three, Bed 01 is calling for a nurse!"

The broadcast's sharp, almost piercing female voice shattered the room's silence without warning.

Before anyone had time to react, Mai Minghe pressed the call button several more times in quick succession.

The intercom, as if galvanized, announced down the corridor in increasingly urgent tones: "A figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at the ward within five seconds—a second figure disguised as a nurse is about to arrive—a third figure disguised as a nurse—a fourth figure disguised as a nurse will arrive at the ward within five seconds!"

Amid the announcements, each more urgent than the last, Mai Minghe thought she dimly heard the red-haired man curse "Are you insane!"; immediately after, a flurry of retreating footsteps receded rapidly, as though the group, seeing things had gone south, had fled the ward ahead of everyone else.

She had not lifted her head the entire time.

Mai Minghe felt the dark shape beside her rising up joint by joint: thighs lifting off the mattress, hips suspended halfway in the air, upper body still flat on the bed.

In the dim residual light, that head turned toward Mai Minghe, and spoke in a voice utterly unlike any human sound: "For an old lady, you've got quite the nerve."

At that very moment, something heavy was suddenly hurled across the room and slammed down hard between her and the patient in the next bed—landing with a thunderous thud, the nightstand instantly smashed to pieces—the shadow tumbled to the floor, and when it scrambled up against the wall, it turned out to be the red-haired man; finding himself wedged squarely between the patient and Mai Minghe, he swore under his breath.

Mai Minghe didn't look at him.

She kept her gaze fixed on the doorway of the ward, and said quietly: "Look again. I'm not an old lady anymore."

Not now. Not tomorrow either.

She would seize this second life—truly seize it—for herself.

By the time you see this chapter, I should already be on the plane—this chapter was set on a timer—having a backlog really gives you confidence! You can even schedule posts! Back when I was writing the apocalypse story, it was feast or famine!

Unfortunately, the backlog, all told, is barely enough to last a little over a week... hopefully I can manage to write at least one chapter on the plane, so once I land I can start bonus updates to pay off my debt.

Speaking of debt—dear readers, aren't you being a little too swift and decisive? The Artifact Report just came into the world and you're already stuffing in red envelopes—what if the child grows up to be the Hunchback of Notre Dame?

It feels like every time I blink, another debt appears...

Aiya, boarding time is almost here, there's a super long line at the gate, and here I am sitting cross-legged typing away—just wait until I've landed, and then we'll properly tally up how much more I owe.

So what if I'm a pack mule—I've been in this business for a hundred years! I'll gather coins with my donkey tail!

Chapter 5 — Sydney Ginn, the Hunter Plagued by a Stalker

Sydney Ginn stood before her own memorial portrait, ears ringing.

A funeral wreath was blocking her front door; open it, and the first thing you'd see was her own smiling, blurred face. The black-and-white portrait photo was crooked-nailed to the center of the wreath, and a line of savage crimson letters — "BITCH" — tore across her smile.

It was the first time in her life she had seen, in person, the kind of wreath used at Asian funerals; and even as fury and shock surged through her, some small part of Sydney found herself marveling at how authentic it looked — identical to the ones on TV — wondering where on earth someone would even get one made.

As for who had left it there, she wasn't curious, because she already knew.

Sydney kicked the wreath over, slammed the door, and walked toward the elevator, pulling out her phone as she went.

"Get up here right now and take a look at what's been left in front of my door."

She had lived in this building for three years, and today was the first time she had ever raised her voice at the building manager like this — before now, she had always been too afraid to be rude.

"What gives you the right to charge such high rent and management fees? This is supposed to be the most expensive address in Blackmoor City? Your security staff — did you borrow them as mummies from the National Museum next door? Are they all dead? I told you, didn't I, that there's been a creep following me lately — why wasn't security tightened? How did he even get the chance to reach my front door?"

When Sydney had first moved into this building, she had been deeply insecure about it.

By any normal trajectory, someone like her — born to an ordinary immigrant family, with no impressive credentials and an equally unremarkable job — could spend a lifetime saving for rent and still never pass the application screening, never gain entry into this century-old landmark, already designated a historic site.

The layered barriers of class and social networks made it difficult even for many newly minted tech millionaires to lease a unit here, let alone buy one.

Not long after she moved in, she had once encountered a woman in the elevator who struck up a very friendly conversation with her, which quietly pleased her; just before the elevator reached the lobby, the woman smiled and asked, "Who do you work for? We happen to be interviewing for household staff at the moment."

It took her several seconds to realize the woman had mistaken her for a maid.

Even dressed in much the same way, something — she couldn't say what — still allowed others to see at a glance that she didn't belong to this class. The building manager on the phone was one of them.

"Miss Ginn,"

the manager explained in a tone that bordered on sympathetic condescension, "I also feel very sorry about this. But you may not be aware that we generally prefer not to interfere in our residents' personal affairs — that has always been our policy.

"The people our residents typically associate with are all respectable individuals of standing, so this sort of thing is happening for the very first time. According to security, he said he wanted to give you a surprise, and he was carrying flowers, so we couldn't quite tell — it seemed like perhaps you and your boyfriend had some kind of romantic dispute..."

"It's not a romantic dispute, it's stalking and harassment!" Sydney snapped, too furious to even register the implication buried in the word "respectable." "And he's not my boyfriend — what he was carrying was a funeral wreath!"

The man had been on a few dates with her and had indeed visited before, having been granted entry each time; it was precisely after seeing her home and her lifestyle that he had begun repeatedly demanding money and gifts from her, and only when she could no longer bear it had she decided to cut off all contact.

She had never imagined that a simple "no" could ignite such an unhinged, consuming hatred.

"Of course, of course, I'll have someone remove the wreath right away. Security isn't like you — they wouldn't recognize that kind of wreath, which is understandable, and I hope you can appreciate that." The building manager continued, "That said, Miss Ginn, I'd also like to ask you to try to communicate with him and calm the situation down. After all, our residents here tend to prefer things quiet and low-key; they don't care for this sort of disturbance..."

"So I'm the one who should be apologizing to you?"

Sydney was too furious to catch anything else the manager said, hung up the call, and kicked the elevator door hard.

When she left the building, she didn't ask the doorman to call a car for her, and walked absentmindedly out into the Blackmoor City streets, where the morning sun was blazing.

Sydney could file a police report, apply for a restraining order — but neither was a sure thing.

For all she knew, the police wouldn't act until she'd already become a victim; and a restraining order might deter a sane person, but how much effect would it have on someone unhinged?

For an ordinary woman, there was little left beyond reporting it to the police, staying on guard, fleeing somewhere far away, and praying — but what that Anthony probably didn't know was that what Sydney could actually do went far beyond any of that.

She wandered for a while, made up her mind, and flagged down a taxi.

The timing worked out perfectly; when she reached the Buluan district, "Between the Backlight" had just opened its doors.

The bar's entrance was hidden behind a short staircase that descended from the sidewalk into the ground, and people walking past could hardly see its sign light; though in Sydney's memory, the sign light had never actually been on — so it hardly mattered whether any passerby could see it.

She pushed open the faded wooden door, and to the dry creaking of the door's hinges, stepped into a cramped, dim basement.

In the murky darkness, chairs sat upside down on tabletops, and cardboard boxes were stacked in the booths. The air was stale and cool, drifting with dust, the smell of alcohol, and a faint trace of vomit.

"You're here this early?"

The back door was pushed open, and a man peered in, then walked behind the bar. He had the face of a Shar-Pei, all drooping brows and downcast eyes, and yet, like a dog, his expression was somehow warm.

He switched the television on for Sydney and gestured toward the bar. "Sit down, I'm still tidying up."

The television mounted in one corner of the bar's ceiling lit up with the midday news. A baby elephant had been born at the Blackmoor City Center Island Zoo, and the female anchor was beaming.

"Any news?" Sydney sat down and asked. "I'm planning to head over in the next couple of days."

"There's a team that's temporarily short-handed and wants to hire an experienced Hunter with no House Faction ties. I thought — isn't that you?"

The bartender's Shar-Pei face remained buried behind the bar counter; he seemed to be scrubbing the cabinet door on his knees, and said over the shushing sound of the cloth: "Not much money — three thousand dollars, departing next week. And of course, whatever comes out of it at the end has nothing to do with you."

A few years ago, three thousand dollars would have lit her eyes up like flashlights; but now, it wasn't nearly enough to make it worth her while.

"I can't work with a group right now — I've got some personal business this time. Are there any other commissions?"

"Then there's nothing—"

He'd barely gotten the words out when the television suddenly rang out with a sharp, urgent chime, making Sydney glance up at the screen — breaking news.

"We have just learned," the female anchor said, her expression grave, "that Wellesley, founder, shareholder, and CEO of the Qunmu Consortium, was found dead this morning at his upstate estate, at the age of fifty-nine. The cause of death is currently suspected to be sudden cardiac arrest, and police have opened an investigation... Mr. Wellesley was also a state senator, a philanthropist..."

Sydney startled. "He's dead?"

The Shar-Pei face emerged from behind the bar, watching the screen. "Did you know him?"

"No, not personally. But I have a client who had some dealings with him... I thought maybe I'd be able to do business with him someday. Pity." Sydney said, and set aside the death of Blackmoor City's richest man. "No other assignments?"

"You could wait a few more days — something might come up." The bartender went back to polishing the beer taps. "When are you planning to go?"

Sydney took out her phone, intending to check the time, but found over twenty text messages on her screen, all from an unknown number; even without opening them, she could tell at a glance they were a mix of pitiful pleading, filth, and threats and curses.

She had already blocked four or five numbers, but it didn't seem to slow the harassment at all.

"I'm going tonight — no assignment, forget it." She put her phone away, her tone cooling. "There's a problem that's not huge but is deeply unpleasant, and I need to go make a trip and bring something back to deal with it."

The bartender nodded and asked, "The usual drink? Or should I pack it to go?"

"Yes," — just mentioning the drink, Sydney was fairly sure the color drained from her face — "I didn't bring a cup, just pour it into a couple of plastic bottles, whatever you've got."

The moment she thought about the drink he prepared for her, even before it was down her throat, her stomach started to heave, as though every organ in her body wanted to empty itself out in advance.

No matter how many times she drank it, Sydney could never get used to the taste of alcohol. She had been forcing herself to drink for the past several years, and she seemed to be turning into Pavlov's dog — sometimes just catching a whiff of alcohol on someone else was enough to make her legs go weak and her head swim with nausea.

"Only the drink you mix has the effect I need. If I drink anything else, my mind goes numb all right, but my limbs get heavy and sluggish, and the moment I close my eyes I fall dead asleep — that's just playing with my life."

A smile flickered across the bartender's face. "But it's still not efficient enough, is it? I'll keep an eye out and see if there's a suitable medication for you."

If she could pop a pill and get the same effect, that would be wonderful. But until she had that pill, she had no choice but to grit her teeth and force the drink down.

If she still wanted to keep living this life.

When night fell, Sydney changed into running shoes and athletic wear and pulled her hair up into a tight bun.

She packed all her usual gear into a bag — not an ordinary backpack, but a half-body-height hiking pack of the kind trekkers used, big enough to stuff a sleeping bag into.

Though she didn't plan to stay long, Sydney didn't dare be careless, and still brought a hunting knife, a ladies' handgun, and a can of bear spray.

What a shame — with real-world laws to contend with, none of these things could be used directly on the stalker; in the end she still had to go the long way around.

The time on her phone ticked over to 9:43 PM.

Harassment messages — each from a different number — kept flooding in without pause, piling up at the bottom of the screen, not a single one swiped open; the unread message count had already reached 129.

Sydney had discovered a few hours ago that the stalker had posted her number on dozens of yellow websites; since then, the messages coming in were not only nauseating but impossible to block fast enough.

She simply shoved the phone to the very bottom of her backpack, out of sight, out of mind.

Night had dyed the entire floor-to-ceiling window black; she sat on the floor before it, as if suspended in midair, adrift among Blackmoor City's skyscrapers and countless lights.

The neon glow, bright as scattered diamonds, would persist through the deep of the night and into the dawn. This city — the largest and most prosperous metropolis on earth — never slept, never rested.

The drink the bartender had prepared for her, she forced down sip by sip, enduring the discomfort, until her consciousness was soon scorched into something light and floating, her blood churning and bubbling; even though the apartment was perfectly quiet, she seemed to hear a hum coming from somewhere.

The primal fear honed by millions of years of evolution was not something that could be habituated to or overcome simply by trying again and again.

If she didn't drink large quantities of alcohol, if she didn't dull her mind into a hazy stupor, Sydney didn't even have the courage to walk to the edge of the balcony — she had always been severely acrophobic; she wouldn't even ride roller coasters at an amusement park.

She gripped the balcony railing with trembling hands, drew a breath, and stepped up onto the chair she had prepared.

The backpack hung heavy from her shoulders, and as she pushed herself up to sit on the railing it caught and scraped against it; the lurch of her body nearly sent both her heart and her stomach sliding up her throat, and it was only with great effort that she steadied her breathing, her palms soaked through with cold sweat.

Even drunk, she still dared not look down, keeping her gaze fixed on the city skyline.

Far away between the buildings, rivers of traffic flowed, countless headlights blurring into bright smears in the fine drifting rain. The cool, thin rain fell in close, slanting lines against her skin, and Sydney felt a vague worry that the cold rain might sober her up, stripping away the blessed numbness.

...Time to go.

She sat on the railing, her back to the neon lights of Blackmoor City, watching her reflection in the glass door and the faint outline of the living room beyond it.

"I'll be right back," Sydney Ginn said softly to the apartment. "Wait for me."

She closed her eyes, leaned back, and fell straight down into the cool early-November night wind.

*I'm back, everyone — first thing I did was eat until I couldn't anymore, god it felt like getting out of jail, I nearly cried over the food — wait, no, what am I saying, the first thing I did was sit my butt down and write, for real!

Hehehe I just posted four chapters and already swapped away from Mai Minghe — sorry about that. The worldbuilding needs multiple perspectives or it'll be confusing for too long, which isn't great. I won't be switching POVs that often going forward.

I should have given a heads-up at the end of the last chapter, but I forgot... donkeys have bad memories, and apparently so do I — you all are hippocampi, I'm a hippo-donkey, the pirated version glitches out, but paying readers will definitely forgive me (right?).

I've always thought one of the big reasons Western fantasy is hard to get into is the names... so I've given all the Western characters in this story names that Chinese readers can actually remember. Take Sydney Ginn — her name is translated as 金雪梨 (Jin Xuěli). If I'd called her 西

妮 · 洁, who would even know who that is, right? I picked up this trick while writing Milady, and it really works — solid 4.8 stars on the reviews.

*Why am I sticking this ramble at the end of the main text? Because the author's note section ran out of space, and I just can't bring myself not to ramble. This chapter is free anyway, so you can't say I'm padding the word count.

Let me see which impatient grannies have made themselves my creditors this time...

Alright, I now honorably owe Tiánxiá one bonus chapter (how does it always end up costing me more than it saves?), owe Magical Grey Feather one big healthy bouncing baby of a bonus chapter (didn't I just say don't be in such a rush?! I actually feel bad), and owe Yīngyòu one big healthy baby (I'd be better off going to stake out the maternity ward at People's Hospital — faster that way)... what are you all doing, you're already here, you didn't have to bring gifts too (lol.

Thank you Tángmián Yè, Shí Zhī Yōulíng, Please Call Me A-Qī, and 锦o (maybe I'll scrape together one kid for the four of you — go home and split it into four pieces, my stockpile is already shivering with cold sweat)

Thank you Péng Xiǎoxī, Pūpū Hāhā, Mí Miēmiē, Mò Yuān (pronounced Black Bird), Fēitiān Dàdào Zéi, Déyún Fūjìn, Kafka, A-Shí qwq, Sān Xī Yī, Yūki Akinana, Qīngqīng Jiǔ, Me and Honeydew Are Mortal Enemies (Melon!!), Jiāng Lù Jīng Lúfù, and Today I Had a Roasted Sweet Potato — what's the rush, grannies, isn't it nicer to let this relationship flow gently like a stream? What if it turns out not good, I'm already second-guessing myself.

Counting the grannies from before, how many bonus chapters do I owe now? Five?

...Five?????

.....????????

Time flows like a river — and by "time," does that mean my stockpile?!

Chapter 6: Sydney Ginn's Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion

She had lost count of how many times she'd fallen from a great height.

Sooner or later, between the alcohol and the repeated falls, her heart would slam against her sternum one final time—and then Sydney Ginn would cease to exist.

But at least this time, she was still alive; even as the blood her heart was furiously pumping surged in waves through her skull, sending wave after wave of dizziness crashing through her.

The hot alcohol turned to sweat and burst from her pores, and the needle-sharp burning across her back faded into a cool, damp chill.

Sydney Ginn would perhaps never stop fearing the fall; but after so many jumps, she had at least learned to land without screaming—there was only her breathing now, ragged and heavy, nearly a whimper; fear like a centipede, crawling and scratching inside her chest and throat.

She had landed in the same old place again.

The room was adrift with the smell of stale dust, the kind that called to mind old cardboard boxes; dim and cool and dark, but not a deep darkness—more like a half-drawn curtain that you could push aside with one hand and find someone hiding behind it.

Sydney Ginn didn't move.

The alcohol still rolled through her like waves born inside her body, rocking and pushing at her.

Something must have been watching over her, because no matter what position she jumped from, she always landed on her feet, like a cat blessed by the heavens.

She crouched in place for a few seconds, then reached out her right hand into the darkness to feel for the wall. Every time she landed, the alcohol left her unsteady on her feet, and she would brace herself against the wall on her right—if someone shone a flashlight on it, they'd probably see the wallpaper gleaming where it had been soaked through with the oils from her hand.

The moment her hand touched something smooth, flat, and square—a plastic panel—she yanked it back as if electrocuted, cursed under her breath, and felt a cold wave of belated terror prickle across her skin.

...Impossible to guard against everything, she thought. Last time she was here, the light switch definitely hadn't been on this wall.

Fortunately, her hand hadn't had enough weight behind it to press down that eager, impatient light switch.

Sydney Ginn moved slowly into the corner and felt her way to the same spot where the faucet always was, then turned it on. She cupped her hands and drank several large mouthfuls; the faucet squeaked and squeaked as it turned two full rotations, then fell silent again.

Unlike food, water in the Nest was generally safe.

Sydney Ginn pulled a flattened fried doughnut and a can of coffee from her bag.

Drink before the jump to numb the fear with alcohol to its limit; after landing, wash the alcohol out with fried food and coffee as best she could—every single time Sydney Ginn entered the Nest, she had to go through the same routine.

She leaned against the corner of the wall and, though she had no appetite at all, forced herself to finish eating, then carefully packed the empty can and paper bag back into her backpack.

Never leave personal belongings behind in the Nest—not even if it's trash. That was a Hunter's first lesson. When she had learned it, Sydney Ginn couldn't remember anymore.

On the far side of the sink, there was a locked storage cabinet.

She fumbled in the dark for several tries before finally fitting the key into the lock; from behind the silently swinging cabinet door, she felt out a radio—cool, heavy, square, and solid.

The static crackle of electricity rose from the depths of the darkness and settled beside her; as she turned the dial searching for the channel, the static slowly resolved into a man's voice.

"Welcome to Nest Radio 173," the man's voice said quietly, as if he were about to begin telling a story. "This is the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion. I am your host."

No name—only "your host."

His—or perhaps its, since no human could live in the Nest—entire identity seemed to exist solely in relation to the radio station.

No matter when Sydney Ginn turned on the radio, the first words she heard were always "Welcome to Nest Radio 173"—as if the host were waiting at all times, and a listener turning on

the receiver was what switched him on.

"Today is Monday, November 16th, 2026."

Time in the Nest moved at the same pace as in the outside world; Sydney Ginn glanced at her phone and confirmed it once more.

On the phone screen, over a hundred ugly unread messages were frozen in place; no signal, no new texts coming in.

"First, let's bring you the Nest news."

In the darkness, Sydney Ginn listened while she waited for the coffee and food to take effect. This hideout should be known only to her, so there was no need to worry about anyone barging in.

In the Nest, where a single moment of distraction could mean the difference between life and death, she sat perfectly still listening to the radio—when she thought about it, she found it a little funny herself.

She was a solo Hunter, without the backing of a House Faction, and the Artifacts she'd managed to get her hands on in the past had all been bottom-tier; by rights, she had no room to be choosy—she should take any Artifact she could get, sell any Artifact she had.

But this one radio—this, she would never sell to anyone. It was her lifeline.

"...We trust that all Residents who truly love the Nest will be very pleased? A great threat to the Nest had only just begun to take root, yet it was swiftly stamped out through the combined efforts of all parties. We hope everyone will share this good news with friends and family—if you haven't already made them into dinner."

Sydney Ginn listened with only half her attention. Honestly, she hadn't understood it; and she had no idea what "great threat" referred to.

The broadcast wasn't made for humans; the host's audience was the Residents of the Nest, so out of every ten sentences, there were about eight that she couldn't follow.

As long as it seemed to have nothing much to do with her, Sydney Ginn couldn't be bothered to puzzle it out; the curiosity she'd felt when she first got the radio had, after nearly dying once, long since vanished completely.

She understood barely half of it, yet she listened anyway.

"A Toyota with the license plate MKA-388 has been parked at the entrance of the Buluan District Public Library for more than seven days. The owner is requested to move the vehicle as soon as possible, or it will be added to the library's vengeance list."

The license plate sounded like a real Blackmoor City plate... could a Hunter really have driven a car in here?

If it had been sitting there that long, the owner was probably dead.

The thought passed through her mind and left no mark.

Being an Artifact Hunter meant racing against the darkness; the Hunters who had been swept under by its black waves and sunk forever into the depths of the Nest were beyond counting by now.

Sooner or later, she would sink down too; she just didn't know what form her grave would take when it finally appeared before her.

"...Next, we'll bring you traffic conditions and map information."

Sydney Ginn snapped to attention, the effects of the alcohol fading considerably, her mind sharpening. She quickly pulled out a pen and a brand-new Blackmoor City tourist map, clamped her phone between her teeth, and used the faint glow of its screen to spread the map out on the concrete floor.

"First," the host said, as though even he understood the importance of this information, slowing his pace, "streets from Fifth to One Hundred and Ninetieth remain unchanged and are accessible as normal today."

She let out a breath of relief.

Whether it was a good thing or a bad thing was unclear, but the Nest seemed to have a life of its own—always slowly mutating.

Before she got the radio, every time Sydney Ginn opened a passage and dropped into the Nest, she had to brace herself mentally—even a location she'd explored more than a hundred times, the next time you pushed open the door, you might still step into a room you'd never seen before.

The Nest resembled Blackmoor City's layout, but in a distorted, off-kilter kind of way—as if the Nest were a slanted, warped mirror image, twisted by light and shadow, breeding from the

gaps and crevices of shade things that did not belong to this world.

Was this a crack in the universe, a legendary hell, or the delusion inside the mind of a madman?

Sydney Ginn had come here more times than she could count, and still didn't know the answer.

After listening to enough broadcasts, she had worked out the patterns.

"Currently undergoing construction/renovation/repair"—this meant the area was in the process of changing.

"Attracting a large number of visitors / a great weekend destination"—absolutely do not go near it; you had to give even the surrounding area a wide berth.

"Unchanged, accessible as normal"—exactly as it sounded: as long as you had previously scouted the terrain and assessed the risks, you could still trust your last experience.

The thing Sydney Ginn had prepared to deal with her stalker was hidden on 99th Street, which happened to fall within an area showing no unusual changes; if everything went smoothly, the journey from her landing spot to 99th Street would take only two days, and she could retrieve the item and return to Blackmoor City.

Two days... she couldn't help letting out a self-deprecating laugh.

By distance alone, it was at most fifteen kilometers between the two points; but in the Nest, covering fifteen kilometers in two days counted as remarkably smooth going.

By the time the traffic and map report was finished, Sydney Ginn's map was covered in circles of all sizes, along with annotations like "DANGER!" "GO STRAIGHT" and "Bus available, but don't talk to the driver."

Based on the experience she had bought with her life over and over again, the broadcasts could be trusted.

If she ever decided to retire, this radio could probably fetch her at least a million dollars.

But Sydney Ginn knew she could never retire—even with a million waiting for her, she couldn't bear to stop being a Hunter—there were too many things in this world worth trying, her desires ran too deep, and a million was far from enough.

"I'm doing him too much of a favor," Sydney Ginn thought, growing more irritated the more she dwelled on it. "What kind of rat crawls out of the gutter thinking he deserves me to bring back an Artifact just to deal with him..."

She put the map and pen away and was just about to pick up the radio from the floor—which was currently playing "Nest's Hottest New Songs Chart No. 1," a track that wasn't actually too bad, sounding like a howling wind through a forest with faint, drawn-out human shrieks woven through it—when the "music" suddenly paused and stopped.

Then again, with something like drawn-out human shrieks, who could ever tell which one was the last?

"What a soothing and melodious song," the host murmured. "I just received a listener call-in, so I'll be adding a special emergency broadcast segment."

Sydney Ginn's breath caught.

A "special emergency broadcast"—since she'd gotten the radio, she had only heard it twice.

The first time, the special emergency broadcast had helped her find a fixed, hidden, and private landing spot—the very small room she was in right now.

She hadn't even known before that, that a human could bind a landing point within the Nest.

In the past, every time Sydney Ginn opened a passage and dropped into the Nest, she had appeared in a public landing point like everyone else—City Hall, the Contre-Jour Garden, St. Louis Hospital, and so on—surrounded by Hunters, Residents, and countless other unknowns, she hadn't even dared stay in one place long enough to finish a coffee.

The second time, the Artifact she obtained through the special emergency broadcast had bought her that apartment in Blackmoor City—the kind of place an ordinary person couldn't get close to in a lifetime. Beyond the payment, the buyer had also signed an open-ended contract: for as long as Sydney Ginn lived, she would have permanent right of residence in that apartment.

Now the third time had finally come.

In that moment, Sydney Ginn's entire field of vision narrowed to the radio on the floor; she forgot to breathe, every ounce of her focus sharpening into a hook, clamped tight around every single word coming through.

"...After entering through Door D of the Museum of Modern Art, take the elevator on the left down to basement level one."

The host's voice flowed slowly from the radio, as if projecting the interior layout of the building inside her mind. "Remember—you must take the first elevator on the left. If the doors of any other elevator open, do not get in, do not look, and no matter what happens, pretend you don't notice."

Although the broadcast audience seemed to be Nest Residents, there were always these small details that made Sydney Ginn feel as though the host was issuing instructions to her specifically—or rather, to whatever Hunter happened to be listening.

"The 'Candlefall' in the first basement exhibition hall is something you'll want to keep in mind. From what I know, it only recently became an Artifact—and some might say it is one of the most powerful Artifacts the Nest has ever produced."

The host paused, as if he could sense the thudding of Sydney Ginn's heartbeat.

"To anyone thinking of going to take a look—take my advice. Human fate is as thin and fragile as a cotton cloth. The floods of this world are too many, too unpredictable—they surge and crash without mercy. A person can only be torn apart and swallowed up in the churning currents, flung by forces far greater than themselves toward a future they cannot see clearly.

"And an Artifact... is a mountain torrent and a tidal wave, a storm and a towering wall of water. It is the genie that grants your wishes, and the god that heeds no pleas..."

He got this far, and then, as if what came next was too difficult to say, he trailed off involuntarily.

The darkened room fell silent for a moment; the host had no breath—Sydney Ginn had realized that long ago.

In the room there were only four or five breathing sounds, including her own, rising and falling together in the dark.

"Dear listeners, that's all for today's broadcast. Please stay safe, everyone—until next time."

Sydney Ginn stood there in a daze for a few seconds, then grabbed the radio and stowed it away again. Feeling her way to the door handle, she cracked the door open and slipped out.

The Museum of Modern Art was in the direction she was already heading.

Go to the museum first to see the Artifact the broadcast mentioned, then head to 99th Street to get what she needed to deal with Anthony...

A day or two's delay was no big deal.

Sydney Ginn only has one chapter, there's nothing in the drafts.

I've seen people asking what Mai Minghe's English name is—Mai Minghe is actually ethnically Chinese, so her Chinese name is just Mai Minghe; but of course she does have an English name, and it's one I'm quite proud of, so pretty that I regret giving it to her—River Rye.

I kind of want to take it back for myself lol.

What's wrong with that? A daughter giving her mother a little tribute is only right, isn't it.

For minor supporting characters like that nuisance Anthony, I'm not going to bother Sinicizing the names—if you can't remember them, you can't remember them; coming up with names that sound both good and distinctive is such a headache.

Writing on an iPad while away from home is such a pain, ugh, it's really affecting my output.

Now I want an e-ink tablet again lol.

Chapter 7 – Sydney Ginn: The Hunter's Life Is No Easy Living

Night in Blackmoor City is also night in the Nest.

Wind tumbled down through the cracks between heaven and earth, tossing her bangs astray. If she squinted and peered out through the shadow of her lashes, Sydney Ginn could barely tell whether she was in the Nest or in Blackmoor City.

A Blackmoor City abandoned and desolate, its shadows twisting, every detail more unsettling the deeper you looked—at the intersection ahead, the green light on the traffic signal had gone dark, replaced by a purple one, blinking on and off; the surface of the empty road was seized by the purple light, then released, seized, then released.

Only sound was truly honest: she couldn't hear car engines, rolling tires, or honking horns; no voices in conversation, no dogs barking, no video blogger narrating into a selfie camera. At this moment, the only sound Sydney Ginn could hear was a steady footstep, one after another.

A soft "tap"—her left foot meeting the ground; before she could even lift her right foot, she heard another "tap."

The footsteps behind her had been following her for several minutes now.

Whoever it was didn't seem much like a Hunter; Hunters who crossed paths in the Nest tended to keep their distance, sizing each other up with cautious wariness—the ever-present threat of extreme danger kept everyone's nerves wound tight, and nobody wanted to invite extra trouble.

If it wasn't a Hunter, then it was a Resident.

Should she pretend not to notice?

Sydney Ginn opened her phone's camera, held it flat against her chest, angled it slightly up over her shoulder, and snapped a photo—quick and discreet.

She quickened her pace to put some distance between them, then darted a glance at the screen.

In the photo, a warped, grinning version of Sydney Ginn's own face was staring back at her.

The teeth were white and enormous, packed so densely they could barely fit inside the mouth, the lips nearly insufficient to contain them. The figure looked to be resting its cheek on someone's

shoulder, flashing a "yeah" hand sign.

Sydney Ginn recognized it at once—that shoulder was her own.

What rotten luck.

"Get lost!" Sydney Ginn hissed without turning around, slashing her hunting knife backward to drive the thing back a few steps. "Who do you think you're dealing with? You think I'm not long for this world?"

Silence from behind. A few seconds of stillness, then she heard her own voice let out a low, tittering "heh heh."

...So it wasn't going to leave on its own.

Annoying as it was, her luck wasn't entirely bad—whatever had latched onto her wasn't especially dangerous.

This type of Resident was common in the Nest. When they set their sights on someone, they would wrench their face into that person's likeness, though the result was always slightly off—an extra eyeball in the right eye socket, a single black hole in place of nostrils, or, as now, a mouth so crammed with teeth it could barely close.

They simply followed their target wearing the target's face, and while deeply unsettling, they posed no immediate threat.

Only after a target met with danger and died would this type of Resident pounce, coiling and writhing and feeding upon the corpse, until when it finally raised its face, it had become an exact, flawless replica of the original. Some said it was perhaps because they longed to return to the human world that they wished to impersonate humans and slip back into Blackmoor City in the original's place—though that was just hearsay, not worth taking seriously.

In other words, they were like vultures over a desert, perpetually circling above animals on the verge of death.

This particular Resident had probably caught the smell of alcohol on Sydney Ginn, noticed the faint sway still in her step, and decided she wouldn't last much longer.

Its technique wasn't up to par with its kind, though—ordinarily, a "Vulture" trailing someone wouldn't let the Hunters notice at all; this one was stomping along quite audibly.

Still, harmless as it might be, knowing that thing's face was hovering just over her shoulder was irritating enough.

She listened carefully, gauging the distance between footfalls with her attention, calculating whether she could create an opportunity to shake it—when a thought suddenly broke through: something's wrong.

Sydney Ginn's whole body jerked. She stopped dead in her tracks, and before she'd even gotten a clear look at the ground ahead, she threw herself sideways off the path, her back hitting the railing with a loud clang.

That noise—who knew whether it would draw other Residents now...

But this wasn't the time to worry about what came next—she'd almost fallen for the Vulture Resident's trick.

"Sydney Ginn" was still standing just a step or two away, watching her, the lower half of its face all smiles and teeth. But the eyes grew deeper and deeper, darker and darker, until they resembled a pair of holes poked by a child's finger into dough.

Sydney Ginn did her best not to look at it, and swept a glance at the ground she had almost stepped onto.

A long chalk-drawn hopscotch grid stretched out ahead, extending far beyond what she could see, covering the entire width of the sidewalk.

The chalk had faded, submerged in the dim yellow glow of the streetlights and the shadows cast by the trees along the roadside; if you didn't look carefully, it was nearly impossible to notice.

The first row had four squares. The first three were blank; only the last one, at the edge, had writing: "Right foot."

"Damn it all, waiting here for me, were you."

Sydney Ginn wiped the cold sweat from her neck with her sleeve, and hissed at her other self: "No wonder your footsteps were so clear, deliberately falling in the gaps between mine, just to make sure I heard you..."

It had been deliberate.

It had wanted Sydney Ginn to fix all her attention on what was behind her, her mind occupied with the question of "how to shake the Vulture"—and there were only so many ways to

shake someone following close behind, and whichever method she chose, she would have ended up breaking into a run and stepping straight into the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid.

If she hadn't stepped into the square marked "Right foot" with her right foot, she would have been in serious trouble.

"November 17th, the Nest, Colorado Avenue. A chalk-drawn Hopscotch has appeared here."

Sydney Ginn opened her voice memo app and briefly described what had just happened, then said, "Although the 'Vulture' did not directly harm anyone, it has shown signs of luring targets into a trap... This is a new behavioral pattern, worth noting."

She had never joined a Hunter House Faction, so when it came to gathering and updating intelligence on the Nest, she naturally couldn't match the systematic, organized approach of House Faction Hunters.

But she had her own way of surviving: she would bring whatever valuable information she'd collected to the bar called "Against the Light," where the owner—whose face looked like a Shar-Pei—would exchange a different set of information in return. He was like a human information exchange board, or a primitive version of LinkedIn.

She put her phone away and looked around, almost wanting to sigh.

To the right was a row of stone-brick townhouses; short flights of steps climbed up to each front door. Between the staircases, clusters of trees separated one from the next, and the railing she'd just slammed into stood just outside the tree line.

Never mind that she was trying to get to the Museum of Modern Art—even if she weren't, she absolutely could not just wander into a Nest building.

To the left, the road was empty; all she had to do was step off the sidewalk and walk along the street to go around the chalk house—under normal circumstances, that would have worked, but not now, because the traffic light was still purple.

"If it weren't for all this garbage, why would fifteen kilometers take two whole days to walk..."

Sydney Ginn muttered under her breath, tucked away her knife and phone, adjusted her trail pack, cinched it tight around her waist, and stepped her right foot into the square.

She stood in the square on one leg like a crane, the alcohol not yet entirely faded, rolling and pushing against her ankle in waves; Sydney Ginn broke into a cold sweat all over, swaying unsteadily, one hand gripping the railing.

The square said right foot only, so she absolutely could not add a left foot.

The smile on "Sydney Ginn's" face froze rigid, then, starting from the cheekbones, began slowly contorting. One cheekbone jutted further and further out, while the other gradually slid downward.

Was it about to give up, seeing that she hadn't taken the bait?

As a rule, when a Vulture saw that "replacing" its target was hopeless, it would abandon the target's likeness—either shifting into someone else's face, or retreating into the shadows and vanishing.

Watching your own features, your own face, warp and melt off another face the way ice cream melts on a summer day—other Hunters had said it was an unexpectedly unpleasant thing to witness.

"Get lost now, and I won't kill you."

Sydney Ginn threw out a hollow threat, turned back, switched to her left foot, and hopped to the middle square of the next row; the moment her single foot landed, the trail pack dragged heavily downward, as if someone had jumped onto her back.

Her hands spun around like a windmill several times before she finally steadied herself, and in her mind she had killed the harassing lunatic Anthony back and forth ten times over—naturally, everything bad was his fault.

But if something good came of this trip, like getting her hands on a rare Artifact, that would obviously be entirely thanks to herself.

She just had to wait for the purple light to go out, and then find a moment to jump off the sidewalk.

The first four or five rows of squares were still reasonable: though hopping forward one foot at a time with a pack weighing more than ten kilograms on her back and alcohol still in her system was exhausting work, at least it wasn't impossible.

At some point—she lost track of which square—the writing inside the squares was no longer just "left foot" or "right foot."

"Left hand," read one square.

The squares on either side of it listed penalties—"Lose consciousness," "Lose all red blood cells produced in the past year," "Visit No. 87 Colorado Avenue."

Fortunately, there was a utility pole right beside that square.

With great difficulty, Sydney Ginn hugged her pack with one arm, braced her feet against the pole, and tipped herself upside down, pressing her left hand into the square—she felt like a circus acrobat, stretching one leg out far behind her, her whole body a trembling, lopsided "Y," barely managing to land on the next square.

"Exchange food for the right to stand," said another square.

That was nothing; Sydney Ginn had no shortage of food in her pack, and good food at that.

She stood on the spot she had purchased with a beef sausage, rested her trembling limbs for a moment, then looked up—and stopped cold.

Every single square within sight ahead was covered in the same three words, packed in densely.

Copied copied copied copied copied copied copied copied

...All penalties?

Copied? What would happen if she stepped on one—

A chill shot through Sydney Ginn. She slowly turned her head, and there on her shoulder she saw a chubby-cheeked profile, flush and round.

Somehow, at some point, it had crept back up without a sound.

She was only about a hundred meters from the traffic light now, yet the purple glow kept blinking on and off, as if it had absolutely no intention of leaving.

The road to the Museum of Modern Art had barely begun, and already she was at a standstill.

Sydney Ginn thought of "The Nest's Current No. 1 Hit Song."

Truly, no exaggeration—the only "song" that could express and carry what she felt in this moment was one of long, drawn-out human howling.

Only six days in and I've already slipped up—can't keep the 10:15 update time anymore...
Whatever, I posted today! Deal with it!

Typed the whole thing with my head drooping, and now my neck is killing me (at home my computer sits on a stand at eye level, so my neck doesn't get tired).

I don't have much neck to begin with—what happens if I lose what's left.

Feeling a bit dizzy and awful, let me go eat something first, then I'll organize everyone's names from the patron list...

(Let me know when you think would be a good time to tell my mom she's suddenly got a lot of new moms.)

Chapter 8: Sydney Ginn's Blackmoor City Transportation and Tourism

Map

"What I'm about to say may be hard to believe. I find it hard to believe myself.

"I'm still standing inside the chalk-drawn hopscotch grid, and I have nowhere to go. I can't go back—I've tried. Behind me, two rows away, there's a square with 'left hand' written in it. When I came through, I could use a utility pole to do a one-handed handstand, but going back, I can't reach that pole anymore."

Carrying a heavy backpack while doing a one-handed handstand on her weaker left side—Sydney Ginn couldn't manage it. Hunters had a passage and could enter the Nest, but that didn't transform them or grant them supernatural strength.

What's more, the Resident's breathing floated constantly at her ear; in the corner of her eye, her own face lingered, vaguely distorted, like a reflection sunk deep underwater, watching her.

She had been gripping the hunting knife again for quite some time now.

Sydney Ginn closed her eyes, then opened them. On the road to her left, the silence continued to be split open—sliced through again and again by flashes of violet light, like wet viscera exposed under an X-ray.

"It seems like Hopscotch and the 'Vulture' Residents have developed a kind of... cooperative relationship."

Sydney Ginn murmured into her phone's voice memo: "I can't think of a better explanation than that they're working together."

The Vultures had tried to drive her into the hopscotch grid, and the grid had returned the favor—once she'd gone deep enough that she couldn't turn back, it had written "Copied" as the penalty in the squares ahead of her...

If she had actually stepped on one, the Resident following behind her would probably become a second Sydney Ginn.

And what would happen to her then?

The original hadn't even died yet, and a Vulture had already become the target itself—she had never heard of such a thing.

"Maybe I'm overthinking it... The traffic light on the road hasn't changed color for nearly ten minutes now. It's been purple the whole time, keeping me trapped on the sidewalk. Could it also be part of this trap? It's hard to imagine... Unlike Residents, other things don't have intelligence. How would they work together?"

The information recorded in the voice memo served more than one purpose, beyond being exchanged as intelligence later.

If she could never leave the Nest and ultimately died here, she could at least imagine that someday her phone would be picked up by some Hunter.

Who she was, where she died, the last moments of her life—none of it would sink with her into the depths of the Nest.

Perhaps somewhere in this world, another person would hear the last few words of her life and know that a Sydney Ginn had once existed. Even if in the very next moment, like wind scattering smoke, her name dissolved with a single turn of that person's thoughts.

Sometimes when she thought about it, she found it strange: someone like her, bursting with desires and devoted to pleasure, was ready to die at any moment, anywhere.

Perhaps without that readiness, you couldn't make it as an Artifact Hunter.

She put away her phone and looked at the traffic light again.

She didn't really need to look up to know the purple light was still on; but what else could she do besides staring at the traffic light over and over?

The buzz of the alcohol had mostly worn off, but her energy and stamina seemed to have evaporated along with it, seeping out through her pores, leaving behind a body that felt loose and heavy; the muscles in her legs trembled, as if they couldn't hold on to the bones.

The square read "trade food for the right to stand"—it said nothing about sitting, so Sydney Ginn didn't dare sit down; the backpack, weighing some ten-odd kilograms, she kept on top of her feet, not daring to let it touch the chalk drawings.

"Just you wait," she said quietly to the Resident beside her. "I don't believe that purple light can stay on for seven days straight."

The Resident didn't respond. It probably knew, too, that Sydney Ginn was just bluffing—even with food and water, standing for seven days straight without sleep was enough to kill a person.

Well, this was exactly why most Hunters, after a few solo runs into the Nest, would put in applications to the major Hunter House Factions... Even someone like Sydney Ginn, who hated taking orders and couldn't stand being managed by others, found herself sighing: it would be nice to have a partner watching her back right now.

She stood in one square of the chalk hopscotch grid as the night wind grew increasingly cool; the longer she stood, the more foolish she felt—what was she even doing here?

She'd survived a fall from a great height, only to stand here like a human post?

After racking her brain for a while, running through every option including climbing a tree and walking a tightrope, only to have each one shot down by reality, Sydney Ginn had even screwed up her courage and, with a what-have-I-got-to-lose attitude, shouted "someone help!" twice—whether it was good luck or bad, nothing came out of that row of stone-brick Western-style houses in response.

She'd tried several plans and was back to her old standby of being a human post.

It would've been nice if the broadcast had given a heads-up—had she known, she never would have taken this wretched road.

That said, Sydney Ginn also knew it was far too much to ask.

If the Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion were to introduce the road conditions on every single street in the Nest, by the time it finished broadcasting, she'd have already gone back to Blackmoor City and there would be nothing left to do.

Thinking of the broadcast made her think of her own map, covered in annotations—wait, what if those annotations could actually be useful?

Sydney Ginn glanced over at "Sydney Ginn."

It was still standing two steps away, but it was looking more and more repulsive—when she'd turned her head just now, it had mimicked her, rolling its dark irises to the right so the whites showed, and then staying like that for a long time, unable to roll them back.

That was her own face. She'd have nightmare material for a week.

Sydney Ginn slid the hunting knife back into its sheath at her waist, took the map out of her backpack, shook it open, and studied the annotations carefully by the flickering violet light and the murky yellow glow of a streetlamp.

A few minutes later, she looked up from the map and snapped a sharp curse at the Resident beside her: "Son of a bitch!"

"Sydney Ginn," unaware it had been cursed at, stared at Sydney Ginn with rapt, entranced attention, and its lower lip suddenly drooped crookedly, as if it were trying to mimic the shape of her mouth.

"Get over here!" Sydney Ginn had found nothing useful on the map, and her anger was surging. "They all say Residents can't be killed—so you won't mind if I stab you a few times, will you? Get over here!"

"Sydney Ginn" simply would not come over.

The more she thought about it, the more furious she got. She pressed her lips tightly shut, worked her tongue around for a moment, gathered up a mouthful of spit, and "ptoo!"—spat it all out onto the chalk square at "Sydney Ginn's" feet. Not that whatever penalty the square handed out was any of her concern.

Unfortunately, the square wasn't about to be washed away by spit—though it would have been wonderful if it could—that patch of foamy wet stain dried in the blink of an eye, as if absorbed by the floor tiles, leaving the chalk drawing completely unchanged beneath.

As a result, "Sydney Ginn" mimicked her: pressed its lips tightly shut, and its tongue seemed to stir as well.

"Oh, you've got to be kidding me,"

Sydney Ginn finally panicked a little, and quickly raised her backpack, ready to use it as a shield against the Resident's spit—but thankfully the Resident seemed to be physiologically different on the inside, and when it opened its mouth, it was just a dark, dry hollow. Nothing came out.

The interlude was over, and she was still at a complete loss.

Sydney Ginn stared at the words "Blackmoor City Tourism and Transportation Map" and had no idea what to do. Her eyes lingered on the map, but her thoughts had drifted away, wandering blankly to some unknown place.

By the time she came back to herself, she realized she had been staring at several rows of small print in the lower right corner of the map's reverse side for several minutes already.

Sydney Ginn slowly narrowed her eyes.

The tourism and transportation map included a great deal of additional information—emergency numbers, police numbers, tourism website URLs, travel insurance details... Among all those rows of small print, her gaze snagged on one thing in particular.

The taxi service hotline for Blackmoor City.

Of course, this was a phone number from the real world.

She was currently inside a delusion-like, nightmare-like mirror world, where there wasn't even a phone signal...

A mirror world...

The yellow taxi—one of Blackmoor City's iconic symbols, the yellow taxi that appeared in countless films and television shows—would it also cast its mirror image inside the Nest?

The thought was like a hand placed at the back of her mind, nearly impossible to ignore.

Sydney Ginn was inwardly laughing at herself for having an overactive imagination, for being driven by desperation into wishful thinking, and yet she once again reached for her phone without meaning to—and of course, the upper right corner showed "No Signal."

She hesitated, but in the end entered the service hotline number digit by digit and pressed call.

There was no harm in trying; even if it didn't work, was she really afraid of being laughed at by "Sydney Ginn" standing next to her?

In her taut, tense anticipation, from beneath the night sky sliced into black and violet, came the sound of a dial tone—"beep—beep—beep—"

"Hello," a woman's voice came on. "Do you need a taxi?"

She stood there with her mouth half open, dumbstruck and silent. Was this a hallucination?

"Do you need one, or not?" The woman's voice wasn't impatient—it asked the question matter-of-factly, like a machine.

"I—I do!" The words were out of Sydney Ginn's mouth before a new wave of anxiety hit her. "Wait—are there any conditions for calling a taxi? What do you pay with? I do have to pay, right?"

"Of course. Please note the following Passenger Rules," the woman's voice said flatly. "One, tell the driver the address you wish to go to. Two, do not look at the driver. Three, sit in the back seat. Four, lower your head and lean it between the driver's seat and the passenger seat. Five, recall a recent experience in your mind. Six, do not panic when the driver collects payment."

"...Recall?" Even with all her Nest experience, Sydney Ginn was sometimes still thrown by its strangeness.

"Yes. Please note the following fare requirements. One, the recalled experience must be from within the past month. Two, the scenes and events in the recollection must be continuous. Three, the experience being recalled must have lasted at least three minutes when it originally occurred. Four, the driver only accepts the first experience that comes to mind automatically—deliberately screened or selected recollections are not accepted."

"Is that all? Just a memory—nothing else? I'll arrive safely at my destination and get out safely?" Afraid the other party might play word games, she went through every loophole she could think of and plugged them one by one.

"Correct."

"That works perfectly," Sydney Ginn let out a long breath. "Send a car right away!"

Never mind the past month—even going back ten years, there wasn't a single memory she'd rather die than give up; and besides, it was only three minutes.

"I'm on Colorado Avenue," she gave her address, then suddenly remembered something and quickly asked: "Can you have the driver open the car door for me when he stops?"

She looked at the square beneath her feet, then at the road beside it, and measured the distance with her eyes. That gap—she could lunge across it.

It was just that "landing" would be considerably more difficult than a normal landing; she couldn't land on the sidewalk, and she couldn't land on the road either—she'd figure out the specifics once the car arrived.

Almost too smoothly to be real, the woman's voice replied, "Yes."

Sydney Ginn's sudden rescue made her heart leap with joy; she hung up the phone, and the screen reflected half of a face pressed right up against hers.

The duck was about to fly right out of reach—it must be getting anxious too, right?

"Back off,"

Sydney Ginn used the same method as before, swinging the hunting knife in wide circles to force the Resident back a few steps—and when she came back to her senses, she was sitting in the back seat of a taxi.

...Huh?

The taxi, gradually picking up speed, glided smoothly through the purple traffic light, the numbers on the meter perfectly still. A human-shaped silhouette sat in the driver's seat, a leather glove on the hand resting on the steering wheel.

"...Where are we going?"

The question was barely out of her mouth before she realized she was breathing hard, her heart pounding—as if she had just been through a burst of intense physical exertion.

"The Museum of Modern Art," the voice seemed to be the driver answering, but no matter how she listened, it sounded like it was coming from beneath her feet.

Sydney Ginn decided not to look down.

Though she couldn't remember how she'd gotten into the cab, a little reverse reasoning made it easy enough to figure out—the first memory that surfaced in her mind was apparently something that had just happened when she boarded: the process of giving the driver the address and having her memory taken had already been handed over as the fare.

Well, that worked out; she'd turned misfortune into a stroke of luck, and could ride all the way to the Museum of Modern Art in one go.

She turned and glanced back at the other "Sydney Ginn" she was steadily leaving behind.

Even from a distance, she could tell the Resident was furious: it flailed its arms like one of those long inflatable tube men outside car dealerships, thrashing wildly, and every so often it threw its head back and let out a long howl—yet another new behavior.

Hopscotch, the Resident, the taxi... everything she'd encountered tonight was brand-new intelligence.

The Nest seemed to be changing; she just didn't know whether the changes were still within normal range.

But Sydney Ginn couldn't summon the energy to write any of it down just yet—she slumped in her seat and let out a long, slow breath.

Before the next crisis came along to torment her, all she wanted was to rest properly for a moment.

I'm dying—suddenly going back to cranking out daily word counts is a bit much... after all, my one-week stockpile of chapters took three months to write.

My update pace is probably a really bad fit for the male-demographic channels—is there a disabled-friendly channel somewhere? Maybe I should go there.

Chapter 9 — Goodbye, Sydney Ginn

"Thank you for riding,"

The driver's silhouette didn't move an inch—the one absolutely motionless object in the moving cab from start to finish. "You have arrived at your destination."

Sydney Ginn stood on the street beside the Museum of Modern Art; with a "thud," the car door closed behind her.

When she instinctively turned to look, she caught a glimpse of the yellow taxi's red taillights gliding into the fog that rose from the depths of the night and the white steam curling up from the drain grates, blurring into the distance.

...She seemed to have forgotten something.

Sydney Ginn stood in the street and watched the taillights until they vanished into the dark night, the foggy blue, and the smoky white—though she couldn't say why she kept staring after them.

She knew, of course, that a stretch of her memory had been collected as the fare, and no amount of trying would ever bring it back.

But Sydney felt that what she'd forgotten lay beyond that taken memory—as if there was something she should have noticed but hadn't. It was like the feeling she sometimes got before leaving the house, a vague suspicion that she'd left something behind; like a layer of cloud covering part of her mind, impossible to brush aside, the moon nowhere to be seen.

At times like these, no amount of thinking ever helped; you had to wait until you were already out the door and the moment actually came, and then you'd slap your thigh and suddenly understand.

Oh well—she'd gotten off the car with all her limbs intact and her head still on her shoulders, so whatever she'd forgotten clearly wasn't a matter of life and death. She'd remember it sooner or later.

She pressed herself against the glass door of Entrance D, peered inside first, then carefully pushed it open little by little.

Unlike Blackmoor City, buildings and facilities inside the Nest were almost never locked. If you came across a door that wouldn't open, it usually meant there was a Hunter inside—the faint comfort of a lock seemed to be something people who ventured into these strange and treacherous depths clung to all the more tightly.

After all, people can't survive without at least a little illusion of safety. If everyone knew exactly what was happening in the world at every moment, would anyone dare step out their front door?

Sydney held the door open with one hand but didn't go in. She waited a few seconds, and when silence held on the other side, she stepped inside as soundlessly as she could, placing her foot on the floor.

Even deep into the night, the museum had half its lights on, and the hallways, galleries, and elevator lobbies were all soaked in a white light that looked like it had been sterilized.

Perhaps because it was a museum of modern art, the lighting design and architectural style always left one with a sense of vast emptiness and coldness. Walking between the still white walls and white light, she felt almost too "alive"—too warm, too much, entirely out of place.

Following the signs, she quickly found the elevator lobby.

The broadcast had given three main instructions: one, "take the first elevator on the left"; two, "do not look at the other elevators"; three, "go to the basement level"—none of them complicated. Fortunately, the fare she'd paid getting into the cab hadn't been this particular memory, or she'd really have been in trouble.

Sydney pressed the button, planted herself in front of the first elevator on the left, and stared straight ahead at nothing.

This wretched place—sometimes it wasn't surprising in the least; when a clear "ding" shattered the still air, sure enough, the elevator that arrived first was the one on the right.

A dead silence held for a breath, then, like a zipper being slowly undone, the elevator doors parted.

Sydney didn't look, but every hair on her body stood up like a tiny antenna. Her eyes were locked rigidly on the closed elevator doors in front of her, and she had a vague sense that the elevator on the right wasn't empty—there was something in there.

Let it come, she'd made up her mind long ago—never mind a Resident, even if a flood of cash poured out of that right-side elevator, she would not turn her eyes so much as a fraction.

"How wonderful, there's someone out here..."

A woman's voice threaded out of the elevator like a strand of silk, drawn by some invisible hand, trembling in the air. "Listen to me—I came down from the third floor. Something very serious happened up there..."

Don't talk to me, Sydney told herself silently. I'm deaf and blind.

The display above the first elevator on the left glowed with a blood-red "28"; this building had only three floors above ground.

"Don't be afraid,"

The woman's voice, which had started out thin as a thread, was gradually thickening, as if voices, too, had roots. Or perhaps the woman herself was crawling out of the elevator inch by inch, and the source of the sound was drawing closer to Sydney.

"I'm a Hunter from Blackmoor City too—I came in to retrieve an Artifact I'd hidden... but after I got in, I lost track of time... What's today's date? The day I came in, Reagan was giving his victory speech."

I'm blind and deaf, I'm deaf and blind—Sydney repeated it to herself like a chant.

She shifted a step to the side as if by accident—but not too far, in case the elevator doors opened and she couldn't dart in at the first moment.

"Whatever you do, don't get on that elevator,"

Now that the voice was closer, it no longer sounded like silk thread—it had become sewage gurgling up from the mouth of a dark pit. "I never should have listened to the host... The first two times I got what I wanted and that made me overconfident; the third time it led me straight to my death. Lucky I reacted fast enough..."

The moment the words "the host" reached her ears, Sydney almost couldn't suppress the urge to turn her head. She still kept her eyes fixed on the elevator, but her heart lurched as if it had been jabbed, beating nearly out of her control, the sound of it hammering over and over in her ears.

Her gaze was propped in midair, too afraid to drop; yet a dark shadow had slowly risen from the floor and stilled at chest height beside her, as if it were listening with its head tilted.

...Did a racing heartbeat count as a response to the woman?

Sydney didn't dare make any reaction at all. Her breathing and the dark shadow at her chest held each other in a frozen standoff for a few seconds in the cool, silent elevator lobby—until another elevator arrival "ding" finally broke the stagnant air.

The door of the first elevator on the left opened.

Wait—the woman was stopped right in front of her; to get past, she'd have to go around it. But if she went around it, could that still count as ignoring it?

But if she didn't go around it, she couldn't very well walk right through it either.

Sydney watched the door part little by little, revealing an empty elevator car; just as she couldn't make up her mind, she felt the dark shadow at her chest suddenly flinch to one side and pull back.

"Annoying..." the woman seemed to mutter.

Sydney never stopped to wonder why good things happened to her when they did, because good things were fragile, and they couldn't withstand being examined too closely.

The moment the shadow stepped aside, she immediately strode into the elevator and slapped the door-close button over and over—"thwack thwack thwack"—as if she meant to punch through the panel; the whole time, her gaze stayed turned to one side, never once looking toward the doors outside.

But even without looking, she could feel it in the corner of her peripheral vision—a shadow on the floor, its limbs swaying against the ground like some enormous lizard, slowly crawling away into the distance.

Only when the elevator doors finally shut completely, grumbling as they carried her down into the basement level, did Sydney let out the breath she'd been holding clenched inside her chest.

So far, she'd followed the broadcast's instructions to the letter—nothing should go wrong again—

"...The first two times I got what I wanted," the woman's voice suddenly echoed back in her mind, "and the third time led me straight to my death."

Sydney rubbed the corners of her eyes and decided to push that nagging, distracting thought aside for the moment.

The Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion was meant to be heard by the Nest's Residents—it was no surprise at all that the woman knew about the host.

Compared to the lizard-like Resident in the elevator lobby, she still trusted the broadcast host a little more; that "trust," of course, carried within it three parts doubt, three parts wariness, and three parts scrutiny.

Yet the next few minutes seemed to prove that the broadcast host hadn't said a single false word. In the dimly lit basement gallery, she found the exhibit named "Candlefall" with almost no effort—honestly, it would have been harder to miss it.

Sydney stood before the exhibit and stared, dumbfounded.

Because the exhibit named "Candlefall" was a colossal white candle—roughly her height in diameter and easily tens of meters long—lying horizontally on the floor.

If not for its unmistakably waxy, milky-white surface, smooth and faintly lustrous, and the black wick the length of an arm drooping from one end, it would have looked more like a giant's roof beam. The candle rested on a series of iron frames specially built for it, beneath which ran a row of metal troughs whose purpose she couldn't make out.

"This thing is an Artifact?"

The candle was so enormous that Sydney walked around it for a while and still hadn't made it all the way. "Hard to say how powerful it is, but the size alone is really something..."

This big—how was she supposed to bring it back on her own? Would cutting off a piece work?

She couldn't even tell what this Artifact did, let alone whether cutting a piece off would work.

Ordinary art exhibits always came with a brief introduction to the piece and its creator; from experience, if there was detailed information about an Artifact, it was likely in the write-up.

Sure enough, when Sydney walked around to the other side of the candle, she found that the introduction for "Candlefall" covered half a wall of text.

"Some say time is like flowing water; some say time is speed. But artist Judy Picault believes time is wax... The time we are living through is a candle slowly melting away, giving us the

illusion that its form is still within our grasp; yet the moment it passes, it becomes hardened candle tears, fixed forever in the shape of history.

"...The artist's interpretation of time ultimately gave form to the exhibit 'Candlefall.' The colossal candle visitors see before them represents a long, primordial span of time.

"It is an interactive artwork. Visitors may build a fire beneath the iron frames to heat the candle, watching it gradually deform and shed its candle tears."

Among the neat rows of printed black text, there were lines of handwriting scrawled in—crooked, lurching strokes, as if whoever had originally printed the introduction for "Candlefall" had deliberately alternated one passage of orderly reason with one passage of wild, crumbling madness.

"It's an Artifact okay Artifact Artifact an Artifact that melts time"

"Melt time and you free history from its chains! Go look at your own history don't accidentally kill your past self put me inside, what do you say, put me right beside your past self"

The next passage returned to normal.

"Once the candle grows transparent from the heat, visitors will notice the contents the artist has embedded within the wax. They represent historical events that occurred within the span of primordial time. By re-melting the hot wax and reshaping it—altering the contents inside—visitors can change 'what originally happened.' The artist believes..."

Reading this far, Sydney could no longer hold back; she turned to look at the enormous milky-white candle behind her, and for a moment simply didn't know how to process the shock.

You could melt and reshape this candle to alter time—no, to alter history?

Was she understanding this correctly?

If she was, then being called "one of the most powerful Artifacts in existence" was a title it had well and truly earned.

She would need to study the specific instructions more carefully, and ideally try it herself once. She'd also need to figure out what effect it might have on the future.

She had to form a basic understanding first before she could think about next steps. Cutting off a piece to take away probably wasn't going to work; even with other Hunters to help carry it, it

couldn't be moved, since everyone's passage was different and they couldn't go back together. It seemed the only option for now was to hide it somewhere...

That was the last thought passing through Sydney Ginn's mind before she turned around and a hunting knife was driven into her throat.

After half a year off, everything else aside, my typing speed has practically gone in reverse... I've realized there's a kind of resolute beauty in all of you—I clearly have no resemblance to a donkey that cranks out twenty thousand characters a day and pays off a debt in a month, and yet when you all pledged your support, you were so decisive about it that I, a trembling donkey, was left humbled and awed.

For example, Wanjin... if you won't feel sorry for me, who will? Can't we let our bond flow on gently, like a slow stream? Alright, that's a sixth big fat baby owed. And then there's 95 — she really isn't my alt account, and I have no idea what potential she saw in me, sending people and money and effort and support my way. Alright, that's another big fat baby...

Buwenhuakaijiv, Grandma, don't you already know what I'm like — and then there's Changgoagao's Fish, Always on the Side of the Egg, Linze, Shimodege — you're all Grandma's readers, and we can really take it slow. Can't keep shearing the same flock of sheep forever, can I?

I also want to thank Haiyan Qifeng, Love Letter W0ZV, nestea, Fengyin (you two seem like new readers? or just the quiet type?), Dongxie (somehow you all feel like a matching set?), Banxia Jiejie, Jianbing Fujin (please for the love of god stop), Kafka, Qiti, Junmi xi, Xuanfeng Feiwanr, Qiwu, Weba de Qingjiatiao (did you flip it backwards?) and everyone else for all your support and encouragement... The word "thank you" in Chinese feels like I've worn it down to a nub from overuse! I haven't written anything that good either — it's really not worth all this!

Seven — seven chapter update AAAAAAAA

Maybe I should just go catch all seven Calabash Brothers instead

PS: This one definitely won't take as long to write as Doomsday! Even an eighteen-year-old values her life! Two or three years, I say with the reckless confidence of youth.

Chapter 10: A Gathering of Heroes at Mai Minghe

Mai Minghe had never heard of the Nest, and had no idea what a "Resident" was or how dangerous one might be.

But she figured that no matter how strange things appeared on the surface, nothing could ever violate the internal logic governing it.

The hospital inside the Nest seemed to operate by the same principles as a real hospital: press the call button, and a "nurse" would come—or rather, someone "disguised as a nurse" would come—and that someone's target would be whoever had pressed the button.

The only difference was that nurses in a real hospital came to take care of patients; what the "nurses" here intended to do... she didn't let herself think any further.

If she couldn't escape the ward, she was about to find out firsthand anyway—why waste the energy thinking about it?

To get out, she needed to create a few evenly matched rivals for the patient in the next bed.

There was one truth that held both inside and outside the Nest: only when multiple blades clashed against one another would gaps appear; a single blade would pass through her without any distraction.

The real question was: could she slip through the narrow gap between those blades?

Clearly, the red-haired man had figured out the thinking behind her pressing the button.

The moment he steadied himself, he drove his foot hard into Bed No. 2—its locked wheels grinding harshly across the floor—sending the patient and the whole bed crashing into the cabinet and beds behind him; amid the impact, he shouted without looking back: "Even if you wanted to draw the Artifacts out, you didn't have to press the damn button four times!"

He had a point; to be honest, Mai Minghe was feeling a little regretful herself right now.

She had just rolled off the bed again, hoping to use the moment the red-haired man was blocking her to drop down on the other side of Bed No. 1 and make a run for the door; but before Mai Minghe could even swing her leg across the mattress, she stopped dead.

On the other side of Bed No. 1, a nurse was already standing there.

What filled her field of vision was the hem of a light-colored nurse's uniform.

She froze on the bed, staring at that patch of fabric, and realized that in just a few seconds the room had filled with people.

One human-shaped shadow after another, like trees sprouting from the floor, far more than four of them, stood silent and still in the dim ward.

In her peripheral vision she couldn't make out their faces—only the vague impression of round, oversized heads, all exactly alike, every single one turned to face the corner of the room where two living, breathing people remained.

How had so many of them come?

"...Everyone's so kind. I'm actually feeling much better," she said flatly. "Why don't a few of you head back?"

As the "nurse" beside the bed slowly tilted its neck down toward her, Mai Minghe closed her mouth.

A flurry of fragmented, terrifying guesses raced through her mind; but she hadn't expected that when the figure lowered its head, she would find herself looking at a perfectly normal, healthy face.

"Where does it hurt?"

It was a young, soft round face. It—or should she say "she"?—spoke with a slightly drawn-out southern accent, as if she hadn't been on the job long enough to lose it.

If she looked only at the nurse's large eyes with their slightly drooping outer corners and ignored the round heads one after another in her peripheral vision, ignored the slender black silhouette several meters tall rising from behind the red-haired man, Mai Minghe might truly have believed everything just now was an illusion, a dream she'd been having while lying in a hospital bed.

"Get away from that nurse!" the red-haired man suddenly shouted.

Mai Minghe startled and instinctively glanced toward him—somehow the red-haired man had managed to half-climb the wall, like a knockoff Spider-Man who hadn't quite mastered his powers and looked a bit awkward about it.

The moment he climbed up, what had been behind him was exposed: the slender black silhouette with its head pressed against the ceiling was walking toward Mai Minghe, one step at a time.

On the left and right of the bed, Residents; the only way out was at the foot—

As if heaven had heard her thoughts and set out to grant her wish, Mai Minghe suddenly felt a tightening around her ankle, as though something had seized it and gave a sharp yank; she was pulled helplessly down onto the bed, the nurse's face and the ceiling sweeping past her eyes as she was dragged straight toward the foot of the bed.

Cold and hot sweat broke out all at once; Mai Minghe frantically reached out both hands and grabbed the edge of the bed, but all that accomplished was leaving her palms burning raw—it did nothing to slow her at all.

Whatever was gripping both her feet from beneath the bed and dragging her toward the foot possessed a strength no human could match—never mind Mai Minghe, even a Marine would be no match for it; in her desperation, she called out: "My ankle!"

The little nurse tilted its head.

"My ankle hurts!"

Even as those few words left her mouth, most of her body had already been hauled off the bed, her feet nearly touching the floor.

The slender shadow that had come down from the neighboring bed was standing at the foot of the bed, waiting for her.

It was nothing like what she had planned—the thing wasn't interested in where Mai Minghe was about to be dragged at all: because as she was being pulled off the bed, her pajamas had ridden up, exposing her lower abdomen—and the coils of "snake bandage" wound around it.

The slender shadow reached its hand toward her stomach.

"Oh?" The girl's southern drawl stretched long and warm: "If the ankle's gone, it won't hurt anymore."

Every word she had ever been told a proper young lady shouldn't say made a lap through Mai Minghe's mind.

At the same moment, the slender shadow made contact with her abdomen.

The instant those ice-cold fingertips touched her skin, Mai Minghe nearly lost consciousness.

It was as though the fibers of her skin, her blood vessels, her fascia—all of it seized and twisted together at that icy touch, tying itself into knot after knot; her mind could not endure the agony of her nerve endings knotting up, and darkness was already rising before her eyes.

The little nurse wasn't stopping the slender shadow, her ankle looked like it was about to be lost, and all the while she was still sliding down toward the floor beneath the bed...

Just as Mai Minghe thought all hope was gone, in a flash she heard a screech erupt from beneath the bed.

The emotions that screech stirred in the human ear were almost impossible to describe: the closest comparison would be discovering that your jackpot lottery ticket had fallen into the toilet—watching a winning ticket spiral away with the waste, that gut-wrenching feeling was more or less what it felt like to hear the screech from under the bed.

But regardless, her feet were finally released.

The little nurse let out a small "Hmm?" It had been standing by the side of the bed just a moment ago, yet somehow had already moved to the foot of the bed as well, crouching down to examine Mai Minghe's ankle.

"There's something on your ankle," the little nurse said. "I didn't get through it just now—let me try again."

As it spoke, it raised its hand—and it was the first time Mai Minghe got a clear look at that hand: extending from the wrist was not a hand at all, but a dense cluster of thick, silver-bright steel needles.

In that instant, she thought she understood.

The nurse had jabbed its needles at her ankle, but a pair of hands was gripping that ankle, so the needles had naturally gone straight into those hands instead...

Mai Minghe understood now, but with her elbows propped on the bed and her feet on the floor, even without anything restraining her, she could barely hold herself up enough to keep from sitting down on the ground—she couldn't move at all—because the slender patient was standing right in front of her, body half-folded down, long fingers slowly peeling away the "snake bandage."

Every time they touched, that agony of knotted blood vessels and nerves left her unable even to breathe, let alone walk or run.

"My stomach," she stared at the countless densely packed needle-tips, forcing the words out: "my stomach hurts now... stick it in my stomach..."

The little nurse seemed unable to see the other Residents, or if it could, it paid them no mind; it glanced down at Mai Minghe's abdomen, raised the needle-cluster high, and jabbed downward.

The slender patient finally stopped peeling away the "snake bandage," and suddenly flung its arm in a sweeping swipe at the little nurse—its arm unfolding joint by joint through the air as if it had an unknowable number of joints hidden within it—it sounds slow described like this, yet in the blink of an eye, a curtain was pulled from nowhere, and the little nurse and its steel needles were blocked behind it.

What kind of strange trick was that?

Mai Minghe certainly wasn't going to sit there and wait to see if the little nurse could get out from behind the curtain.

She seized the opportunity, leapt up, darted past the slender patient, and sprinted for the ward door—from the moment she had first spotted the little nurse to now, only a few seconds had passed, and already she felt like half her life had been used up.

"Keep it up," a round-headed figure said from the darkness.

Do I need your encouragement?

"Duck," said another round-headed figure, still in place, in a flat tone.

Who would duck at a time like—

Mai Minghe slammed to a halt and dropped into a crouch. She immediately felt something whip past just above her head—and something went thud against the doorframe of the ward.

She was only five or six steps from the door now, yet she had no choice but to turn back; unwilling to give up, she shot a quick glance—there seemed to be a pale white hand embedded in the doorframe, attached to an impossibly long arm.

A spiderweb of cracks spread across the wall around the doorframe.

If she hadn't ducked, that hand would have landed squarely on the back of her head and smashed her against the doorframe like a fly.

Well. She really did need the round-heads' encouragement after all.

"Hey!" Mai Minghe ran toward the cluster of motionless round-headed figures and called out: "What's the deal with all these big heads?"

From behind one of the round-headed figures, a shadow suddenly stirred—Mai Minghe had barely startled before she heard it suck in a sharp breath, as if fighting through pain, and answer: "I've never seen this kind of Resident before. I don't know either."

Apparently the red-haired man had come down from the wall at some point and seemed to have been injured in the process; probably to avoid the slender patient, he had also moved close to this cluster of round-headed figures in the center of the room, separated from her by several shadowy forms.

Mai Minghe badly wanted to keep asking him what Residents he had seen, and what Residents even were, but this was clearly not the time—the slender patient had already turned its head in this direction, and the sound of its crown scraping against the ceiling made a soft, rasping hiss.

As if terrified of the slender patient getting close, the red-haired man quickly threaded himself between the round-headed figures; his face was ashen, slicked with sweat, as he edged sideways in small steps through the crowd toward the door, not daring to brush against any of the round heads.

Mai Minghe followed his lead and quickly stepped into the forest of round heads as well.

The moment she got a clear look, it felt as though every organ inside her had lost its support and dropped deep into her gut.

The reason they had all looked identical was that in the dimness, every head appeared swollen and round and enormously large; but up close, the round-heads were actually of all kinds—men and women, old and young, their features all different.

Yet what should have been normal human skulls had every bone separated—the facial bones, the cranium, all of it—and some gas-like substance beneath had inflated the skin outward, forcing the shattered bones and human skin together into a perfect sphere: the fragments of bone shattered beneath the skin were still recognizable by their shapes, calling to mind the continental plates drifting on the surface of the earth.

The eyes, one on each side, were set separately into either side of the skull, like two blisters risen from the flesh, swiveling to follow Mai Minghe's footsteps; the nasal bone had been split cleanly in two down the middle, pulling two crooked, elongated nostrils open across the "face."

The mouth, at least, was normal; beside the corners of the mouth, across every face, long lines of deep-purple sunken grooves ran everywhere—the marks left by skin stretched until its fibers had torn.

A guess suddenly surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind. "Could these originally have been people?"

The red-haired man rounded the last round-headed figure, stepped clear of the cluster, and strode toward the door. "Sorry—you're the Resident's target, and there's nothing I can do about that. If I ever get the chance to see your body again, I'll bring it back to Blackmoor City for you."

He truly wasn't the target; he was nearly at the door of the ward already, and the slender patient paid him no attention whatsoever.

At this point the nurse was still standing blankly behind the curtain, only its shoes visible below; the two hands reaching out from under the bed were also motionless.

Only the thin, elongated patient drifted slowly back and forth before that cluster of round-headed silhouettes, as though waiting for an opportunity to strike at Mai Minghe.

"It can't get in," said one of the round-headed figures standing to Mai Minghe's left, almost as if to reassure her.

The one on the right said, "We'll all surround you,"

A round-headed figure behind her finished the thought: "and walk together toward the door — you'll be able to get out."

Ugly as these things looked, they had a surprisingly good heart, and their idea wasn't bad either — Mai Minghe lowered her head, staring at the floor, and a thought that had surfaced not long ago flickered through her mind again.

No matter how bizarre the surface appeared, nothing could ever violate the inner logic by which it operated.

She snapped her head up and called out, "Hey, young man — stop right there, don't you dare step outside!"

Honestly, I was perfectly comfortable in the women's fiction side of things, and it was never my intention to come stir up the men's fiction scene... The numbers on the women's side aren't great, sure, but it's a nice little space for a small community to enjoy themselves. The mood is calm — everyone's numbers are more or less the same, there's no real difference between first place and tenth, and it's all very harmonious.

Men's fiction is a different story. The vibe feels anxious and high-pressure, like everyone's grinding out ten-thousand-character daily updates trying to blow up and dethrone the kings, chasing votes, chasing tips, rushing the plot, fast-forwarding to the power fantasy moments... I don't have that kind of firepower. Looking at all the rankings and charts and votes, I don't know how to put it — it feels like being swept into a roaring current, and it wouldn't be surprising to sink to the bottom any moment.

I still hope to work slowly and carefully, and write as well as I can. I also hope everyone will feel free to ask me to take days off — I'll absolutely say yes, every time.

Chapter 11: Mai Minghe's Rock-Paper-Scissors

In truth, Mai Minghe didn't really expect that the red-haired man, upon hearing her shout, would immediately pull back his foot and not step outside.

With an escape route right in front of him, who would hold back from taking that one step?

So what happened next truly exceeded her expectations by a wide margin: the red-haired man urgently pulled back the foot he'd been about to step into the corridor with, the motion so sharp he nearly lost his balance; he pressed one hand against the wall, hopped back two steps on one foot, and stopped in the doorway between himself and the round-headed figures, letting out a curse.

"How did you know?" His gaze passed over the round-headed figures one by one and landed on Mai Minghe.

The room was packed with "Residents" ready to move against them, yet at this moment there was a hairline gap between the knife's edges—a rare opportunity to exchange a few words.

Mai Minghe answered immediately: "I don't know what's going on exactly—I only know we can't go out there. What did you see? You didn't stay in just because some elder told you to, did you?"

"Don't talk down to me like you're my elder." The red-haired man rubbed his face irritably and said, "There's a Resident at the doorway."

The ward door stood wide open, revealing a hollow, brightly lit corridor; in the corridor's light, there was not even a shadow on the floor tiles.

"Really? Well, that's something—don't tell me it knows how to turn invisible?" Mai Minghe said, surprised, and couldn't help marveling, "Have they actually made that work? I remember back in '75 or '79, some scientist said they could use electromagnetic waves or something..."

"Stop rambling about nonsense," the red-haired man cut her off, his expression darkening further. "How did you know we couldn't go out?"

Mai Minghe first glanced at the tall, thin patient.

In her youth she'd stood five foot eight, yet even then she could only have seen the tall, thin patient's navel; the hospital gown was far too short, hanging at chest level, and there was a dark,

gaping hole in its stomach—she didn't dare look long, and quickly averted her eyes.

Mai Minghe hadn't forgotten that inexplicable step she'd taken outside.

The tall, thin patient still seemed unwilling to give up, but just as the round-headed ones had demonstrated, as long as she was surrounded by them, it appeared to lack the nerve to come inside.

She had a moment to catch her breath, though she had no idea how long it would last.

"These things came here to harm people, didn't they?" Mai Minghe explained. "They're so eager to help me get out—that means we definitely can't go out."

The red-haired man paused, as though Mai Minghe's words were a handkerchief stuffed into his mouth. "...That's it?"

"There are two other reasons, actually," Mai Minghe said, a little sheepish. "I don't know if you'll agree. You seem familiar with the Nest—take a look: are there a lot of lines on the faces of these round-headed ones?"

The red-haired man gave a nod—only half his attention was on Mai Minghe; the other half kept shifting back and forth among the round-headed figures, the tall, thin patient, and the empty doorway, staying alert.

"Same principle as stretch marks," he said in a low voice, "except they've grown on their faces."

For someone who didn't look like a married man, he knew a fair bit about that sort of thing; Mai Minghe couldn't help thinking that in the old days, if a man knew too much about women's bodies, it was somehow considered shameful.

Young people nowadays seemed different—though she wasn't sure how much things had really changed.

"Right. Their heads have been stretched as full as a nine-month belly, so it's no wonder they've developed those marks—but marks like that only appear when the fibers of living human skin are pulled apart and torn.

"It occurred to me: the bird-like Residents inside the Nest aren't human at all, so why would they bother growing stretch marks? If the round-headed ones were once living people... what on earth turned them into this?"

A bubble-like eyeball swiveled around and looked at her.

The red-haired man kept his gaze on the doorway, nodded, and said, "Makes sense. It means whatever turns people into Residents like this hasn't shown itself yet—it's lurking somewhere."

Even though it was invisible, the thing was right there in the doorway; thinking about it that way, no wonder the round-headed ones were all gathered in the center of the room, leaving the door clear instead of blocking it.

If Mai Minghe hadn't pressed the call button four times, if the thing hiding in the doorway were the only Resident she'd summoned, she would surely have woven past the figures in the room and made straight for the exit—and in that situation, she would almost certainly have walked straight into its hands.

From below the ceiling came the tall, thin patient's voice: "Had enough of the deduction game?"

The voice slid into her ears with a sticky, slithering quality, and Mai Minghe was hit by another wave of dizziness—nauseated to the point of retching—the biological instinct to expel invading pathogens and toxins from the body.

The tall, thin patient slowly bent at the waist; its face was about to emerge from the darkness and into the light of the doorway.

The red-haired man suddenly cried, "Don't look at it!"—Mai Minghe instantly turned her gaze away, retreating behind one of the round-headed figures, her heart hammering again. She noticed her mouth had gone dry and bitter; she didn't know how long it had been.

"Give it to me,"

The tall, thin patient was bent over, its skull hovering above Mai Minghe, its voice echoing and dripping down, so that one almost had the illusion that the sound itself carried slime and shreds of flesh.

Its hand circled above the crowd several times as though trying to grab Mai Minghe, yet it never reached down; it only howled: "Give it to me! Give it to me give it to me give it to me give it to me!!!"

Mai Minghe hunched over, her stomach acid surging up without control, spattering onto the floor.

Dizzy and weak-legged, she reached out and grabbed one of the round-headed figures by the arm; the round-headed figure immediately began to moan softly, murmuring, "It hurts... it hurts so much..."

Your skull is splitting open and you don't call that pain, yet me grabbing your arm for support is?

Mai Minghe steadied herself, straightened up, and let go; the round-headed figure fell silent.

"Damn it, this thing is dead set on getting the Artifact." The red-haired man stood against the wall, staring at the tall, thin patient. "Residents inside the Nest who want Artifacts are actually pretty rare—and of all things, you ran into a troublesome one."

Even without looking at it or going near it, the mere sound of the tall, thin patient's ceaseless howling was unbearable; if Mai Minghe kept vomiting, she would be dehydrated and unconscious before long, left as helpless as a fish on a chopping block.

The red-haired man had more than just experience—he probably had a way to deal with this too. She was about to ask him what to do when she heard him speak again: "...Rock, paper, scissors."

What?

A rustling sound came from below the ceiling, and even the elongated patient seemed to turn its head toward him.

"Are you casting a spell?" Mai Minghe asked with a wry smile.

"No, I just suddenly thought of that game." The red-haired man pressed his back against the wall, standing in a spot far from Mai Minghe and all the Residents, and said, "Think about it—why does the tall thin one want to grab you, but won't actually reach out and do it?"

"It's... wary of something?"

"Right, it doesn't dare touch the round-heads. The round-heads said it themselves—they counter it. So it won't make a move on the Residents by the door either, because the moment it turns around, the round-heads behind it can pounce." The red-haired man continued, "As for exactly why, I don't know either. And then the tall thin one counters you—no question about that —"

Hearing this, Mai Minghe understood.

"Like rock, paper, scissors, where each one beats another in a cycle," she said, cautiously reaching out toward one of the round-heads. "So next would be... I counter the round-heads?"

The moment she touched its arm, the round-head immediately began buzzing and moaning, its legs even starting to tremble and shake.

"I don't understand why they're afraid of you either," the red-haired man said.

"It's not fear, though..."

The elongated patient laughed in halting, staggered bursts, as if it had realized it could torment Mai Minghe with its own voice—and it had to be said, it had found the right approach.

"These humans—after being caught by the thing at the door, it pumps its own bodily fluids into them, turning them into flesh tentacles, each one standing upright from the ground, used specifically to deal with other Residents."

Mai Minghe wanted to hear more information; she just wasn't sure whether her insides would hold out.

As the elongated patient spoke, she stood half-bent over, feeling as though some great beast were churning deep in her abdomen, trying to force its way up her throat; all she could do was curl like a shrimp, wracked with spasms—she was completely helpless.

"A person has to be alive to serve as a flesh tentacle. When stimulated by another living person, the anesthetic effect of the bodily fluid diminishes, and the flesh tentacle risks regaining consciousness, separating from the host, and dying." The elongated patient explained with almost patient deliberateness. "When you touch them, it's the same as waking them back up—dragging them into unimaginable pain."

"Shut up," said one of the round-heads at the front, in a flat tone.

Mai Minghe was of the same mind—please, shut up.

"So that's how it is—the situation's at a stalemate." The red-haired man let out a small sigh of relief and said, "If the flesh tentacles attack the tall thin one, they have to move, and the moment they move, they expose you. If the tall thin one seizes the chance to grab you, it can use you to make the tentacles wake and detach, and in the end the two of them destroy each other. But that has nothing to do with me—getting dragged into this is a real injustice."

No one, human or Resident, paid him any attention.

...He had probably already made his plan—to use the moment the Residents came for him as a chance to escape.

Mai Minghe was furious, nauseated, and envious all at once, wishing desperately she could trade places with him.

"We can take a page from the human spirit of negotiation. Give me the person," the elongated patient said, not the least bit concerned about whether Mai Minghe would vomit up her stomach, "and give me the Artifact."

That was bad.

"How do we give her?" one of the round-heads asked.

"You have the flesh tentacles part," said the elongated patient. "I take the Artifact off her, then toss her to the door—toss her right into your mouth."

"And you guarantee it?"

"Of course. I have no interest in her."

The round-head was silent for a moment, then answered: "Agreed."

Mai Minghe felt very much not agreed.

But cold sweat was already breaking out across her back, and she had no idea how to stop this. Even if she could counter the round-heads, so what? Could she actually bring herself to wipe out her only line of defense?

Sure enough, the round-heads began to part in front of her, and all she could do in that moment was follow along behind them—wherever they retreated, she retreated too. For a moment, it was almost like playing a deadly game of duck-duck-goose.

"If you'd just given me the Artifact at the start, I might have let you live out your days as a little old lady," the elongated patient said, utterly unbothered by her stalling and resistance, laughing in a flat, measured way. "But you had to be clever, and in the end you'll only bring about your own ruin..."

It hadn't even finished speaking when Mai Minghe involuntarily doubled over again in another round of dry heaving. She had already emptied everything there was to empty; her consciousness was swimming and dim, and she could feel the round-heads hurrying away from her side.

No good—she had to stay with them—

She had no time to straighten up before the elongated patient reached down one hand and closed it tightly around her calf.

1. A stockpile of saved chapters is like snow under the summer sun—every glance shows there's less of it, and sooner or later it runs out completely... Last chapter I saw how enthusiastically everyone was asking me to take a day off. In male-oriented fiction where even one chapter a day can get you cursed out, isn't that something of a revolutionary force? It'll happen, it'll happen—I'll make sure everyone goes home happy, welcomed in like guests, cozy and chatting away.

2. I'm getting on a plane again on the 23rd—this year's theme is just one long haul after another. By my count, over the next few weeks I'll have spent thirty or forty hours in total curled up on planes. Every airline would find life a little emptier without me.

3. The world of the Artifact Report has a lot of settings and details to cover from every angle, plus the shifting POV format—I'm not sure how you all are finding it so far? Does the worldbuilding need to be laid out more plainly? Even though it's a modern Western setting, it doesn't feel like too much to swallow, does it? I stuck with Western-style translated names for the locations—otherwise Sydney Ginn getting into trouble on Red Flag First Street would feel like a completely different show.

4. I just love rambling. After all, a mouth is a mouth—when I'm bored it's either eating or talking, and talking nonsense doesn't put on any weight.

Chapter 12: Mai Minghe's Comedy Horror

In the instant the world tilted, Mai Minghe remembered only two things.

The first was sharp and overwhelming, driving away all capacity for thought and conjuring a warped hallucination before her eyes—for some reason, she found herself thinking of a time more than forty years ago, when she had gone on an outing in the countryside and seen a large tree.

It was the ugliest tree she had ever seen in her life: infected by some fungus or virus, the entire trunk was covered in gnarled, knotted burls, one piled on top of another, galls and warts crisscrossing every which way, so that at first glance it looked almost nothing like a tree—more like one great mass of brown, misshapen, overgrown flesh.

In cold sweat, trembling, and pain, she looked down at where her right calf should have been, and had the illusion that she was looking at that tree from forty years ago again—she hadn't even noticed when her head had struck the floor.

Thin, sickly fingers wound around her calf, joint by joint, long and slow.

The second thing was not really a feeling at all—it was a dull thud she heard, as though some heavy object had struck something, not far from her.

When she first heard it, Mai Minghe's mind had been wiped blank by the onslaught of pain, and she had not thought at all about what the sound might be; but something—whether it was the slick floor beneath her palm, or a flicker at the edge of her vision—struck her like a bolt of lightning through her hazy consciousness, and her mind suddenly lit up.

...So that was it.

Because the Slender Patient had been deliberately tormenting her, she had barely done anything since this all began—she had been doubled over retching amid the circle of Round Heads, unable to do much else; but no one in the ward had anticipated that this torment would bring with it another entirely unexpected consequence.

Which was that the ceramic tile floor of the ward was now smeared everywhere with slick, sticky patches of vomit and stomach acid.

In the "eagle catches the chicks" game just now, five or six pairs of feet had tramped back and forth through this slippery filth, spreading it all over the place—which meant that anything

walking on two legs faced a very real risk of slipping and going down hard enough to knock its teeth out.

No matter how strange a flesh-tentacle thing might be, if it walks upright on two legs, it still has to eat dirt when it slips—right?

The moment that thought came to her, strength surged from Mai Minghe's battered body; and as the Slender Patient's shadow loomed over her, she wrenched herself around with all her might and saw it.

Not far away, one of the Round Heads had indeed just fallen to the floor and was flailing, feet skidding, trying to get back up.

In that moment, if Mai Minghe could have laughed, she would have laughed out loud—think you can run?

No matter how bizarre the surface might be, the underlying logic could not escape; it seemed that the basic laws of physics applied to the strange things inside the Nest just as well.

In that moment, Mai Minghe forgot the Slender Patient entirely, lunged forward, stretched out her arm, and grabbed that Round Head by the ankle.

At the same moment, the Slender Patient's hand touched her abdomen again.

It would not have been strange at all if she had lost consciousness; what was strange was that she didn't.

The Slender Patient's shadow loomed high above her, and she still did not dare look at its face—her eyes fixed only on the ankle gripped in her left hand, staking everything on it.

Through the pain that blurred her mind, through the growing emptiness and dread as the "Snake Band" was peeled away from her body inch by inch, Mai Minghe held on to that Round Head's ankle without loosening her grip one bit—and then a pained groan that did not belong to her shuddered through the room.

"Tell it... tell it to get lost..." she wheezed, her words barely intelligible. "Otherwise I won't... I'll never..."

She didn't finish the sentence, but it didn't matter—the Resident at the door understood perfectly well.

Within a few seconds, one of the distant Round Heads said aloud, "Let her go!"

The Slender Patient appeared not to hear, still peeling the "Snake Band" away little by little, its movements slow and careful, almost gentle—yet no matter how delicate its touch, the pain it inflicted was still enough to blacken her vision.

"Hurry up,"

all the Round Heads urged in unison, striding toward the Slender Patient in perfectly synchronized steps. "A mature flesh-tentacle can't be lost—make her let go, or—"

"I know," said the Slender Patient, which was indeed wary of the Round Heads; seeing them all advance together, it finally released the hand gripping Mai Minghe's calf—its other hand still held the "Snake Band," and it clearly was not willing to let go of the Artifact.

The moment it let go, blood began to return to her calf, and what had been a knotted, tumor-covered tree slowly became a flesh-and-blood limb again.

But it was too late for that to help her.

Mai Minghe watched as a long, ghastly pale hand drifted through the air above her, its fingers unfurling joint by joint—how many joints were there?—and swung down toward her arm; never mind how much it would hurt when it connected, she had no confidence whatsoever that she could withstand that sweeping blow without having her hand knocked away.

If her hand was knocked away, wouldn't all her effort be wasted?

Before it could reach her, Mai Minghe shoved off the floor, barely managed to twist her body, and shot her right hand out toward the Round Head's ankle—if one hand wasn't enough to hold on, would two do?

She knew this idea was perhaps naive. She knew she had been driven into a corner that an ordinary human could not fight their way out of.

The world seemed to run its wheel over a person again and again, all just to make you bow your head, make peace with it, and swallow your resentment; she didn't know how she had lived through eighty-six years of it. The days that had felt endless at the time, like she could never endure them to the end—they had all passed in a flash.

If she had pushed back a little more often, resisted a little longer here and there, perhaps she wouldn't be carrying so much regret today—too much to bring herself to think about.

Compared to all the tangled suffering that people in this world had made for one another, these strange creatures were refreshingly simple and direct—almost endearing in their straightforwardness.

All she had to do was reach out one more hand. She could do it.

She could definitely—

The thought hadn't finished forming when a brief darkness swallowed Mai Minghe's mind and she knew nothing at all.

When the shapes around her came back into focus, she found herself lying on her side, both hands slack and empty against the floor.

The Round Head had long since scrambled up and retreated; the Slender Patient was peeling the last section of the "Snake Band" from her back—just one more coil and it would be gone from her entirely.

...She had failed?

Even two hands hadn't been enough to keep hold of the Round Head.

Mai Minghe lay on the floor smeared with her own stomach acid, her body seeming to have gotten a head start on returning to her eighty-six years, all weak softness and heavy weight.

The Slender Patient extended two fingers—long enough to skewer a person clean through—and flipped Mai Minghe over like a lump of dead meat, laying her flat on her back, then continued to peel away the final stretch of "Snake Band."

Being flipped like that, Mai Minghe's right hand flopped softly onto her own chest.

...Hm?

Her fingertips were wet—she didn't know if it was blood or filth; her nail beds especially were thick with it, a heavy, uncomfortable layer.

Wait.

...Blood?

The thought that surfaced in her mind sent a shudder through her whole body; as though driven by pure survival instinct, without thinking, she raked her hand down at the Slender Patient's arm.

Every time she had touched the Slender Patient before, the pain had been unbearable—so the Slender Patient had probably never imagined that Mai Minghe would willingly reach out and touch it. But there was something else it had imagined even less.

The instant Mai Minghe's fingernails made contact with the Slender Patient, it burst suddenly into a great churning mass of billowing shadow.

It was as though her touch had been an agony beyond all measure—so painful that the Slender Patient hurled the Artifact away, its long body writhing and shuddering, like a plume of grey-white, startled mist rising in the dim air.

...Just as she had thought.

Mai Minghe did not dare waste a moment; she immediately pushed off the floor and hauled herself upright, and the "Snake Band," as if alive, wound itself around her body again in coil after coil.

Once she was on her feet, she quickly stretched out her hand and flicked the liquid from her fingertips hard toward the Slender Patient—and as she flicked, she thought it over, and couldn't help but start laughing between gasps, the sound like broken glass, halting and sharp and bright.

It wasn't that she had a strange personality, laughing in circumstances like these—it was that the scene was actually funny: a spindly shadow with its head pressed against the ceiling, writhing and rolling, arms and legs flailing; and next to it, a woman flinging her hand at it in tremors so violent they looked like a stroke—one person, one ghastly thing, both looking like they'd grabbed a live wire.

Anyone who saw it would have to agree: even if you'd blundered into a horror film, this was a comedy horror.

"What's happening?" the red-haired man asked blankly from the other end of the ward. "Did it take the wrong medication? Did you?"

He was standing beside a hospital bed, pushing it toward the door, and at the sight of the Slender Patient's condition he had stopped moving altogether.

The moment Mai Minghe saw him, she understood immediately what he was doing, and called out at once: "Wait—take me with you!"

Even as the words left her mouth, she had already skirted around the Slender Patient and sprinted toward the bed; before the red-haired man could react, she leaped onto it and rolled on,

crying urgently: "Go, go, go—it's not dead yet!"

The red-haired man looked like he wanted to curse, then seemed to realize he had no time for it.

"You've got a nerve, hitching a ride—"

He bit off his complaint halfway, gripped the bed rails, and broke into a run, pushing the bed at full stride; just before they reached the doorway, the red-haired man grabbed the side rail, shoved off with one foot, and jumped onto the bed—and with the momentum already built up, the bed went rattling and rolling straight out the door, carrying both of them with it into the corridor.

"Don't touch the floor," the red-haired man shouted, kicking off against the wall to send the bed sliding farther down the corridor. "That Resident is underneath the floor!"

"It really is under the floor?" Mai Minghe gripped the bed tightly and said, "I told you not to go out the door because I'd noticed what looked like lots of fine lines drawn on the floor tiles between the Round Heads—I knew something was off about that. Thank goodness it wasn't invisibility."

"Invisibility has nothing to do with it!"

As the bed slid past the doorway, the floor tiles seemed to sense something; blood-red threads suddenly seeped up through them, like the countless red veins that appear in an eye filled with urgent fury—but both of them were seated on the bed, not touching the floor, and the "eye" could only watch helplessly as they glided away down the corridor, bed and all.

"What made that tall skinny one suddenly go berserk?" the red-haired man asked, pushing off the wall to move forward, not forgetting to ask.

The explanation was actually quite simple: when Mai Minghe had made that grab for the Round Head just now, she hadn't caught it, but her right hand had scraped open the skin of its ankle.

Before falling into the Nest, she had been a bedridden old woman whose fingernails had gone uncut for a long time and had certainly never been filed smooth—that desperate, clawing grab had dug deep enough to break the skin, and her nails had come away coated in the Round Head's blood.

"...Doesn't the Round Head counter it?"

Mai Minghe gave the wall a kick as well; the bed advanced through the corridor in a Z-pattern, and with each lurch as it struck one wall, it jolted whoever was speaking mid-syllable.

"Then whatever's inside a Round Head's body must counter it too—right? So I smeared that bit of blood on its hand. I really didn't expect it to have such a big effect."

The red-haired man couldn't help but smile. "And this is really your first time in the Nest? Well done."

"Are they going to catch up?" Mai Minghe asked.

"Very likely," the red-haired man glanced back down the corridor—still empty for now. "Get ready—we'll slide a bit farther, then we'll have to jump off and run."

As they spoke, the bed carrying the two of them glided past the window of one of the rooms.

In the glass, Mai Minghe caught a fleeting glimpse of her own reflection: hair in disarray, face pale, one side smeared with filth...

But a smile played at the corner of her mouth, and she looked the very picture of someone in the prime of their life.

Tomorrow I have to leave for the airport at five in the morning, and there's another flight the day after landing — absolutely exhausting. Watching the last little bit of my stockpiled chapters about to run dry, I feel like a wastrel who's squandered his inheritance: my ancestors left me a thousand taels of silver and ten thousand acres of farmland, and I've gambled it all away. It's over!

Before I board the plane, let me take a moment to sincerely thank the following new patrons:

Thank you Haynes for feeding me McDonald's (I already know exactly what I'll spend it on) — your support will surely be converted into body fat, keeping me company on my person, possibly for the rest of my life...

Thank you Ironclad Baitang for the several cups of coffee you gifted (you're back for the new book! Coffee is the only thing in the world keeping me from turning into a zombie) — if you ever catch a whiff of coffee in a chapter from now on, part of it is thanks to your support;

Thank you Weibaodeweimaor for the Minoxidil gift; why, you ask — seeing your username gave me quite the illusion that I'm Sun Wukong, as if plucking a hair and blowing on it would summon an enthusiastic reader to support me. What a bargain that would be. I want to grow more fur.

I also want to thank vitang for the sweets (my life ambitions really aren't all that grand), and to thank Kankankǎn Sherlock, Miemie's Little Fatty Soap, and the whirlwind Feiwán who treats gifting like checking in daily — thank you all for the encouragement. See you after I land!

Chapter 13 — Mai Minghe: The Way Things Tend to Go

"We've been through life and death together — I saved you, and you saved me."

The red-haired man was covered head to toe beneath a white sheet, and his voice came out muffled when he spoke.

In the room thick with the smell of disinfectant, an old incandescent bulb began to hum the moment it was switched on; Mai Minghe opened her eyes, only to find a white cloth draped over her face, her whole field of vision a murky, dim white.

"With that in mind, I won't go after the Artifact on you — for now. But if you run into any of my other Hunters, and they come for you, I certainly won't stop them. This is our mission, after all, and my people risk their lives to enter the Nest — I have no right to ask them to give that up."

"...That part I can live with,"

Mai Minghe spoke from beneath the white sheet, a warm, damp breath of air trapped between her and the fabric. "What I want to know is why we're lying in the morgue pretending to be corpses."

A few minutes earlier, the two of them had decided they were far enough from the Residents below, and had leapt off the hospital beds and bolted, desperate to put as much distance between themselves and the ward as possible and shake the Residents for good.

But as Mai Minghe ran, she had glanced back in a hurry, and in the distance she caught a dark shape flashing across the doorway of the ward — it looked like a Resident had given chase. The red-haired man noticed too, and hissed under his breath: "Running isn't going to work. We need to hide — follow me!"

The Spindly Patient was three or four meters tall and could stretch its body further still; if that was the one chasing them, there was truly no outrunning it.

What Mai Minghe hadn't expected, though, was that the red-haired man would lead her straight into a stairwell, clatter down to level B1, and then push open a door marked "Morgue" as if he'd done it a hundred times before.

When she hesitated in the doorway, he turned and shot her a glare. "Get in here — what are you standing around for? Do you want the Residents to catch up?"

Easy for him to say — who sees the word "Morgue" and feels any urge to rush inside?

Still, when she saw that her only living companion in this godforsaken place had already stridden in, it became clear that staying outside wasn't really an option either.

The moment she stepped through the door, an involuntary shudder ran through her; the temperature inside the morgue was at least three or four degrees colder than out in the hall.

"Find an empty bed," the red-haired man said, switching on the morgue light. He lifted a white sheet off one of the beds, lay down on it, and pulled the sheet back over himself. "Do what I'm doing — cover yourself head to toe, and don't move. If a bed already has someone in it, leave it alone; it'll be fine."

Mai Minghe stared at the gurney in the corner of the room — the white sheet draped over it rose and fell in the shape of a human body. The light flickered on and off, and she couldn't make out whether the figure beneath it was breathing, let alone whether it was a person, a corpse, or a Resident.

At any rate, whatever lay under that sheet hadn't exploded upright to greet them when they walked in, which was probably a good sign.

"Um..." She pointed at the gurney, only managing two words before the red-haired man, already flat on his back and fully covered, prompted her from beneath the sheet: "Hurry up."

In the span of a moment, the entire morgue had come down to one living person still standing — Mai Minghe — and two figures shrouded in white.

As she climbed onto the gurney and pulled the sheet over herself, a faint sense of unreality washed over her: an eighty-six-year-old woman, first admitted to a hospital ward and then ending up in the hospital morgue — it really was very much in keeping with the way things tended to go.

The whole night felt like a metaphor; for what exactly, she wasn't wise enough to say.

The red-haired man let out a sigh beneath his white sheet.

"First-timers in the Nest are nothing but trouble — they don't know anything," he said, dropping his voice. "Training new recruits is one of my least favorite parts of the job."

"It's not as though I wanted to lie in a morgue either," Mai Minghe replied. "You can't get through life without doing things you'd rather not do."

Including playing dead.

"Don't be so put out — the morgue is the 'door of life' in this hospital. Sounds ridiculous, right? How can a place for dead people be a door of life?"

Mai Minghe made a sound of agreement right away.

"The Nest contains countless locations, and each one has its own distinct terrain, dangers, and opportunities. St. Louis Hospital is a location my House Faction knows fairly well — this is my third time here. In St. Louis Hospital—"

"Wait, this is St. Louis Hospital?" Mai Minghe couldn't help cutting in. "You said this was the Nest — but St. Louis Hospital isn't far from my home at all."

She had been to St. Louis Hospital a few times before, and she'd never seen anything like this.

"No — the one you're thinking of is St. Louis Hospital in Blackmoor City. What we're in right now is the St. Louis Hospital that exists within the Nest.

"The Nest exists entirely outside the human world."

The red-haired man was quiet for a few seconds, as if giving those words time to truly sink into Mai Minghe's understanding.

"Perhaps the universe cracked somewhere, and the shadow that Blackmoor City cast into that crack became this Nest — a place full of danger and strangeness, an otherworld that only a handful of people can enter. Any place name you know from Blackmoor City, you can find here in the Nest as well, though it will almost always be a twisted, darkened version of itself."

As if afraid she might interrupt again, the red-haired man pressed on: "Long story short — we've found that when a person encounters a danger they can't shake inside St. Louis Hospital, say, when a Resident has set its sights on us, the morgue acts as a kind of 'reset' point."

"Reset?" Mai Minghe was working hard to absorb what he was telling her, and whatever she couldn't absorb, she fixed firmly in her memory.

She wasn't always up on the words young people used; smartphones — or was it "smart phones"? — had taken her quite a while to figure out too.

"Right. Simply put: you come to the morgue, pull the sheet over your face, lie still for a bit, and in the eyes of St. Louis Hospital, you've 'died.' The person the Residents were chasing is dead, so naturally they stop chasing. When you walk back out, you're a brand-new living person — nothing's after you anymore. It sounds absurd at first, but think it through and it actually makes

sense, doesn't it? Someone who's ended up in a hospital morgue — of course the hospital forgets about them quickly enough."

"It's the same in ordinary life," Mai Minghe murmured. "It's not only hospitals that forget you."

"Which is exactly why I brought you here," the red-haired man concluded. "Count yourself lucky — if you were a Hunter from any other House Faction, I would never have brought you along so easily."

"Why not?"

"Rivals don't do each other favors."

Mai Minghe understood, more or less. These people called themselves Hunters, and the Hunters were apparently divided into many House Factions; they had no way of knowing whether other factions had discovered that the morgue was a reset point, and if they hadn't, there was naturally no reason to give away something so valuable.

"But why do you all come to the Nest in the first place...?"

"Come on," the red-haired man gave a short laugh. "Feel the Artifact on your stomach and think about why. The effects Artifacts can produce are endless — from raising your IQ by five points to overturning fate itself, nothing is beyond them; they can even bring the most impossible human fantasies to life. But Artifacts only exist in the Nest. Back in Blackmoor City, there's no shortage of powerful people in politics and business willing to pay a fortune for them. Where there's demand, there's supply — economics is what leads us all into the Nest."

He paused, then said: "That's why we're called Artifact Hunters."

Artifact Hunters...

In the very city where she had lived her whole life, there was apparently a whole world of people chasing and trading in things as fantastical as something out of a dream...

And now, through her own carelessness, she had stumbled into a world beyond the world, and been given a second life.

Mai Minghe lay on the gurney, her heart thudding.

What surprised her was that she felt no fear right now, no urge to flee back home; instead she felt rather like a child who had wandered into an amusement park in the dead of night — the

darkness was its own domain, and the unfamiliar, eerie silhouettes of the park in the dark were as irresistible as they were vast and wondrous.

The Nest... in the deep blackness of a shadow-filled night, a fairground where she could climb onto a spinning carousel horse and ride toward the extraordinary.

"I never imagined... that I would ever fall into a place like this," she said softly.

Set against tonight, all the years before seemed to have suddenly shriveled and gone dull.

"It's understandable that you didn't know the Nest existed before now. Without someone experienced to guide you, finding your passage by sheer luck and stumbling into the Nest on your own is not something that happens often—"

"Passage?" Mai Minghe seized on the word, nearly bolting upright like a corpse reanimated. "After I ran into the television screen, I fell straight into the ward. Does that mean the television screen is my 'passage'?"

The red-haired man considered this and gave a low "hm."

"So that's how you got in... You've never run into a television screen before, have you?"

Of course not — nobody goes around headbutting televisions for no reason.

"Every Hunter's passage is different." The red-haired man gave a quiet laugh and said: "Of all humanity, only one percent are born with a passage that can lead them into the Nest. The conditions vary from person to person, and most of them are pretty strange and demanding. So even within that one percent, who knows how many people live out their entire lives without ever opening their passage — never even knowing the Nest exists..."

Wasn't that exactly her situation? Eighty-six years, right up until the night a thief broke through her front door—

Mai Minghe gave a start.

...Right. That thief was an Artifact Hunter too.

"Some people have relatively ordinary passages," the red-haired man went on. "I've heard of someone who could enter the Nest simply by sitting down in a full bathtub. Not that his luck was anything to envy, mind you — the first time you take a bath, you're small and young and bare and you haven't brought anything with you. What are the odds you make it back out of the Nest alive?"

"Then there are people whose passages are more troublesome — standing in the toilet bowl while flushing, opening a door in an abandoned building, and so on and so forth, the list goes on. The conditions for simply opening a passage are already so exacting that a huge number of people are eliminated right there; and on top of that, there's one more important requirement for entering the Nest."

"What requirement?"

"Your passage can only be opened in a city with a population of over ten million. We don't fully understand why, but..."

The red-haired man lowered his voice. "The general belief among Hunters is that the Nest is a byproduct born once human civilization reaches a certain scale. So the most densely populated places are the ones connected to the Nest."

Mai Minghe lay quietly for a moment.

Every word he had just said was like a piece of a puzzle, slowly assembling in her mind into a deep world she had never imagined existed; she very much wanted to reach up and press her fingertips to her temple — the spot swollen from hitting the television screen — just to confirm she wasn't dreaming.

"All right,"

There was a rustling of fabric nearby, the sound of the red-haired man lifting the sheet and sitting up. "That should be enough time — the reset ought to be complete. If you want to hold on to that Artifact, you'd best not let any of my companions see you."

The young man did have a decent streak in him after all.

"The Artifact I'm carrying — are you planning to hand it over to Wellesley?" Mai Minghe asked.

"That's right, he's the one who hired us," the red-haired man said, startled, turning to look at her. "You know about that too?"

"He's already dead — he can't buy the Artifact anymore." Mai Minghe thought back to the news that had been running nonstop on television for the past two days and asked, "Haven't you heard yet? When did you all enter the Nest?"

The red-haired man gave her a skeptical sideways glance, then looked away.

He clearly didn't believe her.

The Artifact Wellesley wanted had happened to land in her hands, and the moment it did, she was already saying Wellesley was dead and couldn't buy it anymore — it was a little too convenient a coincidence, no wonder he didn't buy it.

"Ha — he's not about to die. Those Artifacts he has on him are so powerful that—" The red-haired man stopped himself mid-sentence, rubbed his nose, and let the thought drop. "Dead or alive, I've already said I won't make a move on you. My advice is to get back to Blackmoor City as fast as you can."

"How do I get back?"

Though the Nest was both terrifying and captivating, Mai Minghe's best move right now was to get out while she could—for the Artifact's sake.

"Haah, this is really..." The red-haired man let his shoulders drop, looking a little deflated. "In for a penny, in for a pound—I'll take you to the exit. But let's get one thing straight: the moment a House Faction Hunter spots us, I'll have no choice but to join them in taking the Artifact from you."

Hello, friends—what you're seeing now is yet another message from on high; I have ascended the throne, so doesn't that practically count as a divine decree?

Day after day it's nothing but power struggles—one minute crowning myself, the next getting knocked off the pedestal.

I have a question rattling around in my stomach (sorry, it's not a baby): I've seen readers mention that Qidian now puts a lot of weight on something called "chasing-read" numbers—what's that? Does it literally just mean the number of people following the updates? What happens if it's too low? What counts as enough? Can I count myself as one... Writing a novel has me on edge every single day.

Chapter 14 — Chase, Where the Sea Meets the Sky

"...AED defibrillator, cardiac stimulant, epinephrine,"

The brilliant neon lights on the distant shore fell into the water and were jostled by the waves, gradually dissolving into patches of dim amber and murky green ripples that rocked along with the hull atop the pitch-black swells.

"Last one — broad-spectrum antibiotics, in case we need to be out here for a while."

Once each item had been introduced, a silver-white medical case snapped shut with a sharp clap; a large hand with long fingers reached under the seat and pulled out a black cylinder.

"This is a cauterizing gun. It can seal large wounds, sear through blood vessels and nerves, and keep a person from bleeding to death — very handy."

Accompanied by a cheerful voice, that large hand gave a hearty slap on the shoulder of the man in the white coat sitting beside him.

"Let me introduce you — Dr. Nate, a decent man. Not only has he supplied me with everything, he's also willing to come in person to handle any unexpected situation... For instance, after I cut off your limbs, he can guarantee you'll neither die nor lose consciousness."

Dr. Nate didn't say a single word. His lips were pressed tightly together, his face contorted, a sickly pallor washing over him — he looked like a wisp of fog floating in the night.

The cauterizing gun was set down, and a pair of hands clapped together loudly. "Come now, say thank you to Dr. Nate."

What answered him was a muffled, incoherent cry — a man with his limbs bound behind his back, wrapped from head to toe in tape so tightly that only his eyes and nostrils were exposed, thrashing desperately, rocking the small boat back and forth and stirring up soft lapping waves.

"I'll speak for Dr. Nate — you're welcome, it's the least I could do."

The man in the expensive suit, tall and broad, his smile never wavering, leaned in and gave the bound figure a friendly pat.

His black hair was combed back, sleek and neat, catching faint glimmers of light in the night above the sea.

"Don't be impatient — I haven't finished making introductions."

He spread his pale hands wide, and with a flip and a grab of his right hand, effortlessly pulled a heavy weight plate from under the seat. "Each arm and leg, once severed, will be tied to a twenty-five-kilogram plate. You'll be able to watch your own limbs go plunk — sinking to the bottom of the sea..."

He let out a low whistle, his fingers swaying nimbly from high to low, like fish gliding down into the depths.

"...Just like that."

The man mummified in tape let out another garbled, heavy groan, like a wild animal trapped in a bag and unable to break free.

The suited man leaned back in his chair, studying his captive with an air of leisurely amusement.

"Ready to start talking?"

The bound man twisted and writhed furiously: "Mmph, mmph!"

The suited man flicked open a knife, gauged roughly where the mouth was, and drove the blade in a deep slash across the tape — blood and a shriek of pain erupted together into the night.

Slender fingers worked into the blood-slicked slit in the tape and pulled out a large wad of medical cotton.

The moment it left his mouth, panting and retching poured out of the man in broken spurts: "You — who are you? What do you want..."

The suited man leaned in close, fixing his gaze on his prey, his eyes so dark they reflected not a single glimmer of light.

"I'll cooperate with whatever you want — there's no need to be this brutal..." As the bound man spoke, the wound on his lips tore wider, and the pain twisted his face; in the darkness his face was slick and wet. "I'm nobody — I'm nothing to anyone..."

"That's the wrong thing to say."

The suited man raised one index finger and cut him off. "A nobody who's nothing to anyone — like an extra in a movie, they die and they die, and no one cares. If you want me to let you go, you first need to make me care about you. Isn't that right?"

The bound man was taken aback.

"You're probably wondering — how do I get you to start caring about me? Well, I'd have to understand you first, empathize with you as a person."

The suited man laced his long fingers together, forming something like a pale bridge in the dark of the night. The face of his watch caught a faint, thin arc of light in the darkness.

"Come then — tell me. Who are you?"

"I... my name is Ivan. I'm twenty-nine years old, I'm originally from—"

"No, I don't want a résumé — that's boring." The suited man cut him off, his tone encouraging. "I want to know: what hopes do you carry in your life? What has left you disappointed? What are your dreams?"

Ivan stared, his face streaked with blood and tears. "My... my dreams...?"

"Yes. Surely you don't plan to be Wellesley's bodyguard for the rest of your life?"

Ivan gave a start, and a flash of sudden comprehension lit up his eyes.

"Could this have something to do with Mr. Wellesley—"

"Furthermore," the suited man continued, deaf to the remark, "Wellesley died a violent death yesterday, and today you can barely save yourself — you weren't much of a bodyguard. No great loss giving it up."

"I don't know anything..."

"Don't waste your energy." The suited man's thin lips curved into a smile like a knife's edge. "A character who can't move me is just a sack of skin — I don't care how many pieces of it end up on the ocean floor."

Silence fell over the boat for a few seconds.

"Speak."

It probably never crossed Ivan's mind, not even in his wildest dreams, that he would find himself in a situation like this, baring his innermost thoughts.

"I... I understand. My dream is to become someone like Mr. Wellesley..."

"The wealthiest man in the city? A state senator? Recipient of the Distinguished Contribution Award on Climate Issues?" The suited man asked with a smile: "...Or the true power behind

Blackmoor City?"

Ivan only nodded without speaking. He stared vacantly at Blackmoor City in the distance — at the neon advertisements on shore, the skyscrapers. Across the central bay lit up by countless lights, dark waves gently lapped and rocked the small boat.

"Good." The suited man nodded. "What have you done to pursue that dream?"

"I haven't done anything," Ivan snapped back to attention and said quickly, "Mr. Wellesley's death has absolutely nothing to do with me..."

"Wrong direction." The pale hand waved through the darkness with the air of a director giving notes to an actor. "I didn't say you had anything to do with his death — but after he died, you took no action at all?"

"I don't understand..."

"With nothing but ambition and no action to back it up, a character that spineless is impossible to empathize with." The suited man seemed nearly exasperated. "If you won't even help yourself, why on earth should I let you off the hook?"

Ivan's bleeding mouth hung open. After a moment's hesitation, he finally ventured: "After Mr. Wellesley died... I didn't leave. I stayed. Does that count?"

"Oh?"

"Mr. Wellesley had dismissed me the night before," Ivan said quickly. "I was supposed to leave, but I didn't want to go, so I didn't tell anyone."

"Why did he dismiss you?"

"It was just bad luck." Ivan's wet, glistening lips went still. After a moment, he said quietly: "I hadn't done anything seriously wrong... I only tried on a pair of trousers..."

The suited man raised one eyebrow and the corner of his mouth. "Trousers?"

"Yes, yes... once you hear it, you'll understand." He paused, then said suddenly: "Do you know that Mr. Wellesley had a very soft voice? When I first started working for him, I was surprised — a man of such importance, I'd imagined he would speak loudly."

Ivan's teeth were stained blood-red, but he seemed to have forgotten his wound; once he started talking, he couldn't stop.

"Later I came to understand: because his voice was soft, everyone else had to give him their full attention when he spoke. When he opened his mouth, he wasn't concerned about whether others could hear him — that was the listener's problem to worry about.

"You see, even the way his voice rose and fell had its purpose, had its wisdom... So in my free time, I gradually began to carry myself the way Mr. Wellesley did, to dress the way he dressed. I even wore a cologne with a similar scent, and I felt like people looked at me differently when I went out."

The suited man held out a cigarette to Ivan.

He took a drag; in the murky darkness above the sea, the tip of the cigarette flared red; pain made his cheek twitch again, but his tone and composure steadied considerably.

"During this period, Mr. Wellesley and a number of us staff had all been staying at the estate in the Upper District. The night before last, he went to attend a banquet, while I was off duty and didn't go with him. When he came back unexpectedly early, I happened to be in his room putting on a pair of trousers, and he caught me right in the act.

"He probably thought I was having an affair in there... his face turned purple. But how could I possibly be doing something like that? He didn't believe me — he shoved me aside and went through the bathroom and dressing room from top to bottom before he was finally convinced I'd really been alone..."

Ivan gave a bitter laugh: "Then he noticed I was wearing his trousers. I only wanted to know what it felt like to wear them... but he flew into a rage and fired me on the spot, told me to pack my things and leave the next morning."

The suited man threw his head back and laughed, the sound deep and resonant, crashing against the night.

"Amusing — but that's all." His large hand patted the cauterizing gun. "You want to reach the pinnacle of wealth and power, and the action you took was secretly trying on someone's trousers? With that, what could you ever amount to?"

"It's not that simple, obviously,"

Ivan was stung into a flash of anger, and blood sprayed as he argued back.

"Dressing and carrying myself like him was only one part of it — I never let slip an opportunity for action either. The moment I heard yesterday that Mr. Wellesley had died in his

study, I immediately realized: word of my dismissal hadn't spread yet. Only Mr. Wellesley and I knew, and with him dead, as long as I said nothing, it was as if I'd never been dismissed — no one would ever know.

"So I rushed to the study door at the first chance. On the surface I was pretending to guard the scene while waiting for the police, but in reality I was secretly—"

Ivan suddenly stopped.

In the darkness, there was nothing left but the sound of waves and his own heavy, ragged breathing.

The suited man fixed his eyes on Ivan, slowly leaning his body forward, like a great python lowering itself inch by inch from a branch.

"So... you went inside the study." He said quietly.

Ivan seemed to realize it then — that when an interrogator conceals their true purpose, the person being interrogated ends up committing mistakes they didn't even know they shouldn't commit.

"...And what happened after you went in?"

Seeing that Ivan refused to answer, the suited man raised both hands. In the darkness between sky and sea, they looked like two vague, enormous white fans — each one large enough to cover an adult man's entire head and face.

"Strange, isn't it? I introduced you to all the first-aid supplies, yet I never showed you what I'll use to sever your arms and legs. That's because I only remembered when I got on the boat — I forgot to bring the electric saw. Fortunately, I have some confidence in the strength of my hands... nick an opening in the skin, and I can peel you apart layer by layer. The bones are easy enough — wedge them against the side of the boat and one stomp will snap them."

In the darkness, the suited man broke into a silent grin, his white teeth bared in even, gleaming rows.

"Why did you go into the study?"

This time Ivan answered quickly. "I — I just wanted to see if there was anything worth taking... in case there was something valuable. I saw a watch..."

"Why did you go into the study?" The suited man's hand came to rest lightly on Ivan's arm.

Ivan swallowed a mixture of blood and saliva.

"You likely know as well — what went missing from Wellesley's study does not belong to this world. Those who had no business touching it yet touched it anyway will only end up as you are now: swept under and swallowed by the fate it carries. An endless sea with nowhere to turn."

The suited man closed his eyes, drew a long, slow breath through his nose, pulling in the salt-smell of the sea, the petrol fumes from the boat's engine, and Ivan's fear — all of it drawn deep into his lungs.

When he spoke again, his voice had gone hoarse.

"The Artifact from the study — where have you hidden it?"

The mega-ordeal begins today... Yesterday, the moment I landed, I got a text saying my connecting flight had been cancelled, so I scrambled to refund and rebook—only to find no flights available, leaving me no choice but to travel to Guangzhou today to catch a flight out. A huge detour added for no reason, and a huge chunk of time lost.

The days ahead are going to be stressful, chaotic, and miserable. Adjust for jet lag? What a luxury that would be—a blink counts as sleep at this point.

Ugh.

All I want is to go home and hole up for a solid year, ideally with a new e-ink tablet in my arms.

Chapter 15: Chase, Hunter Among Men

Chase drew a silver comb from his suit pocket and slowly combed a loose strand of hair back behind his head.

The comb was small, its inlaid emeralds casting a deep, crystalline light that sank into the black hair and shattered between the strands.

Luxurious and precious things exist in this world to be used. Chase would never lock a comb away in a jewelry cabinet just because it was a valuable antique.

"I stripped his clothes off with my own hands."

Chase leaned back in his chair and said, "I don't mind finding a new use for the cauterizing gun, but Dr. Nate was afraid I'd be too rough and puncture his intestines, so he handled the search himself. I watched the whole time—I can confirm there was nothing on that bodyguard."

Rolan Key, sitting across from him, made a low sound of acknowledgment.

He was past sixty, his hair faded to iron gray, like the heavy fog of a cloudy morning. Wrinkles carved out a hard face with few expressions, and his pair of pale blue eyes always seemed to be watching people from a great distance, as if peering through deep mist.

In his presence, Chase sometimes still felt like a small child.

"What about his home?"

"I only got back from his place this morning—there isn't a single unbroken tile left." Chase thought for a few seconds and continued, "I searched the car too. Nothing. I also checked the driving records and surveillance footage—after he left the estate, he drove straight home and didn't go out again before I found him. Aside from a pizza delivery driver, he hadn't met with anyone. If he hid the Artifacts at the estate—"

"Not a single one left at the estate," Rolan Key said quietly. "The newly arrived Hunters have already scanned it."

Chase nodded, his thick dark brows knitting together.

"Out of the four Artifacts that went missing from Wellesley's study, the bodyguard didn't take a single one?" Rolan Key asked.

Chase stared at the ceiling and thought for a moment.

"No," he murmured, "he got one... he got at least one."

"How do you know?"

Chase straightened up, a hint of irritation in his movement, his two large pale hands clasped tightly together, tendons rising on the backs. A thin line of dark reddish-black stain still lingered in the creases of his fingernails—he hadn't yet had the chance to clean them.

"I searched every place I could think of to hide something, and there were no Artifacts anywhere. The man couldn't take pressure—all it took was one broken left arm and he was already begging me to search his home, his car. He didn't even wait for me to ask before giving me the address of his sister's place outside the city."

He pulled out a few banknotes, folded them into two stacks, rolled them up, and used their sharp corners to slowly clean out the stains from his fingernails.

"My search was thorough—I'm confident I missed nothing. But as I watched him on the boat, a feeling gradually took hold of me... I can't explain it, but I just knew." Chase stared at the dark reddish-black on the corner of the banknote and said, "He got an Artifact."

Ivan had been terrified and in agony, willing to do anything to escape the small boat and escape Chase—and yet there was something... something indescribable, like bone itself, that held up the man who was weeping and convulsing and howling, and made him grit his teeth and keep the secret.

Someone who had seen another world seemed to gain a certain distance from the reality before their eyes. Even bodily pain, at first, felt as though it were filtered through a layer of cotton.

This was a feeling Chase had encountered before, in Hunters who had just returned from the Nest.

Ivan was not a Hunter; he had only come into contact with another reality through an Artifact, and so carried only a faint, vague trace of that same quality.

But on his own, he wouldn't have been able to hold out for much longer.

The moment Chase thought of this, his hands wrenched together with a sharp, restless twist.

No matter how precious an Artifact, it could not be worth more than life and limb; even a rare Artifact capable of granting someone supreme wealth and status would not be worth

becoming a human torso.

In the deep of the previous night, Ivan had sat naked in a pool of blood, shaking violently in the cold sea wind, his arm snapped in several places and dislocated at the shoulder where a bloody hole had torn open, hanging a full length longer than his right arm.

Looking at him, Chase had known that even without resorting to real measures, the man was not far from his breaking point.

By any standard, Ivan was not a man of iron will.

A few more minutes, and he would have talked—but it was exactly at that moment that a light suddenly pierced the pitch-black curtain of night over the distant sea; the roar of a large speedboat's engine carved through the waves, pushing its light steadily into Chase's field of vision.

Dr. Nate snapped his head up and said under his breath, "Is that the—the Coast Guard?"

From what Chase knew, the Coast Guard didn't usually appear in this location at this hour, but out of caution he still dropped the bloodstained dumbbell plate he was holding; it landed with a heavy thud, making the hull shudder faintly.

"Get down," he ordered the bodyguard, then said, "Doctor, hand me the cover cloth under the seat."

The cloth normally used to cover the boat was thrown over Ivan hood-first, concealing pale flesh and dark crimson blood all at once.

Chase stepped over the trembling, rustling cloth in one stride, took a can of beer from the liquor cabinet, tossed it to Dr. Nate, and said, "Drink."

The crisp crack of the pull-tab was swallowed up by the engine sound growing ever closer; Chase could already make out, faintly, that the approaching vessel was a large speedboat very much resembling standard Coast Guard craft—by the look of it, within a few minutes it would come crashing through the waves and pass right in front of them.

"Great, the taxes I pay, coming to get in my way."

Chase muttered as he sat down and picked up a fishing rod from the boat, not even casting the line into the water.

That night the clouds were thick and formless, with no stars or moon to be seen, and visibility on the sea was extremely poor—a few meters out and one's gaze seemed to tumble into a black

void.

If the other vessel didn't shine a searchlight on them, they wouldn't be able to tell how many people were on the boat, let alone spot a fishing line; the cloth, the beer, and the fishing rod were prepared purely as a precaution.

Boats out night-fishing at two or three in the morning were rare enough, but the central bay was never short of private pleasure craft, and the Coast Guard seemed to have a different target altogether—it plowed straight past them without the slightest interest in Chase's small boat, not even slowing down.

The large speedboat racing past threw up wave after wave, tossing the small boat up and flinging it back down, again and again—and in the midst of the rocking, Chase suddenly cursed under his breath, leapt to his feet, and lunged toward the cover cloth.

He lost his footing and slammed into the railing from the pitching of the boat, but he seemed to feel nothing of it; he swept out an arm, and a large hand with long fingers closed around the cloth.

"What's wrong?"

Amid Dr. Nate's startled cry and the crash of waves against the hull, Chase pressed down on the cloth that was heaving and shifting beneath him, and closed his fist around it—Chase was confident in his grip; if he locked his hand around someone, they couldn't get free unless they pulled a gecko and shed a limb.

And yet Ivan had slipped away all the same.

At the time the whole thing happened so quickly that it was only afterward, thinking it over, that Chase was able to piece together how Ivan had escaped.

Taking advantage of the boat's pitching in the waves, Ivan had crawled from under the cloth toward the railing, trying to jump overboard while Chase was distracted; Chase had noticed in time, lunged over, and grabbed him, yanking him back—but in the rocking of the waves, with the cloth between them, Chase hadn't anticipated that what he'd grabbed was the very arm he himself had broken and torn open.

As the bodyguard's shoulder was wrenched by that pull, the wound that had just been cauterized and sealed tore open again, deeply; a long cry of agony rang out from beside the railing, piercing sharply into the night.

Along with that cry, a gush of fresh blood poured from the body.

The pain was unbearable, but it was precisely the flood of blood that acted as lubrication—and so Ivan finally managed, in a sway of the waves, to wrench out his broken arm by sheer force and roll overboard off the small boat. All of this happened in the span of two or three seconds; but by the time Chase rushed to the railing and swept his gaze around, the bodyguard had already sunk below the surface and was nowhere to be seen.

The night was dark and the sea was vast; even with a flashlight, one could only see a few meters of churning water.

Though the bodyguard was dragging an injured arm, if he held his breath and swam underwater for a while, moving beyond Chase's range of visibility was not difficult.

"He thought he could swim back to Blackmoor City with an injured, bleeding arm?"

Chase tried to smile, but found the muscles of his face too heavy to move. "He most likely died in the central bay long ago—who knows where the current will carry him. I'll keep an eye out over the next few days for any reports of a body being found."

"You're going to wait for news of a dead man before you know how to proceed?" Rolan Key smiled slightly and asked.

"No... of course not, Uncle Key."

Chase couldn't help it—even his voice dropped lower. "I'm planning to go find his sister, and the pizza delivery clerk."

Rolan Key, however, seemed to have no interest in his next steps. He took a sip of black coffee and said, "Anything left in plain sight for you to see isn't where something is hidden."

Chase made himself swallow those words.

He had nothing to say to that.

Before Ivan had jumped off the boat, Chase had already gotten hold of his keys, phone, documents, and even important passwords—all that had escaped was a bare body. In principle, even if the bodyguard had gotten away, as long as he'd hidden things somewhere he'd been, Chase should sooner or later be able to find a lead.

But Chase had searched every inch of every hiding place he could think of, and had still come up empty.

Just where had he missed?

Chase's hands had been unconsciously twisting and grinding against each other all this while; only now did he notice that the banknotes he'd used to clean his fingernails had been reduced to a scatter of fine shreds, drifting down into the carpet—he felt a sudden flush of embarrassment.

"Uncle Key, let me get the vacuum. Is the handheld one still in the usual spot?"

He had barely risen to his feet when Rolan Key said, "No rush. Sit down."

Though puzzled, Chase sat back down.

"Force cuts both ways," Rolan Key said slowly. "The full weight of a punch thrown at someone else inevitably reverberates back into one's own bones and heart. That's why interrogators who use violence either start out numb and dull, or gradually become numb and dull through violence."

A warm, tingling sensation spread from his palms to his chest.

"I'll be careful, Uncle Key," Chase said, with genuine gratitude. "It's just blood. I can handle it."

"That's not what I mean."

Chase's heart suddenly sank. He waited for what Rolan Key would say next, the way one waits for a punch that is about to land in the gut.

"A numb, brutal enforcer is the most worthless thing in this business," Rolan Key said. "You grew up at my side. I thought you would conduct yourself with more intelligence than this."

It was only after a brief moment that Chase's breathing returned to normal.

"For a Hunter House Faction to grow, the Nest is merely the foundation. What truly matters is how we establish ourselves and act in the human world—how we build influence. A truly powerful Hunter House Faction holds dominion over the 'reality' that every one of us must live within."

Rolan Key gave a low, slow chuckle from the back of his throat.

"...And yet dominating 'reality' cannot be achieved through violence and bloodshed alone. Don't tell me that's the only card you have."

Chase hadn't known his own head could feel so heavy; for a moment he wanted nothing more than to drop it into his hands—and it wasn't because he hadn't slept all night.

He knew that Rolan Key had not grown angry, but he would have preferred the man to lose his temper—to question him, scold him for failing to get things done.

Chase stood a full head taller than Rolan Key now, trained and formidable, a man even Hunters were wary of. And yet when Rolan Key was disappointed in him, Chase still felt that drowning sensation of sinking into ice water—because he could not stop being disappointed in himself.

He stared at his own hands; faint white scars ran across the backs, extending until they disappeared behind his watch and cuffs.

In his youth, trying to locate his own passage, Chase had run many experiments on himself and left all manner of scars and hidden injuries on his body.

Only 1% of humanity possessed a "passage"—a channel through which they could enter the Nest; but no one knew what their own passage was until they tried every method one by one. He had tried every known method of opening a passage, yet still stood in the mortal world, unable to see the Nest.

Now he was thirty years old, and he still could not forget the moment when Uncle Key finally accepted the truth that he had no passage—the way he had lowered his eyelids and said nothing.

Like watching a work of art shatter on the ground, revealing the foam padding inside.

The scar on the back of his hand was not from the experiments. It was from after the experiments—Chase had cut it himself with a hunting knife, and he didn't know why; perhaps he had believed, in that moment, that he could cut open a passage that way.

"I understand." Chase said it, then noticed his voice had gone hoarse, and cleared his throat. "Uncle Key, I made you a promise—everything on this side of the world, I will deliver to you."

He could not enter the Nest, but he could become a Hunter in the mortal world, seizing every scrap of power and wealth that could be taken and bringing it into the Key family's hands.

Because what Uncle Key truly wanted, he could never give him.

Chapter 16 — Chase and the Artifact Submerged in the Metropolis

"According to the surveillance footage we obtained,"

Chase said as he drove, "Ivan left the gates of the Wellesley Family Estate at 7:21 a.m. on November 16th, and never looked back."

The bodyguard naturally had no intention of going back; the moment he'd stolen the Artifact, he put his job out of his mind without a word to anyone and headed straight for Blackmoor City.

"What about his movements after leaving the estate? How do you pin those down?" The young woman in the passenger seat wore her hair in long, thick dreadlocks dyed a deep violet, and when they fell over her shoulders, they looked like a great cascade of flowing lavender.

"His GPS records are in my hands. The route we're driving right now is the same one he took on the 16th."

The young woman paused at that and glanced over at him.

"I know," Chase said, his expression unchanged. "The fact that a route is logged in his GPS doesn't mean he actually drove it."

"Right — I've heard you'd need to pull the route data from the manufacturer to know exactly where he went," the dreadlocked woman replied. "That'd be hard to manage without police resources, wouldn't it?"

Generally speaking, that was true.

But Chase had always had good luck.

He quickly discovered that a grocery store sat across from Ivan's apartment building — since people lived on the second floor, the owner had installed a smart security camera out front that recorded all comings and goings.

Posing as a police officer, he smoothly pulled up the time window he needed: at 10:47 a.m., Ivan's car had turned onto the street, circled for a bit, and snagged a parking spot.

That day was a Saturday, with no rush-hour traffic. Ivan had taken 3 hours and 26 minutes to get from the Upstate District to Blackmoor City — only thirteen minutes more than the GPS

estimate. Given the overcast, rainy weather, a discrepancy of a few minutes was not significant at all and fell entirely within the normal range.

"If he'd taken a different route, the timing wouldn't have lined up so neatly."

Every other GPS route would have added at least twenty minutes, making the timeline impossible; and besides, Ivan had been fleeing with the Artifact — by all logic, he'd want to move as fast as possible and wouldn't take the long way around.

This meant the possibility that Ivan had made a detour en route — to his sister's place, for instance, or a rented storage unit — and handed the Artifact off to someone else for safekeeping was virtually nonexistent, because a few minutes' discrepancy simply wasn't enough time for any of that.

But what if Ivan had called ahead and asked his sister to wait for him somewhere?

As he drove past, all it would take was passing a package through the window — a delay so small it would never show up in the driving record.

That theory, however, was quickly dismantled by Chase himself.

He had everything of Ivan's in his possession, and he easily pulled the call records from the carrier, finding that Ivan hadn't made a single outgoing call that morning, and hadn't been in contact with his sister in the days before or after, either — in fact, Ivan's entire call log for the 16th contained only two entries: the first was a call from the head of the bodyguard team, demanding to know why he had quit without authorization; the second was a call that afternoon to a pizza place, ordering one large pepperoni pizza.

Surely no one would hand over a priceless Artifact to a complete stranger making a delivery.

If the two knew each other, that would be one thing; but according to the Hunter sent to investigate, the delivery driver had no connection to Ivan whatsoever.

It was possible he had used someone else's phone — there was just no evidence to support that at the moment — and Ivan didn't seem like the kind of man capable of thinking that far ahead.

Regardless, Chase still had to exhaust every possibility.

He had to bring back what Uncle Kai wanted for the House Faction; before that single objective, no obstacle could be allowed to remain one.

"Mr. Monroe, I have a question—" the young dreadlocked woman began.

"Just call me Chase," he cut her off. "When other Hunters call me Mr. Monroe, it means they know they're in trouble."

Kingsley had not been with the House Faction long — she'd previously been an unremarkable Hunter of no particular renown — but recently her reputation had suddenly soared and she'd become a sought-after talent. Since she'd been recruited into the Key household, today was the first time Chase had actually met her in person.

As far as Chase knew, this kind of transformation in a Hunter wasn't all that unusual.

The Nest took on a thousand forms, strange and fantastical beyond all imagination; aside from the Artifacts that could be brought back into the world, Hunters might encounter creatures, rules, domains, or things that defied all definition — their interactions with such things produced no telling how many kinds of consequences and effects. Not all of them, of course, were good.

The vast majority were not good.

But occasionally, a lucky soul like Kingsley would draw the winning lot — returning from the Nest one day in possession of abilities she'd never had before.

"Chase," she corrected herself, then said: "I swept the Wellesley Family Estate. I can confirm there isn't a single Artifact left inside or outside the grounds. All along the road we drove in on, I didn't sense any Artifact presence either. That supports the idea that the bodyguard took the Artifact and carried it straight to Blackmoor City without stopping — that part is still easy enough to follow.

"But why did he lock himself in his apartment after he got home? If he went to the trouble of stealing an Artifact, he must have understood what it meant and what it was worth — he'd know people would track him down. If it were me, I'd go home, grab what I needed, and run — actually, I might not even go home at all. I'd leave everything behind."

Before answering, Chase lifted his chin toward the window.

Outside, a heavy, overcast sky hung there grey and sullen, brooding with the constant threat of rain; beneath it, a dull, dark-green blur of trees streamed steadily past.

"Well? Are you getting anything?"

Kingsley furrowed her brow, paused for two seconds, then said, "It overlaps quite a bit with my last detection range... still no Artifact."

Chase glanced at the time and said nothing.

He had no idea what method Kingsley used to sense things.

For a Hunter, the ability to "detect Artifacts" was fundamental and invaluable — but the problem was that Kingsley's detection precision was truly terrible.

He had been driving at fifty kilometers an hour for several minutes, and they still hadn't left the range of Kingsley's last sweep.

By rough calculation, her Artifact detection range was about a five-kilometer radius — as for exactly where within that five-kilometer radius an Artifact might be hiding, only heaven knew.

With a sensing method this vague, was she really a prize worth poaching for a Hunter House Faction?

Chase had never set eyes on the Nest himself, so he didn't know the answer to that question.

"That Ivan — he had a bit of cunning about him."

He pulled his thoughts back to the present, fixed his gaze on the road ahead, and said: "He knew people would track the Artifacts that went missing from the study, so he gambled against fate — he bet he could slip through the cracks."

"Slip through the cracks?"

"If Wellesley's former bodyguard fled the moment he died, everyone would have known immediately that something was wrong with him. Never mind that no one even knows yet whether Wellesley's death was natural or not. If it was murder, running would tie Ivan to it as well.

"If Wellesley was murdered, a fleeing Ivan would draw the attention of three different parties.

"First, the police investigating the cause of death; second, whoever killed Wellesley, who wouldn't want any loose ends discovered; and third, the various Hunter House Factions suspecting he'd stolen the Artifacts."

Kingsley nodded. "That makes sense... he'd be better off acting like he didn't know anything. Even if he planned to run, he should at least lay low through the first few days and not attract attention."

"Exactly. He couldn't stay at the estate, because the estate would be the first place anyone searched for Artifacts. Wellesley had fired Ivan before he died — as long as he used that as his excuse, he had a reason to leave. And since four Artifacts went missing, and he'd likely only taken one, if he kept a low profile, there was no guarantee anyone would come looking for him specifically."

"So how did you find him?" Kingsley asked with genuine interest.

"...I got lucky."

"Lucky? I don't believe in luck," Kingsley said, looking at the road ahead with a smile.

"Everything I have, I earned for myself."

What a young thing to say.

The Nest was not a primary school teacher; the Nest did not reward sheer effort — but Chase kept those words to himself.

"Is that so? Then I suppose you wouldn't care about what the other Hunters say about me."

"What do they say?"

"That the reason I have such good luck is that I draw the good luck away from the people around me."

Kingsley probably thought he was joking and started to laugh, glancing over at Chase as she did — then, like a cloud shadow passing overhead, her smile dimmed and faded quickly, leaving her quiet.

Anyone who became a Hunter had sharper instincts than the average person, to some degree or another.

Following the GPS route, Chase exited the highway and entered Blackmoor City proper.

A forest of modern towers built from glass and steel, classical buildings that had stood and settled over centuries past, neon advertisements layering light and shadow over one another, office workers striding briskly down the streets, tourists perched atop red double-decker sightseeing buses with their phones held aloft — like pieces of a puzzle, it all gradually assembled before his eyes into the most prosperous, vibrant, and diverse metropolis in the world.

Chase had lived in Blackmoor City for thirty years, yet everything he'd learned about it probably didn't amount to the tip of the iceberg; accompanying its vast and endlessly varied

population was an unknowable quality — the sense that no one could predict what the next moment might bring. Chase had never wanted to leave Blackmoor City, and beyond his ties to the Key household, it was because he needed that unknowability, the way he needed air.

If every day of his life were the same as the last, he would be as good as dead already, just waiting to be buried.

To minimize distractions, Kingsley closed her eyes and rolled down the window, as though listening to the pulse of the city.

"Nothing... nothing... up ahead is Buluan 5th Street?... nothing there either."

"Are you sure?"

Kingsley's eyes snapped open. "Wait!"

Chase lifted his foot off the accelerator. The moment the car slowed, a wave of irritated honking erupted from the line of vehicles behind them.

Blackmoor City residents were not known for their patience or their courtesy.

"Got one!" Kingsley's eyes went wide as she twisted her head left and right, scanning around — yet a shadow of puzzlement wouldn't leave her face. "Hold on, let me just—"

"Where?"

Kingsley seemed not to hear him. She craned her head out the window, held still for a few blank seconds, then dropped back into her seat with a thud.

"It's gone," she said quietly. "I thought there was an Artifact nearby... but it's strange — the feeling flashed past, and by the time I focused and tried to sense it again, it had vanished. I swear my instincts are usually spot-on; I've never run into anything like this before..."

Flashed past?

The car crawled along, and the honking and shouting from behind had been completely shut out of Chase's mind.

His attention spread outward like a searchlight sweeping in all directions: the road, the streets, the buildings, the pedestrians, the signs — scenes he had passed by countless times before all registered in his mind one by one, sharp and vivid, as though he were seeing them for the very first time.

An Artifact that "flashed past" within a range this large — a full five-kilometer radius...

His eyelids gave a sudden twitch, and his gaze landed on a round sign in the distance bearing the letter "D."

A thought occurred to Chase.

He looked over at the oncoming lane, waited for a gap with no approaching cars, then gave the steering wheel a sharp turn, cut across half the road, and swung onto the other lane.

Amid the shriek of brakes, blaring horns, and furious curses, he pressed down on the center of the steering wheel and leaned on it without letting up, while the car had already mounted the sidewalk; the pedestrians who scattered to either side in fright were like waves the car had thrown up in its wake.

Kingsley gripped the overhead handle with both hands and cried out, "What are you doing? Where are you going? You're going to hit someone!"

With one set of tires on the curb and the other on the road, the car tilted forward at an angle; they tore past a row of storefronts, startling a customer who had just stepped out and sending coffee splashing all over him.

The chaos and commotion outside the car meant nothing to Chase.

He kept his eyes fixed ahead and said, "I know where the Artifact is."

Friends, yesterday I got up early in the morning and headed out to take care of some things — I even sent the chapter from the car. Chapter numbers, author's notes, none of that was on my mind; I just needed to get the food on the table first, and if I remember the cutlery later I'll bring that too. For now just eat with your hands, we've been at this long enough, we make do.

As for what I'm doing today — as I write this, I'm once again on my way to the airport. If you went to the headquarters of every major airline right now, you'd find my portrait hanging there. Seriously, go look if you don't believe me.

As for writing author's notes, I have mixed feelings — I can't bring myself to leave out all this pointless rambling, but whenever I do write them, I always end up seeing comments saying the notes are better than the actual chapters, and honestly I don't know whether to be happy about that. Maybe after the novel goes on the paid roster I'll just post nonsense — sound about right?

Chapter 17 — Chase: The Hunted Hunter

Ivan was either a genius or an idiot.

No, Chase thought, perhaps he was a mixture of both; they say that when an idiot has a flash of brilliance, even the smart ones can't compete.

"Are you trying to get yourself killed? Don't drag me into it!" Kingsley forgot to be polite to her superior in her panic and cried out, "This isn't the Nest — this is the real world! There are consequences for driving like this. You hit someone, you go to prison — do you not hear the sirens behind us?"

It had only been a few minutes since he'd blown through a string of traffic laws before he heard the sirens.

The wail of sirens carved through the sky behind them like circling knife-tips, slicing again and again; sometimes growing more distant, making Chase think he'd shaken the last patrol car, only for them to close in again as new ones joined the chase from other directions.

But the patrol cars never managed to cut him off, because they couldn't do what Chase did — tear across sidewalks, drive the wrong way through red lights, and blast through intersections as if the road were empty.

Along the way, he lost count of how many pedestrians he saw throwing themselves to the side of the road in frantic panic, and lost count of how many times he heard the sharp screech of tires grinding against asphalt.

Wherever the car went, chaos followed — running, honking, screaming; and by some miracle, by the time Chase finally straightened out and roared down the open road, he had only knocked a side mirror askew and caved in one headlight, without causing any truly irreversible damage.

"Hold on," he said, glancing back at the vast sweep of flashing red and blue lights behind them. "I'm going to accelerate."

"More? You—"

Kingsley didn't get to finish — the car surged forward and the force of inertia drove her back into her seat.

Chase spun the wheel; the car twisted around the vehicle ahead, then cut sharply in front of it, drawing a chorus of furious honks. "The search I had you run earlier — you still have it open, right?"

Kingsley let out a sigh and brushed her lavender hair back from her face.

"It's open," she said, holding her phone up into the edge of Chase's vision; the screen was indeed lit up with a map app. "Fine — it's not like I'm the one driving. Where exactly are we going?"

"Buluan Community College," Chase answered briefly, blasting between two more cars.

"...Why?"

"When you sensed the Artifact flash by, I caught a glimpse of the subway sign for 'Fullington Station' on Line D. Buluan Community College is the terminal station for Line D in that direction."

Kingsley absorbed this, blinking several times in quick succession.

"Wait — you're saying you think that bodyguard hid the Artifact at Buluan Community College Station?"

"No," Chase said. "I think he hid the Artifact on the subway."

Kingsley's jaw dropped. Two seconds passed before she pulled it back up. "The subway? Blackmoor City's subway? You — he — is he out of his mind?"

Somehow, she had the feeling that what she'd originally meant to say was something more like "are you serious."

Blackmoor City's subway could be called world-famous — just not for being busy or crowded.

Beyond ordinary commuters and tourists, the cars were always filled with cult members recruiting followers, vendors selling fake newspapers, people announcing the deaths of public figures who were still very much alive, prophets warning of the coming apocalypse, performers changing clothes in public to beg for money — an endless parade of strange and colorful characters.

People often said that to tell whether someone was a true Blackmoor City native, all you had to do was watch them on the subway — if they could sit there, completely unfazed, from the moment they boarded to the moment they got off, then they were the real thing.

Anyone's first instinct, if they needed to hide something, would not be to hide it in a place like that.

And besides — once the subway pulled away, how would Ivan ever retrieve it?

"There's a lot I don't understand," Kingsley said, thinking it through. "Ivan stopped the car on his way into Blackmoor City, went into the subway station, and came back out quickly — that part makes sense, and he would have had time for it. But how do you know he hid it on the subway?"

"You said the Artifact 'flashed by,' right? If your detection method is really as reliable as you say, then it means that at the moment you sensed it, it was at the very edge of your detection range, moving forward at high speed, and left your range an instant later.

"In other words, before you began detecting, it had already been traveling through your detection range at a certain speed for some period of time — that's exactly why, at the moment you started detecting, it happened to be right at the edge of your range, and ultimately 'flashed by' like that."

Her detection range was enormous. Pedestrians, bicycles, even cars moving at city speed limits — if they weren't moving fast enough, they couldn't leave her detection range in any short span of time.

Based on the picture they'd pieced together so far, Ivan had not been in contact with anyone; and within the city, what could travel continuously at high speed without being restricted by traffic, carrying the Artifact out of Kingsley's detection range?

When Chase's gaze had landed on the "D" sign, it came back to him: Fullington Station was right nearby.

While they'd been searching without finding anything, deep beneath their feet, a subway train had been thundering off into the distance — with the Artifact on board.

The possibility that another Artifact had simply happened to appear along Ivan's route was something neither of them had stopped to consider — "possibility" and "probability" are two entirely different concepts. Even with any number of Hunters tirelessly trying to carry Artifacts out into the world, the total number of Artifacts in existence remained very small.

Kingsley glanced back at the cluster of patrol cars refusing to give up the chase, and resigned herself to her fate. She gripped the overhead handle and said, "No wonder you cut across the

streets and didn't hesitate to drive against traffic and over the speed limit — you're racing the subway, and just taking a regular shortcut probably wouldn't be enough. Though this is actually terrifying. If I don't die in the Nest but end up dying in a car crash, that would really be too ironic."

Chase didn't respond to that. He glanced at the time and said, "When you detected the Artifact, it was around 10:03."

He had an obsessive habit — no matter the situation, he had to know the time, and it had to be precise to the minute.

The habit had held for over twenty years; now, even without checking his watch, his internal clock was nearly flawless. Before he'd even looked, he already knew it was 10:13 — he had been speeding through the pursuit and blockades of patrol cars for nearly ten minutes.

Ahead of him, there were still any number of red lights waiting. Every one of them was a choice: stop and get caught by the police? Run it, and get split in two by oncoming traffic?

He needed to think of something — how to carve an empty road out of Blackmoor City's sea of traffic?

Chase asked, "What's the current interval between trains on Line D?"

Kingsley glanced at the map app on her phone. "Seven minutes," she answered.

"Check your navigation — how many minutes until the next train departs from Fullington Station? And how long does it take to reach the terminal?"

"The next train departs in two minutes. It takes thirty-five minutes to reach the terminal."

As Kingsley said this, she caught on as well, her eyes gradually lighting up. "Ah — the train with the Artifact on it will reach the terminal station at 10:36! We just need to get to the platform before 36 minutes past."

People who could treat "entering the Nest to hunt" as a career rather than a final hobby before death were never slow on the uptake.

If the next train departed at 10:15, then the ones before it had left at 10:08 and 10:01 respectively. When Kingsley had started detecting at 10:03, the subway that had left at 10:01 was just about to leave her detection range; by the time it traveled from Fullington Station to the terminal, it would be exactly 10:36.

"But I still have one question," Kingsley said, frowning. "How do you know that subway was heading toward Buluan Community College Station and not going the other direction?"

"I don't," Chase said.

Kingsley's head snapped toward him and she stared.

"I only know one thing," Chase said — he was more patient with Hunters from his own House Faction than with anyone else, and he explained: "When you go down into Fullington Station, the platform on the first underground level is the one heading toward Buluan Community College Station. The second underground level is the one going in the opposite direction."

"Oh," Kingsley's frown relaxed and she nodded. "So you're betting that the bodyguard just got on the nearest available train. That tracks — he only took thirteen minutes more than the GPS-estimated route; factor in the time to park, get out of the car, and wait for the train, and it means he didn't linger in the station at all. He was in and out."

Ivan only needed to ride one stop — once he'd hidden the Artifact, he could get off at the next station and, without even waiting, cross the platform and catch the subway going the other way.

"Still, to know a random subway station has two platform levels," Kingsley remarked, "you must have been born in Blackmoor City. You know this place so well."

Chase didn't answer. He simply said, "Make a call. Report it to the police."

Kingsley blinked twice, unable to help glancing back at the patrol cars behind them. One had gotten very close; the spinning flicker of its lights cast blue and red across the rear window glass.

"We're not short on police," she pointed out.

"Don't waste time." Chase kept his foot steady on the gas, continuing toward the intersection ahead where the light was red. "Call it in — tell them you're on a speeding car, and have them seal off the area from Columbia Avenue and East 106th Street to Cherry Street within ten minutes."

"You're the boss either way." She muttered as she opened the dialer.

Kingsley had barely finished pressing the three digits when her eyes yanked away from the screen — from the road on their right, a large truck had just crossed through the intersection and was now rumbling toward them, on a direct collision course to slam into the black Mercedes broadside.

"The truck—"

Chase didn't brake — he accelerated, flooring the gas pedal level with the floor, and the engine let out what sounded almost like a cry of desperation as the car shot straight ahead at breakneck speed.

Kingsley's involuntary scream filled and echoed through the cabin, then was swallowed by the thunderous crash that struck the rear of the car — though only the corner of the tail end was clipped, the impact wrenched the entire vehicle hard to one side, nearly spinning it to a sideways stop in the middle of the intersection.

Two large hands wrenched the steering wheel hard over, and amid the shuddering groan of metal and engine, the car broke free of the intersection and pulled out onto the road ahead; behind them, the truck slammed on its brakes and skidded diagonally across the road, and a chain of rear-ending cars piled up in an instant into a steel serpent, blocking the pursuing patrol cars on the other side.

"I joined the Hunter House Faction for more security," Kingsley cried out, still reeling from the shock. "Not to put my life on the line at work! This isn't the Nest—"

"911," a woman's voice came from below the seat. "What is your emergency?"

"Hurry," Chase kept his foot on the gas, snapping his fingers in front of Kingsley. "We might not be so lucky at the next intersection."

"Hello — hello!" Kingsley scrambled to pick up her phone. "I'm in the car that's been barreling through the Buluan District!"

She rattled off Chase's instructions at speed, then paused, glanced at him, and said, "...You want to know who I am? Well, I've been — been kidnapped into this car. He's pointing a gun at me and making me make this call. He says if they don't block off the road... he'll throw a bomb into the traffic."

Chase shot her a sideways glance and broke into a grin, a flash of white teeth.

"I'd say it's been a pleasure working with you," he said quietly, after Kingsley hung up, "but our work together has only just begun."

My stockpile of chapters is almost gone after tomorrow, aaaaaahhh

And I've been running around like crazy these past few days and haven't had time to check who the new sponsors are — the bonus chapter debt is still at 7. Well, as long as I don't look, it stays at 7... No, I mean, I will definitely write those bonus chapters. I promise.

Today is packed again — Qidian in the morning, errands in the afternoon, and then some unexpected last-minute event tonight that I absolutely cannot skip... I had no idea this thing was happening, and my suitcase only has jeans, sneakers, and T-shirts, so they might not even let me in the door — hey, if they don't let me in, doesn't that mean I get to come back and write? See, I'm such a responsible, work-minded person.

PS: Prices are going to be the death of me... Especially to my friends in Shanghai — how do you people survive? I was absolutely floored by the prices. I paced back and forth in front of a single bottle of mouthwash four times, like I was working up the nerve to propose to it. The store clerk was already staring at me before I finally steeled myself and grabbed it. A small bottle of mouthwash is like under ten yuan anywhere else, right?! What is Shanghai mouthwash made of — can you drink it after rinsing for beauty and wellness benefits or something?!

Chapter 18: Mai Minghe's Fourth Person

The exit of St. Louis Hospital (Nest version), according to the redhead, was inside the guardhouse outside the hospital building.

To get there, they had to go up to the first floor, cross the lobby, and walk out the main entrance—and the whole way, they'd have to avoid not only Residents, but also the redhead's companions; without someone to lead the way, it was a actually thorny problem.

Mai Minghe was grateful.

"Young man, what's your name?"

She smoothed the white sheet back into place—a habit she had kept for seventy or eighty years; even after climbing down from a mortuary slab, she still had to leave it neat—and sighed: "What a shame we don't know each other back in Blackmoor City. Otherwise, no matter what, I'd have knitted you a sweater and sent it over. Look at you—you didn't dress warmly enough today. It's November and you're still wearing short sleeves."

The redhead glanced at her as though she were the strangest thing in the entire Nest.

"...It's not like you're my great-aunt," he finally muttered after a long pause. "My name's Jonah. But I'd advise you, once you're back, to keep pretending we don't know each other. Don't let my House Faction find out about you."

She still had countless questions and very much hoped she could ask Jonah in a safe environment—but he was right; none of those questions were as important as the Artifact.

Questions about the Nest she could slowly tease out, bit by bit, in time.

"Let's go," Jonah said. "We reset, but it's still safer not to take the same route back."

As the two of them left, Mai Minghe switched off the light on her way out. In the instant before the light died, the body lying beneath the white sheet in the corner of the morgue swept across the edge of her vision one last time—and then was swallowed by the darkness.

The morgue door was heavy; left unbraced, it swung shut on its own, closing behind them with a heavy thud.

Mai Minghe followed behind Jonah, turning down the other end of the corridor, and for reasons she couldn't quite name, her mind felt hazy and unsettled.

Her thoughts kept drifting back to that silent, sheet-covered shape in the morgue—it struck her as a truly genuine corpse: no reaction when Jonah turned on the light, no reaction while the two of them talked, and no reaction when they left.

"Do they actually use the morgue to store real corpses?" Mai Minghe asked. "The moment I think about how we might have been lying right next to an actual dead body just now, my heart just—it gives me the creeps..."

"Hm?" Jonah answered absently. "Just now? A dead body?"

She swallowed back a sentence that had nearly slipped out, and raised her eyes to look at his back.

Jonah's red hair was cut very short; below the neat line of his hairline at the back, there was still a faint dusting of light-orange fuzz that hadn't been shaved clean, hovering like a mist across the nape of his neck.

Something stirred and settled uneasily in her chest, and she could hardly have said what she was thinking—she said vaguely: "Right... just now."

Jonah was quiet for a second or two.

In the rhythm of their footsteps, he said, "I don't know—maybe someone would do that. It is a morgue, after all."

Mai Minghe gave a low "mm" to show she'd heard.

She turned to look behind her; at her back stretched a straight corridor, leading to the staircase they had come down earlier.

If she turned and ran from here, she had nowhere to change direction—fleeing in a straight line, it would be very hard to shake off a pursuer... No, no, maybe she wouldn't need to run at all?

Maybe she was overthinking it?

Right—don't rush, think it through first, Mai Minghe told herself.

1. The morgue was a "reset" location: a person went in, lay down, and played dead; after enough time had passed, the hospital Residents would forget them.

2. Before they entered, someone was already lying in the morgue—or at least something person-shaped.

3. After they came out, Jonah had clearly forgotten that someone was still lying in the morgue.

Goosebumps rose in waves across the skin of Mai Minghe's thighs, every pore seeping cold.

Reasoning from these three known facts, there was only one conclusion to draw: Jonah was a Resident.

But that conclusion was absurd—he was plainly a flesh-and-blood living person, and he had saved her. She must have missed something; she needed to think it over again.

Jonah's pace was fast, and after following him at a brisk stride for a while, Mai Minghe found they had climbed up a staircase on the other side of the hospital and emerged onto the first floor, not far from the emergency room.

The hospital corridors and waiting areas were all brightly lit, but the nurses' station was completely empty.

Aside from the all-round emptiness, this place was an exact replica of the real human world. On the surface of the nurses' reception desk, there was even a paper cup—only without anyone to drink from it, as though the apocalypse had arrived without warning and humanity had abandoned the place.

Along the corridor they were in, there were several examination rooms; some doors were shut tight, others stood half-open, revealing a sliver of impenetrable dim darkness.

The whole way, there was nothing to be heard but their own footsteps and breathing. Jonah had chosen a very good route—not a single Resident encountered, every danger avoided.

"There's often something in the emergency room," Jonah crouched behind a wall, carefully peered out, surveyed the space for a moment, then said to Mai Minghe: "When we pass through, we have to stay absolutely silent."

Mai Minghe nodded, but a thought forced its way into her mind.

...But when they were playing dead, they hadn't needed to stay silent?

She actually knew nothing about the Nest or about "life gates," but thinking about it logically, she felt that when a person was pretending to be a corpse, they shouldn't be chatting and

laughing back and forth the way the two of them had just been doing.

A corpse—shouldn't it be like the figure lying in the corner... motionless, utterly silent, no matter what happened?

What if the person in the corner was a Hunter who was truly in the middle of resetting...

Then had she actually reset successfully?

Mai Minghe looked down at her fingertips.

As for how to verify whether Jonah was a Resident or a living person—when she thought carefully, she actually did have a way.

Although she had wiped most of the blood off onto the lanky patient earlier, a thin line of dark blood still remained deep under her fingernails, not entirely cleaned away.

Mai Minghe used the nail of another finger to work out a little of the dark red residue and held it between her fingertips. When Jonah stood up and said quietly, "Let's go," she immediately reached out and grabbed his arm, calling out: "Wait."

Fortunately, he was wearing short sleeves; the dark red blood on her fingers transferred cleanly onto Jonah's skin.

Nothing like the writhing and thrashing the lanky patient had shown happened at all.

"What is it?" Jonah half-bent, stepping back behind the wall. "Did you spot something?"

He looked a bit pale—but who could look rosy-cheeked in a situation like this; Mai Minghe suspected her own complexion was worse—yet apart from that, he seemed completely normal, no pain, no reaction, not even noticing that the round-headed one's blood had gotten on his arm.

It seemed he wasn't a Resident after all. Mai Minghe quietly breathed a sigh of relief.

There was probably some other explanation for what had happened in the morgue, even if she couldn't think of it at the moment—but she wasn't God; how could she possibly account for every single thing without a gap?

From now on, she'd just have to stay a little more careful and watchful.

"Say something."

"Mm... I was thinking," Mai Minghe, under his stare, needed an excuse, and hemmed and hawed: "Once we get out of here, isn't it going to be pretty dangerous? We should find some useful

weapons before we head out."

Jonah frowned, thinking it over. "We don't have much time. Who knows how long this corridor will stay safe? As long as we're fast enough—rush to the exit before danger closes in—weapons aren't strictly necessary."

It had only been meant as an excuse, but now that he put it that way, Mai Minghe actually felt that finding a weapon was necessary. In this life, no matter what you're doing, being prepared does no harm; a youngster like Jonah, brimming with confidence, was perfectly normal—but she couldn't just go along with his overconfidence.

"How about this—when we pass the nurses' station, I'll duck in and take a quick look around. It won't waste any time."

To leave the building they had to pass the nurses' reception desk anyway; if she went in one end and came out the other, it would only take a few glances.

Jonah wasn't thrilled, but he didn't argue.

"Then I'll come in with you," he tilted his chin in indication. "If there's nothing strange inside the nurses' station, it's actually safer than being out in the open—gives us some cover."

Decision made, the two immediately crouched low, moved lightly on their feet, and slipped out from behind the wall.

Scanning left and right as they went, they hurried toward the nurses' station—like two frantic beetles, four legs rustling and scraping across the floor—and slipped behind the partition of the nurses' station.

The nurses' reception desk was rectangular, with entrances on either side directly facing each other. Mai Minghe was perpetually afraid that the moment she looked up, a face would appear at the opposite entrance; so, almost compulsively, every few seconds she had to sweep a glance over before she felt at ease.

On the side facing the lobby were three nurses' workstations, fitted with computers, office chairs, telephones, and various odds and ends like folders and forms—if not for what she had just experienced, she could hardly believe this wasn't the real St. Louis Hospital.

How could there be phones and computers in the Nest? Who had brought all this in?

The letters on the keyboard had worn white, as though someone had actually typed on it for years; a small cactus—real or fake, she couldn't tell—sat grey and dusty in the corner of the desk.

For a moment she almost forgot her objective entirely, caught in the strange wonder of a TV viewer first setting foot on a film set—even the most mundane, unremarkable things, the duty roster and the ballpoint pen, seemed to take on a fresh novelty that made them worth a second look—but unfortunately, she couldn't find anything that might serve as a weapon.

Mai Minghe had just stretched out her hand, wanting to listen for a dial tone on the phone, when Jonah immediately stopped her.

"Don't touch anything that could make contact," he warned her in a breath. "There's no telling what it might attract."

He had probably been traumatized by her pressing the call bell four times in a row—his whole face read: "Have you learned nothing?"

Mai Minghe withdrew her hand and thought for a few seconds.

"There's nothing here," Jonah crouched behind the workstation; that way, no one looking in from outside the nurses' station would see anyone inside. He pointed to the entrance on the other side and said, still in a whisper: "Let's go, don't waste any more time."

"Okay."

When Jonah crouched low and moved to the front of the entrance, he suddenly stopped and looked back at Mai Minghe. "What are you just standing there for? Come on."

Mai Minghe pulled out an office chair; the four wheels rolled and rumbled, breaking the quiet, and stopped in front of her.

She bent slightly forward, both hands pressed on the back of the chair, looking at the face across from her.

Jonah looked no older than thirty—as a grown adult, he had barely begun his journey in life. His eyes were a little red, his lips dry, his body carrying a faint shimmer of warm sweat—very human.

She didn't know the truth of it, but she couldn't help feeling sad. Like a conditioned reflex, she felt sad for a child so young, and sad for the mother who had raised him little by little.

"You go ahead," Mai Minghe said, her voice a little hoarse. "I'm not going with you."

Jonah furrowed his brow, stared at her for a moment, as if he thought she was talking nonsense.

But after two seconds, his brow relaxed.

"...You noticed something?" He no longer seemed to care about being seen—he straightened up beside the nurses' station entrance and flashed Mai Minghe a bright smile. "Tell me about it."

"Not counting the lanky patient who was already in the room,"

Mai Minghe said quietly: "After I pressed the bell four times, a nurse came—plus the pair of hands under the bed and the underground Resident controlling the round-headed one... that's three 'figures disguised as nurses' in total. The fourth one to enter the room was you."

Truth be told, I thought that after posting the Mai Minghe and Sydney Ginn sections, someone would definitely spot the foreshadowing about "the fourth person" and "the exit" — but nope! (In Sydney Ginn's section, it was mentioned that returning to Blackmoor City also goes through the passage.) So this round goes to me — anyone who goes back to leave a comment about it now doesn't count!

I suppose my dear readers took pity on me and let me have this one win — after all, I've had such a rough time lately, running around exhausted and stressed and irritable every single day... Ugh, I won't get into the unpleasant stuff.

My backlog is gone. Starting tomorrow I'll have to live by my wits and perform for you all on the spot (not really) — I opened the Artifact Report page and took one look: variety arts, miscellaneous rambling, stand-up comedy (not actually).

First I lured everyone in with a novel, and now that the stockpile's dry, I'm putting on a ballet called **Swan Lake: Wielding a Broadsword** to pay back what I owe my dear readers — is that okay? Quite the innovative scam operation we've got here.

Chapter 19: Mai Minghe's Reproductive Unit

Looking back on it now, Jonah had kept quite a close watch on her.

He would turn his head every so often to check whether Mai Minghe was keeping up, and whenever she hesitated or slowed down, he would urge her to keep moving. Even for someone actually warm-hearted, his concern for her safety seemed almost excessive—not only was he willing to forgo the Artifact, he was even ready to abandon his companions for her sake.

Of course, all of this reflection on Mai Minghe's part was hindsight.

"You're that sure about it?"

Jonah still kept his voice low—no longer a whisper exactly, but as though he didn't want anything else to hear him either.

"This is your first time in the Nest. How can you be so certain that ringing the bell would definitely bring a Resident out? What if one of them didn't go, or went but found they couldn't outcompete the others and simply didn't enter the room?"

"If I really am just a Hunter who got caught while trying to escape and was thrown into the ward, yet you're this suspicious of me, wouldn't you just be throwing away a valuable ally for nothing?"

"...So are you?" Mai Minghe asked quietly.

Jonah licked his dry lips, thought for a moment, and smiled.

"...No."

The word had barely left his mouth before Mai Minghe had already kicked a chair, sending it flying straight at him.

She didn't wait to see whether it connected—she spun around and ran immediately. A clang rang out, as though the chair had struck something hard, sending a heart-stopping echo through the empty, silent waiting hall.

It didn't sound like it had hit a human body, but Mai Minghe had no time to look back and find out. She burst out of the nurses' station, sprinted across the hall, and charged toward the

corridor she had come from—she remembered there were several examination rooms along it, their doors left ajar, and if she could dash into one and lock it, she might be able to hold Jonah off.

A sharp whistle pierced the air behind her, followed immediately by Jonah's voice: "Come!"

What was he calling?

Mai Minghe forced herself to pump her legs even faster, twisted around a corner, and plunged into the quiet corridor—strangely, not a single footstep sounded on the floor behind her, as though Jonah hadn't given chase at all.

She couldn't suppress her curiosity and shot a quick glance back over her shoulder.

The corridor was empty, pale light soaking into the desolate silence.

Jonah really hadn't come after her.

Never mind why he hadn't; she'd already run this far—even if he started chasing now, he probably couldn't catch up, could he?

Should she still duck into an examination room?

The question flashed through her mind, and she made her decision at once: yes.

She knew nothing about this St. Louis Hospital inside the Nest, and running around blindly might land her in any number of dangers. She had at least glanced into the examination rooms as she passed—they weren't entirely unfamiliar territory.

The door of the first examination room was firmly locked; she tried the handle and found it wouldn't turn, so she immediately ran toward the next room, whose door stood half-open—it was a heavy sliding door sheathed in a steel panel. The moment she got a clear look at it, she cursed under her breath and kept running.

Fortunately, the next examination room wasn't far, and its door hadn't been shut all the way either, leaving a gap; she gave it a quick push, only to find it wouldn't budge more than a fist's width, as though something was jamming it.

"Why didn't you go into that last room?" Jonah's voice asked.

Mai Minghe's heart skipped a beat.

She slowly raised her head and followed the sound, and there, wedged in the angle where the ceiling met the wall, she saw a human face hanging upside down.

Of course—Jonah had climbed the walls before. He had crawled along them to get here; no wonder she hadn't heard any footsteps.

Jonah's abdomen faced the ceiling, his hands and feet clinging firmly to the plastered wall like some enormous insect. She had no idea when he had gotten above her, nor how he was managing not to fall.

His neck bent downward, his eyeballs drooping, fixed on Mai Minghe with a wide expanse of white showing—Jonah at this moment reminded her of a certain kind of doll whose eyes open and close with gravity, the kind that always made her feel, whenever she held one, as though she were holding a living thing pretending to be lifeless.

She also understood now why the door wouldn't open.

One of Jonah's hands wasn't gripping the ceiling at all—it was thrust into the gap in the door, clamped firmly around one corner of the panel so she could neither push nor pull it.

"Don't be in such a hurry—just wait a little longer,"

Just as the question surfaced in Mai Minghe's mind, Jonah opened his mouth; his upper teeth, upside-down, flickered in and out between his lips. "My child is almost here. Reaching full maturity still depends on you."

What child?

Mai Minghe stepped back sharply from Jonah, then quickly cast a glance down the depth of the corridor.

What came around from behind the corner was a very small shadow. Had it not been crawling toward her with a faint rustling sound, Mai Minghe might never have thought it was alive.

At first glance it looked like a ball, or a crumpled plastic bag; but within a few seconds she could see it clearly—it was roughly the size of two fists, a wrinkled mass of pinkish flesh, and along both its sides, numerous slender legs were moving in rapid alternation, blurring into a smear of shadow.

What on earth was that thing?

The thought had barely crossed her mind when she felt a sudden chill on both her cheeks; two hands dropped down from the ceiling, fingers like iron claws, locking around her skull.

Mai Minghe jolted in fright and struggled with everything she had, fists pounding up against those arms again and again, each blow landing with a dull thud against hard muscle—but it didn't loosen the grip by a fraction. The two male hands pressed deep into her cheeks, seized her jaw, and forced her mouth open.

The wrinkled pink ball of flesh seemed to grow suddenly excited, crawling faster, several tentacle-like legs climbing up along her pajama pants.

Never before had she wished so badly to have a weapon in her hands—anything at all, even a length of pipe would do; but she had spent the first half of this night as a bedridden old woman, and aside from the clothes on her body, she was completely empty-handed.

"Don't be afraid," Jonah's voice soothed. "Look—am I not perfectly fine right now? As long as memory endures, a person isn't really dead. After I entered Jonah, his memories as 'Jonah' are still continuing, which means 'Jonah' is still alive... there's simply one more symbiote, that's all."

No wonder the round-headed one's blood had been useless against him—because the blood had been smeared on Jonah's body, not on the Resident's true self.

Mai Minghe flailed and swept her hands frantically across herself, trying to knock the thing off, but the flesh-ball moved like a nimble cockroach—its legs scuttling lightly and swiftly, darting away from her palms again and again, pressing ever forward toward her head.

"You could try covering your mouth the way Jonah did at the time," said the Jonah above her head.

What kind of advice was that—utterly insincere?

Now that he had said it, she honestly didn't know whether she should cover her mouth or not—or was that precisely the effect he was going for?

Mai Minghe truly regretted pressing the bell four times; since falling out of the hospital bed, she had lurched from one danger to the next, each situation more unpleasant than the last.

In that moment of hesitation, the thing had already crawled up to her chest, and up close it looked more and more like some hybrid of a brain and an insect—a raw, icy smell rose from her chest, five or six thin legs stepped across her collarbone, and an ugly, slick, wrinkled thing, its folds of skin layered over one another, appeared in Mai Minghe's field of vision.

Mai Minghe suppressed the instinct to raise her hands, twisting her head desperately to dodge, and rapidly pulled off her outer robe—the older you got the colder you felt, and she was no

exception; she slept in several layers, and the outermost one had its buttons undone, so she could yank it off in one go.

Two long, slender legs had already crept into her mouth—revolting, and maddeningly itchy.

Mai Minghe forced her gaze upward, fixed on her target, swung her arm, and with a sharp crack lashed her robe across Jonah's eyes with all her strength.

If he was using a human body, surely he couldn't escape the limitations of human physiology?

Who could stay perfectly still and composed after taking a hit straight to the eyeball?

Sure enough, Jonah let out an involuntary cry of pain, and the hands gripping Mai Minghe loosened slightly.

The moment she felt the hold slacken, she immediately bent low, pulling her head free from Jonah's reach; at the same time, Mai Minghe wrapped her hand in the robe and grabbed the thing that had been crawling into her mouth, pulling it out.

Thank goodness the skeletal patient had already wrung her dry of anything to vomit, because if she hadn't been, the sight of that squirming ball of flesh thrashing its limbs right in front of her face would have made her retch all over again.

Mai Minghe wrapped it in the robe, gripped it in her hand despite the revulsion, and ran.

She couldn't afford to be choosy this time; when she realized she had run back to the steel-paneled sliding door, Mai Minghe suddenly had an idea. She charged inside, immediately spun around by the door, and sure enough saw Jonah on the ceiling, eyes half-narrowed and blood-red, crawling rapidly toward her with his face twisted in fury.

"You slippery old woman—"

Mai Minghe kept her face expressionless and pulled the door with one hand.

These Residents.

"I told you, I'm not an old woman," she said quietly, and tossed the ball of flesh to the ground, landing it right on the sliding track. She pulled hard on the door, and it pressed down onto the flesh-ball.

Jonah's scream sounded as though it might tear his throat apart: "No, wait!"

The heavy sliding door, made of lead sheathed in steel plate, came crashing down on the wrinkled flesh-ball just as it hit the floor, before it could steady itself. Without so much as a cry, it was crushed and burst open, blood and shredded flesh spattering in all directions—in an instant, all that remained between the door and the wall was the largest fragment, a flat piece of flesh, its thin legs still twitching.

Before she could kick the remains aside and shut the door all the way, a hand covered in bulging veins slammed against the door frame with a crack.

Through the gap in the door, half of Jonah's face barely looked human anymore; his nostrils flared open and snapped shut like a pair of bellows that had opened on his face.

"My child!" he shrieked.

Mai Minghe braced against the door with all her strength, not daring to let him wrench it open and come through, while at the same time she swept a quick glance around the dim interior, then couldn't help letting out a quiet, resigned sigh.

Just as she had expected, this room was a medical imaging room.

Rooms for X-ray scanning required radiation shielding on the doors and walls, and few hospitals would install windows in an X-ray room—not because special shielded windows didn't exist, but because they were expensive and not cost-effective—which meant that once you were chased into an X-ray room, you were a turtle in a jar with no way out.

That was also why Mai Minghe had passed this door without entering the first time: if she went into an ordinary examination room and locked the door, she could still escape through a window, but in an X-ray room that would be impossible.

"Does something like you really need to pass on offspring?" Mai Minghe said through gritted teeth, still straining against the door. "This is the Nest—you don't need to go in for ecological reproduction here, do you?"

"Once I've killed you," Jonah's words came out in a wet, rasping hiss, as though each syllable was sticking to the next. "Your corpse will dissolve in the Nest, and from your constituent units, I will rebuild my child..."

"You mean, using my flesh and blood to rebuild your child?"

Mai Minghe leaned against the wall with her whole body braced against the door, muscles trembling, still unable to force it completely shut. She scanned the room for anything that might

serve as a weapon while buying time with conversation: "My flesh and blood probably aren't disgusting enough to make one."

Jonah suddenly burst out laughing.

"Flesh and blood? I don't want your withered old flesh and blood at all! As long as you have ever given thought to the matter of 'reproduction,' your mind and body have already been marked. The you who once considered 'reproduction' is still a part of who you are today, and as long as I can obtain that part—"

Mai Minghe froze.

She hadn't expected that, here and now, she would be pulled back into memories from years ago: the anxiety over her day-by-day declining fertility, the confusion over what choice to make, the unease about the prospect of old age...

Without realizing it, her grip loosened slightly.

Jonah caught it.

The sliding door was shoved open with a sudden, forceful push—she had barely startled when a red-haired head poked through the gap.

Digging a saved draft chapter out of my iPad, I've scraped by another day—it feels just like finding a thousand yuan in the pocket of a winter coat!

Chapter 20 — Mai Minghe and the Jonah Who Begged for Help

The shock hit Mai Minghe like a thousand volts crackling through her body all at once; she threw every ounce of strength she had into pushing the door forward—and she was fast enough that the sliding door clamped tight around Jonah's neck just before he could squeeze himself through.

If she could simply choke him out that way, things would have been simple.

Unfortunately, the door was pressing against the side of his neck, over the carotid artery—enough to flush his face deep red and make his breathing labored, but not enough to crush his windpipe fatally; as long as he could still breathe, he still had strength, and one hand hooked around the door's edge as he shoved hard back toward Mai Minghe.

The man could even talk.

"Did you know?"

His breath was ragged, but his words came out clear and complete: "...Anyone who lingers in the Nest for more than seven days, or who dies within it, is not merely broken down in body—their mind, their memories, their emotions, their experiences, even a single passing thought, are all dismantled piece by piece and transformed into other forms, becoming part of the Nest. You've lived a long life, haven't you? Quite a few experiences. And no shortage of wicked thoughts too, I'd wager. When you die here, I wonder what extraordinary things will emerge... People who die in the Nest at seventy or eighty years old are very rare indeed."

She half understood, and half did not.

After death, emotions, memories, and experiences would all become part of the Nest? What did "part of it" mean—would her own memories each become a Resident?

As if he had heard her thoughts, Jonah laughed, his breath hoarse: "What things will come walking out from eighty-six years of a life... I'm so looking forward to it."

Was this speech of Jonah's meant to shake her again, the way it had before?

Mai Minghe braced against the door with everything she had, teeth clenched, thinking: then he had miscalculated.

"Is it because Jonah always has to train new people that you can't help trying to enlighten me too?"

Even as her muscles trembled and her whole body shook, she still had no trouble finding words; she said, her voice quivering: "You live inside someone's body like a roundworm in an intestine—you have no experience of human life. What person makes it through this life without setbacks and hardship? But the thing is, life always finds a moment you least expect to offer you a little light and warmth.

"Even if you kill me here today and use me as raw material to produce a Resident, I won't be in pain, and I won't be angry. I didn't have many days left to begin with—lying in bed day after day, like a dried-up husk. The best of it has been gone forever. But before my life ended, I got to be young again, to live again, and to die in the image of myself as I was in my memories—who could be lucky enough for that? This is the gentleness Heaven has given me. I'm quite happy about it."

"Shut up!" Jonah couldn't get a word in, and he let out a hoarse shout: "Shut up!"

"When a person gets older, they can't help rambling a bit—once they start talking, they just can't stop."

Jonah seemed actually furious; he led by example and shut his own mouth first, pressing his lips into a tight line; a person and a disembodied head then engaged in a silent reverse tug-of-war for a while, accompanied only by each other's heavy, labored breathing.

Mai Minghe, true to form, could not hold herself back, and spoke again.

"You've burrowed into Jonah's body—doesn't that mean he has no independent will left at all? Hey, young man, are you still in there? Get a handle on that brain-worm of yours—this can't go on."

Jonah's face had long since burst into patches of broken capillaries from the pressure, covered in large, vivid blood spots all across his skin, like a swollen purple grape—yet he seemed entirely unbothered, showing no reaction to Mai Minghe's words at all, and kept pulling at the door.

People were dangerous when they went down a dead end, but it turned out that something that wasn't a person, going down a dead end, was just as hard to deal with...

Mai Minghe knew her own physical strength was no match for Jonah's.

Even if she had recovered her youth and regained a strong body, that was only in comparison to her eighty-six-year-old self; Jonah was powerfully built and had routinely walked the line

between life and death, and the two of them had never been on the same level to begin with—and what was more, the elderly had poor appetites, and in the day before she fell into the Nest she had eaten only a few crackers and a little egg, all of which she had vomited back up, and now, looking at the mutilated remains of the "child" on the floor, she was actually beginning to feel a faint twinge of hunger.

That she had managed to hold on this long was purely due to the advantage of her position; if the stalemate continued, she was bound to lose sooner or later.

Mai Minghe glanced once more at the remains of the "child" on the floor and suddenly sucked a sharp breath through her teeth: "Hm?"

The flicker of startled suspicion was enough to involuntarily slacken her grip.

Jonah reacted at once, and sure enough followed her gaze, glancing downward—Mai Minghe had been waiting for exactly this moment; she immediately seized the chance, threw her full body weight behind the door, and slammed it forward with all she had; a dry, cracked screech tore out from between the door and the wall, as if a frail, crumbling rubber tube had been caught in the gap.

"A child's trick, and it actually got you to look down," Mai Minghe said—though inside, she cursed under her breath.

She had hoped that while Jonah looked down, she would have a chance to slam the door shut completely.

Now, of course, the situation was hardly any different from before, and there was no telling how much longer the stalemate would drag on.

Air passed in and out of Jonah's throat in fitful, broken intervals, as though each breath was harder than the last.

Had it caught on his windpipe?

Because he had turned his head, she couldn't quite tell from her angle.

"I... I..." Jonah's face was to the wall, and his voice came out muffled and hoarse—less like speech, more like a balloon slowly leaking air. "I'm... a Hunter with Morgan House Faction..."

Now of all times, he was still bothering to introduce himself?

The doubt had barely formed in Mai Minghe's mind before a sense that something was different came over her; she kept listening.

"My name is Jonah Janko... This is already my fifth day in the Nest..." he said with great difficulty. "I beg you... go to Morgan House... ask for rescue..."

A layer of goosebumps prickled softly across Mai Minghe's skin.

Whether it was because the door had caught something critical and temporarily severed the Resident's control, she couldn't say—but the one speaking to her now was not the Nest's Resident bent on killing her, but Jonah, a Hunter from Blackmoor City, begging for his life.

"Where are your companions?" Speaking was a strain for Mai Minghe too at this moment. "Can't you call them here? You can see my situation—I can barely keep myself alive."

Her limbs had long since begun going weak in waves; all she could do was keep telling herself "one more second," and when that second passed, "one more second," and that was how she had held on until now.

"Get out of the Nest... get out now..." Jonah was still speaking in broken fragments.

"I can't get out," Mai Minghe cut him off. "Can you keep control of your body and stop the Resident from coming after me? From here to the exit of the Nest is still a long way—"

"No, no... it lied to you."

Mai Minghe snapped her mouth shut, and her teeth clicked together with the force of it.

"However the passage brought you here... is how you go back..." Two rattling clicks came from Jonah's throat, and then silence.

Just as Mai Minghe's heart clenched and she thought the Resident had wrested back control, he spoke again without warning: "Fell in through the television... the television... go back that way. You've already passed through the passage once, so when you see it again, you'll feel it..."

"But the moment I let go, the Resident will regain control of you, won't it?" Mai Minghe couldn't fully conceal her agitation. "Never mind that I might not even make it out—even if I could run, I don't know if I'd find the tele— before it catches me—"

The word "vision" lodged itself in her throat, unfinished.

Her gaze came to rest on the far end of the room.

After a few seconds, Mai Minghe asked in a low voice: "When I see the passage, I'll know that's what it is—is that what you mean?"

Jonah's throat hissed faintly, as though he could no longer answer her.

Mai Minghe couldn't help swallowing, her heartbeat loud enough to hear inside her own ears.

In the dimness, she could just barely make out, at the far end of the room, a small door.

Although the medical imaging room had no outward-facing windows, a small room had been partitioned off inside it, and that door led to the small room; beside the door was a glass window facing directly toward the X-ray machine.

When she had been searching for a weapon, she had only looked at what was close at hand, so she had noticed the small door and the glass window without thinking anything of them; but now she suddenly realized something—when she used to go for X-rays, the doctor would always sit in that little room.

Why sit in there?

Because the doctor had to operate the equipment and view the images.

From the edge of the window, she could now make out the shadow of half a computer screen; with no light, everything was blurry and indistinct, and if one hadn't specifically looked for it, one might not have registered it as a screen at all.

The screen was used for viewing medical images and was quite large—and the feeling she'd had back then, lying in the bed and desperate to get to the television, suddenly ignited inside Mai Minghe like a wildfire, burning brighter and brighter.

Could it be that her passage was not a television set, but simply a "screen"?

But then—when she had passed the nurses' station and seen the computer screen on the counter, why had she felt nothing?

That question didn't matter right now, and this was not the time to think about it.

"Hey, Jonah?" Mai Minghe called out. She wanted to confirm her guess with him, but from Jonah's throat came only a low, wet gurgling.

"How am I supposed to find Morgan House Faction? Do you have... do you have their phone number?"

You wouldn't find a Hunter faction in the Yellow Pages, would you—oh, right, there were no Yellow Pages anymore. People in the old days had worried about no one being able to find them, so they'd list their home numbers in the public phone directory; people nowadays were exactly the opposite, as if what they feared most was something called "a privacy breach."

The world had changed.

How was she supposed to find "Morgan House Faction"? Would it be on a smartphone? She couldn't let a perfectly good young man be done in by some rotten worm.

But Mai Minghe called out to him a few more times, and Jonah gave no response whatsoever.

She looked at the screen in the small room, and inside her chest the wildfire burned.

If her guess was wrong and she made a dash for the small room only to find she couldn't return to Blackmoor City, that would certainly mean death; but if the stalemate dragged on indefinitely, death was just as inevitable.

Since danger lay on either path, she might as well act.

Mai Minghe took a long, deep breath, and lowered the foot she had been bracing against the door.

She let go; the moment the pressure on the door eased, the Resident snapped awake. At the very instant Jonah's shoulder forced the sliding door open, Mai Minghe took a step and broke into a run toward the small room.

Today is another day I find myself on a plane; by my estimate I'll have to fly at least three more times in the next two weeks—all the major airlines are popping champagne right now, except for China Eastern.

Just seeing the words "China Eastern" when I'm booking tickets is enough to make me feel unwell—I have to scroll past it immediately. There's a saying that people won't remember what you said or what you did, but they'll always remember the way you made them feel. That's exactly how it is with China Eastern and me—I've long since forgotten what it was that disgusted me in the first place, but that disgust has weathered the passage of time and stands unyielding to this day. The mere thought of China Eastern can make me motion-sick sitting on the toilet, so I'd rather take a Southern Airlines flight that doesn't arrive until eleven at night than give a single cent to an afternoon China Eastern flight.

Chapter 21 — How Can You Tell If I'm Making Excuses?

Friends, grandmas, extraterrestrials — honestly, I don't know myself whether this counts as a fake excuse note or not.

Grandma, put the shoe down first, let me explain for a moment, and then see if you can hold back from swatting me like a cockroach.

I was originally supposed to fly out yesterday. I checked the weather in the morning, Shanghai was clear and sunny, I was pretty happy about it — trotted off to Pudong Airport, figured I could sneak in some writing in a quiet corner while waiting to board. Had it all planned out; I was even willing to buy a lounge pass just to get some updates done.

After all that hassle getting there, I took out my phone and looked — well, would you believe it, the flight was cancelled.

Apparently all of Guangdong was under an orange weather alert — thunderstorms — which just goes to show how warmly my home province welcomes me back.

But I couldn't just strand myself in Shanghai forever, I still had to leave — so I immediately applied to rebook. The rebooking alone took a goddamn two hours, during which there were all sorts of phone calls, checking flight information... After two hours, I successfully got rebooked onto a 9:30 PM flight that same night — except it departed from Hongqiao Airport.

Fine. Off to Hongqiao.

Every DiDi driver in Shanghai must have me enshrined on their dashboard or something.

I got to Hongqiao Airport and looked at the departures board — there was an extra line of text. Above "Scheduled departure 21:35," a new line had appeared: "Estimated departure 23:35" — I ask you, is that how human beings communicate? What is this, a competition to see who knows the most synonyms? I already had a bad feeling at that point. After all, Guangdong's rainstorms don't play favorites. What was I supposed to do — I couldn't just sit in the airport waiting to see when the plane might eventually decide to fly. I'd better book a hotel.

It's not like I'm staying overnight anyway, cheapest one will do, maybe in a few hours I'll be on my way. I thought naively.

So I dragged my luggage into a cab and got ferried to a place that looked less like Shanghai and more like a county town. Got out of the car. It really was close to the airport — a jumbo jet thundered so low over my head it nearly blew my wig off (going so hard on the writing that I started losing hair at eighteen). I took a few pictures of the planes while I was at it. Couldn't come all this way for nothing.

Checked in, walked into the room, walked right back out — why? To go buy disposable toilet seat covers. That toilet seat was yellowed like old braised stock — one look and you knew it had been marinating in ancient piss for years.

Right. This is the hotel that still costs over three hundred yuan at the cheapest. I am indeed in Shanghai.

Well, would you believe it — the universe heard me say "not staying overnight." The second flight was delayed too. Delayed until five in the morning.

Even owls can't pull an all-nighter like that!!!

I rebooked a second time, to eleven o'clock this morning.

And then I just stood there in that hotel room, holding my bag, trapped and miserable, realizing I really was going to have to spend the night here. If I'd known it would come to this, why didn't I book somewhere decent? The heavens are out to get me. First I put the door chain on (I never normally bother with that), then I pulled back the duvet and inspected the sheets — the sheets were okay, at least they looked white.

By this point I'd been through the wringer and it was already evening. Having typed not a single word but feeling utterly drained in body and soul, I reached down to feel the mattress.

...Where is my mattress?

These individual springs, poking me one by one — what are they made of, diamonds? Don't mattresses usually have some kind of padding on top? Where's the padding?? I could feel every single spring through the sheet, like I was taking its pulse — WHERE IS MY PADDING?!?!?!?

I honestly felt like crying right then. You want to know how I slept that night? I spread the duvet back out flat and used it as a mattress. Lying on top of the duvet, the sensation was exactly like lying on a sidewalk.

Then I pulled one end of the duvet out, wrapped it around myself from the side, and made myself into a stuffed flatbread. That way I had both a mattress and a blanket at once — one item,

two functions — and only then could I actually sleep.

By this point I had typed all of three hundred words and was completely spent. I closed my eyes somewhere after nine. Going to bed that early was a form of disrespect toward the neighbors next door.

So around past ten o'clock, I heard it. You might think the sounds in a hotel are more or less the same few things. You'd be wrong.

I heard a pair of high heels going click-clack-click-clack down the hallway — at least twenty laps of it (no carpet) — then the door slammed, one loud bang, and whoever it was went inside. After that, someone began moving furniture.

Half-asleep, I was lying there thinking even in my dreams: how are you moving the furniture? The tables and beds in hotels are all bolted to the goddamn floor — so what on earth is that heavy thing scraping across the floor???

And why did it go on for half an hour?! Are you renovating the hotel??

What is everyone in this place here for???

Anyway, long story short, I made it through the night. Once I post this little account of the situation, I'll have to pack up all my bags again and head to the airport. I'm exhausted, worn out, and half-convinced I smell terrible (didn't dare shower here)··· Estimated landing time is around two in the afternoon. If the flight actually lands on time, there might be an update tonight. If there's another delay, I'm going to go jump in the Huangpu River.

After everything I went through on this trip to Shanghai — you think I'm done once I get home?

No. Business isn't finished. I have to come back again on the 8th, after the holiday.

Wonderful. I'm clearly here to build character and experience life to the fullest.

Chapter 22: Sydney Ginn, After Life and Death

They say that at the moment of death, a lifetime of memories passes before your eyes like a revolving lantern; Sydney Ginn now knew that this was neither entirely right nor entirely wrong.

She lay on the cold floor of the exhibition hall, and yet she felt like a small boat adrift—the ropes that had bound her to the world of the living had come loose, and she was slowly drifting out onto a river thick with fog.

Sometimes the fog thinned and parted, revealing the scene of her first arrival in Blackmoor City; back then she had split the rent on a semi-basement apartment, and looking out the living room window at the street, all she could see were passing shoes and trouser hems.

Sometimes she saw the client from her very first transaction, turning an Artifact over and over under a desk lamp, the light falling into their eyes and rendering both their pupils and their suspicion half-transparent.

The experiences closest to her—opening the passage, attracting a stalker, being killed—felt more like things that had happened to someone else, flat and bleached-out descriptions that the fog swallowed whole. The distant, long-ago moments were more vivid: carrying out the scallion-and-meat pie her mother had baked, going over to a classmate's house every week in seventh grade... open the door, walk inside, and she could go home.

Drawn along by those faraway memories, Sydney Ginn drifted further away; the faint, desperate rattling in her injured throat grew harder and harder to hear.

Her head lay submerged in a pool of blood, which spread out around her like a river of the dead.

"Go ahead and die," a voice floated from somewhere above, whispering in a hissing, leaking sort of way.

And yet it was this send-off that called Sydney Ginn partway back.

...How did it come to this?

She had called the taxi, paid the fare, followed every instruction to the letter without daring to step out of line, and had a stiff neck to show for it by the time she got off.

She had pretended not to see the female Resident crawling out of the elevator on her right, fought her way into the ground-floor exhibition hall with great difficulty, and held her breath in tense, coiled readiness the entire time...

She had done everything, done it all, and still ended up like this. How could she not be furious.

A dark figure stooped down, apparently kneeling on the floor, studying her face.

Sydney Ginn could no longer make out details; all she saw were blurry silhouettes: a rounder shape was a skull, connected below it was a neck, and jutting out from that neck was another dark shape—the hunting knife she had driven into the other's throat.

As the figure opened its mouth to speak, the knife buried deep in its neck trembled gently up and down with each word. The blade had cut through its windpipe, and between syllables it leaked air with a hiss: "...I really should thank you—you've reminded me what it was I forgot. It was the hiking backpack."

Even though Sydney Ginn still had thoughts, none of them showed on her face. Blood had stained her neck a black-red, as though her throat had been erased; her body had gone still, utterly motionless.

When she had leapt onto the first taxi, she must have accidentally stepped on the "Copied" square.

She still remembered the moment she lifted her foot—someone had given the hiking pack on her back a sudden violent yank, nearly sending her tumbling backwards; when Sydney Ginn caught herself and turned around, she was looking at her own face—no distortion of any kind, the features smooth and fine, like looking in a mirror.

She had frozen.

"When did you copy yourself into me?" that other "Sydney Ginn" demanded, glaring at her and getting in the first word. It seemed to want to shove her, but wasn't quite brave enough to make contact, and snapped: "Get away from me!"

So the square labeled "Copied" really just meant she would be copied, and nothing else?

That actually made sense—copying something didn't necessarily mean the original would be damaged...

Apart from the existence of a copy, Sydney Ginn felt, going over herself from head to toe, that nothing was wrong; if there was one thing that made her most uneasy, it was this—"Sydney Ginn" seemed to have inherited both her body and her mind simultaneously, and was now utterly convinced that it was the real one.

...Then how could she be certain, one hundred percent, that she wasn't the Resident? She, too, was absolutely sure she was the real Sydney Ginn.

No—no, that was impossible; the one in front of her was the Resident, and it was about to take her place and go to the Museum of Modern Art.

There was one key piece of evidence that proved she was the real Sydney Ginn—the backpack, the hunting knife, and her phone were all still on her, none of them copied into a second set; the other one had nothing on her, not a single thing.

"At the time, my mind was entirely on how to jump onto the taxi, so I forgot to take the hiking backpack. I was standing in the square the whole time—it was too heavy to keep on my back, so I'd set it down on top of my feet..."

The dark figure hovering before her, shaped like a human face, went on leaking air: "What happened afterward that made me fail to pick up the backpack—that I forgot, because I handed that stretch of memory over to the driver."

Even at this point, "Sydney Ginn" apparently still did not believe it was the Resident.

It paused there, as though something had occurred to it: "I'd actually meant to ask you—Passenger Rule number four: can you lift your head once the fare is paid? But you're a Resident; you don't follow the Passenger Rules, so what could the consequences possibly be... never mind, it doesn't matter. I made it off the taxi just fine either way. I didn't expect you to bring my things to me, though."

...How could she not be furious.

At the time she had not dared to keep fighting with "Sydney Ginn," afraid of stepping into some punishment square; so she had called another taxi, paid the fare with memories, rode the whole way with her head bowed, following behind "Sydney Ginn," and got off at the Museum of Modern Art.

Whatever it did, she did the same, until she finally followed it into the underground exhibition hall, seized her moment, and drove the hunting knife deep into its throat.

Sydney Ginn had heard that Residents couldn't be killed. Even if they died for a moment, they could regenerate somewhere else.

But Residents were bound by rules that went beyond life and death, so an attack could still have some kind of effect—what she hadn't anticipated was that driving a knife into a Resident's throat would only result in a leaking windpipe.

She had let go of the knife handle in a daze, staring at "Sydney Ginn."

When it tried to spit, nothing came out of its mouth, which gaped like a dried-up black hole; now with the knife buried in its neck, it only hissed and leaked air, unable to bleed.

The other stood motionless, its eyes rolling down to look at the hunting knife, then lifting back up to look at her.

For a second or two, neither of them moved.

"Sydney Ginn" slowly spread her familiar teeth at her in a grin. She had brushed every single one of them countless times, studied their color and shape in the mirror until she knew them at a glance—and yet here they were, in someone else's mouth.

...Disgusting.

"My neck has been stabbed with a knife," the Resident said, matter-of-factly, after that second or two. "Since you copied yourself into my likeness, your neck should be pierced as well."

The moment those words were spoken, Sydney Ginn's neck opened its mouth.

...Why? How could this be?

So this was how cold the outside world was; when the blood vessels and muscle were torn open in one stroke, it was like ice water being poured in along the wound—and the pain came only belatedly, trailing behind.

The sudden cold at her throat was instantly swamped by the scalding spatter of blood that splashed across the face of her "self" opposite her—Sydney Ginn pressed one hand hard against her gaping throat, instinctively trying to clamp the wound shut again, but blood kept bubbling up through her fingers.

With her consciousness shattering at the edge of death, she crumpled to the ground.

Her eyelids froze half-open, half-closed, and her soul drifted into the deep, dense fog.

Sydney Ginn forced down the crawling dread that raised every hair on her body, pressed one hand tight against her neck, and seized the hunting knife's handle with the other.

Her palms were slick with cold sweat; her legs had gone so weak she couldn't stand, and she could only slowly slide down until she was sitting on the floor. A few steps away, the corpse that looked exactly like her lay on the ground, its eyelids half-open, the pupils beneath already clouded over like a dead fish's.

"Sydney Ginn" hadn't driven the blade deep enough, and had missed the critical structures—perhaps the one small mercy in all of this.

She knew very well that when a blade penetrated the body, pulling it out would only deepen the wound and cause heavy bleeding; the first rule of first aid was "do not remove anything from a wound." Sometimes a blade lodged in the body could temporarily act as a plug, sealing the wound and reducing blood loss.

The reason "Sydney Ginn" had died from the same injury while she herself was still alive was almost certainly due to that one crucial difference—the hunting knife stanching the bleeding. So Residents weren't unkillable after all, at least not the "Vulture" kind.

The logic of killing it was just a bit convoluted: you had to let it copy itself into a second version of you first, then, after you received a fatal wound, remind it to copy the fatal wound onto itself—only then would it die.

Even a wound that merely looked fatal would do.

Even though she knew she wasn't going to die, having a knife lodged in her throat was a torment to every nerve in her body; and besides, she couldn't call an ambulance in the Nest, couldn't go to an emergency room, and certainly couldn't climb all the way to the top of a high-rise and jump off with a knife in her neck just to get back to Blackmoor City for medical treatment...

She would have to handle it herself.

She dug a spare T-shirt out of her backpack and wrapped it tightly around her neck and the knife, winding it so tight she kept seeing stars and gasping for breath. She felt along the skin for the knife tip, located it with her fingertips, and got ready—the moment the knife was pulled out, she would press down on the wound immediately; she couldn't risk a major hemorrhage.

Sydney Ginn knew the Nest was dangerous, and had no doubt given herself first aid more than a few times; but even with her self-taught basic first aid knowledge and her well-stocked pack, this kind of injury was truly beyond anything she had imagined.

Even she herself didn't know how she had managed to stop the hemorrhage and then clumsily sutured the knife wound closed—it was nothing short of a miracle.

Despite the successful "surgery," Sydney Ginn couldn't hold on any longer and lost consciousness for a while.

When she came to, the underground exhibition hall was still perfectly silent; she and the stiffened corpse of her dead self lay slumped on either side of the enormous candle, and if she cocked her ear to listen, the place felt like a tomb.

Sydney Ginn rested for a long while before she slowly climbed to her feet.

The serious injury, the lingering fear, and the exhaustion made her want nothing more than to go home, to curl up under her covers, breathing in the familiar scent of jasmine laundry detergent, and sink into a long, deep sleep.

But it wasn't time yet.

Sydney Ginn was also quietly astonished; she hadn't expected that, faced with an Artifact, she would show a toughness that seemed beyond ordinary human limits. With a knife wound to the throat, how could an ordinary person survive?

She walked step by step to the candle, hesitated for a moment, and placed her hand against its surface.

A small line of text immediately floated up beside her palm: 2009.4.22.

...So the history encoded at this position corresponded to April 22nd, 2009?

She was currently standing several meters below the top of the candle. Why did this particular spot represent April 22nd, 2009?

Sydney Ginn thought for a moment, walked to the very top of the candle, and reached out to touch it—and sure enough, she saw her own birthday: 1998.9.29.

So that was it... her gaze followed the length of the candle downward.

That meant the flow of time encapsulated within the candle ran from the day she was born all the way to the present day while she was still alive; the candle held no future.

Because the future was chaos, unfixed—and therefore could not be foreseen?

Though her greedy hope of glimpsing the future had come to nothing, which was a little disappointing, looking at it from another angle it was a strange kind of comfort: since fate was not already written, she could still choose what to do and where to go. A person wasn't a small insect sealed inside a transparent cage, every possible path already defined.

In this bewildering, disorienting world, a person still had this small measure of control over themselves.

Of course, Sydney Ginn wasn't arrogant enough to think the Nest had custom-built this Artifact especially for her—whoever touched the candle, it should show history beginning from that person's date of birth.

She walked on a little further and, judging the distance by feel, placed her hand on the candle again to search.

2026.5.2. She found without difficulty the moment she had first encountered the stalker Anthony.

Sydney Ginn had an idea.

She crouched down and found an ignition switch beneath the metal trough. With a *click*, flames ignited beneath the candle's base.

She wanted to try—to snuff this whole thing out before it could begin.

All the sleep debt I'd racked up from the exhausting scramble of recent days came knocking the moment I finally got back... No matter how much coffee I drank, I was drowsy from the moment I opened my eyes in the morning until I fell into bed at night... By eight o'clock I simply couldn't take it anymore and had to sleep...

Chapter 23 – Sydney Ginn: If the Mountain Won't Come to You

The exhibition hall was as dead-still as a cave, broken only by the soft crackling of the flame.

Sydney Ginn's nerves were strung as tight as a bowstring; every little crack of the flame was like a finger plucking that string.

She had read through the long description of the Artifact "Candlefall" in full, and stood there turning it over in her mind for a good while before she could consider it even halfway digested.

She walked another circuit around the underground exhibition hall, making sure nothing lurked in the corners and shadows ready to launch a second attack—being attacked by herself once was already more than enough.

When she passed the corpse, she quickened her pace to move past, then suddenly stopped and turned back.

The corpse of her dead self always made Sydney Ginn feel deeply unsettled.

She had no wish to look at it, and even less to be looked at by it, so she simply covered its face with a towel, smothering that accusatory, scrutinizing gaze her own eyes had fixed on her, and only then returned to the candle.

Using a small flame to heat such an enormous candle naturally took a good deal of effort.

She had completed a full circuit of the exhibition hall before the candle had at last melted enough to proceed to the next step: the section of wax representing early May 2026 was beginning to soften and slacken from the bottom up, drooping heavily toward the floor like a belly swollen with child—except that the "belly" was gradually turning translucent, dark shapes drifting and shifting slowly within it, as though it were pregnant with a womb full of ghosts.

Sydney Ginn hurried over in a few quick strides, bent down, and peered at the past world showing through the melted wax.

The first thing she saw was herself.

According to the Artifact's description, because she was the one who had touched the candle, what the wax revealed was primarily her own personal history—the reason for "primarily" being that no person can survive apart from their broader environment, so significant events in the world around her that had shaped her would also surface within the wax.

The exact words in the description were as follows:

"...In today's highly integrated world, the historical turning points that carry decisive influence are more often than not caused by a handful of people. The mass movements that occasionally succeeded in the past are now almost impossible to replicate.

"Yet the decisions of a small number of oligarchs can influence and reshape the fate of all humanity. By the same token, when applied to personal history, the candle will faithfully render the key figures and key events that influenced and reshaped the individual's immediate environment."

This passage had seemed somewhat obscure at first reading, but after watching the history in the wax for a while, Sydney Ginn understood.

For instance—why had she come to meet the harasser Anthony in early May?

The most direct cause was that a female friend had invited her out to a bar that night.

Amber was not a Hunter and had no passage, but she worked in finance for the Morgan House Faction and had crossed paths with Sydney Ginn a few times before; the two of them got along well enough. It was that very night, at the bar, that Sydney Ginn had met Anthony—all gilded surface and nothing beneath.

But thinking one step deeper: why had Sydney Ginn, who hated the smell of alcohol most of all, agreed to go to the bar with Amber that day?

Because at the end of April, a regional war that had dragged on for years—exhausting the entire world with inflation and wearing everyone to the bone—had finally ground to a halt after immeasurable bloodshed, ending in what amounted to a farce.

The outcome of the war was far from satisfying to anyone with a sense of justice—no matter which side their sense of justice supported—but after years of tragedies that had repeated themselves until people were nearly numb, the whole world had collectively let out a breath; on the day the war was declared over, there were no shortage of celebratory parades and spontaneous public festivities, and even the news anchors seemed somehow lighter.

Artifact Hunters had one foot in the Nest and one foot in the human world, and their outlook always kept them a few paces removed from worldly affairs; Sydney Ginn was no exception.

But even she had felt those days as if sunlight were falling warm on her skin, her mood as brimming and expansive as the approaching summer—when Amber suggested going out for

drinks to celebrate, Sydney Ginn thought she could always have fruit juice, and agreed without a second thought.

If the war had not ended, Amber would not have invited her to celebrate; without going to the bar, she would never have met Anthony; without him becoming her stalker and harasser, Sydney Ginn would never have entered the Nest, would never have had a knife driven into her throat, would never have been standing beside her own corpse—and would certainly never have found this giant candle.

Everything she had endured today, traced back to its root, had come about because of some bald old man on the other side of the world who had started a war... so how could the people and events closer to her—those that had shaped her—possibly not be enfolded into the candle?

"When you are reshaping what lies within Candlefall, you will find that the greater the physical distance between you and your target, the harder it becomes to alter their past."

Immediately following this, the description for "Candlefall" contained this passage:

"Someone standing right beside you can have their past changed with the utmost ease—simply reach into Candlefall and nudge or mold the wax itself, and you can shift their position, experiences, and actions; the past will change naturally as a result.

"Someone on the other side of the city can still be changed, albeit with difficulty—but you will find that the portion of Candlefall encasing them is somewhat stiff and uncooperative when you try to mold it. Fine details are hard to adjust; at most you can alter a rough outline—and as for how much of a difference that change will actually produce, that is even harder to say.

"And what of someone on the other side of the world? Regrettably, even if such a person appears within your candle, you cannot exert any influence over their past experiences."

That hardly mattered, Sydney Ginn thought, gazing at the still-slightly-hazy scene within the candle. What she wanted to change was about to come out through the bar's back door and step right up beside her.

The wax had turned transparent and become a pool of liquid that hung suspended just above the floor, as though it were a glimmering basin of water floating in midair. She reached out and touched it gently, and found it was not hot.

Reflected in that pool was a night in Blackmoor City blazing with countless lights; leaning closer, Sydney Ginn could even catch the distinct smell of the bar—alcohol, tobacco, and perfume

mingled together.

Within the pool formed by Candlefall, tall buildings, the bar, shops, and streets all looked like tiny miniature models. A figure the size of a fingertip—herself—stood at the bar's back door, gazing up at the starless night sky over Blackmoor City.

Right there.

There was no need to stir the wax and search for the right moment; she only had to wait—in this regard, working with Candlefall was a little like scrubbing through a video's progress bar: she could drag it backward or forward, or let it play forward naturally in time.

She remembered that before meeting Anthony, a motorcade of several black Mercedes SUVs had driven past nearby—every window reinforced against blast—and she had stared long enough to catch herself; shortly after the motorcade passed, the back door of the bar, painted dark red, had—

There it was.

The moment the bar's small back door was pushed open the tiniest crack, Sydney Ginn immediately extended her little finger and pressed its tip firmly against the door from within the Candlefall.

The shortest finger, and yet it was nearly as large as the bar door itself—pressed there against it, the sight was actually strange.

Through the door, Anthony shoved again and again, his force no more than a small insect kicking its legs against her fingertip; but how could someone so tiny within the Candlefall ever push open her enormous fingertip?

She leaned close to the wax and heard, muffled beneath the raucous music behind the door, a curse: "...This damn door—what is wrong with it?"

The tiny Sydney Ginn who had stepped outside the back door for some air paid no attention whatsoever to the enormous finger stretching across the air beside her.

When she heard the cursing from behind the door, she only glanced back briefly, then stepped a few paces away—a competent Blackmoor City resident always kept a certain wariness and cool distance from strangers, let alone a stranger who was cursing.

The would-be harasser behind the door shoved furiously a few more times, then finally gave up, and seemed to turn and walk away; quiet returned behind the door.

That should do it, Sydney Ginn thought, not quite daring to pull her hand back yet, still holding the door shut.

As long as they never met in the first place, none of what followed would ever happen.

The rage and indignation she had originally felt toward Anthony seemed, after witnessing "her own" death, to have been soaked through by a cold shiver, and was no longer as fierce; her first priority now was simply to use the candle to run the experiment—revenge had fallen to second place.

As for what effect changing history would have on the "present," the Artifact's description had offered a detailed explanation:

"...After the point where a change occurs, history will continue to develop naturally according to its own internal logic, and the person's 'present' will shift accordingly.

"There is a time-travel paradox that asks whether a person can go back and kill their own grandfather. Because if the grandfather dies, the person would not exist—but then no one would have gone back to kill the grandfather in the first place... and so a paradox is formed."

When it came to traveling through time and changing the past, it seemed there was always a great deal to explain—whether in film and fiction, or with Nest Artifacts.

"'Candlefall' will not fall into any such paradox. The candle constitutes a fixed segment of time—beginning from the birth of the person who touches it, and ending at the very moment they touch it. Therefore you cannot change the past before your own birth.

"However, changing history through 'Candlefall' will still affect the present. For example: if you melt open the wax for a month ago and crush your past self within it—at the instant of that crushing, you will also vanish from before the candle, and the candle will return to its original state.

"That is an extreme case. If you caused yourself to break your leg a month ago, then naturally, a month later, you would not have met a potential client on the ski slopes—correct? As stated above, history will always move forward according to its own internal logic and produce the consequences that naturally follow."

In other words, if she prevented herself from meeting Anthony that night, Sydney Ginn would also vanish from beside the candle—with no harasser, she would have no reason to enter the Nest; and having never entered the Nest, she would of course not be here now.

"However, to preserve the continuity of the timeline, memories of using 'Candlefall' and altering history will still be retained in full—they will not be lost because you have made changes to history."

In other words... if Sydney Ginn prevented herself from meeting Anthony, she would not be in the Nest today; and yet she would still remember that in the "previous version of history," she had met Anthony, entered the Nest, and altered history.

Retaining the user's memories was enough to preserve the continuity of the timeline? But why?

Sydney Ginn turned it over for a while, arrived at no answer, and let it go. Being able to retain her memories was a great boon; great boons don't hold up to scrutiny, so it was best to simply accept it without question.

Only by keeping her memories could she come back and find "Candlefall" again—and compared to such a precious Artifact, what did the nauseating memories Anthony had brought matter at all?

Within the Candlefall, the tiny Sydney Ginn stamped her feet, turned around, and seemed to be heading back inside the bar.

Sydney Ginn moved her little finger aside and watched that tiny version of herself pull open the door and disappear into the flickering lights and music on the other side.

Good—it was all done. She could extinguish the flame and let the candle solidify once more.

Only when Candlefall had solidified again would it set into the shape of a new time and a new history.

The pool of transparent liquid wax suspended in midair slowly turned white, grew cloudy, rose back up little by little, was drawn back into the body of the candle, and once again became smooth and unblemished—no matter how one looked at it, it was as though it had never melted at all.

Sydney Ginn took one last look at the shrouded corpse not far away, closed her eyes, and waited quietly for the brand-new "this moment" that would come after changing history.

After a little while, she opened her eyes.

She had not returned to Blackmoor City; she was still inside the Nest.

The pool of blood beneath the shrouded corpse had nearly dried to a dark, purplish-black; the candle stretched long and unbroken into the distance; the exhibition hall was utterly silent.

In her mind, the string of memories—being stalked and harassed by Anthony, entering the Nest, being copied by a Resident, melting the candle—were all there, clear and complete, exactly as the Candlefall's description had said: none of them had disappeared.

There was only one difference.

The place where she and Anthony had first met had changed from the back door of the bar to the front door.

These past two days have been absolutely exhausting... I overdid it a while back and still haven't recovered. We're 18 now, not 17 anymore—not as young as we were—and I'm really starting to feel the toll on my body. Sigh.

When you're this tired you can't tell if you're sleepy or just hungry, and you spend the whole day thinking about food, but the moment you eat anything you pass out right after—which only makes things worse... These past two days have really been... rough...

Chapter 24 — Sydney Ginn's Altered History

The wound on her neck had stopped hurting much. Her toughness and resilience truly surpassed her own expectations.

But Sydney Ginn's irritation only grew thicker, like a heart overrun with weeds that couldn't be pulled no matter how hard you tried.

Who would have thought history had such resilience — changing one small detail still couldn't alter the course of events. People always say that sometimes missing one turn can change your entire fate. What a lie.

A stalker, putting on the airs of destiny and fate — just thinking about it was nauseating.

Sydney Ginn glanced at the corpse.

She had killed a Resident for the first time — supposedly one that couldn't be killed — and she'd managed it only by talking her way through it, so she couldn't help feeling uneasy. She was afraid that in the blink of an eye it would stagger back up from the floor again, so every now and then she had to take another look.

But she was worrying too much. Death had already soaked through that body like cold water, fixing it completely in place.

After watching the corpse for a while, she finally relaxed a little and opened the fire trough again.

Time to try once more. This time, Sydney Ginn intended to cut off any possibility of the two meeting right at the root.

She melted the candle for the same window of time, watching the transparent Candle Tears fall and pool mid-air into a lake once more.

In the lake-like Candle Tears, a tiny Sydney Ginn and a tiny Amber stepped out of a miniature taxi together, laughing and talking as they walked into the bar — Sydney Ginn watched them enter through the front door, then shifted her gaze back out to the street, sweeping it up and down.

She clearly remembered that on that night, when the stalker Anthony had approached her, he'd said: "You must have arrived at the bar before me. Otherwise, when a girl like you walked

through that door, there's no way I would have failed to notice."

She couldn't take a pickup line at face value, but thinking back on it afterward, it did seem like Anthony had arrived a step later than she had.

Sydney Ginn pushed down the restlessness in her heart and kept her eyes locked on the bar's front entrance, not daring to look away for a second.

There had been a lot of people going to the bar that night, and in the span of just twenty or thirty minutes, four or five groups of strangers stepped out of several cars in succession — she had never seen so many miniature living people, clustered together in twos and threes, walking through the night under the lights, which made them even harder to make out; she stared until her eyes nearly blurred, and at last she spotted Anthony rounding the corner from down the street.

According to the description, "suicide" via the Candle Tears seemed to be possible — but it said nothing about whether it could kill someone else.

Sydney Ginn decided to try.

What could be more final than turning him into a dead man outright?

She had never been willing to kill lightly. In fact, ever since she had become a Hunter, although she had seen no shortage of dead people, not a single one had actually died by her hand.

But tonight, it was as if something inside her had cracked open, and something not quite the same as before was trying to push its way out.

Come to think of it, she had already killed "herself"; trying to kill someone from the past — a stalker, at that — what was the big deal?

If she couldn't kill him, she would think of something else — whatever the outcome, at least it would count as learning more about what the Candle Tears could do.

Sydney Ginn's finger hovered above Anthony's head, like a massive celestial body about to come crashing down on the earth and crush the dinosaurs.

He was still completely oblivious, hands shoved in his pockets, tall and loose-limbed, looking every bit like a decent man.

...Crushing him to death still meant washing her hands afterward.

Sydney Ginn curled her knuckles and brought them down hard on that carefully styled head.

She had expected the sensation to be something like squashing a large bug, but instead it was like pressing down on a slippery ball; the stalker stumbled, and her forceful strike had only shoved him half a step to the side — he quickly steadied himself, and not only was he still alive, he didn't even seem to feel any pain.

Anthony looked down, muttered a curse, and kicked a pebble away.

...Could it be that she couldn't reach in and kill someone else directly? That the only one she could kill was herself?

That was truly funny.

Despite her frustration, two more attempts seemed to bear out the theory: she tried pushing the miniature Anthony into the road, but an oncoming car swerved in time, leaving him with nothing worse than a few curses from the driver; she managed with great effort to knock a sign light loose, timed it carefully, but it bent in mid-air and crashed to the ground right in front of Anthony's nose.

The stalker was apparently no ordinary person — he brushed past danger several times in a row without anything happening to him, and walked into the bar as if nothing had occurred.

"One of the most powerful Artifacts" — the broadcast was full of hot air. It couldn't kill a person, couldn't prevent a meeting; what was the point of this broken candle containing the past at all?

In the end, wasn't everything exactly as it had been? Nothing had changed at all?

Suppressing her frustration, Sydney Ginn swept through the Candle Tears, searching for herself.

She had already grown quite practiced at working the Candle Tears, and quickly found the moment the two had met: a tiny Anthony pushed open the dark red back door, spotted a tiny Sydney Ginn, walked over to her, and struck up a conversation.

"I didn't have the courage to ask for your number at first — I'm not the type who goes around talking to girls," Anthony said with what seemed like genuine feeling. "But do you know what? On my way here just now, a sign light suddenly crashed right in front of me — this close... if I'd been half a step faster, I would have died. Thinking about how full of surprises life is, I couldn't bear to let this pass..."

She had actually helped him upgrade his material?

Sydney Ginn had played a computer game called The Sims as a child, and now, watching the two of them talk in the Candle Tears, a strange, hazy sense of familiarity came over her, leaving her somewhere between the urge to laugh and the urge to cry.

But this was not a computer game.

Sydney Ginn watched that tiny, oblivious version of herself exchange numbers with Anthony just as she'd expected, and could only sigh inwardly with weary irritation as she closed the fire trough — she needed to let the Candle Tears cool and solidify first, to let this chapter of history "set," and then melt it again before she could change it once more.

The tiny Sydney Ginn — she had lost count of how many times now — pushed open the back door and stepped out of the room thick with tangled music and the smell of alcohol, standing outside to get some air.

A convoy of all-black Mercedes SUVs rose silently out of the night; each vehicle, fitted with anti-terrorism and armored modifications, maintained an equal distance from the others as they passed in succession before the bar's back entrance.

As the last vehicle was about to drive past, Sydney Ginn reached out and flicked it toward the back door — the matchbox-sized SUV was caught by the force, lurched involuntarily, veered off the road, and with a shriek of tires slammed its nose squarely into the bar's back entrance.

The bar's back door, which had not been fully shut to begin with, now had its panel caved in and its hinges twisted by the impact, hanging crookedly at an angle — anyone could see at a glance that it would never close again.

The tiny Sydney Ginn stared at the SUV only two paces away, her face drained of color.

Oh — she had forgotten to protect her past self... Never mind, she hadn't been hit by the car, and alive was good enough.

It wasn't as if she had wanted to get so tangled up with a stalker in the first place — so why was she putting herself through all this trouble? Letting her past self get a good scare was no less than she deserved.

Sydney Ginn watched with a faintly disgusted indifference as that tiny version of herself hurriedly backed away a few steps and called out to no one in particular: "Someone help! There's been a crash!"

If the bar had to temporarily shut down because of this, it might scatter the two before they could meet —

Before Sydney Ginn had even finished the thought, the driver's door of the SUV was shoved open, and a man in a black suit half-tumbled out and quickly swung around behind the wide-open door, dropping into a half-crouch; his left temple had been split open by the impact, and blood, curls, and an over-ear earpiece were all tangled together in a matted mess.

But what stood out most was the 9mm pistol held between his two hands.

Nearby, the tiny Sydney Ginn's gaze landed on that black pistol, and her lips pressed together instantly.

After the vehicle was struck and disabled, his first move was to leap out — so he wouldn't be a sitting duck; he sheltered behind the car door to use it as cover against any potential sniper; even though he had clearly taken a significant blow, that 9mm was still held steadily in a position ready to return fire at any moment, his slightly bent elbow not trembling in the slightest...

Both the Sydney Ginn inside the Candle Tears and the one outside it could see it: this was a personal bodyguard with highly specialized professional training.

Then the other vehicles —

Sydney Ginn turned at once, and sure enough found that the convoy had not wasted a single moment — the other four SUVs had already split off in separate directions, each changing lanes and altering course in an instant before accelerating away, disappearing into the night and lights in every direction.

The level of professionalism here was very high, she thought.

At the exact moment the rear vehicle was struck and lost control, the convoy had immediately abandoned it and broken formation, each turning onto a different route and rapidly increasing the distance between them... this was clearly a contingency plan prepared well in advance.

Such a plan generally has only one purpose: to protect whichever vehicle in the convoy carries an important figure, so potential enemies cannot tell which car that person is actually riding in.

"...No, at present we cannot confirm what was done to the vehicle. Yes, no attacks so far."

The man in the black suit crouched behind the car door, speaking in a low voice into his earpiece: "The situation with the car is strange, but I've detected no signs of Artifact use in the

vicinity... Yes, there's a bar here, and there are witnesses nearby — they've probably already called the police."

Artifact? Had he just said Artifact?

Sydney Ginn's interest sparked immediately, and she leaned in closer — fortunately, the man in the black suit was nothing more than a tiny figure within the Candle Tears, unable to see that floating between heaven and earth above the car was a gigantic human ear, listening to every word he said.

"...Understood," the man in the black suit replied quietly after a few seconds. "In the negotiations and handling that follow, I will not mention Mr. Wellesley's name."

Mr. Wellesley?

Sydney Ginn froze.

An important figure, and surnamed Wellesley... could it be that the person so carefully protected by this convoy was Wellesley himself — Blackmoor City's foremost figure in both wealth and standing?

Wellesley was indeed a person of great status, but he wasn't a head of government; that his security should be this tight clearly meant he knew he was in danger...

Could it be that his death, not long from now, was not from natural causes but something deliberately brought about?

Had he noticed, months in advance, that someone wanted to assassinate him — and that was why he had taken such thorough and careful security measures?

Curious as she was, Sydney Ginn hadn't forgotten her original purpose, and glanced back at the back door.

The crash had drawn all the bar patrons outside — some were watching the spectacle, some were on their phones, and some were taking photos and posting on Twitter; the man in the black suit had a sharp read on the situation and, to avoid causing a scene, had already holstered the 9mm back beneath his jacket — though one hand remained pressed over it, ready to draw at any moment.

Among the crowd of onlookers, the tiny Sydney Ginn and Amber were speaking in low voices; a few steps away, the tiny Anthony was glancing toward them again and again.

Within seconds, he walked over and greeted the tiny Sydney Ginn with a smile.

Unbelievable — was there truly no way to keep herself from running into Anthony?

Sydney Ginn cursed under her breath, but after a brief consideration, she decided to set the stalker matter aside for now.

Wellesley appearing in her Candle Tears history meant that he and her fate were bound together in some way... and that was exactly what made it interesting: what possible connection could the soon-to-be-dead richest man in Blackmoor City have with her?

She set little Sydney Ginn and the stalker aside, and working backward along the timeline of when Wellesley's motorcade had appeared, she traced the thread until she had a rough location, then lit a new wax channel.

If she could keep an eye on Wellesley's history, she was sure to dig up quite a bit of information...

The more you wait for something, the slower it comes.

Sydney Ginn fidgeted restlessly—touching the melting candle one moment, adjusting the flame the next—impatient and anxious, her thoughts scattered; her gaze wandered here and there, yet it was only after quite some time that she suddenly realized two things.

First, the stretch of Candlefall from when she and Anthony had met due to the car accident had solidified again, setting into the latest version of history.

Second, the corpse on the exhibition hall floor had vanished at some point without her noticing.

I finally managed to recover a little today! But then I looked at the date—it's already the 5th, and in the blink of an eye I'm going back to Shanghai again...

Following those seven Calabash Brothers from a while back, I don't even know how many Minions I owe everyone now—let me check...

Okay, I'm back after checking, and I owe way too many—can't fit it all in the author's note, so I'll open a separate chapter tonight and thank everyone properly first (。

Thank you all for your enthusiastic support, darlings—I've already bought property in the OB/GYN department of Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, and I'll be living there from now on; everyone is welcome to visit bearing cakes and gifts.

Why is it always Shenzhen Second People's Hospital, you ask—because that's where I was born, and we like to keep things full circle.

Chapter 25 — Sydney Ginn, Latest Version, Present Day

Although the beginning of the story had been rewritten several times, the moment Sydney Ginn met Anthony had never changed:

On the eve of summer's arrival, in a soft and restless night, she ran into a handsome-looking venomous thing.

Of course, her eyes could not see through Anthony's smooth, attractive skin and hair to the dark, twisted liquid writhing deep inside his mind—and when a person feels they are getting everything they want, one by one, they are perfectly capable of being gentle and generous, attentive and considerate.

Especially at the very beginning.

"...That scared the life out of me just now," Sydney murmured to her friend. "He suddenly lost control—the car came straight at me. Lucky I've been keeping fit; my reflexes were fast enough that I threw myself out of the way in time... otherwise I'd be a human pancake sandwiched between his bumper and the wall by now."

Amber drew a sharp breath. "That dangerous? Thank goodness you always go to—"

She stopped herself, glanced over at Anthony, and corrected course: "Thank goodness you always go to the gym."

Amber wore her hair short, had a round little face, and a pair of ears that stuck out sharply from her straight hair like an elf's; her personality matched her looks—quick-witted and perceptive.

Sydney often told her it would be wonderful if she had a passage too, so the two of them could go adventuring together in the Nest—though she also knew that if Amber had a passage, she would be a Hunter for the Morgan House Faction, making the two of them potential rivals.

"You had a real brush with death there. Keeping up with exercise is never a bad idea."

Anthony suspected nothing; he fussed over Sydney with worried concern, the lingering fear on his face so vivid that it looked as though he himself had nearly lost his life just now.

In the space of a minute or two, his emotional range proved quite comprehensive—moving from worry to relief and gradually into righteous indignation, covering the full spectrum: "What

kind of driving was that? Was he drunk? Standing off to the side all sneaky like that, not even coming over to apologize! When the police come to take the statement, you have to spell out exactly what happened."

What would later feel false was, at the time, quite welcome. Sydney flashed him a smile and lowered her voice: "He wasn't drunk... he's probably a private bodyguard. I caught a glimpse of his sidearm just now."

"A bodyguard?" Amber slid a glance sideways and immediately let out an "Oh," her voice dropping. "No wonder he's been keeping one hand under his jacket the whole time... There's no one else in the car—did whoever he was guarding leave already?"

"Already gone," Sydney answered. "He had a whole motorcade ahead of him; the moment his car hit trouble, they all scattered immediately. No idea what went wrong with his car—why it would crash into the door like that."

The moment he heard the word "gun," Anthony's face tightened slightly. He hesitated, then reached out and pulled both women behind the bar's back door, saying repeatedly, "Better safe than sorry... what if he's not a bodyguard but some kind of lunatic? Should we go inside?"

At the time, Sydney thought he seemed quite steady and careful.

"I'd rather stand here a bit longer," Amber said, stealing several glances toward the black-suited figure behind the SUV. "I just love watching the drama unfold—you two don't mind, do you?"

Anthony glanced at her, then at Sydney.

Amber wasn't there for the drama—Sydney knew that perfectly well.

Compared to the everyday dealings of a Hunter's house faction, a car crashing into a door wasn't even interesting enough to bother mentioning.

Moreover, the look in Amber's eyes was nothing like someone watching for entertainment: a bright, focused light had settled in them, moving from the car to the figure beside it, as if that one point of light had already seized on something amid all the noise and confusion.

With a major Hunter house faction behind her, Amber had access to a remarkable amount of information. The Matthew Effect applied here as well: the more a person knows, the better they know where to look for more, and the better they know what actually counts as real "information."

Unfortunately, Sydney couldn't ask her directly what she had spotted—Anthony was right there beside them.

"Then I'll keep you company," she said.

Anthony showed no sign of reluctance.

"The public order in Blackmoor City really is getting worse and worse—I suppose even the wealthy are starting to feel the water heating up." He leaned against the wall and chatted idly with Sydney: "Ordinary people like us can't afford bodyguards; we can only look after ourselves... especially a young, attractive woman like you—you're more likely to become a target."

With his warm gaze fixed on her face, Sydney instinctively smoothed her hair and said with a smile, "I'm not particularly worried."

"Having a boyfriend is a lot safer," Anthony said. "Didn't your boyfriend come with you tonight?"

"I'm single."

Because she had a good impression of him, Sydney didn't bother taking offense at such an obvious fishing attempt; she thought for a moment, then added: "I can take care of my own safety perfectly well. Not to mention anything else—I have a small ladies' pistol at home, and a hunting knife I bought specially from Europe."

Anthony froze.

Something seemed to rise to his throat, then he held it there in his mouth without speaking, rolling the words around on his tongue. While he was sifting and weighing them, Amber gave Sydney a light tug and murmured, "His colleague just arrived."

Sydney's gaze cut through the crowd, and sure enough she spotted a car that had just pulled up; the driver who stepped out was dressed in the same black suit and strode over quickly to meet the bodyguard who had caused the crash.

Whatever had caused that bodyguard to crash earlier, the danger had long since drained away from the scene, replaced by curious bar patrons, the deeply frowning manager, and the emergency responders who had just arrived... The bodyguard had finally relaxed as well, and was now sitting in the driver's seat with the car door hanging wide open, answering questions from two police officers while letting the paramedics check his pupils.

"Dylan," the newly arrived black suit called out.

"Ivan?"

The crash-causing bodyguard looked up at the sound, startled to see who it was, and lowered the cotton pad he had been pressing against the wound on his temple. "Why are you the one who came?"

The second bodyguard, named Ivan, seemed to be lower in both rank and experience, and his manner was respectfully proper: "Something went wrong here, and the boss got a bit uneasy having to go pick something up in the middle of it, so they brought in quite a few extra people on short notice. Sister Mi was worried it would be hard for you to manage on your own, so she sent me over to lend a hand."

For some reason, his voice was pitched a notch lower than most people's. Sydney was quite certain that Amber, just like her, had been straining her ears and edging several steps forward just to catch the general gist of it.

Dylan showed little warmth or gratitude toward this reinforcement.

"Got it," he said, pressing the cloth back against his wound, looking like a man who had nothing more to say and wanted Ivan to stop talking as well—perhaps because there were police officers right beside them.

"We're still open for business as usual," a bartender called out loudly from the back door, apparently trying to remind the patrons to hurry back inside and keep spending money. "Don't worry, everyone—nothing's been affected!"

"Shall we?" Anthony tilted his head down and spoke to Sydney very gently: "Let's go back in and have a proper chat—let me buy you a drink."

Running into Anthony tonight had been a complete surprise; she found herself torn on the spot between "bodyguard crash" and "attractive man"—and it was Amber who smiled at her, tipped her chin toward the bar's back door, and said: "You go ahead. If anything interesting turns up, I'll tell you about it later."

Sydney had no choice but to remind her, "Come find me inside in a bit then"—and after Amber promised she would, Sydney went into the bar with Anthony.

As she settled into her seat, her thoughts flickered briefly to Ivan. He had said something about the boss "picking something up," hadn't he? Picking up what? And was it at all connected to

whatever had caught Amber's interest in the matter?

But she didn't let herself think too deeply about it. Because Anthony had settled in beside her, a lock of hair slipping down over his face, the light in his eyes rippling faintly beneath the shadow of his hair; as if she were some rare treasure the rest of the world had somehow inexplicably overlooked.

Later, Sydney reflected that no matter what the quarry is, a person who can be a Hunter needs a certain instinct—for instance, she hadn't felt there was anything particularly distinctive about her own appearance or dress, yet Anthony had still picked her out from among the crowd of bar patrons at a glance.

In the Nest, she was a Hunter. Back in the human world, she was the prey.

"What would you like to drink?" he asked.

"I absolutely hate alcohol," Sydney said—and hearing herself say it out loud inside a bar, she couldn't help laughing.

Using "not drinking" as a topic of conversation, she began her chat and first date with Anthony.

Over two or three months, they went from seeing each other occasionally to growing closer and closer; after Anthony visited her home for the first time, he became very nearly the most perfect boyfriend in the world—though that illusion didn't last very long.

At some point along the way—she couldn't remember which meeting it was—the two of them were talking and the conversation drifted to the black SUV that had crashed into the bar's back door in early May; it was only then that Sydney remembered she'd never gotten around to asking Amber what she had actually discovered that night—perhaps the whole thing had turned out to be not worth mentioning after all, which was why Amber had never thought to bring it up.

"By the way, I remember you said that night that you had a hunting knife you'd bought specially from Europe." Anthony's interest suddenly sparked, and he asked: "You can get hunting knives here too—what makes a European one special? Let me take a look?"

Sydney immediately leapt up from the sofa, retrieved the hunting knife, and launched into its brand, craftsmanship, and value; the more animated she became about it, the more Anthony's desire was kindled.

"I'm not trying to take it from you," he said, still performing a degree of embarrassment back then: "Could I borrow it for a while? I have a friend who specifically collects knives—I'd like to show it to him."

Sydney thought it over and figured she probably wouldn't need to enter the Nest again for the next two or three months. And even if she did, she had other weapons and tools. "Fine—just bring it back when I need it."

...She slowly opened her eyes, unable for a moment to tell whether the stiff, cold thing was her own body or the exhibition hall floor—the two had nearly fused into one.

Anthony never returned the hunting knife.

Sydney looked at the two threads of memory running through her mind, feeling both lost and bewildered, and suddenly, blindingly clear.

She turned her head without a sound, her gaze traveling across the floor and far into the distance, where it came to rest on the enormous candle lying across the exhibition hall—

And on her own back, seated before it.

So that was it.

In the second version of history—the one that had been altered for unknown reasons—Anthony had borrowed the hunting knife and never returned it; Sydney had entered the Nest without the knife, and had naturally been unable to drive it into the Resident's throat.

And so the Resident had not caused the same wound to appear on its own throat—

And so she had survived.

Today the May Day holiday ended and I went back to my usual chaos—spent most of the day running around outside, so the chapter's a bit late... I'm exhausted every single day, all I want is to go home and sleep properly...

This author's note is being typed on an e-ink screen! I keep buying them and returning them, buying and returning—I'm already on my third one. Will this one survive the 7-day no-questions-asked return window? Stay tuned... The first two I returned the moment they arrived.

(Okay, I can't break the em-dash rule, are you trying to finish me off—)

Chapter 26 — Sydney Ginn's Choice at the Crossroads

For the first few seconds, Sydney Ginn stared at the distant silhouette of herself crouched over a fire, her mind reduced to something like a battlefield after a nuclear detonation. Fragmented thoughts drifted like radioactive fallout—scattered, impossible to form into anything coherent.

Why did she have two separate lines of memory?

In the first memory line, the night she had encountered her stalker Anthony, there had been no car crash behind the bar; she had never mentioned owning a hunting knife, so Anthony had never "borrowed" it from her.

She had entered the Nest intending to retrieve something that could take care of Anthony, only for things to go sideways—at the Hopscotch grid, a Resident had copied her appearance and taken on her identity.

That Resident was utterly convinced that it was the real "Sydney Ginn."

Even the fact that it had no backpack, no phone, and no hunting knife had been explained away: a scuffle between the two of them just before they boarded the taxi had made it rush onto the cab, leaving her things behind.

The truly troubling part was this—if the Resident was so certain that it was the real Sydney Ginn, then by the same logic she could no longer rule out the possibility that she herself was the Resident. Sydney had originally thought that having her phone and hunting knife on her person was proof enough that she was the real one; but what if she had simply forgotten the moment when she had taken those things from the original?

After boarding the taxi, hadn't a stretch of her memory been taken away? If that missing memory happened to cover the moment when she, having become Sydney Ginn, had seized her things from the real one, then she had absolutely no evidence left to comfort herself with.

Between the Sydney lying on the floor and the one sitting before the candle—which one was truly the Resident?

No... that question was a bottomless rabbit hole; fall in and you'd never climb back out. She could set it aside for now. Better to treat herself as the real Sydney Ginn and trace the timeline from the beginning.

After the Resident left, she had called a second cab, carefully followed the Passenger Rules, and trailed the Resident all the way to the Museum of Modern Art. On the basement level, Sydney had found her moment and driven her knife into the Resident's neck.

Not one thing she had hoped for came to pass.

The Resident had stood where it was, both hands pressed over the wound; she had barely glanced at it and couldn't tell whether it bled at all—and she'd had no chance to look more carefully—because in no time at all the Resident had looked at her and smiled, baring a mouth full of teeth she knew too well.

"Since you copied my form, your neck should split open just the same."

The first memory line ended with her own throat suddenly splitting wide, blood spraying outward, her body crashing to the ground like a shattered stone statue.

Sydney Ginn knew she had died.

And yet death was not her ending; after death, she entered the second memory line.

On the night she had encountered Anthony, a black SUV had come barreling straight at her; she had barely dodged it before it slammed into the back door. Starting with the fact that the driver was a bodyguard, she had mentioned to Anthony that she owned a hunting knife—and not long after, he had taken it from her.

When she entered the Nest, Sydney had muttered a quiet curse—being down one weapon always left her feeling a little exposed.

From there, the second memory line was no different from the first: she heard the broadcast, stepped onto the Hopscotch grid, called a cab, and was copied by the Resident... The only difference, at the very end, was that when the second memory line terminated, she opened her eyes on the floor.

Staring at the silhouette before the candle, Sydney Ginn climbed to her feet as silently as she could manage. The floor tiles were smooth and cold, unstained by a single drop of blood.

The second memory line had overwritten the first, becoming the true, most recent version of history—so she had never stabbed the Resident, and had never had her throat cut by a single sentence.

She didn't dare stand up straight for fear the Resident would notice her, and crept on all fours back behind a pillar, holding her breath so rigidly that her chest began to ache—she had to keep it under control, because she actually feared she might start sobbing without meaning to.

...How could a single sentence cut someone's throat?

Compared to a mouth opening in her neck, she couldn't even say for a moment which frightened her more: being killed again without rhyme or reason, or discovering that she wasn't a real human being at all and would spend the rest of her existence wandering the Nest as a Resident.

If she wasn't a Resident, why had her neck so faithfully reproduced the wound on the other one?

Not a single one of these questions did Sydney Ginn have an answer for.

Her back pressed against the pillar, she squeezed her eyes shut and covered her mouth, wishing she could draw herself inward into a ball so tight the Nest would never find her again.

No—calm down first, think it through...

There were several pieces of circumstantial evidence pointing to the other one being the Resident: first, it had no phone, no hunting knife, and no backpack; second, according to what she had witnessed in the first memory line, it had boarded the taxi without following the Passenger Rules and had still gotten off without incident.

Third—and most compelling—the neck's skin was only a thin layer wrapping arteries, nerves, blood vessels, the trachea, and the esophagus; could a living person really perform first aid on a stab wound to the neck and carry on as though nothing had happened?

Sydney Ginn calmed herself a little and quietly peeked out.

The Resident was still seated before the candle, repeatedly adjusting the heat of the flame tray, looking visibly impatient for the candle to melt. The candle, growing gradually soft and drooping, had formed a pool of nearly transparent Candle Tears in midair; from this distance, Sydney could just barely make out what sounded like a voice inside the Candle Tears calling out "Mr. Wellesley."

The candle was surely the key—the reason she had come back from the dead and formed two separate memory lines.

The broadcast had said it was an immensely powerful Artifact, and that was clearly no exaggeration—something that could drag a person back from death was formidable by any measure.

But why was the Resident so keenly interested in it?

Sydney looked around and noticed that the far wall of the exhibition hall was covered in a dense block of exhibit text—Artifacts in the Nest were almost always accompanied by some form of "item description," and this had to be it.

The only problem was that the exhibit text was on the other side of the hall, and to reach it she would have to pass directly behind the Resident.

No matter how she thought about it, she had to deal with the Resident first.

Regardless of whether she was truly the real Sydney Ginn, once the "Sydney Ginn" beside that candle was dead, she would naturally become the "real Sydney Ginn" by default—right?

When survival was on the line, it seemed that even something fundamental, something principled, could be glossed over... Before today, Sydney Ginn had never imagined she would find herself thinking this way.

But if the Resident could kill her with a single sentence, how was she supposed to kill a Resident?

Sydney's gaze swept the room and landed on her hiking backpack slumped on the floor not far away, its mouth hanging open and lopsided, exposing a wadded hand towel and various odds and ends inside.

"Where did it go—"

In the distance, the Resident was still fixed on the Candle Tears, muttering under its breath, looking thoroughly impatient. "It seemed like he said something really important just now... didn't it? Where was it said..."

Taking advantage of its attention being entirely on the candle, Sydney quickly slipped off her shoes and padded toward the backpack in her sock feet, step by careful step—sure enough, she made no sound.

As she passed the backpack, she reached in and hooked out a long towel, then retreated quickly to the far end of the hall—she didn't dare stand out in the open of the sparse exhibition

space with her head tilted back reading the exhibit text, and instead slipped behind another exhibit at the far end of the hall; that piece was far enough from the candle, and was made of bundles of long wooden poles fanning outward in a spiral, which was lovely to look at even if she couldn't tell what it was supposed to be, but at least it was just barely enough to hide a woman crouching behind it.

The Resident would eventually notice that she had disappeared from the floor.

Even if its attention was fixed on the candle for now, it would soon enough discover that its neck was completely unharmed and that the wound had been erased. This was the only window she had to strike first—but how should she use it?

Should she use this chance to read the candle's description first, or make her move against the Resident first?

If she struck first, could the candle become the Resident's trump card to turn the tables on her? When she had her throat cut by a single sentence earlier—had that been connected to the candle?

Unfortunately, when Sydney had followed the Resident down here in the first timeline, she hadn't had a chance to read the candle's description carefully.

At every fork in the road, it's impossible to foresee the chain of dominoes that will follow one after another; just as Sydney herself had never imagined that entering the Nest to deal with Anthony would lead to news of an Artifact, and that searching for the Artifact would lead to being copied by a Resident.

Which path should she choose?

After a moment's hesitation, Sydney couldn't quite say what moved her to do it, but she took out her phone, silenced the shutter sound, aimed it at the exhibit text on the distant wall, zoomed in, and took several photos in quick succession.

Before she could even enlarge the photos to read the description, the Resident suddenly stood up—she contracted all over, seeming to shrink to half her size, and stared tensely at its silhouette through the gaps between the wooden poles.

It hadn't noticed anything was wrong yet. It seemed dissatisfied with the candle in front of it; it placed a hand on the candle, took a few steps as if searching for something, then crouched back down, and with a click snapped the flame tray open.

The flame swayed like underwater grass in the stirred air, casting light on the features that were hers.

Sydney let out a small breath of relief and enlarged the first photo, reading quickly.

The text in the first photo was the closest to her, and though the writing was blurry it was still legible enough to get the gist. By the time she finished reading it, her mouth had gone dry: no wonder she had been pulled out of the fatal ending of the first timeline—it turned out the Resident had accidentally altered history. She had never once imagined there could be something so inconceivable in the Nest.

If she could bring it back to Blackmoor City...

She tapped open the second photo, but the angle and distance were far less ideal than the first, making the specific text actually difficult to make out.

It didn't matter—the most important thing was already clear: though the candle was powerful enough to reverse history, it could not be used as a weapon.

Then she would proceed with the original plan.

Sydney Ginn made her decision, pressed her two fingers down, and locked her phone screen.

In the screen as it went dark, a second face looked back at her.

Lately it really feels like all my stats are kuacha kuacha dropping across the board... I guess this is the price you pay for writing niche stuff (not really lol)

Gotta get on another plane tomorrow ahhhhhh

When on earth am I going to be able to go home and just lie down in peace ahhhhhh

Chapter 27: What?! I've been an ungrateful wreck since April 23rd?

Time flies, the years rush by, and in the blink of an eye, those seven Calabash Brothers I owed you all have...

Never grown up, because I still haven't given birth to them...

I always felt like my last thank-you post to you all was just recently — but I just checked, and the last one was April 23rd?? So I've been heartless, shameless, and utterly without conscience ever since??

I'm so sorry, everyone. You've been supporting me and cheering me on nonstop, while I've been nonstop ungrateful... Let me take stock of the family ties and count how many of those original seven Calabash Brothers have turned into little Minions by now. Don't go flipping past this just because it's a thank-you chapter — what if your name gets called?!

I've been running around nonstop lately, and I figure I can't properly pay my debts until I'm back home. Fortunately, this stretch of running around looks like it's finally entering its last leg — Shanghai is the last stop. Once I'm home, I truly never want to leave again for the rest of the year. I love writing, writing loves me, and nothing can tear us apart.

(Unless someone warmly invites me to New York to gather material for an Artifact report.) (I could leave right now, seriously.) (What do you mean a side project — shouldn't I be working even harder on this one?)

The crowd waiting outside the OB-GYN department of SZ City Second People's Hospital to collect their babies has grown quite a bit:

Well, well — Bohemian Xiang (I dare not look too hard at that username) has shown up to offer their support. I figure quite a few of you still remember this legend... I've completely lost count of how many babies I owe you... Can we just call it one for now...?

A new legend has arrived: Gunsmith Rousseau. You alone added two spots to the baby quota, and I'll be honest, my knees are shaking a little... The username feels vaguely familiar, but I don't dare claim to know you. Are you a new reader who got lured in by the Artifact report? Or are you a blessing from my ancestors delivered via apocalypse (?)

姥姥 b111111111, I refuse to believe you got the number of 1s right the first time you typed that username! I figure you can't tell whether I've written too many or too few either (jk), but either way the baby debt is on the books (.)

Thank you to Yaoyao and Linlin for the KFC (yes, I've abandoned McDonald's — the Golden Arches have let me down, and did you know they've switched away from Heinz ketchup?), to Tie Jiǎ Bái Táng for the dessert (desserts are so expensive now — I nearly fainted seeing egg tarts going for 20-something yuan), and thank you to Chū Shí Qíng Zì Chán, Mò Yuān (pronounced "Black Bird"), and Yǐng Yòu — each of you snuck me a cup of milk tea (the flavors these days are so wild, who even comes up with them?). Haynes even treated me to dinner. You guys basically covered my entire day!

How many babies does that make — oh, I owe another five — so what!

Too many persimmons and your mouth won't pucker!

Thank you to Èr Shí Sì's QD for getting me a DQ (DQ is actually so good, and it was such a lucky buy), to vitang (you've already bought me two bottles of mouthwash — Shanghai ones, no less), to Fēng Yīn (did I still owe you from last time?), and to Joiiiiii for sending an opening flower arrangement...

And also to Lǐ Bāo Bāo de Bāo Bāo (oh my, I actually don't know the story behind that name — really, tell everyone), Zhǎng Gāo Gāo de Yú (this fish is truly very tall — I've been eating it since the last book), Jūn Mǐ Xī (all longtime readers~), Dōng Xiē (oh come on, you're too kind, hehe), and Ā Ā Ā Zěnmē Fēi Shì (how even)

And also Murakami's Kafka (no Consort to sit next to you this time), Sān Xī Yī (I think I saw your comment), Cīlè Mò (what did you say again — I'm just plucking a few sheep here), and Shí Wàn Fú Tè (were you the one who recommended the Northeast bathhouse?)

Thank you to Chén Chéng Yè (new reader?), Xiǎo Sūn Dài Nǚ Fēi (not a new reader), Liú Jǐn Qí (know you all too well), Parsons Yùbèi Shēng, Emmy酱, whhit, MARGINAL Yú, Yǎ Er (nice to see you again), 书友20240202130643416 (I nearly died typing all those digits), 书友20230109114807508 (please, I'm begging you both to go change your names)

Let me catch my breath and keep going:

Sān Jiǔ's Exclusive Bandage (fine, you don't have to shower), Méi Tóu Nǎo Diū Diū, Xuán Fēng Fēi Wán who tips like it's a daily check-in, Yuè Zhuó Xǐ Huān Mào Xiǎn Gù Shì, Mǐ A Áo, Lín

Sān Jiǔ's Dog (?), Yú Xiā Xiè Wú Chù Bù Zài, Nǐ Yǒngyuǎn Shì Qiàn Tàiyáng De, mocaozy, yoleen Yú...

And to everyone who's sent monthly votes — I can basically see all of you, I just actually can't fit everyone in. I'm so grateful that you're willing to cast your monthly votes on a story this niche. I've actually started worrying a bit about the numbers lately, and seeing the monthly votes and readthrough stats is actually reassuring.

I've noticed that saving up all the tips and thanking everyone at once makes it look like business is booming (jk)... It's only 12 babies, right? Come on — let's run through all twelve zodiac signs (.

Chapter 28 — Hello everyone, your Southern Airlines Ambassador here

Welcome to the Southern Airlines Passenger First-Hand Experience Channel, where you can feel the full boarding experience in real time — no Wi-Fi, no social distancing, two hours of upright seatbacks with nothing to eat — all without leaving your home.

That said, I'm actually pretty content: the two girls sitting next to me smell nice, not a hint of anything unpleasant (if anyone smells, it's probably me — I've been running around all day), and the flight isn't even delayed!

What an honor!

Right now the seatback is digging into the back of my skull, the seatbelt buckle is jabbing my butt, my bag is crushing my feet, and the screen in front of me is showing a podcast called "Why We Love the Song Dynasty," while a faint whiff of something drifts over from up ahead (someone let one go a little too early).

I haven't even lifted my head since I sat down — racing against the clock to bring you this live flight report. Why, you ask?

Because

a wandering soul like me won't touch down until seven-thirty

and who knows

when this broken, rootless

update

will

go live in China time.

(continued)

A little poem, just for you — thank you all for tuning in.

Finished the poem and realized I have a tiny bit of time left, so let me ramble for another two cents' worth: the new chapter is five hundred words in! Still featuring the big-eared monkey (?) Sydney Ginn!

If the heavens would grant me two — no, three hours, I'd definitely get an update out today.

But who knows what time I'll reach the hotel... I'm landing at Hongqiao but staying over in Pudong... My biggest hobby in life is donating money to airlines and DiDi drivers as an act of charity.

Why do I always stay in Pudong? Because that's where the starting point of the Nest is.

I'm about to venture deep into their lair again!

(Can my editor see this? I am absolutely not calling you a Resident.)

What? What if it's too late by the time I get to the hotel?

Eat first, eat first — come on, fill up your cups, let's all eat and chat after, eat and chat after.

Chapter 29: The Attack Pattern of the Sydney Ginn Resident

The moment Sydney Ginn caught the first words spoken behind her, amid her terror, a faint flicker of relief managed to surface—

"I knew long ago that you came back to life,"

her own voice, thick as a miasma, drifted up slowly from somewhere above and behind her head. "You're so easy to fool—nothing like me at all."

Good, Sydney Ginn thought, pivoting on her knee and twisting her body around in the same instant, thank goodness its first words were a waste of breath.

So what if it had noticed early? Either way, the two of them were always going to end up fighting for their lives.

She had long since steeled herself for this—yet the moment "Sydney Ginn" flashed into view, she couldn't help but catch her breath, as though someone had shoved her from the front.

Compared to the "Sydney Ginn" she had seen in her memory, the Resident now looked somehow more vivid, more real: a forehead faintly glittering with beads of sweat in the firelight, a strand of golden-brown hair stuck to a temple; the fine down on a cheek, warm breath spilling from parted lips...

Those eyes, blazing bright as if nothing else remained.

This was Sydney Ginn—this was herself—and yet she herself was standing outside her own body, one arm raised high, bringing a dark shape crashing down toward her face.

At the last possible moment Sydney Ginn finally lurched sideways in time; a thunderous crash exploded beside her ear as the exhibit was bitten deep, gouging out a huge chunk; amid the shower of splinters, she squinted and rolled outward across the floor as fast as she could—her face and the backs of her hands already bristling with who knew how many wooden slivers.

"Just die already—there can only be one Sydney Ginn in this world!"

Her own voice, strange yet unmistakably hers, rolled in waves through the exhibition hall; "Sydney Ginn" strained and wrenched a fire axe free from deep within the exhibit of wooden strips.

When had...?

Before she could even finish the thought, Sydney Ginn sprang to her feet and bolted—but in her panic she had forgotten that she'd taken her shoes off earlier, and with nothing but socks on her feet, she had almost no traction at all on the smooth exhibition hall floor.

At the instant she was about to pitch face-first onto the ground, she flung herself forward in a diving posture instead—since she had opened her eyes again, she seemed to have spent more time sprawling and rolling on the floor than standing upright.

The fire axe struck the tile with a dull thud, biting deep—only one step behind her.

Sydney Ginn had never stripped off a sock so fast in her life.

While the fire axe was still stuck in the floor, she tore the sock off and hurled it straight at her other self's face, aiming for the eyes; just like any normal person, the Resident had no desire to let a sock hit its eyeballs, and jerked its head to one side.

Sydney Ginn would have loved to press her advantage, but she had no chance to pull off the other sock and throw it—the Resident had already closed the distance in one stride, raising the axe high above her.

Almost on pure instinct, she kicked hard at the Resident's ankle.

Once the Resident had copied Sydney Ginn, it was nothing more than an ordinary human body; kicked in the shin with full force, it stumbled back two steps in pain. Sydney Ginn seized the opening, scrambled to her feet, and ran forward—one foot steady, one foot slipping.

But as she ran, she found herself involuntarily replaying the sensation of that kick landing on the Resident's ankle.

She had never thought about it before: what shoes was the Resident wearing?

She already knew that when a Resident copied someone, it couldn't replicate their bag, phone, and other belongings. But what about clothes? What about shoes?

In that brief glimpse during the life-or-death moment just now...

"Wait!"

Sydney Ginn knew full well that with one bare foot she couldn't possibly outrun the Resident; and the more chances she gave it to talk, the more dangerous things became—she wheeled around and called out urgently: "What are you wearing on your feet?"

The other "Sydney Ginn," teeth clenched, bearing down hard behind her, startled at the question but wasn't distracted—it brought the axe down first; only after Sydney Ginn barely dodged did it laugh breathlessly: "Trying to say something useless to buy time?"

"A Resident can't copy a backpack, and it can't copy clothing either!"

Terrified it would catch up again, Sydney Ginn hurried on: "You copied my appearance, but the shoes you're wearing are still your own. You must have the memory of what I was wearing when I entered the Nest today, right? Look down, then think—do the clothes and shoes you remember match what's actually on your body?"

"Sydney Ginn" froze for a moment, and actually looked down at her clothes.

Even a Resident in the Nest couldn't go around naked—there was generally something on it.

This particular one, perhaps because it was a Vulture—always ready to become someone else at a moment's notice—was wearing plain, highly versatile black trousers and black shoes. One couldn't really blame Sydney Ginn for never having noticed its clothing; when a face identical to your own rises out of the darkness, you're not very likely to pay attention to what shoes it has on.

"That's exactly right," it said when it raised its head again, enunciating clearly. "When I enter the Nest at night, I always wear black from head to toe so as not to draw attention. If you think you can trick me with that, it's really quite laughable."

It hefted the fire axe in one hand and gave a small kick with the tip of its shoe.

"I can even tell you—I bought these shoes at Bloomingdale's during a sale, because I thought: anything I wear into the Nest just needs to be good quality; there's no point paying full price for something fashionable."

Now it was Sydney Ginn's turn to freeze. That line of thinking was unmistakably her own; she could even recall several pieces of clothing she had bought for exactly the same reason.

"And you?" The Resident smiled at her, a strand of hair sticking to its lips, framing its teeth. "If you truly have my memories, you'll find that it's your clothes that don't add up."

Sydney Ginn couldn't help but look down, her gaze dropping to the khaki joggers.

She remembered pulling on these exact pants before climbing out the window... but where had they come from?

Most people can recall, at least vaguely, where they bought their clothes—yet these joggers felt as though someone had pulled them onto her body mere seconds ago, so unfamiliar that her mind went blank.

Why was there no memory of buying these pants?

"It seems that after a Resident copies its original, it smooths over and lubricates the memories—patching up details that don't match reality, filling in the gaps... which is why you're so firmly convinced that you're the real me."

While she stood with her head bowed, staring blankly at the pants, the other "Sydney Ginn" had been slowly closing in; its voice, its breath, its smell, and its feet in their black shoes were gradually encroaching on her existence.

"Residents can't be killed—I've heard that."

It said quietly, "Still, I'd feel better once I've taken away your ability to move... I imagine there's a time limit on how long you can hold a human form? When the time runs out and you haven't returned to Blackmoor City to replace me, you should revert to your Resident form, right?"

Wait—what was it saying?

As though something had quietly pricked a point deep inside her mind, a grain-of-rice-sized point of light slipped through—but it flared for only an instant before heavier, more pressing shadows closed over it and blotted it out.

She neither heard nor saw anything—it was something beyond the five senses, some pure instinct, that made Sydney Ginn suddenly duck low and lunge forward the moment the fire axe swung down toward her forehead, wrapping her arms around the Resident and driving it off its feet.

The Resident's arm, tensed and swinging with full force, came crashing down hard against her ear and the side of her head; but the fire axe itself—the truly lethal part—finally glanced off her shoulder, slipped free, and clattered onto the tile a short distance away.

The two of them went down together, and the back of the Resident's head struck the floor with a sound that made every organ in the body clench.

"You copied my form," it still managed to speak with difficulty, "so you also—"

Before it could finish the sentence, Sydney Ginn had already pulled the towel she'd tucked into the back of her waistband and shoved it over its mouth.

The Resident twisted its head from side to side to avoid it, and though the towel didn't go in cleanly, it stopped the Resident from finishing what it was saying.

Sydney Ginn didn't dare let go; gritting her teeth, she endured the blows the Resident kept landing on her body, holding the long towel taut with both hands, and seizing the moment when the Resident's lips parted, she pressed it deep into the Resident's mouth—the towel ran like a rope across her other self's cheek, driving its tongue to the back of its throat, leaving it capable of nothing but muffled groaning, unable to form a single clear word.

"I... I think I understand..." she murmured, staring at the face distorted beneath the towel. "I think I've figured out your attack pattern. You really are the Resident."

Yesterday I arrived at the hotel, had dinner, typed for a while longer, and simply couldn't hold on—fell asleep... Woke up early this morning and kept going, otherwise I'd feel guilty.

This time the hotel stay was thanks to some perks from Qidian—you know they had that promotional event for the Joy of Life drama production, right? I'm not connected to that, but I tagged along and piggy-backed on it, sort of like sneaking in through a side door... How to put it—I keep having this guilty feeling like someone will audit the accounts afterward and make me pay for the room. Someone from Qidian told me Maoni was also staying there. Round it up and down, and you and Maoni are basically the same tier.

That's some seriously wide rounding—one step would carry you from the Huangpu River all the way to Tokyo...

Chapter 30: The Way Sydney Ginn Fights Back, and Establishing True Identity

Looking back now, it was probably because she had the "Virtual Guide to the Infinite Illusion" that Sydney Ginn had almost never truly gone head-to-head with a Resident—let alone fought one in a life-or-death struggle.

It was only after she was released from death once more that she finally arrived at a conjecture.

She knew that every Resident had its own distinct way of surviving and attacking.

But "attacking" alone was far too vague and broad a term: punching someone was an attack; splitting someone's throat with a single sentence was also an attack—and so, crowding out your existence bit by bit was an attack as well.

"You said it yourself—Residents alter memory details and fill in gaps and holes, which is why a Resident is absolutely, unshakably convinced that it is the real person."

Sydney Ginn was already struggling to keep the towel pressed down; if the strength the Resident beneath her was now using to thrash was actually her own, then all those years of keeping herself in shape had paid off quite well—well enough that her teeth were clenched and her arms were trembling, and she could be thrown off at any moment.

But not a single word of what needed to be said could be left out.

There could truly only be one Sydney Ginn in the world—the Resident was not wrong about that.

"When I think back, I find that I'm not like that. Ever since I discovered there was another 'Sydney Ginn,' I haven't been able to shake the self-doubt—especially after I came back from the dead... I can't explain why I would copy your wound onto myself, or why I can't remember where I bought those pants. If I were the Resident, I should have had a smooth answer to all of these questions long ago."

The "Sydney Ginn" beneath her had the towel shoved deep into her mouth; her lips were pressed into two long, thin, taut lines, teeth half-hidden and half-bared, saliva and drool and

retching sounds and her tongue all churning and struggling in the depths of her throat as though she still wanted to speak—her own face looking like that was almost unbearable to witness.

Sydney Ginn knew what it wanted to say.

"You want to say that precisely because I am the Resident, when I face questions I cannot answer, I take that as proof that I'm the real one—is that it?"

A muffled whine rose from its throat, something that sounded like an angry "Yes."

"Impressive... no matter what argument I raise, you can turn it into doubt I cast upon myself."

The Resident drove a fist into her side, and for an instant it was as if it had knocked the air and the light clean out of the room.

Sydney Ginn's vision went dark in waves; she bore the pain and kept pressing it down with all her strength, managing only to twist her body to the side and curl her legs up, using her thighs as a bulwark to absorb its pounding fists—her other knee still had to pin down its other arm, and the muscles were screaming.

"This is your attack pattern, isn't it?"

She had to say it out loud; only by saying it out loud could there be any chance of survival. "Between the two of us, you are the one with absolute, unshakable certainty, and I am the one filled with fear and doubt. It's that little seed of doubt in my heart that gives your words their power to wound—that's what turns them into reality."

The reason a single sentence had split her throat open was not because she was a Resident; it was because of that tiny sliver of doubt within her.

A Resident's weapon was "language"—but its method of attack was like a syringe filled with poison: it had to pierce the skin before the poison could take effect.

And that tiny grain of self-doubt was the entry point on the skin—without an entry point, a Resident's verbal attack would have no effect.

If the Resident had said that same sentence to Anthony, his throat would certainly never have split open, because his sense of self was perfectly clear and had nothing whatsoever to do with "Residents."

"...Your instinct is to crowd out my existence. So you keep reminding me, pointing out all sorts of problems and inconsistencies, trying to make me believe that I am the Resident. 'Sydney Ginn' is a seat—if I die, or disappear, the seat is vacated, and only then can you sit in it forever, and truly become Sydney Ginn.

"To that end, you split my throat open with a single sentence, and then you told me that a Resident's 'copying' has a time limit—even if no such thing is actually true, because you've said it out loud, after a while I'll gradually start turning into a Resident, won't I?"

The tiny sliver of doubt she had felt about herself just now had already served as an entry point, letting that sentence seep inside; the time left to Sydney Ginn was running short.

If she still hadn't dealt with the Resident before her in a little while, she was afraid she would begin to take its place and become the Resident herself...

Even though she felt she had worked everything out, the moment that thought arose, a small voice still surfaced from somewhere deep inside her: Was that really true?

When the time came, would she be "replacing" it as the Resident—or "reverting" to what she had been as the Resident all along?

...No, now was not the time to think about this; she was already struggling to keep "Sydney Ginn" pinned down.

Sydney Ginn shook off that voice from the depths of her mind and picked up her pace, wanting to pour out everything she had to say before the moment slipped away.

"When you said the 'Resident' has a time limit, that was actually what began to reveal the truth to me. Because the real 'Sydney Ginn' would have no knowledge of that piece of information whatsoever—I even doubt whether that information actually exists, or whether you invented it on the spot, just to make me take your place as the Resident."

The final syllable was stretched into a broken note.

With one violent lunge from the Resident that gave it more room to move, it slammed its fist into Sydney Ginn's temple; amid the clanging bells and white stars, by the time her vision cleared again, she found that at some point she had been thrown to the ground.

"Sydney Ginn" was climbing to its feet, dry-coughing as it did. The long towel had been soaked through with saliva, heavy and sodden, lying flat on the floor beside it.

"You're wrong," it said.

Its voice was hoarse, as though its lips and tongue were still numb and sluggish, not quite obeying. "...The real Sydney Ginn does know about that piece of information. Last month, when I was listening to the radio, the host mentioned it in passing as a rumor—I remembered it..."

Fire axe—three words leapt into Sydney Ginn's mind.

She couldn't let it get to the fire axe.

She couldn't stand up; she pressed her limbs to the floor and crawled in an unsteady wobble toward the fire axe. The Resident had clearly spotted her target too, and gave a soft, contemptuous laugh, turning as if to kick at her—just as Sydney Ginn scrambled to dodge and sat back down hard on the floor, the Resident strode toward the fire axe.

It seemed there was only one way left to slow it down.

Even if she could only buy herself a few seconds, just enough to catch her breath.

Staring at the back of another version of herself hurrying toward the fire axe, Sydney Ginn called out in a hoarse voice:

"Then why don't I?"

The other "Sydney Ginn" stopped dead in her tracks. It turned its eyes and looked at Sydney Ginn from beneath its lids.

"You said the real Sydney Ginn knows about that piece of information, right? If you're the original and I copied you, then naturally I should also have that information somewhere in my memory."

Sydney Ginn let out a low, dry laugh at her other self. Her throat felt as if it had just been rolled through sand and coated in a layer of grit.

"...When you brought up that piece of information, I suddenly realized—I don't have it in my head. I'm not the copy. You are."

The Resident stood there blankly, as if momentarily unsure how to react.

"Don't forget—there's one more key point."

Sydney Ginn didn't dare crawl toward the fire axe again; she was afraid of jolting the Resident out of its daze. The more confused it was, the better for her. "...Residents can't be killed,

can they? But I've died once—haven't I?"

The Resident lowered its head and shook it hard several times.

"No—you could be lying to me, knowing full well but pretending you don't. Wouldn't that be simple enough?"

It spoke in a voice that was almost a murmur.

If a voice could have a shape, it would be like a worm drilling endlessly into the darkness, never looking toward the light. "The idea that Residents can't be killed has always been just a rumor—before I killed you today, I'd never actually tried to kill a Resident before... its validity has always been up for debate."

"You see," Sydney Ginn laughed under her breath and said, "a Resident really will find all kinds of excuses and reasons to fill out its own memories and logic, to convince itself that it's the real person."

The words settled, and the hall was silent for a second or two.

She watched herself slowly lift its head toward her.

A person is not very familiar with their own expressions, unless they spend every waking moment looking in a mirror; so Sydney Ginn found it difficult to describe exactly what the look that flashed across that face meant—if she had to describe it, it was as though something that had been suspended high up in "Sydney Ginn's" mind suddenly came crashing down.

The next instant, she understood.

"No matter which of us is actually the Resident," that face—her own face—twisted slightly and said, "as long as I kill you, I'll naturally be the real Sydney Ginn."

Before the words even finished falling, it had already lunged forward, snatched up the fire axe from close by, and swung its gaze back toward Sydney Ginn—Sydney Ginn cursed her luck inwardly, hurriedly yanked off her remaining sock, rolled to her feet, and ran.

Truly worthy of being her copy: faced with the same problem, it had arrived at the same answer.

She had originally thought that once she punctured the Resident's confidence and sowed doubt in it, things would take a turn for the better—but whether the Resident was confident or not, it was still coming to kill her, so hadn't the situation remained fundamentally unchanged?

Worst of all, she couldn't kill a Resident, but a Resident could kill her—was there any way to win this fight?

The exhibition hall was large, but when someone behind you was chasing you with an axe, it suddenly felt far too small.

Sydney Ginn was barefoot and couldn't run toward the area covered in wood splinters and debris—if a splinter lodged in her foot and she couldn't run, she'd be leaving her life here; that left only one direction of escape open to her, which was where the enormous candle stood.

...And the flames dancing at the base of the candle.

The Resident hadn't put the fire out, and it hadn't let the candle solidify—the thought jumped into Sydney Ginn's mind.

When she had been watching from a distance just now, she had noticed that the section it had melted seemed to be not far from the time period when she had first encountered Anthony—in other words, about six months ago.

Wait—if the section from six months ago could be melted, then—

Before Sydney Ginn could finish the thought, her feet had slowed without her realizing it, her mind elsewhere.

A heavy, sharp pain cut through both her train of thought and her shoulder at once.

Friends, I'm sorry—I was completely exhausted yesterday. I am an extreme introvert, and these past couple of days I've unexpectedly turned into a social butterfly who's also been gaining weight (actually gaining weight—I've barely had a proper meal, and I'm already up to 125 jin), and yesterday I basically collapsed dead in bed.

But today I pulled myself together and mustered my motivation—can you guess where I finished writing this chapter...

I opened up a passage, entered the lair of China Literature, and wrote it to completion right there in their headquarters...

How do I put it—the pressure was very real, but you need pressure to get an update written... after all, tomorrow I, well, have to get on a plane again, so a little pressure is necessary...

(Honestly, this trip to Shanghai has completely unfolded into an entirely different storyline—I really never expected to have my cover blown like this. When I have a moment, I'll fill you all in

on the details.)

Chapter 31: All Those Chapters Before Sydney Ginn Are Gone

Two streams of memory, like neighboring rivers whose banks had crumbled away, were gradually converging. Each surface mirrored the other's ripples, until it was impossible to tell where memory ended and reality began.

Sydney Ginn lay on the ground, and directly above her field of vision loomed the belly of an enormous candle.

For a moment she couldn't remember why she had fallen: had her left shoulder been hacked off? Or had her throat been torn open?

All she knew was that she seemed to be losing blood rapidly.

Having sustained such grievous trauma, her body had not yet gone into shock, but her consciousness was already teetering at the edge of dissolution.

"I thought about it again, and I still think you're the Resident after all."

Her own voice rang out a few steps away, heavy with labored breathing. "I'm not sure why, but I believe you weren't lying—maybe because I know myself. You said you had no information in your head about 'Resident copies having a time limit,' and I believe you. But you overlooked one thing. Do you know what it is?"

Sydney Ginn heard the words, yet they reached her as if through some foggy barrier, too muffled to make sense.

She lay with eyes half-open, watching the candle not far away slowly form a transparent pool across her body, as though the lake of blood beneath her were merely its reflection.

Perhaps this kind of death was fitting—watching another version of herself from some other time and place going about her life, blissfully unaware, while she slowly decided when to close her eyes.

"When you got into the taxi, you handed over a stretch of memory, just like I did. The memory you gave up was most likely the information that 'Resident copies have a time limit'—that's why you feel like you don't know it. And that, in turn, made it so convenient for you to latch onto my words, treating it as a loophole, as proof that you're the real one..."

Even in her dying state, Sydney Ginn understood that last sentence.

"So you're the Resident." The other self concluded.

If I were the Resident, I wouldn't be dying here.

Sydney Ginn desperately wanted to say those words aloud, but all that came from her throat was a hollow rattling. Her injured left shoulder felt like it had become a black abyss, and her mind and consciousness were draining away through it at a terrifying speed; so that when she struggled to turn her head slightly to the left, she couldn't even bring herself to glance at her own shoulder.

Through a vision stained red, the other "Sydney Ginn" was bending down to pick up the fire axe.

The axe, coated in her flesh and fragments of bone, had bitten in too deep just now; the Resident had lost its grip on it, and it had slipped free and fallen to the ground.

Sydney Ginn dimly recalled that after taking that axe blow, she had somehow stumbled forward a few steps—at that moment, the fact of her "shoulder being severed" was still distant, still unprocessed by her brain; her mind had been fixed entirely on reaching the correct spot beside the candle.

So when she finally gave out and collapsed, the better half of her body had ended up falling beneath the candle.

"...Resident," she murmured, watching the silhouette bend down and lift the axe. "I'm not."

"Ha."

The Resident didn't look up. It hefted the axe and let out a single syllable.

"The pants..." each word she spoke was barely a ghost of breath, no longer even qualifying as sound. "The taxi... took them."

Truly worthy of being another "Sydney Ginn"—it was exactly like talking to herself; the few words that anyone else would have found incomprehensible made it pause, then quickly understand.

"You're saying that the memory the driver took from you in the taxi was actually the memory of you buying a pair of pants?"

To convey how absurd that was, it gave a deliberate laugh and said, "Are you out of your mind because you're dying? This is the Nest—the Hopscotch section especially, which is strange

and dangerous. Right after fighting me and then getting into the taxi to pay the fare, the very first thing that jumped into your head was where you bought a pair of—"

It didn't finish the sentence. It stopped.

If this Resident had not copied Sydney Ginn, it would never have wasted even half a second on such a ridiculous claim—it would simply have walked over and swung the axe to end her life.

But precisely because it had become "Sydney Ginn" completely and utterly, it suddenly halted, standing in place with the axe hanging from its hand—and after two seconds, it looked down at the pants it was wearing.

It made a small sound through its nose, like someone being roused from a deep morning sleep by an unwelcome phone call.

They say that knowing yourself is the hardest thing in the world; yet if a person has lived for twenty-eight years and is not the sort to drift through life in a dull, numb stupor, they will have some measure of self-knowledge.

There was one trait Sydney Ginn shared with a puppy under a year old—a pigeon flying past would make it snap its head around; a faint noise in the distance would make its ears prick up; Sydney Ginn was the same way.

A neon sign with a letter missing a leg, the white feathers flashing when a bird ruffled its wings—things like these would slip into her attention and briefly steal her thoughts away.

One of the Passenger Rules was to lower your head and let it hang between the driver's seat and the passenger seat.

What would happen after she followed that rule?

Sydney Ginn would find that part of her field of vision was filled with her own thighs and pants.

"You're saying... you lowered your head, saw your pants, and involuntarily thought of the memory of buying them, and that was the memory the driver took away?" The Resident stood in place, murmuring.

Sydney Ginn let out half a groan from her throat in answer.

"Ridiculous," the Resident said, and for a moment it didn't move. "Impossible."

Even though it had already made up its mind to kill Sydney Ginn regardless of who was real and who was not, it still couldn't help but fall into thought—perhaps this was part of Sydney Ginn's personality asserting itself, or perhaps it was simply human nature, copied onto it.

While it sank into its thoughts, Sydney Ginn had already managed to make out the history unfolding inside the Candlefall not far away. A tiny version of herself was giving instructions to a doorman: "...If anyone suspicious comes, don't let them ring my doorbell..."

She remembered—that was the day before she received the funeral wreath.

The Candlefall encasing that day was suspended just above her lower abdomen... the next day—today, the day she had entered the Nest—would be right next to it, wouldn't it?

Sydney Ginn closed her eyes and imagined that her right hand was a mole searching for its target, quietly creeping along.

Only by pretending it was not part of this rapidly cooling body could she manage to move it at all—feeling her way forward, gently flipping open the next switch on the fire groove.

The left half of her body was flooded with a howling cold wind; the right half of her body, however, grew faintly warm—like a hallucination.

She couldn't let the Resident notice what she was doing—otherwise it would immediately know what she was trying to do.

The flame had only just leapt up and the candle had not yet fully melted, but the Resident had already surfaced from its thoughts, exhaled, and began to speak.

"Look at that—I almost let your words tie me in knots. All this true-or-false, going around in circles—I can't sort it out, and I don't need to. Same as I said before: kill you, and every problem disappears."

Buying a few seconds of delay had already taken tremendous effort, yet it was still nowhere near enough; Sydney Ginn fought desperately against the dizziness, trying to gather her dissolving consciousness, while searching through the white fog of her mind for the next excuse.

She had to say something to divide the Resident's attention—fortunately, she was not someone who was hard to distract; a flaw that had now become the very thing that might save her life.

"You can't..." Two words drifted from her lips, like dust stirred by a breath.

The Resident walked toward her step by step, the fire axe still dripping blood, and asked, "Can't what?"

Sydney Ginn's mind was like a fire on the verge of going out; on the edge of unconsciousness, dazed and heavy, she let the thought in her heart slip out: "...Can't kill me."

The Resident gave a short laugh, crouched down, and reached beneath the candle to grab her ankle. "And why can't I kill you?"

Whether it was its hand or those words, something ignited a few bright red sparks again in Sydney Ginn's mind.

She watched the great swathe of white wax on her body wobble and soften, beginning to sag downward, as though it were reaching down to close her eyes and spare her further suffering.

"If I die... it proves you're the..."

The hand gripping her ankle paused.

The Resident let out a cold laugh from beyond the candle and said, "You're trying to say that because Residents don't die, if you die, it proves I'm the Resident?"

Who could have imagined that the one and only kindred spirit in her life—the one who needed no words between them—would turn out to be a Nest Resident that had copied her own form.

Sydney Ginn narrowed her eyes, her gaze trembling as it settled on the Candlefall; a dark shadow was finally beginning to take shape within it, but it wasn't enough yet—she wanted to see tonight's version of herself as soon as possible.

"The last time I killed you, I already understood. You're the Resident, but you don't think you are. You believe with your whole heart that you are the real 'Sydney Ginn,' and even your inner self-doubt has become, for you, proof that you're the real one.

"If we're talking about who is more absolutely certain, it's actually you, all right?

"Given that you're completely convinced you're the real person—if I inflict a fatal wound on you, you will die from it. Haven't you heard of that experiment? A person is blindfolded and told that they are about to be burned with fire; after artificially inducing the sensation of pain, an actual burn mark appears on their arm.

"That is the power of the mind at work. The reason I can kill you is exactly the same principle as that experiment."

"Sydney Ginn" talked and dragged her at the same time; but one hand wasn't enough to drag her, so it put down the fire axe and used both hands—Sydney Ginn slid across the floor like a heavy lump of dead weight.

Inside the Candlefall, a tiny Sydney Ginn had just come out through a door. She was walking along Colorado Avenue, still a little unsteady on her feet from the alcohol that hadn't worn off, unaware that a human-shaped shadow had quietly fallen into step behind her.

Just a little more—Hopscotch was about to come into view.

This desperately struggling thought made the dying embers in her mind flicker with bright red sparks; Sydney Ginn couldn't tell where she found the strength, but as she slid outward again, she raised her hand and swept it through the Candlefall.

She had just watched the Resident manipulate the Candlefall and already knew how to adjust the timeline. Perhaps heaven still couldn't bear to leave her utterly without hope, for in the midst of her dying struggle, Sydney Ginn managed to land exactly on the right moment—from within the Candlefall came the sound of her own voice cursing the Resident just before she got into the taxi: "Get away from me!"

The sound rang out, and those two hands released her; her feet dropped and hit the ground with a thud.

"What did you do?" The Resident reacted with lightning speed. "You want to stop 'Sydney Ginn' from being copied by the 'Resident'? You'll disappear—you're the Resident!"

It looked like it was about to lunge at her.

Sydney Ginn's right hand felt like an empty sack of skin, without muscle, without blood, without strength; yet she still clenched her teeth and shoved the tiny Sydney Ginn into the taxi—her enormous fingers became a wall of separation, cutting little Sydney Ginn off from Hopscotch.

Before Sydney Ginn finally lost consciousness, she saw, dimly, that the tiny Sydney Ginn inside the Candlefall had not been copied.

The "Vulture" Resident within the Candlefall had not turned into another version of herself, either.

Which meant... the chapter of history in which "being copied by the Resident" had occurred was changed, erased, had never happened at all.

Soon, there would be only one Sydney Ginn to open her eyes in the underground gallery of the Museum of Modern Art.

And only when she looked back at the thread of memory in her mind would she know which Sydney Ginn had been the Resident, and which had been herself.

Today the flight was delayed again, wasted a whole day of my time — by the time I got home it was nearly nine at night, and I only just finished writing the update now... Sorry to keep everyone waiting so long.

There's actually a lot I could share, but it's too late tonight, I'm about to pass out from exhaustion — I'll talk about it next time.

Because Sydney Ginn changed history, the content from the previous seven or eight chapters all disappeared — it's as if it never happened. Seriously, go check for yourselves if you don't believe me.

Chapter 32: Chase's Underground Chase

It was only after hanging up the phone that Kingsley thought of the critical question—by which point Chase was still barreling through Blackmoor City like a man with a death wish, treating the roads as if they were his alone.

You couldn't blame Kingsley for being slow to react: after watching a truck come thundering toward you, anyone who could immediately calm down and think clearly existed only in novels.

"Wait, you gave them the whole range," she jolted upright and said. "Doesn't that mean by the time we reach our destination, we'll have driven straight into a police cordon?"

Chase had given a wide range precisely to spread the police thin and keep them guessing which direction he was actually heading; but broadly speaking, Kingsley's understanding was correct.

"Watch yourself," he said, wrenching into a sharp turn and forcing the car off the main road and into a dim, narrow alley. "The way you're talking, you sound like the criminal."

Kingsley grabbed on to steady herself and came back to her senses. "Oh, right, I was 'kidnapped' into this car..."

"That's right. Remember it. In a little while, that's the only truth."

The other side mirror didn't survive either, clipped off against the alley wall; the already dented Mercedes paid no attention to the garbage cans blocking its path and plowed straight into them—clang—a can tumbled over the windshield, plunging the interior into darkness for a moment.

The garbage bags burst open, and the car tore through a shower of flying trash, emerging streaked with filth. The wiper knocked a banana peel aside but smeared a sticky trail of muck across the windshield in its wake.

Not that there was any saving this car anyway.

"What's your plan?" Kingsley asked.

"Open the glove compartment in front of you," Chase said. "There are zip ties inside—take them out and bind your own hands."

Kingsley looked up, stared hopelessly at the sky for a few seconds, and finally resigned herself to her fate.

She found the zip ties, held them in her teeth, and after a great deal of struggling managed to loop them halfway around both wrists but couldn't fasten them, so she had to ask him for help—Chase reached back with one hand while still driving and pulled the zip tie tight.

As he drew his hand back, he couldn't help but frown, finding the zip tie wet with saliva; Chase shot her a cold look, then wiped his hand firmly on the shoulder of her denim jacket.

Kingsley let out a small, smug laugh.

"This goes against every survival principle I've ever held," she muttered, lifting her bound hands in front of her face like a bundled bouquet of flowers.

"You don't need to survive anything." This wasn't the Nest.

"Fine, so what am I supposed to do in a moment? You surrender so I can be gloriously rescued?"

"Don't talk nonsense."

Chase steered back onto a side road; the pursuing police cars had disappeared from view behind him—but he knew it was only temporary. This whole area would already have patrol cars monitoring it, and at any moment one could appear in his rearview mirror and latch onto him again.

"Almost at the destination," he said, eyes fixed on the road around him. "I'll slow down, but I won't stop. It's almost time—get ready, I'll need you to detect Artifacts at any moment. Do you want a light injury or a serious one?"

Kingsley stared at him. "I want no injury."

"If you think you can walk away without a scratch and talk the police around with nothing but your mouth, be my guest. If you don't want to get hurt, it comes down to how fast your reflexes are."

"What do you mean?"

The next moment, Kingsley understood exactly what Chase meant.

The moment the Brooklyn Community College Station sign came into view, Chase immediately reduced his speed; he unclipped his seatbelt, shoved open the door, and threw himself

out, rolling up from the road surface in one motion and sprinting toward the subway station—the driverless car immediately veered off course and drifted toward the center of the road.

"Just you wait—I'm demanding a contract revision when I get back!" Kingsley cursed and shouted from the car behind him.

A beat later, her voice rose again: "It's here, it's really here!"

The Artifact had indeed entered Kingsley's detection range—on the next train, just pulling into the station.

Chase didn't look back, but as he took the station steps two at a time, he heard a dull impact echo from somewhere far down the road behind him.

The impact didn't sound serious—better than he'd expected; it seemed that even with her hands bound, Kingsley had managed to bring the car under control in time.

Chase vaulted one-handed off the subway turnstile, leaping clean over the barrier and landing with a jaguar's grace; despite a body of one meter ninety-eight, his feet touched the ground with only the softest sound.

Nearby, a group of idle young men who had been whispering to one another and passing something between them looked over, then burst out laughing and cheered: "Nice moves, man! But what, can't a suit-and-tie guy afford a ticket?"

Chase ignored them entirely; within a few breaths he had already charged down to the platform, where he immediately slowed his pace, glanced around, and melted into the crowd of waiting passengers as if nothing had happened.

He checked the time: 10:33.

His suicidal driving had gotten him there three whole minutes ahead of the subway.

There must have been no shortage of witnesses to the moment he jumped out of the car and ran into the station; once the police arrived at the scene, they would immediately realize the suspect had gone into the subway, and their next move would naturally be to seal the exits and send people down to search—for now, all he could do was wait and see which arrived first: the train or the police.

He took a slow, deep breath and ran through each of his next steps carefully in his mind.

One small mistake, and he'd be a turtle in a jar.

The first thing to deal with was...

Chase looked up at the security camera mounted in the corner of the platform.

Blackmoor City's subway system had been built and put into service around 1905; most of the platforms still retained the look of the early last century, and the monitoring equipment installed in recent years always looked slightly out of place against the old stations.

If he was caught on camera, even if he managed to shake off the pursuit later, it would be trouble down the line.

He reached into his coat pocket and pulled out a remote control no longer than his index finger.

The remote had a small plastic display screen, currently lit with a single line of text—**【Countdown: 127 days, 21 hours, 36 minutes】** .

Below the screen were two buttons: one labeled "replace" and one labeled "cancel"—aside from looking cheaply made, they gave no indication of what they were for.

Chase raised the remote, pointed it at his own throat, and lightly pressed "replace," then tucked it back into his trouser pocket.

Not one of the people waiting around him glanced up; most had their eyes glued to their phone screens, and others wore earphones, staring blankly at the tracks ahead and the platform on the far side of the tracks—the far platform was completely empty, not a single person on it.

Even if someone had been watching Chase the whole time, they still would not have understood what he had just done.

The first time Chase had received this little remote from a House Faction Hunter, he hadn't thought much of it.

Strangely enough, Artifacts from the Nest, no matter how unusual their appearance, seemed to follow rules similar to those of the real world: the more refined, valuable, and substantial something looked, the greater its power and function; if an Artifact felt like it was made of thin plastic, its abilities were bound to be limited.

But the Hunter had smiled with quiet confidence and said: "Try it and you'll see—the function is indeed limited, but it's practical."

She pulled out her phone, opened the camera, handed it to Chase, and stood in front of the lens herself.

Chase watched the screen as the Hunter slowly raised the remote, pointed it at her own throat, and pressed "replace."

On the screen the next moment, her entire head had become a massive, snow-white goat's head; the goat head wore a floor-length black robe, like a demonic creature stepped straight out of some medieval horror legend.

Looking at the Hunter outside the screen, though, she was exactly as before: hair half-wavy and half-straight, pulled back behind her head, wearing outdated skinny jeans and a pair of sneakers—in every way, she looked like someone's middle-school-aged kid's mother.

Most astonishing of all was that even in the first few seconds of footage recorded before she pressed "replace," the Hunter's head and face had already been replaced with the goat.

"Pretty impressive, right?" the goat head on the screen said, opening its mouth: "Press the button, and your real face won't be captured by any device—from any camera, you'll just look like a big goat head. And the effect can even be applied retroactively up to one minute before you pressed the button—so if you forget to switch, you've got a one-minute window to fix it! Considerate Artifacts like this aren't easy to find in the Nest."

It was, for Chase, exactly what he needed.

After a quick round of testing, he made up his mind without hesitation: "House Faction will take it. Twenty thousand."

The only drawback was that this Artifact could only exist outside the Nest for six months—which was also why Chase had only valued it at twenty thousand: by any measure, a six-month expiry was simply too short.

"Don't be too disappointed," the middle-school-mom said with a smile as she was about to leave. "It's a good thing that Artifacts eventually expire and disappear after leaving the Nest—that's precisely why we Hunters can keep doing this job, generation after generation."

Indeed.

Chase didn't know how long the Nest had existed, but its history was surely no short one; generation after generation of Hunters had brought untold numbers of Artifacts back into the

world, and if those Artifacts could exist forever, the world by now would have turned into some chaotic science-fiction film.

If anyone were to review the security footage afterward, they would find that at 10:33, there was a goat head in a long black robe on the departing-side platform. It stood near the staircase entrance, occasionally glancing up toward the stairs, then lowering its head, propping its face up on one large hoof, looking like a brooding, deeply preoccupied goat.

That was Chase listening to the sounds of the subway station—as for the goat hoof, that was him raising his hand to cover his face.

After all, everyone around him could still see him as he truly looked with the naked eye, so naturally the less he exposed, the better.

At 10:34, a faint commotion drifted up from somewhere in the station.

Footsteps hurried past overhead on the stairs; someone was asking "What happened outside?", and someone else asked, "Is the subway still running?"

It seemed the police had arrived.

Chase glanced at the platform display screen: the departing train was due to arrive at 10:36.

He took a slow, deep breath—both the departing and return trains were arriving at the same time, which meant that when the moment came, a margin of one or two seconds could represent the difference between his life and death.

10:35.

A group of people suddenly came shouting and charging down the stairs, jumping down from the last step and startling the passengers nearby—it was the same group of young men who had been whispering at the station entrance and had praised Chase moments ago. One of them looked back and swore: "Why are there so many Blue Bags?"

Chase moved to the far side of the staircase and stopped at the platform edge near the tracks. "Blue Bags" was slang, named for the blue color of the police uniforms; some people also just called them "Bags" for short.

He heard several sets of footsteps, moving in the same trained, urgent, heavy rhythm, mingled with the scrape of body armor and gun holsters, all converging on the staircase at once.

There were at most thirty seconds left until 10:36.

One more second, he told himself through gritted teeth—one more second...

From the distant subway tunnel, a deep rumbling finally began to echo faintly, still far enough away that it was almost like an illusion, trembling at the very edges of the nerves.

"Everyone on the platform," a voice suddenly shouted, "stay where you are! We are pursuing a dangerous driving suspect!"

Chase smiled.

The moment everyone's attention was drawn to the person shouting, Chase leaped off the platform, landing softly beside the rail, like a large cat silently sliding off a rooftop.

By the time a passenger finally noticed and let out a low gasp, he was already sprinting across the subway tracks, hurling himself toward the platform on the other side—

"Stop!" someone behind him shouted. "Or we'll shoot!"

But the subway gave them no chance to shoot.

The train scheduled to arrive at 10:36—the one carrying the Artifact—roared out of the tunnel and hurtled toward Chase; its headlights blazed across half his body and the platform just inches away.

I've discovered that Shanghai has a kind of gravitational pull—I'd call it Shanghai Gravity—and here's how it manifests: easy to get in, hard to get out. Put nicely, it's like an American university; put not so nicely, it's like a certain place of reput—

Ugh, I still have to go back someday, so let me just shut my mouth.

Anyway, yesterday I got to the airport at 11:30 p.m. and sat there suffering until 4:30 in the afternoon before my flight finally took off.

At first I used my points to get into a VIP lounge—I figured I'd only be waiting an hour, so sitting in the VIP lounge felt pretty indulgent—but wow, I have never in my life spent points so well. I got back every single one, triple.

I sat there complaining to people about how uncomfortable the chairs were—lumpy and sunken, like sitting in a torture device—and asking whether this really counted as VIP. Then I went to the restroom and realized it is indeed a proper VIP lounge, and you know why? The toilets all have intestinal-cleanse mode. I stood there reading the notice on the wall encouraging everyone to hold it in and conserve water, and for a moment I was actually in a daze.

Chapter 33: The Form of Chase's Artifact

When Chase hauled himself up onto the platform and rolled clear, the subway train grazed his back and screamed into the station—

The icy chill of the metal car body, the hard gust of wind it kicked up, felt as though it would shear away an entire layer of flesh from his back; if he had reached back and found half his skull missing, that would not have been the least bit surprising.

Chase gasped and pulled himself up from the ground, and as the train gradually came to a stop, its window glass reflected back at him a man who was still perfectly whole.

...He had always had good luck.

The subway departing from this station rumbled in right behind the other, almost as if it had been arranged, blocking the police on the opposite platform; even if they wanted to follow Chase's example and cross over, they would first have to go all the way around, losing a good deal of time.

The shouts from the other platform were muffled by the train between them, swaying and echoing through the station: "You lot, give chase... go around to the other end and cut him off, check every single person coming through the exits!"

Chase couldn't help but smile. He rolled his shoulders and neck, tilted his head back, and let out a breath.

For exactly one second, he allowed himself to sink into the rush of adrenaline surging through him, his whole body burning with the tide of his racing blood.

When he opened his eyes, all the subway doors were sliding open, and the arriving passengers streamed off the train and onto the platform.

"Hey!" From the front of the train, someone who looked like a driver came walking out and shouted across at Chase: "Are you insane? You almost got yourself killed—"

Before the man could get a clear look at his face, Chase turned neatly and slipped into the flow of passengers heading for the exit. The driver muttered a couple of curses and turned back toward the train, at which point Chase immediately shoved aside the person next to him and, just before the carriage doors closed, lunged inside.

The entire train was empty—not a single person.

Looking left and right, the carriages ahead and behind seemed to stretch on forever, an endless repetition of circular handholds and plastic seats; with nothing but the single element of "people" removed, the train had become a narrow, repetitive, elongated foreign realm, rather like the interior of a roundworm's belly—truly strange.

The train began to move, holding to a low speed—it was likely heading for the turning loop to reverse direction and pick up passengers again; Chase walked toward the rear of the train over the gently swaying floor and entered the last carriage.

Car-body advertisements, handholds, support poles, seats, graffiti, food wrappers, and drink bottles thrown on the floor... it looked like an ordinary carriage; the places where something could be hidden were neither many nor few.

...The part that required the most patience was about to begin.

That was fine.

Whether in the Nest or in the world of men, no matter what target was being pursued, a good Hunter needed a great deal of patience—and Chase happened to have it in abundance.

"If I were a clever idiot," he murmured to himself, "...where would I hide an Artifact?"

To guess the answer to that question, he first had to know what the Artifact he was tracking actually looked like.

Artifacts came in every form imaginable, with infinite variety beyond the limits of human imagination—but fortunately, he didn't need to search blindly and hope for luck; because any Hunter in Blackmoor City worth their salt had heard something about Wellesley's Artifacts.

Moreover, Ronan Key had been a Hunter for decades, with deep and far-reaching connections throughout Blackmoor City, and almost any intelligence related to Artifacts inevitably drifted past his ears at some point.

"I need you to get your hands on the Artifacts from Wellesley's study—even just one will do."

When news of Wellesley's death arrived, Ronan Key had summoned Chase. The sky outside the window was still a pale duck-egg blue at the time, as though a thin haze were floating over it; Chase later learned that when he sat down at the breakfast table, Wellesley had been dead for exactly three hours.

At that moment, Mrs. Wellesley, still alone in Blackmoor City, was still asleep, not yet knowing she had become a widow.

And in one hour and twenty-one minutes, Ivan would leave the Wellesley Family Estate carrying the Artifacts he had stolen.

"The first Artifact—he bought it from me back in the day. It's a black cube, about ten centimeters on each side."

Ronan Key's tone was even, making it hard to tell whether he now regretted that transaction.

The Artifacts in Wellesley's hands had laid the foundation for a business empire that stood among the foremost in the world; looking at the wealth and influence he had accumulated afterward, it even seemed strange that anyone had been willing to sell him those four Artifacts in the first place—perhaps that was what set Wellesley apart: the ability to look at the same thing as everyone else and see a future that no one else could.

If they had known from the start how valuable they were, no one would ever have sold those Artifacts to Wellesley.

"The second is a set of tailor's tools."

Ronan Key paused and said, "This set of tailor's tools—I've heard it's roughly the size of a laptop computer, though I can't say for certain whether that's accurate. This Artifact is said to be the most precious and most important of the four; getting your hands on it alone would be worth trading away an entire House Faction."

In his spare time, Chase had once worked out an estimated valuation for the Key House Faction.

Hunter House Factions were hard to define—they operated like criminal gangs but were structured like modern companies, something of a hybrid between the two.

By corporate standards, the Key House Faction's valuation was well into the tens of millions and beyond—to trade away a House Faction like that, and for Ronan Key to suggest it still sounded like getting the better end of the deal?

"What does it do?" Chase asked.

"If you can get your hands on it, you'll know naturally. Until then, the less you know, the better off you are."

Chase nodded. "What are the other two? What are they?"

Ronan Key sighed and set down his coffee cup.

"The later an Artifact came into his possession, the less complete my information is... he sealed off many of the channels through which information leaked. The third is said to be extremely dangerous; ever since he obtained it, any adversary standing in his way that money, power, law, or market forces could not remove would conveniently and neatly disappear from the world—even an oil trader as far away as Yemen was no exception."

Beyond "extremely dangerous," he offered no further detail, and Chase didn't raise a single word of objection.

He was the person who resolved problems for the Key House Faction; incomplete information was simply part of the problem he had been handed.

"And the fourth?"

Ronan Key was silent for a few seconds.

"About that one, I've only heard a single rumor," he said quietly. "...It is a rumor that produces rumors."

Chase even forgot to chew, letting the piece of egg just sit on his tongue for a moment.

Once he came back to himself and swallowed the egg, he sought confirmation: "Uncle Ronan, do you mean that the Artifact itself exists in the form of a 'rumor,' its function is to 'produce rumors'... and all of this is itself only a rumor you've heard?"

Ronan Key nodded and said, "Yes—going round and round like that, it's enough to make you think for a while."

What would Wellesley want with a rumor that produces rumors?

And besides, how do you find a rumor?

Then again, when it came to the Nest and Artifacts, no matter how bizarre or outlandish something seemed, one could never simply assume it didn't exist.

If the thing being searched for was a "rumor"—invisible and intangible—then at the very least it ought to have a sound, shouldn't it?

Since a Hunter had once been able to bring it back to the human world, there was no reason Chase couldn't find it.

Standing on the train, he tilted his head and listened for a moment, gradually sorting the ambient sounds and filing them away in his mind: the friction of the wheels against the rails, the airflow from the vents, the material sounds of the car's components in motion... not a single one came close to a human voice.

Since nothing like a whispering haunting was drifting over, did that mean the fourth Artifact wasn't here?

He hadn't expected to find the Artifact right away anyway...

Chase let out a sigh, and for the first time found himself resenting his own height.

Like a giant spider trying to fold up its legs, he lowered himself awkwardly to the floor and swept his gaze beneath the seats, taking in the full length of the floor under an entire row at once: a forgotten shopping bag, a single earphone, fire-suppression equipment, stains... and even a shoe, leaving one to wonder whether its owner had stepped off the train with one bare foot.

It sounded like quite a lot, but in fact the vast majority of the seats had nothing underneath them at all—one glance was enough to confirm there was nothing that could reasonably be called an Artifact—though even a piece of chewing gum was not something Chase could afford to overlook.

Chase pulled a short, matte-black baton from the small of his back, snapped it open with two sharp clicks, and extended it into an arm-length, weighty rod—a T-shaped cast-iron head at one end, a threaded grip at the other.

Blackmoor State law prohibited civilians from carrying firearms in public, so carrying a gun sometimes drew unnecessary trouble—it was unexpected that this trusty, portable weapon he never left home without would find a different use today.

Patient as he was, as Chase used his beloved weapon to prod and poke at the various pieces of rubbish under the seats—hooking that smelly shoe aside, jabbing a wad of gum a few times, then straightening up and running his gaze across the car-body advertisements—he couldn't help feeling that this sort of job really ought to have been handed off to a low-ranking newcomer in the faction.

But another person might not be as swift and thorough as he was; in only a few minutes, he had finished searching one entire carriage.

Chase stopped and glanced out the train window.

Rather than heading up onto the turning loop and back to the departure platform as he had expected, the train was moving slower and slower, until finally it stopped.

Outside, the tunnel was dim, its dull yellow lights barely illuminating a broad expanse of ground—beneath a vaulted ceiling like an empty cavern, several tracks ran parallel and crossed one another, like an aerial view of a compressed interchange.

This was clearly not a place meant for passengers... where had the train taken him?

As Chase continued searching the next carriage, he heard footsteps approaching from the other end.

As the person walked, a key ring jangled at their side, and they hummed a song in a vague, mumbling way; apparently it was the only thing they knew—they hummed the same line over and over again: "baby please don't go."

Chase straightened up, T-bar in hand, and stood quietly in the center of the carriage, waiting.

A man in a subway employee's uniform had not even made it into the second carriage before he pulled up short—it was the same subway driver who had shouted a couple of curses at Chase earlier.

"When did you get on?" His face instantly went rigid, barely holding down the confusion and faint fear beneath. "What are you doing up here? This train is going into reserve service—you need to get off right now."

Reserve service meant it wouldn't be taking passengers for a while.

At his current pace, he could finish searching the entire train in another forty minutes... not reversing to pick up passengers was actually more convenient for Chase; the only issue was that staying on the train would go more smoothly with this man's cooperation.

Chase had the T-bar, and he also had a wallet stuffed with cash—in today's world of electronic and card payments, carrying cash on hand served almost only one purpose.

Just as he was weighing which method to use to get the driver's cooperation, the driver looked at his face, then at the T-bar, and suddenly furrowed his brow, his expression gradually filling with

a fear he could no longer suppress.

"You—you're not..." he said, stumbling back two steps as he spoke. "I still have a family, I have children... please..."

Who does he think I am?

Chase was taken aback. He had always been careful in his work, and outside the Hunter community, essentially no one knew who he was; yet here he had only driven through a few streets, and he was already being treated as though he had a fearsome reputation?

Wait... "fearsome reputation"?

A bolt of electricity suddenly crackled through Chase's mind, like lightning illuminating thick clouds; though everything wasn't fully clear and open, he had seized on the single most important thought.

A moment later, the driver murmured, "You—you're really the serial subway killer from the rumors?"

Chase slowly licked his lips.

...He'd found the Artifact.

Friends, folks, I know some of you aren't fond of switching perspectives, but this is exactly what I envision for this new story—each character's storyline piecing together one big world, where the characters influence and intertwine with one another. Just thinking about it excites me; no other approach to this story does that for me.

Compared to the traditional web novel approach of sticking to a single character's perspective from start to finish, this will indeed bleed off a large portion of readers—my path just keeps getting narrower, I know, no need to remind me again, thank you very much. This is the writing style I chose for myself; nobody held a gun to my head, I just couldn't help going down the harder road.

Chapter 34: Chase's Logically Coherent Story

Ever since he began chasing the subway, Chase had carried a question in the back of his mind.

Blackmoor City's subway system ran at least several thousand cars in total, and the cars could be split apart and recombined in different configurations; once a train pulled away, it was like a stone dropped into the sea—stumbling onto that same car afterward would be as unlikely as winning the lottery, especially since the trains were cleaned every day.

How could Ivan be so confident he could retrieve the Artifact?

It wasn't until he watched the subway driver retreat step by step and then break into a run that the answer suddenly came into sharp focus, taking shape in Chase's mind.

The target Ivan needed to find again was not one among hundreds of near-identical, untraceable subway cars; it was a subway employee with a name and a steady job. Finding the car might be impossible—but finding the person? Nothing simpler than that.

He almost wanted to laugh out loud. He had thought Ivan was a brilliant idiot, yet he hadn't quite identified where exactly the idiocy ended and the brilliance began.

A priceless Artifact, one capable of rewriting a person's fate, had actually been left by Ivan on a complete stranger—he still couldn't decide whether that was stupidity or audacity, though perhaps there had never been any difference between the two.

Ivan's true stroke of genius was that no one in the world, apart from himself, could connect him to this fleeing subway driver—because in the vast sea of Blackmoor City's population, they were two distant, randomly chosen people with absolutely nothing between them.

It seemed Ivan understood perfectly well that the moment anyone had him in their sights, even the delivery driver who brought him pizza would be dug up and picked apart; people with actual ties to him would fare even worse.

A total stranger, someone who had never had any connection to him whatsoever, thus became the safest hiding place of all.

Once the Artifact was placed on the driver, he was free to move about as he pleased, meeting whoever he liked; in fact, the more people he contacted, the more he could mislead those tracking

him and drain their time and effort—hadn't Chase himself wasted quite a bit of effort on the pizza delivery man?

It appeared Ivan hadn't thought of that, otherwise he wouldn't have stayed behind closed doors that day.

Chase was still turning this over in his mind when he reached out one large hand and lightly caught the back of the driver's shirt.

When Chase grabbed the back of the driver's coat and yanked him down to the ground, the man seemed not to understand what had happened—he fell flat on his back with a blank look on his face, apparently unable to figure out when Chase had gotten behind him.

It wasn't until the back of his head hit the floor with a thud that the driver came back to his senses, hissing in pain through his teeth, struggling to roll over and get up while crying out, "Please! I'm begging you, don't kill me—I haven't done anything!"

That was probably the truth. Chase had no intention of saying so, naturally.

He pressed one large hand against the driver's chest, his long pale fingers caging the man's torso like the bars of a cell.

Chase applied no force at all, yet the driver didn't dare move; his shadow fell over the driver's face like the canopy of a great tree.

"What—what are you going to do to me?" the driver asked, voice trembling, propped up on his elbows, neither daring to rise fully nor willing to lie back down completely.

That was actually a very good question.

In truth, Chase had never imagined he would find this most inexplicable of Artifacts in quite this way.

He had the man in his hands—but what to do next, he found himself, for once, at a loss.

To begin with, Ivan had had no time or opportunity that day to fabricate a plausible excuse and trick the driver into taking something; the driver could not possibly know he was carrying an Artifact, and he didn't seem like someone who knew about passages or the world of the Nest.

Besides, Ivan would never have entrusted an Artifact to someone connected to the Nest—for only when the other party was an ordinary person, wholly ignorant of the Nest, would he have any hope of retrieving it again.

Ivan must have attached the Artifact to the driver when the man wasn't paying attention.

The more he thought about it, the more questions piled up.

What did it mean for an Artifact to exist in the form of a "Rumor"? How did it attach itself to a person? What did it look like? How did you take it off?

"I—I'm still on shift, and if they see I'm not working normally, someone will definitely come to check on me..." the driver was murmuring plaintively. "Please let me go. I have a bit of face blindness—I won't remember what you look like..."

Since reaching adulthood, Chase had never once met a person who, having seen him once, failed to recognize him the next time.

"No rush," he said quietly, and thought for a moment.

How do you extract information from a target who doesn't know the truth himself?

He had interrogated quite a few people with his own hands, yet he had never encountered a situation like this: the target clearly held the key intelligence, yet still knew nothing at all.

Judging by Ivan's movements that day, he'd had no time whatsoever to interact with anyone; the Artifact must have changed hands in a single brief encounter, and the driver might not even remember him.

The odds weren't good, but Chase decided to try anyway—he gave a brief description of Ivan's appearance, and was met, as expected, with a blank stare.

"This 'subway serial killer' you mentioned," he said, thinking it over and deciding to approach from an angle the driver might actually have something to say about, "where did you hear about that?"

The driver flicked a quick glance at him from the corner of his eye, then hastily fixed his gaze on a handrail somewhere in the distance.

He paused for a moment, then spoke tentatively into the air, as though testing the words: "... Well, a few nights ago, after the C Line subway stopped running for the night, didn't they find a woman's body? I remember it made the news."

Chase frowned.

He did recall that; but people died in Blackmoor City so often it barely registered, and had the driver not mentioned it, that news item would have vanished from his memory forever.

"The subway staff thought she'd fallen asleep and missed her stop, but no matter how they called to her she wouldn't wake up, and when they gave her shoulder a push, her whole body rolled off onto the floor."

As he spoke, the driver's eyes drifted to the seat beside them, as though he could see that body rolling to the ground before him. "The one who found her happened to be a colleague of mine—we sometimes get together for a few hands of cards... When he described it to me afterward, his face was as white as paper."

What did one dead person have to do with an Artifact—and with the Rumor in particular? And how had the rumor of a "subway serial killer" come to exist?

But the driver seemed to interpret the slight shift in Chase's expression as something else entirely, and rushed to explain: "Of course, the more I think about it, the more I'm sure I made a mistake—a fine, distinguished-looking man like yourself, how could you possibly be a serial killer? Ha, it's just that I've been on edge lately, and when I'm alone on the subway I start imagining things; the moment I saw you carrying that pole I jumped to the wrong conclusion... Anyway, the body had been slumped against the wall, so you couldn't tell anything was wrong at first—it was only when she rolled to the floor that my colleague saw the impact wound on her head..."

Some people, when panic set in, opened their mouths and never stopped—words coming faster and thicker, as though they were trying to talk themselves into solid ground—and this driver appeared to be exactly that sort.

Chase decided to stoke his fear a little higher, to burn a blacker hole through his composure.

He lowered his head and looked at the driver, and slowly spread a smile.

When Chase smiled, his lips went very thin. His teeth were white—not a bright, lustrous white, but the suffocating, airless white of concrete. Those teeth, without a trace of warmth in them, were packed tightly between his thin lips; when he smiled, they all came out at once, as though the lower half of his face had been unzipped.

"You see," Chase said softly, "weaving a story that holds together logically takes a certain skill. That skill—you don't have."

"What? Me?" The driver startled, just as Chase had expected. "I'm not lying. That news story is real—look it up if you don't believe me! I saw it on the news, and that's what made me misread the situation. I really was being rude to you—I admit that..."

The news story might be real, but it didn't explain his behavior.

"Killing only one person—how does that make someone a serial killer?" Chase spoke like a careful editor hunting for inconsistencies. "Or rather—why did you think the person who died was killed by a serial killer?"

The driver opened his mouth slightly, as though he'd been asked a question he'd never considered himself.

A bulge rose abruptly on one side of his cheek, slid down along it, and disappeared—as though he'd pressed his tongue against the inside of his cheek.

"I... you've got it wrong, I haven't gotten to the second thing yet. It's because the Brooklyn District has had bad public order lately—after the body was found, there was another assault. Someone came off the night shift, walked out of the subway station, and the moment they stepped outside, someone hit them with a pole—I mean, a club—right on the head..."

He swallowed.

"The detectives who came to investigate called in quite a few people from the subway company to question. They didn't say it outright, but from what was said, they suspected someone was committing crimes in a series..." The driver pressed his tongue against his cheek again before continuing: "That's how the rumor spread—I'm not making this up. One of the detectives was quite attractive, too, and her partner looked like they made a handsome pair, very flirty with each other... All of it spread around together, everyone knows about it."

Chase was silent for a second or two.

Plenty of people lost their filters when nervous, but having gossip like this suddenly burst out actually caught him off guard. "...What?"

"Very flirty,"

Under terror and tension, the driver's words came spilling out in an unstoppable torrent: "They were going back and forth at each other and nobody else could get a word in. The man didn't seem to be a police officer—apparently some criminology professor brought in as a consultant from a university somewhere, divorced once, nobody quite knows the story. Anyway, the long and short of it is..."

Chase lifted his hand from the driver's chest and took out his phone.

Life truly was an unpredictable and strange thing.

For instance, the Chase of this morning could not have predicted that the Chase of noon would be driving recklessly across Blackmoor City; and the Chase driving recklessly across Blackmoor City could never have predicted that thirty minutes later, he would be sitting on a subway car, pulling out his phone, opening the App Store, and downloading Netflix.

"What are you doing?" The driver's angle gave him a view of the phone screen, though not a clear one.

"You have an account," Chase said—not a question, but a statement. "...Log in."

"Wh—why?" The driver was completely baffled, but clearly didn't dare argue; he typed in his password in a hurry and asked, "If I give you my account, can I go?"

Chase said nothing and took the phone back.

On the home screen, under "Continue Watching," several shows and films were lined up, each one previously viewed; he scrolled through them, and within a few seconds had found what he was looking for.

He glanced at the screen, then looked at the driver.

The man had no idea what he was doing, still staring up with a blank face, a faint sheen of sweat on his skin, mouth half open, like a small cave had formed in his face.

Unless subway drivers moonlighted as Oscar-winning actors, it was evident the man had not the slightest awareness that the story he'd just told—about "a female detective and a male consultant jointly investigating a serial killer case"—was the plot of the first season of a crime drama on Netflix, even though he had watched it.

Chase could no longer say his story wasn't coherent.

Hello everyone, I'm catching another flight today—not sure if I'll have time to write and update once I land, so here's this chapter for you first, eat up, eat up, order more if it's not enough. (As for when the next order will arrive after you place it—that I cannot say.)

Chase's portion of the plot, while not as complex as Sydney Ginn's, ended up taking the most time to research... Passages that might be glossed over in a single glance while reading had to be taken seriously when writing: for instance, would the same train at the same time on the same day be the same physical vehicle? I searched and searched without finding an answer, and in the end

went to Reddit to find a channel run by a New York subway enthusiast (apparently that's a niche hobby that exists), posted a question... and finally got my answer: no, it's not the same car. Once the train pulls away, it's gone without a trace.

Then there's the layout of the subway stations, how spare trains turn around, this and that — in short, I researched a lot and used very little of it.

Blackmoor City is fictional, but beyond that I want all the background details to be as accurate as possible — a strong sense of reality makes for a better experience.

I'm finally getting to go home! My cat is probably forgetting what I look like, and who knows how many socks it's been saving up to feed me after this month away.

Chapter 35 — Folks, Grannies, I'm Home

This whole trip absolutely wiped me out... I spent the entire time curled up in my seat like a roosting bird, couldn't sleep properly, the food was absolutely terrible, and after all the layovers, train transfers, subway rides, hauling luggage, and climbing stairs, I finally get home and—

Dust everywhere, like I'd stepped straight into the Sahara.

I normally use pine cat litter at home — clean and virtually dust-free — but it needs to be scooped frequently. Whenever I'm about to sit down and write, I'll make a point of going to check: did the cat poop? Does it need scooping? Yes? Perfect, that's another ten minutes I don't have to write.

Since I had someone come over to look after the cat while I was away, I couldn't exactly ask them to show up three times a day on a strict poop-scooping schedule, so I had to switch to regular cat litter — my God, the dust it kicks up. Every single object in the apartment, regardless of what color it originally was, is now uniformly gray-white. My place looks like it got hit by a sandstorm. It is no longer fit to host the National People's Congress.

Vacuumed, mopped, wiped down all the furniture — already half-dead from exhaustion — and then I discovered there was a load of laundry sitting in the washing machine. Clothes I'd washed before I left... sitting in there this whole time, never taken out. Use your imagination. Picture that smell. There are not enough lives in the world to survive it.

I just squatted on the floor and dry-heaved out approximately half my soul.

Got everything cleaned up, but the smell wouldn't leave. In the midst of the cat-poop stench still hanging in every corner of the room, I finally managed to brew a cup of coffee and sit down (let's see who can't help themselves and makes a kopi luwak joke), opened my laptop — and, well, guess what, the screen wouldn't turn on.

I kept closing and opening the laptop over and over; occasionally it would deign to light up for a moment, I'd type in my password, and then — black again, like a bashful young maiden.

AAAAAA

AAAAAAA

West Lake beauty, in the month of June

So the display is dark — how am I typing, you ask? Because I have a secondary e-ink external monitor... with extremely low resolution, extremely blurry. Things like those "click all the images with traffic lights" login verification challenges are completely out of the question; all I can manage is typing text and telling the difference between letters and background.

How blurry is it? If it's not your native language, good luck making anything out.

On the plane, when I was being a roosting bird but wasn't completely exhausted yet, I wrote 980 characters. I've been home for several hours now, and I'm at 1,020.

Anyway, I'll post this chapter whenever I finish it. Right now my legs are shaking just going up and down the stairs, my muscles have developed the grain of lumber, and I have no idea how I got this tired...

Chapter 36: Chase Searches for the Rumor Artifact

When Chase was young, Uncle Key would sometimes take him camping in the mountains.

Deep in the mountains, far from the sleepless clamor of Blackmoor City, heaven and earth were pitch-black and hushed. Beyond a single blazing campfire, only the stars overhead could be seen; he had never witnessed a night so pure, as though even the forest had dissolved into outer space.

Uncle Key taught him to identify the constellations, softly connecting one star after another in the vast sky—drawing out the shape of a water dipper, a great bear... The mountain nights were cold, so he always brought two extra blankets. Young Chase, wrapped head to toe in one of them, would sit beside Uncle Key and let his gaze drift through the universe.

Right now, in this very moment, he thought again of those lines drawn between the stars.

It was far from as beautiful as a sky full of stars, but several points of light seemed to be gradually surfacing on the subway driver before him—points that, once connected, formed a shape.

From that vague shape, he had formed a guess.

One: "A woman's body was discovered after the subway stopped running"—a fact, recent news.

Two: "Someone was attacked after finishing a night shift"—Chase wasn't sure yet whether this was true or false; it could easily be one of the hundreds of everyday news stories in Blackmoor City.

Three: "A female detective and a male professor form a partnership to investigate a series of crimes"—a TV drama.

And there they were: the three elements that composed the Rumor.

Seen this way... his appearance on the subway was like a sudden spark of electricity, illuminating something in the driver's mind.

Before he had caught sight of Chase, the subway driver showed none of this so-called "paranoid suspicion" or "inner fear"; when he'd been walking alone through the empty subway car, he had still been humming a tune.

Yet the moment he laid eyes on a tall man holding a weapon, the subway driver had clearly, if briefly, lost his ability to distinguish truth from fiction—the three points above were rapidly pieced together, and in the span of a single breath, a Rumor was born: "a serial subway killer has recently appeared."

What was interesting was that the moment the driver blurted out the Rumor, he had fully believed in what he himself had just created, and had even begun to fear for his own life because of it.

...So this was how the Rumor Artifact worked?

By combining and reshaping raw information, it caused the finished Rumor to flow out of a person's mouth—but that was only the first step; what came next would probably require getting hold of the Artifact itself before it could be understood.

No, that wasn't quite right—perhaps it was more accurate to say: this was one of its modes of operation.

From every indication, the subway driver was merely an information repository that happened to hold the right key details, a mouth capable of speaking words aloud—he had no idea what had influenced him and no awareness of it whatsoever. It was difficult to imagine Wellesley allowing an Artifact to manipulate him, rather than the other way around.

There must also be a way to use it actively, to deliberately manufacture Rumors; that, however, was not the most pressing question at hand.

The most pressing question right now was to get the Artifact into his hands first.

Chase fixed his gaze on the driver's cheek, watching what appeared to be a bulge—as though pushed from inside by a tongue—slide briefly across the surface. It had happened several times now.

"Spit out whatever you have in your mouth."

The driver startled. "In my mouth? There's nothing there."

Chase looked at him and said nothing.

"Really, there's nothing—I just have a habit of pressing my tongue against the inside of my cheek." Under Chase's gaze, the driver immediately panicked and said in a placating tone: "If you don't believe me, I'll open up, you can look—"

Chase directed his gaze, with no great enthusiasm, into that flesh-pink cavity.

He had seen plenty of human insides; though he was used to it, he always found it slick and unpleasant to look at.

A human mouth was a strange thing—stare at it long enough and it even put him in mind of alien creatures: a trembling red throat, a furry tongue, both perpetually rolling and sliding in a thin layer of gleaming liquid, as if possessed of their own will.

But however unpleasant they were to look at, they were no Artifact; apart from what ordinarily belonged in a person's mouth, there was nothing extra inside the driver's.

Of course, Chase had never really expected the Artifact to be spat out so easily, so coming up empty left him unsurprised—after all, if someone truly had something in their mouth, how could they not notice? Ivan had no way of slipping something into a person's mouth without them knowing.

Although he still didn't know the Artifact's form or appearance, if it was hidden somewhere inside the driver's body and would need to be extracted, there would likely be some blood and mess... The backup subway car was not an ideal location. As the driver had said, someone might show up at any moment.

Chase grabbed him by the collar and had just started to haul him up when the driver suddenly seemed to realize something and began struggling and kicking wildly, shouting, "Where are you taking me?"

He was a broad, heavysset man—solidly built—and in someone else's hands might have been actually difficult to subdue. But the instant Chase sensed his movement, he had already released his grip; in the same motion, his right foot swept sideways in a heavy kick to the driver's ankle. The driver's cry of pain had barely left his lips when Chase's T-bar drove deep into his abdomen, knocking breath, balance, and strength clean out of him all at once, and he crumpled to the floor without another sound.

The driver didn't quite make it all the way to the ground—Chase had already caught him by the back of his shirt, hoisting him like a bag of groceries.

Only this particular bag of groceries was quite large, and his legs dragged limply along the floor.

"I'm very interested in this Rumor business," Chase said, dragging him forward in a perfectly reasonable tone. "I just want to have a chat. Whether that chat happens with all your limbs intact is entirely up to you."

The driver couldn't even breathe properly, and for the moment could produce nothing but broken, muffled groans; Chase decided to take that as his consent.

It wasn't until he had dragged the man a few more steps that he faintly made out a few words amid the groaning—and Chase stopped in his tracks.

He glanced out the window; the dim, silent subway tunnel showed no sign of anyone coming yet.

"What did you say?" He bent down and asked, almost gently: "Say it more clearly."

The driver spoke again, his voice thoroughly muffled.

Even straining his imagination, Chase could only catch a few baffling words—something like "line," "broken," "electricity"—and make nothing coherent of them at all.

He was about to ask the driver to repeat himself when something stirred in his mind.

He knew exactly how heavy his own force was, which was why he had deliberately held back just now. Besides, a blow to the abdomen with a rod shouldn't leave a man unable to speak clearly ten-odd seconds later.

Thinking about it that way... when the driver spoke just now, had he actually opened his mouth?

The thought seemed to prick him; he flung the driver away with a toss of his hand, and the man toppled to the floor like a bundle of rags.

The driver's face flashed upward for an instant before rolling back toward the ground, and in that brief moment Chase saw it clearly—the driver's face was drawn taut and thin, his lips pressed together until they nearly vanished; he looked as though he were wrestling with something, the tendon along his jaw standing out in sharp relief, pulsing up toward his temple as he clenched his teeth shut.

His eyes had rolled back toward the ceiling, as though there were a deeply terrifying question that the harder he tried to understand, the more afraid he became.

A moment ago, he had been afraid of Chase and couldn't stop talking; but now his lips were sealed tight, and he seemed to be afraid of something new entirely.

The next second, Chase understood where his fear was coming from.

The driver's head knocked against a handrail—just a single bump, yet it seemed to knock loose the tension he had been holding so rigidly all along.

He did not open his mouth, but from between his sealed lips came a human voice once more, far clearer than before: "The car... electric lights... the line—broken, falling..."

Had Chase been even a blink slower to understand, he might have had electricity surge through his entire body from the wire swinging down from the ceiling—and even as it was, he only barely managed to dodge at the last possible instant, crashing into the seats beside him as a burst of crackling electric sparks swept across the floor in front of him, the dancing embers tracing the path of a snake.

Was the Artifact trying to protect itself?

The thought flashed suddenly through Chase's mind.

The driver instinctively wrapped his arms around his head and curled up; the wire fell to the floor without touching him, then bounced back up, swinging through the air once more and hurtling straight at Chase.

The car wasn't particularly wide, and the spot where the casing had come loose and the wire had fallen was right in the center; a live, crackling, thrashing wire was already a considerable problem—but when Chase swung his T-bar and batted back the sparking end of the wire, driving it back several paces, he heard the voice again, coming from inside the driver's cheek.

"Want to go home,"

Hearing it now, he realized it was a voice entirely unlike the subway driver's—speaking quickly and indistinctly: "Want to go home, passage—the passage that lets people enter the Nest —"

For an instant, Chase thought he had been struck by the wire.

Every pore on his body went numb and tingling; he found he couldn't move, as though afraid of startling it, afraid it would stop speaking. The scar on the back of his right hand woke, tightening and contracting the skin in waves.

Chase stood dazed before the seats, one hand still resting on a plastic seatback. Except for the voice beneath the driver's cheek, the whole world seemed to have receded from his awareness, and he was back in the dark, hushed mountain forest of his childhood. The difference was that in this darkness, he could see only a single star.

"...There is none." The voice beneath the driver's cheek said.

The wire leapt back into the air; a streak of electric sparks arced through it and landed at Chase's feet.

He heard his own heart thud against his ribcage, unable to break free, sliding back down into the deep darkness.

In the dead silence, he became aware that he had stepped forward—his legs stiff, his fingers gripping the fabric of the driver's shirt—yet that hand seemed as though it truly belonged somewhere far from him.

This meaningless body of his seemed far from him too.

"A Resident,"

As the driver was yanked to his feet by him, legs too unsteady to stand properly, a voice came again from behind the driver's sealed lips. "The passage that allows a Resident to enter the human world—there is one. A Resident. One."

The driver's ragged breathing, the rush of air from the subway car's ventilation system, the crackling of the wire... it was as if a floodgate had been pulled open, and every sound came surging back into Chase's awareness all at once.

"Make it be quiet," Chase said through clenched teeth, squeezing out four words toward the driver.

After those four words, his peripheral vision told him: ahead, a black glass window was bowing inward into the car, like cloth being pressed from behind by something enormous.

I know this might sound like I'm making excuses to get out of work, but yesterday when I was dizzy with exhaustion, I actually got stuck at 1,500 words and couldn't write another line—the plot felt like it had hit a dead end, I had no idea who wrote the first 1,500 words or who was supposed to take over from there, and I just couldn't do it, because my brain is a wooden carving.

Today I didn't sleep well either (the cat was yowling, I had an early meeting, didn't get enough rest), but at least I slept at all—and when I sat back down to write, it was different. Somehow images and ideas came, and somehow I finished.

And after finishing, I'm actually a little pleased with myself? Especially pleased with the part where Chase is bitterly disappointed (lol).

Chapter 37: Chase's Least Favorite Thing

Time — he needed time.

In the span of just twenty or thirty seconds, one unexpected development had followed another, each more bewildering than the last.

But Chase knew that given even a little time, he could connect the dots between each "point of light" and assemble them into a clear, comprehensible picture.

The world might be chaotic and complex, but Chase believed it could always be understood this way: first, seize enough key pieces of information from the noise and confusion, then use those pieces to trace the outline, connecting dots into a shape that brought the whole structure to the surface.

The only problem was that time was precisely what he had least of right now.

When Chase turned his head and his gaze fell on that pitch-black glass bulging high into the car's interior, he knew he had made an unavoidable mistake — it was impossible not to look at the window; no one could have helped it. But the moment he looked, his attention had been split.

In that instant of distraction, the live wire that had just been torn open was sparking and whipping through the air, swinging toward the back of his head.

Even the air felt twisted and taut with the current; he could almost smell the electric sparks, feel a flash of scorching blue across the skin on the back of his neck.

...No matter how quick you were, you couldn't outrun electricity.

Chase closed his eyes.

The moment of waiting for the shock seemed to stretch on forever; the memory of enduring electric shocks years ago in search of a passage rose up again, like a preview of the piercing pain that was about to come.

Yet after just one short breath, Chase opened his eyes again.

The crack of electricity striking, a pained grunt, the thud of a body hitting the floor — he heard all of it; but the current itself he felt not at all.

Someone had been electrocuted, but it wasn't him.

Chase turned his head sharply, and sure enough, the driver was collapsed on the floor behind him, his face an ashen, sickly white, body curled and convulsing in waves — as though some nerve inside him had been seized and pulled taut, leaving him unable to straighten up or escape. The wire, drained of its earlier frenzy, hung limply on the floor nearby, motionless, as though ashamed of itself.

Chase glanced at the window swelling like a balloon, then glanced back at the driver lying a step behind him; for a moment, he nearly laughed.

"I forgot to mention," he said, picking the T-bar up off the floor and giving it a testing heft in his hand, "my luck tends to run well — because I drain the luck from everyone around me."

The driver couldn't speak at all; he seemed barely conscious.

"Just now you followed my gaze and turned to look at this window, didn't you? I was distracted for a moment and let go of you." Chase wasn't looking for an answer from the driver — he needed to work through everything in front of him himself. He stared at the window and said, "You saw the window in that state and panicked, stepped back — and ended up taking the shock meant for me. Am I right?"

A low rumble rolled up from the driver's throat.

That being the case, it seemed the Rumor Artifact could not control its host's physical actions — otherwise the driver wouldn't have stumbled back onto the wire out of sheer fear.

"I should thank you — because you took that shock for me, I now have a little time."

Chase carried the T-bar and walked step by step toward the window ahead of him, swollen as though nine months pregnant. When he was two paces away, he swung the T-bar high overhead and drove his full weight behind it, slamming it into the pitch-black window — no sound of shattering glass came; instead the window yielded like a sheet of rubber, caving inward, swallowing all his force without resistance.

Behind the window there was presumably a Resident capable of entering the human world, so it stood to reason that the T-bar would have no effect on it.

"What I'm about to say isn't for you — it's for whatever's inside your mouth. 'Rumor,' right? May I call you that?"

The driver lay half-conscious on the floor; the voice beneath his cheek had gone quiet too, as if in tacit acknowledgment.

"For an Artifact to possess a degree of intelligence, enough to understand self-preservation — that's actually remarkable. But you have no self-awareness, and your cognition isn't high enough; otherwise you wouldn't be an Artifact, you'd be a Resident."

From the window, bulging as though inflated by a breath, the shape of a human hand pressed through from behind the glass — five fingers splayed wide, rising slowly to the surface, feeling its way along.

Wherever the hand moved, Chase's gaze followed.

"If your intelligence were high enough, you'd have realized by now that when I threatened the driver and went after him, it wasn't to hurt him — it was to get to you. But that chain of cause and effect is too complex for you to grasp. You don't understand it... you only have instinct.

"When the driver you've taken up residence in has his life threatened — when the whole person is plunged into fear and panic — your survival instinct gets triggered as well. I don't know what you look like, but it seems you have to exist by attaching yourself to a person. If that person dies, you'd be in serious trouble, wouldn't you?"

The driver had stopped convulsing and lay still on the floor; a thin thread of consciousness remained, his eyelids half-open and faintly trembling.

From between his slightly parted lips, a small voice was saying rapidly: "Help, help!" — as though calling for rescue on the driver's behalf.

Chase turned his gaze back to the window; in the swollen black glass, a distorted reflection of himself stared back. As the corner of his mouth curved up, the reflection too showed a crooked half-smile.

"And who exactly are you calling to for help?"

Chase didn't know whether other people's lives were like his — always full of this kind of darkly ironic humor. If it weren't happening to him, he could almost laugh out loud.

It was worth noting that half the reason the driver was so frightened in the first place was the "subway serial killer" rumor the Artifact had fabricated, convincing the driver he'd picked up a serial killer — which, incidentally, was further proof that Rumor lacked sufficiently high intelligence.

It couldn't grasp how the rumors it generated at random might affect its own host.

"Judging from the 'subway killer' and the 'falling wire' — you can't conjure things out of thin air, just by saying them.

"Whatever you say has to be grounded in some existing reality. If no one had ever died on the subway, you couldn't have invented the 'subway killer' rumor; if there were no wire here, you couldn't have just willed one into existence out of nowhere.

"The wire couldn't kill me, so you summoned a Resident capable of entering the human world... but you don't actually want to go back to the Nest — you just sense that inside the Nest you could hide from me."

A surge of ink-black tide rose within Chase, and for one instant he felt a powerful urge — to seize whatever was behind that window and grind it to dust and splinters.

Sometimes he wished he could use these hands to grind his entire life to pieces.

When his words fell, the carriage sank into a brief and total silence.

The Artifact made no sound; the driver's breathing was barely a thread. The hand behind the window had finally felt its way to where the glass met the frame, and like someone picking apart stitches, it began to tear the glass away, bit by bit.

"I don't know how limited your intelligence actually is. But if you can understand even one word I'm saying, you'd do best to send that Resident back to the Nest right now..."

If this Artifact had truly wanted to go home, it had no shortage of chances before today.

There had to be Hunters around Wellesley, and every Hunter had a passage — it could have hitched a ride back with any one of them. And even if it couldn't reach a Hunter, why had it waited until now to call in a Resident capable of entering the human world?

"Help..."

The Artifact spoke again, this time without urgency; after listening to Chase, it seemed to hesitate a little itself, and when it called for help again, its voice lifted into a question at the end: "Help?"

"I'm telling you to send it back for two reasons," Chase said, his tone calm. "First: once a Resident enters, I can protect myself, but I can't guarantee your host's life."

Between the glass and the window frame, a few grayish-white fingertips had begun to push through. Chase watched the fingertips and said quietly, "Second... you're not wrong to sense that

— I indeed have no passage and cannot enter the Nest."

For a moment, both the Resident and the Artifact seemed to be waiting for him to continue.

"However, this is not the first time I've encountered a Resident."

Chase looked at his own reflection and slowly rolled his shoulders and neck.

"The thing I hate most in the world is a Resident that can enter the human world. When I see one, I can't help but lose my temper. Fortunately they're rare, so it doesn't happen often.

"But today you've brought one right in front of me."

Chase let out a sigh.

"If you actually want to stay safe, you'd be better off not making me angry."

Rushed and scrambled, but I finally got a chapter out before the day ended!

As I slowly get back to my normal schedule, I should start thinking about giving you all some bonus chapters... ugh, what if I took a month off starting today, but all the updates during that month counted as bonus updates — would that be too sneaky? Like, sneaky written all over my face?

PS: Going forward, barring anything unexpected, updates will be in the evening. I'm still working during the day — I've got a mountain of backlogged tasks to get through.

Chapter 38: Chase's Second Memory

"Chase, Chase, wake up—time to go home."

A hand gave his shoulder a gentle nudge, and his dream cracked open at the seam; fragments slipped away and drifted off, and Chase opened his eyes.

The horizon had faded to a pale violet, the long clouds stained deep crimson, as if someone had dragged a finger across the sky and left streaks of rouge behind.

The shadows of palm trees rose tall against the darkening sky, and one by one, dim amber lights blinked on across the evening parking lot.

"Sleeping so soundly—must've been a good dream?"

Mom was standing outside the car window; seeing him awake, she drew her hand back through the half-open window and straightened up. Chase couldn't make out her expression, but he heard a trace of guilt in her voice. Her tone was very gentle, because guilt is a kind of softener.

Chase couldn't remember the dream anymore. The light inside it had been very bright—far brighter than a western evening in a parking lot; he'd been very tall in it, far taller than he was now.

But as for what exactly he had dreamed, he had forgotten it all.

"No overtime today?" he asked, watching Mom open the car door and settle into the driver's seat on the other side.

"I begged my manager to let me leave early today." Mom glanced at him, a hint of a smile surfacing, but it couldn't break through some heavy lid pressing down on it and dissolved again. "I didn't dare tell him you'd been waiting in the car for me this whole time..."

"Why not?"

Mom placed a plastic bag on the back seat; the smell of the food inside was familiar. She always brought home leftovers from the restaurant to serve as dinner for the two of them. She started the car and said, "How could that be considered a good thing? If anyone found out, Child Protective Services might just take you away."

Chase didn't understand what was wrong with sitting in the car waiting for his mom to get off work—the window was half-open, a soft breeze drifting in, chip crumbs stuck to his fingertips, and the storybook on his knees had slid to the floor while he slept.

"Sorry, sweetheart—it won't happen again. When you grow up, please don't complain to a therapist about me. Put on your seatbelt."

It would actually happen again, because the only person willing to watch Chase for a small fee was a neighbor girl who lived nearby, and she didn't always have the time.

Later, Chase thought that what he had truly wanted to say back then was "I like waiting for you"—but somehow, what actually came out of his mouth was a complaint: "I want to go home and watch TV."

"All right," Mom said, pulling out of the parking lot. "Not until after dinner."

By the time they got on the freeway, the sky had gone completely dark; bright headlights cut through the night and swept past their old car in a flash. The freeway sat high up, with a cliff face on the left; looking out from the road, you could see all the way to the distant horizon.

The vast, sprawling city of LA lit up beneath the night sky in countless stars of light.

They had driven this road so many times it was as familiar as their own kitchen. Chase kept watching the nighttime cityscape outside the window while Mom listened to the radio, the two of them chatting idly off and on.

It all happened without any warning: a heavy freight truck up ahead suddenly veered sideways and crashed through the right-side guardrail at an angle, and Mom was still mid-laugh when it did.

Her sharp intake of breath made Chase whip his head around—just in time to see that long truck slewed across the freeway ahead of them.

The piercing shriek of the emergency brakes tore through the entire cabin, yet the car couldn't overcome its own momentum and kept hurtling straight toward the truck—Chase was pinned into his seat by the seatbelt, watching the truck loom larger and larger, like a catastrophe sweeping down to swallow him whole, and in that moment he couldn't remember whether he had screamed.

All he remembered was turning his head and finding the driver's seat empty.

The seatbelt was still buckled into its clasp, lying flat across the driver's seat as though it were there to protect an empty chair; the steering wheel, with no hands left to hold it, gave a faint, slight turn.

...Huh?

The bewilderment lasted only an instant; by the time Chase came to his senses and lunged for the steering wheel, he slammed into the truck—in that split second, the hood crumpled and buckled upward, filling most of the windshield and his field of vision, and the next moment Chase sank into darkness and knew nothing at all.

Ah, right—Chase Monroe died in a car accident when he was five years old.

...He did die, didn't he?

Something felt off, somehow.

If Chase Monroe had died at the age of five... then who was the one reliving this memory from his perspective right now, the one who believed he had died?

A small voice raised a quiet objection.

Does it matter who is doing the remembering? Whether he died or not—that doesn't matter either.

What truly matters is this: if he stops all this useless thinking and simply lets himself sink down into the warm, amniotic darkness, closes his eyes, and falls asleep—all his struggling and confusion will find comfort and resolution... no need to worry about anything anymore...

No need to... worry...

Absolutely not.

Chase's eyes snapped open.

He was lying on the floor; the nearly blinding white light of the subway car made it so that, for a brief moment, he couldn't see anything at all.

Some instinct that jolted awake from deep in his bones suppressed, in the very first instant, his impulse to roll over and leap up; he forced himself to stay perfectly still, listening to a soft rustling sound on the floor drift past his ear and slowly recede.

His vision cleared quickly, and he found himself lying in front of a car window that had lost its glass.

He still remembered how the glass of that window had just moments ago swelled out like a rubber balloon, with several grayish-white fingers picking apart the seam between the glass and the window frame; now the window was empty, and scattered across the floor and the seats were shards of broken glass.

The Resident had already crawled in through the window—it had entered the human world...

But no matter how hard Chase tried, he could not recall why he had ended up on the floor.

When he fell, the back of his head must have struck the seat first before hitting the floor; his neck was twisted awkwardly now and throbbing with a dull ache.

He listened as the rustling sound came to a stop a few steps away, and from deep in the driver's throat came a low, trembling moan—it had barely begun when it cut off abruptly, as though it had been choked off.

Dead?

Chase's heart sank. That Artifact—

"...So you are... con-scious," a sticky, glutinous voice said, breaking the words up in an unnatural way. "Good to... know that then."

A Resident.

"So you're conscious—good to know"—that line was directed at the driver, which meant the driver probably wasn't dead yet...

Chase held his breath and slowly shifted his gaze, making out a blurry grayish-white silhouette standing not far away on the floor; it was hard to tell for certain, but the impression was that the shadow had its back to him.

He tensed his abdominal muscles inch by inch, and soundlessly, bit by bit, lifted himself off the floor—and saw the T-bar lying at his feet. He did not reach for it.

Judging by the state of things, it looked as though he had gone down before he'd had a chance to do anything at all...

The stooped, hunched figure had a small build, reaching only to Chase's waist. Its entire body was wrapped in a grayish-white cloth robe, ragged and tattered, torn to shreds in many places.

From beneath the grayish-white robe, one grayish-white palm—larger than a mop head—lay limply against the floor with its face upward; the other hand was raised in the air, three long fingers extended, one of which was bent down toward the driver.

"Three... memo-ries from which... you can... die."

Once the cadence fell apart, the meaning itself became hard to catch at first listen; Chase paused for a moment before he understood it to be saying, "Three memories from which you can die."

Which meant—

Chase understood everything all at once.

He recoiled in horror, no longer caring about concealing himself, and drove a kick into the driver's ankle, shouting, "Wake up—don't believe it, you're not dead!"

He had effectively given himself away—before his next thought could even form, that hunched back swiveled around, and a face spun to face him.

The moment his gaze landed on that face, the subway car once again blurred rapidly, dissolved, and slid into darkness; Chase fell back involuntarily against the seat behind him, the Resident's sticky laughter filling his ears.

"Thirty-nine... memo-ries from which... you can... die."

So that's how it is...

That mixture of indignation, fear, and restless anxiety, as he tumbled into the memory, faded rapidly from the edges of his consciousness like gray smoke.

If the car accident when he was five was the first memory the Resident had found—one in which he could die in the process of reliving it—then Chase now knew what the second memory it had found would be.

The second time his life had been in danger was six days after the accident.

It was also the day Mom came back from the Nest.

Chapter 39 — The First Resident Chase Ever Saw

In the beginning, the hospital ward was a constant stream of people coming and going.

Strange faces drifted in and out, their features quickly blurring together until Chase could no longer tell one from another. He remembered traffic officers, nurses, doctors, detectives, social workers — every vague, flesh-colored face would open its mouth and pour an endless torrent of questions over him.

Who is your mother?

Where did you get on the highway?

Did you notice the car door — was it closed? Did she jump out of the moving car?

What about your father? Oh, you've never met him?

Then are there any other relatives at home?

Aside from being able to answer "My mother's name is Daisy Monroe," Chase couldn't answer a single question.

Chase used to sometimes imagine that he actually had a father — a CIA agent, deep undercover abroad, or perhaps a top scientist working on a classified project, which was why they couldn't meet. The ordinary fantasies of a child.

But during those few days, Chase sat alone on the hospital bed with his arm in a cast, watching one stranger after another come in and go out, leaving behind snacks, empty paper coffee cups, cigarette butts, contact cards, and an endless string of questions in the ward.

All those naive fantasies fell away in the face of reality, like shedding a shell that had long since stopped fitting.

"It's just me," he told the police officer. "There's only me left at home now."

That day, he heard a few people talking by the door — whether they were police or social workers or something else entirely, a child had no easy way to tell.

"I've been doing this job for decades and I've never seen a mother run off like this," the middle-aged man said, chewing tobacco. "Parents who walk out the door in the morning and never come back — that's common enough. But how did she just vanish from a car accident?"

"It is strange. There's nothing in the scene evidence that shows how she disappeared," said another, younger-looking person. "Though it's ironic, in a way — if she hadn't suddenly vanished, that child would probably have ended up with more than just a broken arm."

"Oh, right, you mentioned that before. Something about the direction of the front of the car?"

"Yeah. You've heard that in an emergency, drivers will instinctively turn the wheel to the left, so the passenger seat takes the impact? That's not always the case — some drivers will turn toward whatever gap is larger. But in this particular accident, the boy's mother had no choice but to turn left —"

Because the right side was a cliff.

The answer surfaced in Chase's mind at the same moment the middle-aged man let out an "Oh."

"She probably hadn't finished turning the wheel yet — or had only just started — when she disappeared from the driver's seat. She let go, the wheel returned to center, right? According to the boy's account, after he realized his mother was gone, he instinctively grabbed the wheel. That caused the car to drift slightly to the right — but not too much, not enough to crash through the guardrail and go over the cliff. It was just right, enough to make sure the boy got off with the lightest possible injuries. It's almost a miracle."

"He really got lucky," the middle-aged man said, then stopped himself. "...No, you can't say he got lucky. Five years old, and with no father or mother. What happens next?"

"His mother has a distant aunt living in Blackmoor City who agreed to come look after him for a few days," the third person cut in. "Whether she's willing to be a long-term guardian is another question entirely. If she's not, the boy will have to be sent to an orphanage or a foster family."

On the third day, Chase was discharged from the hospital, carrying a broken arm in a cast and a bill he had no idea what to do with.

His aunt was getting on in years; her glasses were always sliding down to the tip of her nose, and she started dozing off at eight o'clock sharp. Neither she nor Chase knew how to be around the other, and the small apartment that had once been full of noise and bustle fell quiet — as though no one lived there at all.

On the sixth night after the accident, Chase could not fall asleep no matter what he tried.

The pain in his arm was one thing; once his aunt fell asleep she snored steadily. Every time he lifted his head, there was a strange, mountain-like shape sleeping in his mother's bed.

By midnight, Chase could no longer bear the boredom and the torment, and quietly climbed out of bed and went to the living room. There was really nothing there either; he thought he wanted to play with his toys, but after staring at the box for a while, he didn't even reach out to open it.

Chase walked to the window and looked down at the familiar, empty street below.

If only Mom could come back, he thought. Right now — walking back up the street, wearing the clothes she had on the day she disappeared, carrying the snacks and breakfast she'd bought for him, her keys jingling with every step.

Though he was only five, Chase had long since understood that his imagination would not become reality.

So when he actually saw his mother walking up the street, step by step, the shock made him lean forward — and with a thud, his face smacked into the glass.

"...Mom?" he called out softly.

The apartment was on the second floor, still far above where his mother was, yet she seemed to hear him — she tilted her head up toward him.

In that instant, Chase didn't move, his forehead pressed against the cold glass.

Half of his mother's face was covered in blood.

In the darkness, the blood was blacker than the night itself, making half her face look as though it had been swallowed by a void. One eye could not open; only the eye buried in the dark, bloodied mess was looking at him, its pupil faintly glowing.

But it was indeed his mother.

The moment their eyes met, his mother reached out her hand and waved at him hard several times, the way she used to when she came to pick him up from kindergarten — then immediately kept on limping and stumbling toward the apartment building, nearly tripping once in her hurry.

He should have gone to wake his aunt right away, but in that moment Chase didn't even remember there was an aunt in the apartment; he ran quickly to the door, threw it open, and clattered down the stairs.

"Mom!"

Chase ran toward her with everything he had — if his mother hadn't quickly reached out a hand to steady him, he would have crashed into her arms, cast and all. "Mom, what happened to you?"

"I tripped and fell," his mother said breathlessly, half bent over, managing a short laugh. "It hurts so much. Your arm —"

"Where did you go?"

His mother studied him for a moment before answering: "A... a very strange place. But it doesn't matter. I'm back. Don't worry — I'll never go there again."

As she said this, whatever force had carried her home seemed to give out all at once; she collapsed onto the roadside like a stack of building blocks someone had suddenly kicked over.

"Mom?" Chase was startled and rushed to help her up.

Help her up — he couldn't really manage that; it was more like he grabbed her arm and ended up sitting down on the ground alongside her.

But his mother waved a hand to signal she was all right. "I'm just tired... need to rest a moment... Is it only you at home?"

"Auntie came from Blackmoor City," Chase answered.

"Go home... have her call... call an ambulance..."

Chase looked down and realized that the front of his body, his arm, and his cast were all smeared with blood.

"Hurry... go on." His mother's voice was low, fragile as something that might scatter in a breeze.

Chase nodded rapidly. Before he stood up, something came over him — his hand trembling, he gently touched his mother's body.

Perhaps he wanted to see where she was hurt and how badly, but what he touched was something strange.

"Mom," Chase froze. "What's wrapped around you?"

In that instant, his mother's face went rigid.

In all his life, Chase had never seen a face so frightening — because the person wearing that face had herself been swallowed entirely by dread.

A suffocating fear, heavy as concrete, slowly crushed the air. For a split second, Chase suddenly wanted to shrink very small, so that no one could see him — not even his mother.

His mother did not look down toward her waist, as though if she didn't look, her fear would not become real. That one eye that could still open was fixed on Chase, unblinking — whether tears had formed in it he couldn't tell, but it shone with a brightness that was frightening.

"Wh... what? Something's wrapped around me... what?"

Without realizing it, Chase had already started crying, tears crawling down his face in a slow, itching stream.

"I... I don't know," he said — he didn't even know what he was afraid of; he couldn't bring himself to pull his hand back, and it stayed at his mother's waist as he said in a trembling voice: "It... it feels like a thin rope..."

Just then, he felt the rope beneath his hand give a slight twitch.

As though someone had tugged the other end of the rope.

The other end...

Chase dimly realized that the rope around his mother's waist must have another end somewhere.

"Don't look."

He heard his mother's voice, pleading with him: "Don't look back, Chase... go home, run..."

But Chase didn't hear a word of it. His body seemed to be taken over by some other self; against his will, he stood up, stepped to the side, and let his gaze fall on the ground behind his mother.

A rope lay limply there, stretching away behind her, gradually disappearing into the darkness that the streetlights couldn't reach.

...How strange. Who had tied a rope around his mother?

The rope twitched again.

"Chase! Come back!"

Chase startled — only then did he realize he had already walked several steps forward along the rope without noticing. He glanced back at his mother, then turned his head again — and this time, ahead of him there was no longer only darkness, a street, and a long rope.

A massive shadow, gripping the other end of the rope, was standing before him — he had no idea when it had appeared.

"Run!" His mother's voice cracked into something close to a shout of fury, jolting Chase fully back to his senses.

He had no time to make out what the shadow looked like; he spun around and ran. He thought he screamed — or maybe he didn't. He thought a neighbor's light turned on — or maybe it didn't.

In that moment, the world suddenly dropped the mask of rational order and exposed the dark, murky nightmare underneath. Nothing felt real anymore.

He heard the shadow speak.

Its voice stretched across the night sky, drifting through the air.

He couldn't understand the words at the time, yet every one of them was carved deep into his bones. Later, Chase came to understand what those words meant — but by then it was long past, everything too late, and he had never let himself think of them again.

Only once — while interrogating a traitor — did those words of the Resident inexplicably leap back into his mind.

By the time Chase came back to himself, someone had him locked in their arms, begging him to stop; the traitor had already been beaten into a blur of blood and flesh, no more human in shape than a heap of mud.

"Thank you so very much,"

the Resident had said. "The only way I can enter the mortal world is to find a dog, tie a rope to it, and have it lead me in. You didn't really think you'd escaped from my grasp, did you? You really thought you could come back and be reunited with your son? Ah, let me have a taste... I've heard that human hope, dashed at the last moment, is the most delicious thing of all."

I thought about it for a while, and in the end I've settled on Daisy for Chase's mother's name.

Chapter 40: Chase Is Very Very Very Simple

Had he been wrong?

When five-year-old Chase had sprinted a few steps out in a frenzy, he suddenly remembered his injured mother, still lying by the roadside.

On instinct, he stopped in his tracks, turned around without a second thought, and rushed back to help her up so they could run together—was that wrong of him? Had he made a mistake?

"I told you to run!"

His mother's shriek in that moment was loud and piercing, nothing like the voice of someone who, just seconds ago, had been too badly hurt to speak.

"Mom—"

He grabbed her arm, and only managed to get that one word out.

The next second, he watched his own feet dangling in midair, swaying as they drifted further from the ground.

His mother tilted her face up—half-blackened with blood—and froze for a split second in shock and terror before erupting in a furious cry: "Let him go!"

The thing hadn't grabbed Chase, nor had it lifted him by the collar.

It dawned on him, belatedly, that a long black shadow had pierced straight out from his chest and extended into the open air—like a blade driven clean through him, holding him suspended in midair—yet Chase felt no pain and shed no blood; he had simply lost all strength in his body, dizzy and heavy-headed, unable to lift his face.

"There's no rush," the Resident said from behind him in a droning hum. "I don't think you've fully grasped the exquisite beauty of your present situation. Allow me to explain it to you in detail."

His mother's voice drifted through the spaces between its words like the wail of a wolf.

"The flavor I most love to savor and appreciate is 'irony.' This particular thing exists only in abundance among humans—the Nest has none of it.

"The disappointment of someone who buys a lottery ticket and doesn't win is still disappointment, but it tastes plain and dull—like a packet of instant noodles, good only for filling the stomach. Yet your disappointment right now is a rare delicacy. Why? Because your hope has been dashed in an ironic way; a losing lottery ticket lacks that particular flavor. I simply must make you understand this beauty completely, or I'll be driven mad with longing."

The Resident jostled Chase up and down a few times and let out a contented sigh.

"First of all, your passage alone delights me to no end. You can only enter the Nest through a car accident—no wonder you're thirty-six years old and only just opening your passage for the first time... But if this car accident had happened a few months earlier, none of tonight would exist. Do you know why?"

His mother's gaze was fixed on Chase, swaying gently with him in the air.

"Because the resident population of your Los Angeles region only just surpassed ten million this year. Just think—if the accident had happened sooner, it would have been nothing more than ordinary bad luck; and if you had moved away this year, as you'd always planned, you would never have entered the Nest for the rest of your life... Doesn't the timing of the accident strike you as particularly ironic? Particularly delicious?"

Chase hazily recalled that his mother had indeed once asked him whether he'd like to move back to her hometown.

Only at the time, he still couldn't understand what moving or not moving had to do with any of this.

"You thought you'd escaped, never knowing that you'd become a guide dog, leading me into the human world—and that was already quite something. If you had gone straight to the police and been sent to a hospital the moment you arrived, wouldn't that have been dreadfully boring and pointless? I would simply have left and gone to find another human.

"But you didn't go to the hospital. Your first instinct was to go home and check on your child, to make sure he was safe—and in doing so, you exposed him to me instead... How wonderful.

"If you didn't love him so much, he wouldn't be dying tonight."

Chase knew he was crying, and he also knew he was not crying for himself.

The sound of his mother's whimpering and wailing from the ground below frightened him far more than the black shadow impaling his chest.

He used to think he had a superpower—whenever his mother was unhappy, he could always make her laugh in just a few words—but tonight, that superpower felt like the arrogant dream of some other five-year-old.

"Don't bother crying for help. Who could possibly save you?"

"Didn't you notice how the neighbor who opened their window to look has already closed it again and gone back to sleep? An ordinary human being who has no passage and has never had any contact with a Resident simply cannot see me—or a child impaled in midair. Right now, you're nothing but a woman sitting by the road in the middle of the night, crying like a lunatic."

In the Resident's grasp, Chase was like a piece of meat skewered on a stick.

With a sudden whoosh, it swung him from midair in an arc past his mother's face—and as she lunged forward with outstretched arms, grabbing at nothing, it hoisted Chase high up again.

"Oh my, mother and child weeping together—you've even made me sad. Don't be like this. I do have a shred of mercy in me. How about this: I'll give you a choice."

His mother stared blankly upward, one eye gleaming with moisture—but it was not the gleam of hope.

"The number of Residents who can come to the human world is very, very, very small—not even one in ten years. Far fewer than the number of humans with a passage. Doesn't that seem unfair?"

The Resident clicked its tongue—if it had one.

"The conditions for coming are difficult and demanding to meet. After all that effort to arrive, one careless misstep and you fall right back into the Nest. Now, I'm going to tell you exactly how to send me back."

His mother went completely still. She murmured, "Wh... what?"

"Very, very, very simple. You still have a rope around your waist, don't you? That rope is actually a part of me. All you have to do is cut it, and the passage by which I came to the human world will be severed—I'll naturally return to the Nest. You don't believe me, do you?"

"That's fine. There's nothing I can do about that. All I can say is: for us Residents who are able to come to the human world, the moment the passage is cut, we fall right back into the Nest. It's that simple. If you don't believe me, try it."

"The choice," his mother pressed one hand to her waist, breathing hard as she asked: "You said you'd give me... a choice. What is it?"

"Oh, it's just whether or not to cut the rope."

The moment those words landed, the air fell silent for a second or two in confusion. Chase couldn't see very clearly, but his mother must have furrowed her brow.

"I... why would I... not cut it? You have... a trap..."

"Wrong. I have no trap." The Resident said it matter-of-factly. "I am a very, very, very trustworthy person. If I allow you to cut the rope, I will absolutely not stop you. The rope can grow back anyway. But you'd better think carefully before you cut it."

Chase felt himself being hoisted up and held high beside a vast, flat black shadow; the Resident seemed to nuzzle him against what served as its face a few times, as if in a show of affection.

"This child of yours—I won't be letting him go.

"So your choices are: one, don't cut the rope, I stay, and I kill both you and your child; two, cut the rope, I take your child's corpse back to the Nest with me, and you get to keep your own life."

Chase felt the flat black shadow that was its face swell outward in a bulge, nudging his body up slightly—the Resident was laughing.

"I promise you, your child will die tonight, without question. The only difference is whether you choose to die with him."

That sharp, anguished shriek from his mother—even after all these years, it still pierced his chest like a blade.

He had indeed died, hadn't he—no matter what his mother had chosen that night, he had without question been killed by the Resident...

A voice in his mind that did not belong to Chase kept persuading him: yes, you died that night. Do you remember? That small body in its cast, hitting the ground with a thud, falling right in front of his mother's eyes...

Were there really so few Residents who had come to the human world?

One had come when he was five. Now another had come.

...He had not, of course, died that night.

Chase refused to accept that he had died in the moment of the car accident, because if he had died in the crash, he would never have been able to see his mother one last time.

He still remembered, to this day, the warmth of his mother's arms when she held his shoulders that night.

Chase equally refused to accept that he had died at the Resident's hands, for reasons that were slightly more complex: one, the Resident had been gravely wounded that night and driven back into the Nest, so what remained of his rational mind deep within him would not allow him to believe the Resident had killed him then; and two, if his five-year-old self had died that night, he would never have been lifted from the pool of blood by Uncle Key.

When he strained to raise his neck, dazed and confused, and tried to turn his head to look at his mother, Ronan Key covered his eyes with his hand.

"Listen... listen to him, go quickly," his mother's last, halting words rose from the warm darkness beneath that palm. "From now on... Mom is leaving you in his care."

If he had never met Uncle Key, he would never have known what had truly happened to his mother that night, and there would never again have been a place in this world where his soul could find shelter.

Chase's consciousness returned to the subway car, and this time he did not open his eyes.

He sat up without a sound. With his focus fully drawn inward, his five senses sharpened and amplified severalfold: he traced the soft rustling sounds, the faint raw and bloody scent coming off the Resident, the breathing of the subway driver... and mapped out the layout of the car in his mind.

Driving the Resident back into the Nest was "very, very, very simple."

All he had to do was cut off the path by which it had come.

Lately, after finishing each chapter, I write a few hundred extra words to stockpile bonus updates... The idea is good, but progress is honestly a bit too slow.

Chapter 41: Chase, Did You Think the Rumor Had Stopped Spreading?

"Hm? Hm hm hm?"

A long, piercing sound of bewilderment rose from the Resident's throat, as though it simply could not fathom why Chase refused to die inside the memory and kept dragging himself up off the ground again and again.

"Can die, go to mem, ory thirty, eight places——"

It had been saying "thirty-nine" just a moment ago, Chase thought. So it was counting down.

A memory it had already used once couldn't be turned against him again, could it?

Good. He'd had more than enough of that helpless, useless, sobbing five-year-old who could do nothing but cry.

His contempt for helplessness ran even deeper than his contempt for the Resident.

Chase shut his eyes and drew a long, slow breath.

"Hm hm hm hm hm?" Seeing that he was still standing, the Resident seemed deeply displeased, its voice growing far more grating: "Thirty, eight places——"

"Stop screaming," Chase said quietly. "As long as I can't see your face, I won't pass out. That's how it works, isn't it."

Every time his eyes met its face, he collapsed immediately and sank into a memory. Even an idiot could connect those dots.

"By any Resident's standard, you're a shoddy, inferior thing." Chase spoke as he stepped back. "You've barely any new tricks, and your weaknesses are plentiful——"

Before he could finish, a rush of air hit him head-on.

The soft slap of bare skin against the floor — the faint currents stirred by countless strips of tattered cloth swaying — the thick, viscous stench of rot that thickened all at once in an instant...

With his eyes closed, his other senses had sharpened.

Chase stepped back again; the sole of his shoe ground over broken glass with a crunch, and he knew he had reached the window the Resident had crawled through.

He suddenly dropped his waist and shot his hand forward in a grab — his hand plunged into something that felt like damp, fetid mist — and sure enough, closed around a fistful of cloth. The nauseating, aching familiar shock of contact with a Resident jolted from his palm all the way up to the crown of his skull — something seized his chest, and the Resident let out a short, smug laugh.

Chase knew why it was laughing.

It probably assumed he would be too overwhelmed to move, because most people, in their first few physical contacts with a Resident, were hit so hard by the physiological effects they couldn't even stay on their feet.

But it didn't know that compared to the Resident from when he was five years old, this thing was cheap merchandise.

Chase clenched his teeth against the trembling in his muscles, closed his fingers tight around the Resident's robed chest, swung his arm, and hurled it hard through the broken window beside him.

The Resident barely had time to let out a "Huh?" before it crashed onto the track outside the window with a distant, dull thud.

Now came the real question — what exactly was this Resident's passage into the human world?

It had crawled in through "a pitch-black train window," but that could not be the only condition.

Otherwise, there were countless "pitch-black windows" in everyday life — it would have been able to enter the human world long ago. Why would it have waited until now?

Besides "a pitch-black train window," there had to be at least one other condition that had also been met for it to crawl into the human world — no matter how Chase turned it over in his mind, he could only think of one.

In the span of a single thought, he had already opened his eyes, sprinting across the car at full speed; halfway there he reached out and scooped up the T-bar, then skidded to a halt beside the half-conscious subway driver.

"Rumor, send it back."

Chase could already hear rustling from behind him outside the window — the Resident was apparently trying to climb back into the car. He raised the T-bar high and said: "Otherwise I'll beat your host into a pulp right now."

He never made empty threats.

The instant the T-bar bit into the subway driver's shoulder, the small voice inside the driver's cheek cried out in rapid succession: "Cancel the invitation to 'Nostalgia Attack!' Cancel the invitation to 'Nostalgia Attack!'"

...What a terrible name.

Chase caught his breath and lifted the T-bar free from the driver's shoulder bone. He stood there and waited a second or two. The car was bright with white light and utterly silent.

Slowly, he turned to look at the window through which the Resident had once crawled.

He had actually braced himself to see a human body half-dangling from the window frame, to see a face smiling up at him — but the window was empty, only a few fragments of broken glass still standing upright in the frame, unknowing that they had already become useless things.

Chase carried the T-bar and approached the window step by step; cautiously, he didn't look directly with his own eyes, but opened his phone's camera and swept it across the outside through the screen.

If the other party was a Resident, it would naturally be quite likely to enjoy toying with people's minds — it might well be crouching outside the car, hands pressed over its mouth, sniggering, waiting to disappoint him.

But outside was only a dim subway tunnel, empty and quiet.

He walked back across the floor of broken glass, over the driver's agonized groans, and returned to stand before the Rumor.

A single blow from his rod to the shoulder had jolted the driver awake from near-unconsciousness; now, seeing Chase approach, the driver was whimpering and twisting his body, trying to crawl backward — Chase pressed the T-bar against his chest and said: "Don't move."

The driver went still, his face a mask of fear and cold sweat. "W-what was that just now...?"

"A dream," Chase said flatly. "You had a nightmare."

The expression on the driver's face, if translated into words, would have read something like: "If you're going to lie to me, you could at least put in some effort."

But Chase had never liked dealing with loose ends, and had even less patience for finding reasonable explanations for everything that had just happened. He was considering how to extract the Rumor Artifact when the driver spoke again.

"What's... what's in my mouth?" the driver said, with a dazed, blank look. "You called it 'Rumor' just now... why is it 'Rumor' again...?"

Chase's attention snapped up like the ears of a dog that has heard something strange.

"Again'?" He leaned in close, startling a hiccup out of the driver. "Who else said the word 'Rumor'?"

Whether from physical pain or sheer terror, the driver's lower lip was wet and trembling. "A few days ago, someone said he'd lost his glasses and couldn't see clearly, so he asked me to read a couple of lines for him..."

Chase froze, and did not interrupt.

"He asked me whether what was written said 'I have a rumor to tell you.' I looked at his phone and said no, it said 'I heard a rumor'... The whole thing was pretty strange, and I had no idea who had sent him that bizarre message, so I remembered it."

"What did that person look like?" Chase asked immediately.

"I don't know..." the driver said, trembling. "He was wearing a mask. All I could make out was that he was a man in his twenties or thirties."

No wonder the driver had shown no reaction to Chase's description of Ivan's appearance — Chase, for a moment, nearly burst out laughing.

He understood everything now.

The answer was so simple; looking back after knowing it, it was almost strange that he hadn't thought of it himself.

Since the Artifact in question was a "Rumor," the way to pass it on was naturally through "words," wasn't it?

The person who had asked the driver to read a message that day was undoubtedly Ivan.

And Ivan's purpose wasn't merely to have the driver read a message — it was to trick him into completing a exchange of words:

"Now say it once: 'I have a rumor to tell you.'"

Chase watched the small bulge in the driver's cheek shift as a tongue pressed against it, then glide away. "Once you say it, I'll leave immediately and won't lay a finger on you again."

"R-really?" The driver startled, then immediately seized this lifeline. "I — I have a rumor to tell you!"

Chase drew a slow, deep breath.

"...I heard a rumor," he answered quietly.

The exchange was complete.

The car fell into silence. Chase watched the driver's cheek; not a flicker of movement crossed his face.

Chase suddenly felt his own tongue move of its own accord, licking the inside of his mouth, then settling back into place.

He slowly broke into a smile.

"You... you said you'd leave..." The driver trembled and pushed himself upright, inching backward, staring at him. "You can't..."

"Relax."

Chase stood up and pulled a wallet from his inner breast pocket. He drew out the thick wad of cash inside and tossed it onto the driver. "Consider it compensation for your undeserved ordeal. When you call the police, make sure you speak clearly."

The moment the driver's eyes landed on the cash, Chase turned and walked away.

He would certainly call the police at the first opportunity — Chase didn't care in the slightest.

"Rumor," Chase said quietly as he stepped up onto the platform. "How much time do you have left?"

He waited patiently, and sure enough heard a small voice from inside his own cheek:

"'Rumor,' countdown: 3,405 days, 16 hours, 15 minutes."

Chase did a rough calculation. Worthy of a Wellesley Artifact — top-tier in every respect. Nearly nine years and four months of remaining time — and to think that many Artifacts, right after leaving the Nest, didn't have anywhere near this long.

It had been in Wellesley's hands for at least several years, hadn't it? After Wellesley died, how had it passed from a dead man's mouth to Ivan?

Chase couldn't think of an answer offhand.

The police chasing him apparently all assumed he had long since slipped out among the disembarking passengers.

He reached up and ruffled his own hair, letting his bangs fall down to cover his forehead, then stripped off his jacket and dress shirt and discarded them, keeping only the white short-sleeved undershirt beneath, and walked out of the subway station almost brazenly — there were indeed a few officers left watching the exits, and one of them even called out at him: "Hey!"

Chase stopped and asked politely: "Officer, what is it?"

That officer looked him up and down.

When he had crossed the tracks earlier, he had only shown the police a suited figure from behind, without letting them see his face clearly; and the tunnel had been dim. Chase was quite confident they wouldn't recognize him. He was tall, but not unusually so.

"Where are you coming from?"

"Ninth Street."

"When did you get off?"

"Just now. I used the restroom and was held up a bit."

The officer thought for a moment, then waved his hand and said: "Got it, thanks for your cooperation. You're free to go."

Just as Chase was about to leave, he found himself asking almost involuntarily: "...I heard there's a subway serial killer. Is that true?"

The officer paused.

"Oh... right," he said, as though the memory were slowly surfacing. He glanced first at his colleague beside him, then said: "Yeah, there is that rumor going around... but who we caught

today isn't him. Or, well, probably not."

"Good luck, officer." Chase smiled, turned, and walked out of the subway station.

Honestly, I'm fairly pleased with this part covering Chase's childhood history — let me take a moment to pat myself on the back. His arc will wrap up in just one more chapter!

Chapter 42: The Root of Chase and Sydney Ginn's Bewilderment

Chase sat on a park bench, staring blankly ahead, his gaze unfocused.

Both elbows were propped on his knees, his body half-hunched forward; his large hands hung loosely, and a T-bar was still tucked into the back of his waistband.

Everyone who passed by on the path in front of him tried their best to step back without making it obvious, giving him a wide berth; the space around Chase for several meters in every direction was empty.

Two young girls had walked over from a distance just moments ago, stealing glances at him and whispering to each other with little laughs—but the moment they drew close, their expressions changed, they fixed their eyes straight ahead, and hurried past with quickened steps.

When people spot someone they think is crazy, they all react pretty much the same way: they steal sidelong glances to see where the crazy person is, what they're doing, how far away they are—while keeping their faces blank, pretending not to notice, and putting distance between themselves as fast as possible.

In truth, this wasn't the first time in Chase's life that people had taken him for a madman; he'd even been called one to his face more than a few times.

But before, it had always been because he came across as savage and brutal, the kind of violent that could get someone killed. A reason like today's had never once happened before.

Leaving the subway station was already something that had happened more than ten minutes ago.

By rights, he should have returned to Key House immediately, handed the "Rumor" Artifact over to Uncle Key, then contacted Kingsley to bring her back from the police—but before he could even flag down a taxi, Chase had been forced to abandon his original plan and duck into a small park first.

...Because the "Rumor" Artifact was using his lips, teeth, and tongue, speaking in his own voice, one sentence after another without stop.

He had lost control of his own tongue; no matter how hard he tried to press it down, it would spring back up and form new words inside his mouth.

Whether it was his struggle against the Artifact that had twisted his expression, or the uncontrollable muttering to himself—either way, he had drawn stares from everyone along the way, with people avoiding him at all costs.

Chase didn't particularly care about the strange looks from strangers.

But the Artifact spoke at a blistering pace, and every time a car horn blared on the street or a power drill whirred at a construction site, he'd miss what the Artifact had said—the words were coming out of his own mouth, yet even Chase didn't know what would come next until he actually heard them.

He had been on the verge of handing it over to Uncle Key, yet he'd been forced to suppress that urgency and patiently listen to every word the Artifact said, hoping to understand its operating patterns and hidden risks as thoroughly as possible.

Because he had to make sure that every Artifact he placed in Uncle Key's hands was, at the very least, safe.

"After you create a rumor and spread it, what happens next?" he had asked, still walking, as he left the subway station.

Who could have imagined that the "Rumor" Artifact would turn out to be such a chatterbox?

A single question seemed to have opened the floodgates.

The subway driver had certainly never asked his own mouth that question, and had never activated the Artifact, so he had no idea there could ever be a scene like this: the Artifact lacked the capacity to say so much all at once, so it had conscripted Chase's tongue and had been talking nonstop ever since, with no sign of stopping.

Don't be fooled by its low intelligence—the sheer amount of information it contained was absolutely not small.

"...It falls into four aspects. One, the generation of the rumor; two, the spread of the rumor; three, changes in the rumor's credibility; four, the consequences of the rumor. Each aspect is further divided into several subcategories based on a number of different situations. I will now begin with the first aspect..."

How to describe this feeling?

It was like someone looking at a PDF that was several hundred pages long—the kind that should have been printed as reading material—and reading it aloud to you at a breakneck speed. Using your own mouth. The feeling was bizarre, the volume of information enormous; lose focus for even a second and you'd miss what was said, and you couldn't ask for it to be repeated, because your mouth had been conscripted.

So Chase sat on the park bench, his upper face blank, his lower face very busy.

"...Under ideal circumstances, a rumor constructed from a blend of genuine information can spread rapidly within an environment and group suited to its propagation. However, it should be noted that a rumor may spread at this stage, but that does not mean everyone will necessarily believe it; at this point, everyone knows it is merely a rumor, and the possibility of it being disproved still exists.

"The shorter the rumor, the less distortion it undergoes in the course of spreading. Once it reaches a sufficient number of people in its original form—that is, once it surpasses the first variable—the rumor gains a certain degree of credibility... We can think of the environment in which the rumor exists as a system; once credibility reaches the second variable, the rumor, as a 'macro-theme' within the system, will generate quantum responses with multiple 'butterfly effects.'"

Chase very much wanted to tell it to speak plainly, but he couldn't say anything himself.

"Let's use an example," the Artifact finally spoke, from Chase's mouth, the words he had been waiting for.

"Suppose you release a rumor that says, 'Little Ming from Nest Elementary gets diarrhea when he eats people.'"

"Assume the true materials composing this rumor are: one, classmate Little Ming actually exists; two, Residents in the Nest occasionally eat people; three, Little Ming sometimes gets diarrhea."

...Right. Go back and remind the House Faction Hunters to bathe regularly.

"...The rumor is fairly short, and the Nest is an environment suited to its spread... Let's assume it smoothly reaches both variables of 'number of people it has spread to' and 'credibility.' What happens next?

"Multiple factors within the Nest that originally seemed unrelated will at this point become 'butterfly effects.' What is a 'butterfly effect'? It is precisely the initial condition that causes change

in a chaotic system, as in the butterfly effect.

"For example, suppose Little Ming has a sister, Little Mei. Little Mei originally eats Little Ming every Wednesday evening, but after hearing the rumor, she decides Little Ming isn't very clean, and so this Wednesday she doesn't eat him."

...Never mind the passersby—Chase, listening to the voice rising from his own mouth, felt very much as if he himself had gone mad.

"'Hungry Little Mei' thus becomes the first 'butterfly effect.'"

"The second 'butterfly effect': suppose a captured Hunter, in order to avoid being killed by the Resident who caught him, offers as a bargaining chip to design a battle royale arena for that Resident."

Chase's mouth and tongue had gone dry, but the Artifact didn't care about any of that.

"It's only an example, so for simplicity's sake, let's just use two 'butterfly effects.'"

"Hungry Little Mei comes out to find food and eats one of the arena's contestants. To make it up to the arena's owner, she hands Little Ming over to them.

"The arena owner, hoping to select the finest children, and inspired by the recent rumor, names the arena 'Nest Elementary'... And so, the outcome of this rumor is that a 'Nest Elementary' truly appears in the Nest."

Chase was momentarily stunned.

He had originally assumed the consequence of the rumor would be that "Little Ming gets diarrhea from eating people" would come true—the feeling, as it turned out, was like stepping into thin air.

"You see, the part of this rumor that can come true might be 'Little Ming gets diarrhea from eating people,' or it might be 'Little Ming eats people,' or it might be 'Nest Elementary exists'... The reason the last outcome emerged is that the 'butterfly effects' within the Nest environment steered the result toward 'Nest Elementary.'"

"If we swap in different 'butterfly effects,' the part that comes true could instead be 'Little Ming gets diarrhea from eating people.'"

Sure enough, the Artifact then went on to ramble through another example.

The result of using different "butterfly effects" was that Little Ming, after eating people, did start getting diarrhea.

In short, its operating pattern was: create a rumor — people hear the rumor — people believe the rumor — "butterfly effects" (if any) begin interacting with the rumor — and finally, the rumor comes true, or it doesn't.

...So, in order to make a rumor come true in the desired way, you'd need to narrow down the range of possible outcomes it could take—was that it?

By the time Chase arrived at this conclusion, his mouth had already finished talking through several more sentences.

If, before spreading a rumor, you laid out the right "butterfly effects" in the environment in advance—like planting foreshadowing—you might be able to steer the rumor toward whatever outcome you wanted...

He had barely thought about it for a few seconds before his mouth, busy as ever, had already moved on to a different thread—from theoretical applications to concrete implementation. Chase quickly pulled his attention back and listened for a while longer, until he suddenly heard himself say: "...Therefore, the rumors produced by each of 'Rumor's' previous hosts can be used as operational reference for the next host."

...Wait—did it mean he could look up the rumors that Wellesley had previously created?

"As long as the host does not delete them, every rumor is recorded and can be retrieved at a later date."

The Artifact paused there—its first pause—as if waiting for Chase's response.

"Tell me,"

Chase was finally able to speak with his own lips and tongue: "What was the last rumor before 'The Subway Serial Killer'?"

Given the command, the Artifact answered quickly, nearly making him bite his tongue.

"The 'Vulture' in the Nest is able to copy itself into a second version of its target human, and use that human's passage to enter the human world."

Chase's hands jerked and twisted together.

Another Resident trying to enter the human world...

No, no—that wasn't the point.

The point was, why create this rumor in the first place? Even if it came completely true, what would be the significance?

"Who created this rumor?" Chase confirmed during another pause from the Artifact.

"Wellesley."

It seemed Wellesley had wanted to conjure into existence a Resident capable of entering the human world. What was his purpose?

"And the date it was created?"

The date the Artifact reported was already more than three months ago.

Considering that a new rumor could only be created after each previous one had run its course and reached its conclusion, this was most likely the last rumor Wellesley had created before his death.

A rumor's conclusion could only end one of two ways: either it came true, or it quietly faded away on its own.

"Did this rumor come true?" Chase asked again.

"It came true just on November 17th," the Artifact answered.

That was... the day after Wellesley died.

The reason I said earlier that writing this story from an ensemble perspective excites me is exactly because I love the feeling of different storylines influencing and entangling with each other...

Think about it—if I were writing solely from Sydney Ginn's point of view, wouldn't the moment of discovering the rumor's contents be far less interesting this way? (And it would be hard for her to find out at all—what grounds would a solo operator Hunter have to learn the contents of a Key House Artifact?)

Chapter 43: Sydney Ginn's Original Plan and the Artifact

Of course... of course it's me.

There was never any reason to doubt it—the real Sydney Ginn was me all along—

The moment that thought surfaced, it was as though something that had been wound tight around Sydney Ginn suddenly came loose.

She collapsed to the ground involuntarily, buried her face in both hands, and burst into tears.

She wasn't sad, nor was she afraid—this bout of crying was closer to a release: the anxiety and suspicion from moments ago, the near-death memory of her desperate struggle, the pain and terror of having her throat torn open and her shoulder hacked through... it all seemed to pour out of her body with each sob, leaving behind only an exhausted, hollow Sydney Ginn.

By the time she stopped, the lingering echoes in the exhibition hall gradually faded, and the cold silence returned.

Everything that had happened in her memories left not a single trace now.

There was no blood on the floor, no fire axe, no gouges bitten into the ground by its blade. The artwork made of long wooden strips sat exactly where it had always been, undamaged, and naturally there were no splinters of broken wood embedded in her face, hands, or feet.

Her trail backpack had been tossed into a corner of the hall; Sydney Ginn walked over and dug out the long towel from inside—dry and soft, never soaked through by another version of herself's saliva.

In this world, no one but Sydney Ginn herself knew that she had died once tonight.

If the Resident, after killing her, had not gone on to melt the candle and alter the history in which she met Anthony, she would have remained forever on the cold floor of the underground exhibition hall, gradually becoming part of the Nest.

It was as though a thick, black fear had reached in and rattled her bones—Sydney Ginn gave a faint shiver.

She walked step by step toward the candle, her sneakers making soft, faint sounds against the floor.

Since all the history the Resident had copied had never come to pass, the candle before her had naturally never been touched—it was cool and hard under her fingers; in the shadow it cast, the flame slot was silent.

2026.5.19—a row of small characters rose from the surface of the candle.

Sydney Ginn yanked her hand back as if she'd been shocked.

She paused, then let out a wry laugh. Two tracks of memory had actually left her with a lingering wariness.

Though she owed her survival today entirely to this candle, the Resident's casual manipulation of history—melting it at will—had still shaken her considerably. After all, the Resident hadn't melted the candle to save her; if Sydney Ginn rashly plunged her own hand into history, who could say what unintended consequences might follow?

That being the case, she couldn't take the candle with her, and she didn't feel at ease using it either...

Sydney Ginn sighed and, after thinking it over for a moment, decided to leave it alone for now.

Honestly, looking at the candle inevitably brought the Resident who had copied her form back to mind—better to let her emotions settle first and figure out what to do with it later.

Besides, a candle that large wasn't going anywhere—if someone could actually carry this dozens-of-meters-long giant candle out of a windowless underground exhibition hall with its narrow staircases, then Sydney Ginn would have no choice but to tip her hat to them.

She picked up the trail backpack from the floor, patted the phone in her pocket—everything was there except for the hunting knife.

In this timeline, the hunting knife had been with Anthony the whole time; and after witnessing the scene of it plunging into her own neck, Sydney Ginn had no particular desire to get it back.

Anthony...

Her hatred for him had only grown sharper and more solid, until she wished it could turn into a blade and drive straight through his gut—the Resident was already gone, and every ounce of her fury now sank its teeth into that stalker.

Before she stepped into the elevator, she turned and looked back at the enormous candle in the distance.

"...The interlude is over," she murmured to herself.

Now, it was back to the original plan—go to Ninety-Ninth Street, get the Artifact there, and then deal with Anthony cleanly and swiftly when she got back. This time, Sydney Ginn would not let herself get distracted halfway and wander off course again.

Once she was out of the Museum of Modern Art, she realized that being copied by a Resident wasn't entirely a bad thing after all.

Originally, she had mentally prepared herself for nearly two days of walking before she would reach Ninety-Ninth Street.

Those two days of travel were, in plain terms, only about fifteen kilometers—the problem was that the paths in the Nest were treacherous, full of unexpected dangers at every turn, and Hopscotch was a perfect example of that.

But now, because she had hitched a ride in the taxi, the journey had been greatly shortened and many of the dangers and traps along the way avoided; with a bit of luck thrown in on top of that, Sydney Ginn had, unbelievably, already reached Ninety-Ninth Street half an hour later.

Standing beneath the street sign, she looked around first before taking out her phone to check the time.

November 17th, 2:12 AM.

She had entered the Nest on the evening of the 16th, before ten o'clock.

After listening to the full broadcast, she had then been held up for a long stretch by Hopscotch on Colorado Avenue—estimating roughly, she must have been copied by the Vulture Resident sometime after midnight.

In principle, a Vulture Resident should only be able to take on someone's appearance after that person had died—yet tonight Hopscotch had acted as though it were handing the creature an opportunity, and the Resident had forcibly copied her form while she was still alive...

No, no—that all belonged to the previous memory thread. In the current timeline, she had escaped the fate of being copied.

With its target lost, the Vulture Resident was probably still wandering around Colorado Avenue somewhere.

Forget it, it was all behind her now—Sydney Ginn pushed down the unsettling image from her mind and brought her attention back to what was in front of her.

Beneath the dark night sky, a staircase descended silently into the ground, swallowed by a mass of darkness.

At the top of the staircase stood a sign printed with the letter "D," marking this as the entrance to a subway station on the D Line. Looking down from the sidewalk, that dense blackness looked like solidified ink—a gaze aimed into it would simply break apart on its surface.

Sydney Ginn remembered the first time she had seen this staircase leading down to the subway station—she had hesitated for quite a while before finally daring to go down.

She took out her phone, turned on the flashlight, and shone it along the side wall of the staircase.

The wall where the station name should have been displayed was instead covered by a single line of large, crooked black characters: "Keep going down for a surprise."

Right—that was indeed what it said.

Good. That was the right phrase.

November was an odd-numbered month; in every odd-numbered month, the characters at this subway entrance read "Keep going down for a surprise," while in every even-numbered month they changed to "Keep going down for a hug."

When it said "surprise," it was safe to go down into the station—not only safe, but you could also retrieve an Artifact there. The Nest was, on occasion, unexpectedly honest. But when it said "hug," no one should ever go down.

Sydney Ginn still didn't know what would happen if someone went down during a "hug," and she hoped she would never find out.

She held up the flashlight and walked down the stairs step by step, passed through the cracked and broken ticket gates, and arrived on a platform lit only by a scattering of white lights.

Most of the platform was dim and murky, with a wall on one side and a wall on the other.

This was the only subway station Sydney Ginn had ever entered in the Nest, so she didn't know whether all Nest subway stations were like this—no tracks, no trains, both sides of the platform sealed off by walls.

At the center of the platform, several people turned their heads toward her.

"Hunter," said one of them, a person in a cap, sounding indifferent before looking away again.

"Yes," Sydney Ginn answered, lowering the phone flashlight slightly so it wouldn't shine in anyone's face. "Why are there so many people today?"

There were four people in total at the center of the platform, all Hunters; from the distances between them, they appeared to be in two pairs.

Sydney Ginn had come here several times and knew that this place wasn't obscure among Hunters—quite a few people would drop by from time to time to collect Artifacts.

Because so many people came, an order had already formed: Hunters generally went by first-come, first-served, took what they needed, and left, each keeping to their own business—yet this was still her first time running into a gathering of four people at once.

"Look," said a woman with a gentle face, tilting her chin forward. "Your timing is perfect—you've caught the vending machine restocking."

Every time there's a transition chapter it costs me a layer of skin—you wouldn't believe how long this chapter took me...

I'll be a little shameless and say this: I don't think the Artifact Reports is the kind of story you can skim through, because I bury information in every single chapter... which is also why it takes me an incredibly long time to write.

Chapter 44: Sydney Ginn Pays for Her Purchases, Obviously

Beneath a tangle of short, messy hair, a smooth expanse of bare flesh looked up to meet Sydney Ginn's gaze.

She managed to suppress the urge to sharply inhale.

Below the brow ridges were faint, smooth depressions that seemed to pass for eye sockets; there were no nostrils and no mouth. When it spoke, beneath its seamless nose, a patch of flesh bulged outward with each syllable—she couldn't stop worrying that it might bulge too high, then fall back and crease into folds, with a dark hollow sinking in at the center of each wrinkle.

Sydney Ginn sometimes really disliked her own imagination.

"So many customers today," the flesh pulsed in and out as it spoke, "don't rush, almost done loading. Lots of new stock came in today."

As it spoke, it loaded several cans of drinks into the dark interior of the vending machine.

When the soft-faced female Hunter had said "the vending machine is being restocked," Sydney Ginn hadn't expected that it would be a Resident doing the restocking.

The four of them had formed a semicircle that happened to block the Resident crouching on the ground, so it had given her quite a shock. Now, stepping closer for a better look, she found that the restocking process was actually quite convincingly done: beside the Resident sat several boxes, some empty, some still half-full; at the moment it was loading the drinks into the vending machine one can at a time.

Sometimes the Nest insisted on "realism" in the strangest of places—rather than loading drinks in one by one, why not first do something about that face?

The baseball-cap wearer's companion was a girl chewing gum, and she had already struck up a conversation with the Resident: "How often do you restock? How come I've never seen you before?"

"Depends on how well things sell," the Resident answered every question without hesitation. "The stock from the last few months wasn't moving, so there was no need to restock, which is why I haven't been around."

The last few months... Sydney Ginn thought about it—she had come by and looked, and indeed the selection had been pretty mediocre, hardly worth the trouble.

In the vending machine at this subway station, different Artifacts would appear at irregular intervals—each can of soda, each pack of snacks, was an Artifact with its own distinct function and varying expiration date. Whether you could buy something suitable was largely a matter of luck.

"What's new in stock today?" the soft-faced female Hunter asked.

"Oh, quite a lot," the Resident said enthusiastically. "The supplier changed—more than half of it is new product! I've put up the new product descriptions too; take a look and you'll know what's what."

The product descriptions it had just posted covered an entire wall.

The five of them exchanged glances; the baseball cap stepped forward first, said "we got here first," and was the first to walk over, illuminating the product descriptions with a flashlight, reading carefully.

The gum-chewing girl stood beside the vending machine, also securing her place first in line; the remaining three kept the customary few steps of distance from the two of them, as per the etiquette around the soda Artifacts.

"All done."

As the five of them waited with anticipation, the Resident finally closed the vending machine, not only taking out a key to lock it, but also picking up the empty cardboard boxes from the ground. "I'm heading off."

The gum-chewing girl's smile was sweet; she gave it a little wave. "Thank you, bye-bye."

Such a civil, harmonious exchange between a Resident and Hunters—Sydney Ginn hadn't seen one of those in quite a while.

Just as that thought crossed her mind, the Resident—already halfway out—stopped in its tracks, holding the empty cardboard boxes, and turned to look back at them.

Even after the baseball cap finished reading and the gum-chewing girl took her turn, it still stood there.

When Sydney Ginn couldn't help herself and stole a quick glance at it, the flesh on the Resident's face pulsed once.

"...Actually, I just remembered—our company is running a promotion, inviting lucky customers to try new products. You can take free samples."

Sydney Ginn quickly looked away and moved one step closer to the soft-faced female Hunter.

The gum-chewing girl seemed to have suddenly lost her hearing, absorbed entirely in reading the descriptions; not a single person turned their head toward the Resident.

"Anyone want to come?"

No one moved, no one looked at it, no one spoke.

"No one?"

All five Hunters seemed to hold their very breath; the baseball cap stood in front of the vending machine, shoulders drawn tight.

"Really no one? You know, opportunity knocks but once—"

The flesh on the Resident's face gave a sudden "pop" right next to Sydney Ginn's ear. "And it won't knock again."

She swallowed back a cry that had risen to her throat, staring fixedly at the floor, with no idea when the Resident had drawn close.

Do not respond—any competent Artifact Hunter would understand at this moment that responding was absolutely out of the question.

Aside from Sydney Ginn, the other four probably hadn't encountered a "restocking Resident" before either, and didn't know how to handle it.

But in those few brief exchanges just now, everyone had clearly reached the same conclusion and taken the same course of action—because Hunters, drawing on experience and instinct, needed to make probes and judgments in a split second.

After its first invitation, the simultaneous silence of all five had been exactly that—a "probe."

Watching and waiting was, in most situations, the safest way to probe.

From its next words—"No one?"—it was clear that the restocking Resident interpreted "no answer = not going," and all five Hunters caught that immediately.

On the other hand, if the Resident's next line had been "Everyone's interested?", then all five Hunters would have instantly realized it interpreted "no answer = wanting to go"; in that case, silence would naturally be the last thing to maintain—they would have had to deny it immediately.

The Nest and its Residents were treacherous and unpredictable, yet it was precisely because there remained even a thread of possibility for analysis, thought, and action that Artifact Hunters had endured as a profession through the ages.

"What a shame."

Those words pushed through the flesh and fell heavily into the hair at the back of the gum-chewing girl's head.

From Sydney Ginn's angle, she could see the Resident standing right behind the girl; that blank, featureless face was leaning forward, pressing into the girl's hair. She still had no idea when it had moved over there.

"Well then, I really am leaving now. No one wants to exchange phone numbers with me?"

A certain behavioral "consistency" often runs through a single Resident.

A Resident that interpreted silence as refusal on one question was unlikely to suddenly treat silence as consent on the next—and so, as the five of them held their breath in a suffocating silence, the restocking Resident retreated, seemingly regretful, step by step, disappearing into the shadows of the subway station entrance.

Several long seconds passed before Sydney Ginn finally let out the breath she had been holding in her chest.

"That gave me a fright,"

The other four relaxed as well; the girl started chewing her gum again and said, "I thought it was one of the harmless type of Residents."

"How long have you been doing this?" the man who had stayed silent the whole time immediately lectured her. "Don't you know Residents can be dangerous at any moment? It all just depends on whether they feel like coming after you. And you were chattering away with it just now!"

"And how long have you been at it? Have you even hit one year?"

The girl walked back from the product descriptions and stood beside her tall, slender companion, eyeing him sideways. "Do you know why I thought it was a harmless Resident? Do you know what the telltale signs of a harmless Resident are? You love playing teacher so much—is there a school paying you for that?"

"Hold on, no need to argue," the soft-faced female Hunter, seeing the two of them on the verge of a quarrel, quickly raised both hands to placate them. "It's not a matter of principle, and besides, the danger has passed. Didn't I talk to it too?"

"You did, and you were wrong too." The man wasn't buying his companion's argument.

"Who died and made you judge?" The girl flicked her hand, and a moment later a layer upon layer of enormous muscle swelled along her left arm, stretching her sleeve to the limit. "Watch how you talk to people next time."

"M&M Beans?" The man glanced at her arm and gave a cold laugh. "What House Faction are you from? You think you're the only one who's bought M&M Beans?"

M&M Beans were among the vending machine's products—the name was an abbreviation, the full name being "Machine Muscle." As the name implied, its general use wasn't hard to guess; simple, but effective.

It was popular among Hunters, especially female Hunters, though unfortunately it wasn't in stock very often. The most inconvenient thing about it was that once taken out of the Nest, it would expire within twenty-four hours.

The girl having M&M Beans on her said at least one thing: she had a place in the Nest where she could stash things—not particularly unusual, as most House Factions had a hideaway.

"Hear me out,"

Sydney Ginn stepped forward and positioned herself between the two of them, feeling that she had no choice but to smooth things over—these two had only clashed on a few lines of dialogue, no real grudge between them, they just needed a way to back down gracefully. Actually coming to blows in a place like this would benefit no one.

"Neither of you is actually wrong. I only discovered tonight that the Residents have been acting a bit unusual lately."

The others all looked at her.

The baseball cap had made their selection, pressed the product code, and asked, "What's going on?"

"You all know the 'Vulture' Resident, right? I just ran into it."

Smoothing things over might have only been a pretext; what Sydney Ginn really wanted was to use the Vulture incident to gauge the other Hunters' reactions and see if anyone could add to what she knew.

What she wanted most of all was to pour out everything she had been through to companions who were flesh and blood and could understand her experience—but she couldn't expose the existence of the Candlefall Artifact, and she also feared drawing their suspicion.

"Impossible."

The moment Sydney Ginn finished speaking, the man delivered his verdict. "You're not dead, so the Vulture can't take your form—that's common knowledge."

"That's exactly why I said their behavior is abnormal." Sydney Ginn was also getting a little irritated. "If you don't believe me, go check Colorado Avenue and see if there's a chalk-drawn hopscotch grid there."

The man said nothing more, and furrowed his brow.

"The changes and anomalies appearing in the Nest lately have indeed been more numerous and more frequent than before."

The baseball cap spoke her longest sentence yet, and only at this moment did Sydney Ginn suddenly realize that the person was actually a woman.

She was at least six feet tall, with broad, level shoulders and short hair; not only was her appearance hard to read, even her voice was a register lower than that of most women.

"I take it none of you are buying from the vending machine for the first time."

The baseball cap tossed the soda in her hand gently into the air and caught it again. "Generally speaking, what do you think something like this Artifact is worth?"

"Five hundred bucks?" Sydney Ginn guessed.

The things inside the vending machine tended to be like that: you had to buy them with real-world money, they weren't cheap, their functions were limited, their power modest, and their expiration dates shockingly short.

Which was exactly why Artifact Hunters had never turned into soda couriers running between Blackmoor City and the Nest.

"That used to be about right." The baseball cap smiled, and a long, narrow dimple appeared on the clean-lined lower half of her face. "I just paid by credit card. This one can of soda came to just over nine thousand dollars. But it was worth it."

The moment she finished speaking, the soft-faced female Hunter immediately strode toward the product descriptions; the flashlight swept two circles, and the female Hunter drew a low, sharp breath.

Since getting home, I haven't had a single decent night's sleep, keeping myself human every day on nothing but coffee and tea. Without caffeine, there would be no fraudulent gatherings of money in this world. Caffeine is my father, caffeine is my mother, without caffeine there would be no ne—

That was a close call, damn.

Oh, by the way, there's something I kept forgetting to mention—friends, I finally know what flavor of chips the Puppeteer is! (Yes, the reason I didn't say before is because I felt no flavor could possibly suit him.)

Want to know? To find out, please call our hotline at 25115222—free consultation, five yuan per minute, remember, 25115222.

Chapter 45: Sydney Ginn Pays Taxes and Launderers Money

The two groups of people who had already made their purchases still hadn't left, standing far apart on the dim platform, conversing in low voices.

Even without being able to hear what they were saying, Sydney Ginn could make a rough guess.

They were all House Faction Hunters; for the House Factions, the product description before them had fundamentally changed the meaning of the vending machine.

Artifact Hunters risked their lives to enter the Nest—when all was said and done, it was for one thing and one thing only: money.

In the past, the vending machine had been overlooked because its products were weak in effect and heavy in restrictions, offering little in the way of potential profit—take M&M Beans, for instance: they expired twenty-four hours after leaving the Nest, so who would pay a premium for something essentially disposable? Selling them at cost already required a wide network of connections and a circle of friends that included some desperate sucker in a pinch.

Now the vending machine's product restrictions remained—and had even grown more severe—but even Sydney Ginn, who had no House Faction, could see at a glance that the potential returns were nothing like what they used to be.

What a shame, though, because that only applied to House Factions.

She swept her flashlight across the product descriptions twice and found a picture of a blue plastic-bottle drink.

The soft-featured female Hunter, after finishing reading the description just now, had without a word bought a bottle of water and immediately muffled it into her backpack; it was only Sydney Ginn's sharp eyes that caught a flash of blue and identified the drink she'd bought.

Gatorade Sports Drink 500ml

Everyone knows that the threshold between life and death is like a great door—on this side of the door is the human world / the Nest, and once you step through, you either go to heaven or to hell.

(Just kidding—how could humans possibly go to heaven, hahaha)

In real life, people don't necessarily cross the threshold of life and death in one clean step; all sorts of unexpected situations arise that leave a person hovering on the boundary. For example, getting hit by a car, suffering a sudden stroke, being shot... in situations like these, you might discover: hey, between life and death, there's actually a precious window of time for emergency rescue.

It's like having one foot inside the door and one foot outside; you'd surely want the human-world side to hold on to you a little longer, wouldn't you?

If that window is a bit longer, giving doctors a little more time to fight for you, you might just survive; if that window is too short and the moment slips away, you're destined to grow cold.

This sports drink is specially suited for those hovering on the boundary between life and death—as if launching an assault on death's door itself! Remarkable! It cannot bring the dead back to life, but it can give you a little extra precious rescue time—so long as liquid can still be safely administered, every 1ml consumed increases the window by 3 seconds.

Disclaimer: This product has the effect of extending rescue time, but does not guarantee successful resuscitation; please defer to the attending emergency or operating physician for specifics.

Post-Nest Expiration: 4 hours

Price: 38,000 blades

Flavor: Blue-Green Lividity

Thirty-eight thousand blades for an Artifact with a post-Nest shelf life of only four hours—for a solo operator or a small House Faction, it was practically a guaranteed loss from the start. Without the network, information resources, manpower, and logistical support of a major House Faction, just finding a client willing to trust you completely was already next to impossible, and yet that was only the first of two difficulties; the second was even greater.

How would you actually deliver it?

Say a client's life is in danger, and their representative sends you an urgent notice at that very moment, telling you to get the Gatorade Artifact to them within ten minutes.

A solo operator would have to enter the Nest through their passage, make their way to a stash location or to the vending machine, retrieve the Artifact, then open a passage back to Blackmoor City... by the time they got back, the client would already be in the ground.

But a major House Faction was a different matter entirely.

Sydney Ginn didn't know the exact procedures and methods involved, but she'd overheard a few fragments here and there that might paint the broader picture—when major House Factions encountered time-critical situations, they dispatched helicopters.

The thought made Sydney Ginn instinctively glance back at the two silhouettes deep on the platform, still bent close together and whispering. They'd bought so decisively—their House Factions behind them must be sizable operations that had no trouble moving product; the cards they used to pay were almost certainly issued by their House Factions.

Ah, must be nice, she thought, turning back with a grimace.

Her credit card limit wasn't even thirty-six thousand—though Sydney Ginn had made decent money from her broadcasts, when it came to this particular problem, she couldn't help but envy the advantages of House Factions: all her income was under the table, nothing that could appear on paper, nothing that could become personal assets, nothing that did any good for her credit score.

House Faction Hunters were a different story.

Their income was all paid out by the House Faction, and could be classified under any number of headings—salary, bonuses, profit shares, commissions, allowances, reimbursements—not only completely aboveboard, but they could even pay a token amount of taxes to keep the IRS from knocking on their door.

And the House Factions' income itself?

"Me? Besides doing accounting and finance," Amber had explained to Sydney Ginn once, plain as day, "I'm also responsible for laundering money for the House Faction."

Sydney Ginn let out another deep sigh.

She had already spotted what she wanted to buy.

The reason she still hadn't rushed over to buy it—standing here foolishly thinking about money laundering and tax returns instead—was partly because she was the type to let her mind wander and spiral into idle thoughts, but mostly for one critical reason: her credit card was over its limit.

Sydney Ginn glanced around, her gaze settling on the soft-featured female Hunter, then, after two seconds, shifting back to the two figures in baseball caps still sitting on the stairs deep in conversation.

Worth a try, she encouraged herself; asking doesn't cost anything. The worst they can say is "no," right?

As she approached the foot of the stairs, one of the baseball caps looked up.

"What's up?"

Sydney Ginn had a nagging feeling she might be embarrassing herself. "Um... excuse me, are you House Faction Hunters?"

The gum-chewing girl gave a nod. "Yeah, why?"

She seemed quite fond of her baseball cap companion—now that her left arm had recovered, the two of them were sitting shoulder to shoulder, and they looked considerably closer than the other pair.

"I'm a solo operator—no House Faction." Sydney Ginn cleared her throat. "The thing is... with the vending machine, I haven't bought anything yet. I've got my eye on something that would be really useful to me, and I can't afford to wait; I need to get my hands on it right away."

The two of them looked at her, waiting for her to continue.

With no way to back out now, she steeled herself and pressed on: "The problem is my card doesn't have enough credit left... I was wondering if you'd be willing to swipe your card for me? I have savings on my debit card, but it doesn't have an NFC chip, so the vending machine can't read it..."

Here they were, in a place as surreal as the Nest, and yet she was discussing something as mundane and pedestrian as this—Sydney Ginn had the nagging feeling that something was off.

Afraid they might misunderstand, she quickly added: "I do have cash, I'm not broke!"

Beneath the shadow of the baseball cap, a narrow dimple suddenly appeared on the half of the face she could see. "You have cash on you?"

Sydney Ginn was in despair. "No, the cash is back in Blackmoor City..."

"So you're asking to borrow money?" The baseball cap's grin widened further, a flash of white teeth gleaming in the dim light.

"The way things stand... it, it seems like... yeah..."

The gum-chewing girl had stopped chewing altogether, mouth half-open as she stared at her—perhaps she had never had a stranger try to borrow money from her inside the Nest before.

Sydney Ginn also felt the situation had gotten thoroughly out of hand, and stumbled over her words: "Well, of course, it's not like I couldn't come back in again, but my passage—ah, that's not convenient to explain..."

The baseball cap suddenly burst out laughing.

When the laughter died down, she took off her cap and reached up to ruffle her head of wavy, short hair, tilting her face up into the dim platform light.

It was the first time Sydney Ginn had gotten a clear look at her, and for a brief moment she felt her thoughts go blank.

Though she was probably also in her mid-twenties, she looked like an androgynous youth; behind waves of tousled hair were a pair of narrow, deep-set blue eyes, like the clear sky mirrored between Arctic glaciers.

The gum-chewing girl glanced at Sydney Ginn, shrugged, and put into words what her expression had already been saying: "I knew it."

"What?" Sydney Ginn snapped back to attention, mortification rushing back doubled. "Never mind, it's fine, I'll just come back in again—after all, if it were me, I wouldn't casually lend money to a stranger either..."

The baseball cap—though she'd taken the hat off, Sydney Ginn still didn't know her name—stood up and pulled a wallet from her back pocket.

"My driver's license and my card," she said, holding up two cards toward Sydney Ginn. "Give me your driver's license, your credit card, and your phone."

"Oh? My phone too?"

"Of course. How else would I know you're carrying a real ID?"

The gum-chewing girl nodded emphatically. "These days, the only things you absolutely have to get back, besides your own children, are your phone."

The baseball cap's terms were reasonable enough: the driver's license went without saying—she naturally needed to know who she was lending money to. The credit card was an extra form of

collateral, in case Sydney Ginn didn't pay her back or ended up dying in the Nest; and besides, she'd only asked for the phone, not the passcode.

Even so, Sydney Ginn hesitated for a long time before finally handing over her phone as well.

The baseball cap looked down at the phone screen, lit up at her touch, and in the glow of it, that clean face paused for a moment. She looked at the hundred-plus filthy messages still frozen on the screen, expression unreadable, said nothing, and slipped the phone into her pocket.

For some reason, Sydney Ginn felt a shame like being stripped of her clothes.

"This is my address and number," she said, seeming to have already forgotten about the messages; she wrote Sydney Ginn a note, then asked: "Is there anything on your phone you need to make note of? Like a phone number?"

Anthony's number was already etched into her memory; Sydney Ginn shook her head.

"Sydney Ginn, right?" The baseball cap glanced at the driver's license, then back at her, and smiled. "Not often you see an ID photo that looks just as good as the person."

Sydney Ginn thanked the two of them profusely for a while, and they exchanged some necessary information. Throughout the whole process, she felt as though she were drifting through fog, unable to believe she had actually borrowed a card from a stranger—a stranger, at that? And in the Nest, of all places?

She'd never quite worked up the nerve to look at the baseball cap's driver's license; it wasn't until Sydney Ginn was back in front of the vending machine that she quietly glanced down at it.

London Moon—even the name was androgynous.

Sydney Ginn took a deep breath, pulled her attention back to the vending machine, pressed a few numbers, and held the credit card up to the reader.

A confirmation that 12,000 blades had been successfully charged flashed up on the screen; with a thud, a can of soda dropped into the slot below.

Sydney Ginn reached down and picked it up, tucking it into her backpack.

She straightened up, turned her head, and found herself meeting London Moon's gaze.

She hadn't tried to hide the can, and it was the only purple item; under the light of the vending machine, the purple was vivid and unmistakable. Anyone who had read the product descriptions should know that the purple soda had exactly one purpose.

Killing people.

How did I discover the puppeteer chips? A colleague from Shenzhen told me there was an imported chip at the Olé supermarket—the best chips she'd ever had in her life—and naturally I was curious, so she gave me two packs.

Indeed very good—whether they're the best is still up for debate—but one of the flavors! In your mouth! Actually had the texture of popping candy!

I took a look: the bubbly serrano chilli flavor—translated, isn't that basically "bouncy little chili peppers"?!

I still have pictures on my phone; I'm thinking maybe I should post them in the comments section of the apocalypse chapter...

Chapter 46: Sydney Ginn's Grape Soda

The most precious thing in the world is something that can pull a life back from the brink of death.

Even if it costs millions, there is never a shortage of people willing to pay; even the slightest increase in the odds of survival draws crowds scrambling for it—like that bottle of sports drink.

But erasing a person's life is cheap.

The things that kill are rarely worth much.

Sydney Ginn glanced once more at the purple can of soda in her hand.

If all she wanted was to kill someone, a knife would do the job—and even if she couldn't do it herself, twelve thousand would be more than enough to hire someone desperate enough.

But using the methods of the mortal world meant bearing the risks and consequences of the mortal world, and Blackmoor City was, after all, a real society with rules and laws. What if someone traced Anthony's death or disappearance back to her?

Not even Nest Residents had managed to catch her—it would be the height of irony if she ended up in a human prison.

She needed to handle this cleanly, without leaving so much as a trace of suspicion on herself—she still had plenty of money and plenty of life left to enjoy.

The real reason this can of soda was so valuable wasn't simply that it could cause a person's death—to be honest, she wasn't even certain that what it caused could properly be called death.

But she was certain of one thing: using an Artifact to deal with Anthony would leave her with no loose ends.

At the very moment Sydney was staring absently at the soda, the small text on its bottom ticked over from "COUNTDOWN: 6 HRS 25 MIN" to "COUNTDOWN: 6 HRS 24 MIN."

It had a total shelf life of only eight hours, and she had already burned through an hour and a half; what infuriated her most was that after those first few calls, she had spent the rest of the time waiting.

Had Anthony been thrown off too—not expecting her to reach out to him first?

Just as that thought crossed her mind, the disposable phone she had just bought buzzed and vibrated on the table. Sydney swept a glance at the screen and snatched it up immediately.

"Anthony?"

There was a one-or-two-second silence on the other end.

Then the voice spoke, casual as you please: "Ah, it really is you."

"Of course it's me—didn't I leave you a voicemail?"

"You suddenly said your phone got lost and told me to call this number. Pretty suspicious." Anthony's delivery was unhurried, but his tone carried something like a rodent sniffing for scents in the shadows. "...When did you lose it?"

Sydney thought for a moment, then named a time before he had started posting her number on adult websites. "Yesterday morning."

Anthony paused.

When he spoke again, his tone had warmed a degree: "What made you suddenly reach out? It's been so long..."

"Can we meet in person?" Sydney asked, getting straight to the point. "At the bar where we first met?"

Choosing a public place was meant to put Anthony at ease about showing up—he would surely worry that she had brought people along to rough him up.

"Is something the matter?" The stalker was, predictably, rather cautious.

In that moment, Sydney summoned every romantic-drama heroine she had ever watched on screen, borrowing their light, earnest voices to say: "I... I didn't like the way things ended between us. I think there may still be room for us to talk—it doesn't have to come to this. Whatever it is you want, we can sit down and discuss it properly..."

Were there really women that foolish in the world?

After being bombarded with calls in the dead of night, subjected to endless streams of curses and threats to "have you killed right now," would anyone actually be stupid enough to sit down for a calm chat with their stalker?

Sydney didn't think so—but Anthony apparently did. Or at least, he wanted Sydney to be exactly that kind of woman.

"Right now?" Something restless and eager crept into Anthony's voice; even through the phone, it made her skin crawl. "I'll need at least an hour before I can get away..."

Sydney said through clenched teeth: "No problem. I'll wait for you."

She hung up, set the phone and the purple can side by side on the table in front of her, and stared at them steadily for a moment.

At the next table, a group of men and women suddenly burst into loud laughter; they looked like coworkers out for a drink after work, raising their glasses and clinking them together in the air.

A waitress came over to the table, smiling. "So? Is the person you're waiting for coming?"

"A little while yet." Sydney pulled several Franklin-faced bills from her purse and handed them over along with the purple can. "As we discussed—when he arrives, I'll be counting on you."

The waitress stared at the cash, visibly startled by the amount of the tip, and looked half-disbelieving. "Are you sure?"

Sydney leaned slowly back in her chair and smiled at her.

"...I'm sure."

It was approaching nine o'clock, and the bar was gradually filling up.

The smell of alcohol mingled with perfume and the waft of tobacco that billowed in every time the door opened, spreading through the haze of light.

When the countdown had dwindled to three hours and forty-one minutes and Sydney was beginning to weigh whether to fall back on her contingency plan, Anthony finally pushed open the bar door—his gaze swept the room, quickly located his target, but he didn't come over right away.

He stood at the entrance and took his time looking over every patron in the bar before sauntering over and dropping himself into the seat across from Sydney with a thud.

"You look exhausted," he said by way of greeting, putting on a show of concern. "Things not going well lately? I haven't been sleeping well either—I think about you all the time."

Sydney considered herself fairly worldly, but faced with this particular brand of shamelessness—utterly devoid of self-awareness—she was still too stunned to find a single word.

"You know," Anthony said, rapping the table with one hand, "before I came, I tried calling your lost phone."

Before Sydney could react, he was already saying with righteous indignation: "Just like I thought—someone picked it up. How can you find someone's phone and just keep it?"

"Wait, someone answered?" Sydney asked quickly.

"Yeah, a guy," Anthony said.

London Moon's voice was lower than most women's—it had indeed made him mistake her for a man; but if she had answered the phone, it meant London Moon and the others were back in Blackmoor City.

"I told him: how much do you want to give my girlfriend her phone back?"

The feeling that came over Sydney at that moment was like visiting the home of a socialite, slipping off her shoes at the door, and discovering she was wearing a sock with a hole in the toe.

"She—he, what did he say?" She dragged a hand roughly down her face and asked.

She had come here today to kill someone, yet right now she wanted nothing more than to hang herself from the rafters first.

"You have no idea how greedy he was!" Anthony said, outraged. "He said, 'Twelve thousand, and I'll give it back'—can you believe it? I got angry right then and wanted to threaten him a bit, scare him—"

"...And then?"

"The guy laughed and hung up." Anthony leaned in as he said it, consolingly. "Don't worry—if you need me to, I'll keep calling until we get your phone back."

Sydney lowered her head and was quiet for a few seconds before sitting back up straight.

Before answering, she raised her hand toward the waitress as a signal, then turned her gaze back to Anthony's face.

Studying him the way one might examine a newly discovered insect, she looked at Anthony and said quietly: "Mm. Bombarding people with harassing calls is indeed something you excel at."

If Anthony had argued back or flown into a rage, that would at least have shown he had some capacity for shame.

He only blinked for a moment, then smiled and said: "I knew you'd hold a grudge. And I'll admit, I did go a bit too far... because I've never cared about anyone the way I care about you."

The waitress came over carrying a tray and set a glass of ice in front of each of them.

With a sharp hiss, she pulled the tab on the soda can and poured half of it into Sydney's glass; thick white foam floated on the surface of the purple liquid.

Just as she was about to pour some for Anthony as well, he reached out and covered the top of his glass with his hand.

"Is that your soda?" Anthony looked at the purple can on the tray and gestured for the waitress to set it down. He picked it up and turned it over in his hands a few times, then said to Sydney: "I've never seen this brand before... you always have the strangest things."

Reluctant as he was to admit it, Anthony had a kind of instinct—it was that very instinct that had made him single Sydney Ginn out from a whole bar full of people.

"It's imported," Sydney said, not wanting the Artifact to stay in his hands too long. She extended hers toward him. "It's quite good, actually—want to try some?"

"No thanks, you have it." Anthony pushed the can back to her side of the table and turned to the waitress. "A gin and tonic, please."

Sydney gave nothing away, and pushed the soda can off to one side, as if it were of no consequence.

Once the gin and tonic had been brought over, Anthony spoke again: "So you reached out to me today..."

"There are a few things I wanted to say to you."

Anthony took a sip of his drink and showed no urgency about finding out what those things were. He glanced at the glass of soda and said: "Drink up—don't you like it?"

Sydney looked down at the soda and brought it to her lips.

Anthony held his own glass and watched her over the rim; she opened her mouth, let the cold liquid slide down her throat, and swallowed.

The moment she swallowed, Anthony seemed to relax. He watched the soda level drop and said with a smile: "I'll have some in a bit—haven't seen it before. What did you want to say?"

Sydney set down her glass and said, slowly: "You have a mental problem."

Anthony's face went suddenly cold.

"I don't know whether it's a congenital defect or whether your environment turned you into something twisted. No one may have said this to you before, but I'm telling you today: you are scum.

"You believe the world—women especially—owes you something, that it's been unfair to you, that others have taken what should rightfully be yours. Why do I have money when you don't? Why won't I be with you? For someone as self-absorbed as you, rejection is the gravest of insults... and so you do everything in your power to harass and retaliate against me, yet you're too cowardly and pathetic to do anything but post my number on websites."

Anthony froze, his face flushing red.

Sydney gave a small smile, picked up her glass, and drained the soda in one go. "What you've gotten today is exactly what you deserve."

"What?" he asked blankly.

"I'm leaving," Sydney said, rising to her feet and stepping out from her side of the table.

"Wait—" Anthony leapt up immediately, reaching out to grab her arm. "Finish what you were—"

As he drew close, Sydney gently blew a breath of air toward his face.

A rich, sweet smell of grape bloomed in the air between them.

"People are watching," she said softly. "What do you think you're doing?"

Anthony let go, reluctantly. His eyes drifted to Sydney's seat and landed on the handbag she had left there; his cheek muscles twitched into a smile, and he sat back down.

He had misread the situation—Sydney was only going to the restroom.

She stood beside the sink, neither using the toilet nor washing her hands, drawing the gaze of a blonde woman nearby. The blonde was a little drunk; she looked Sydney up and down, then smiled and asked: "Why are you wearing rain boots?"

Sydney was in a good mood; she tapped her toes on the floor a few times like a tap dancer, showing her, and smiled back: "The forecast said rain."

When she felt enough time had passed, she walked back out and returned to her table. The chair at the side of the table was empty—no one there.

The seat was soaking wet, a large pool of purple liquid dripping steadily down to the floor. A puddle had already collected on the ground, as if someone had carelessly knocked over a can of soda—or two.

Sydney Ginn stepped into the puddle, liquid splashing up onto her shoes. She bent down and picked up her bag, then grabbed the soda can from the table.

On her way out, she nodded farewell to the waitress.

"My friend already headed out," she said with an apologetic smile. "I accidentally knocked over a drink just now..."

"No worries, don't give it a second thought!" the waitress said cheerfully. "I'll go mop it right up."

The part I was most proud of in yesterday's chapter, besides London Moon's name, was also a gate-raid — I wonder if anyone spotted its real-world counterpart? It's Gatorade!

Sigh, I need someone to set up the punchline for me.

Chapter 47: The Strange Thing Sydney Ginn Had Overlooked

The last time she had seen London Moon was no more than a day ago; Sydney Ginn hadn't expected the two of them to meet again so soon—in fact, barely half an hour after Anthony dissolved into soda.

Why, you ask?

Well, as that girl named Joy Jo had said, the only things people absolutely had to get back these days were their own children—and their phones.

Sydney Ginn had no children, so all she could say was that without her phone, it felt like she'd actually lost a piece of her soul.

"Oh, so it's you in person this time?" London Moon laughed softly when the call connected.

There was really no need to keep reminding her of that embarrassing business, whether directly or in hints. Even without reminders, she could remember every mortifying incident for at least ten years—and they always had a habit of barging into her mind in the middle of the night, chasing away all hope of sleep.

"I can pay you back now. Are you free tonight?"

London Moon was quiet for a second. "Where?"

Sydney Ginn gave her the address of the Between the Backlights bar, and heard London Moon say, "That's not far from me."

She wanted to ask whether London Moon lived nearby, but worried that might come across as fishing for intelligence on a Hunter's whereabouts, so she held back—and before she could say anything, London Moon added, "I just finished a handoff with a client. I'll head over."

Must be nice—one trip into the Nest and straight back out with money in hand. Meanwhile, Sydney had gone in and come out twelve thousand in the hole.

Perhaps it was because that thought hung over her head like a storm cloud, occupying most of her attention; or perhaps it was knowing she was back in Blackmoor City and no longer needed to stay on constant alert—whatever the reason, by the time she walked into Between the Backlights, she still hadn't realized she'd made a terrible mistake.

"Don't move!"

A sharp shout came at her, startling Sydney Ginn the moment she stepped through the door.

She looked up and found that every Hunter in the bar had risen to their feet, every single one of them staring at her with drawn, hostile tension; a few had even dropped a hand to their waist, clearly ready to draw at any moment.

"What—what's going on?"

Sydney Ginn froze mid-step, not daring to move, and looked around the bar in bewilderment. "What's wrong with all of you? What's wrong with me?"

Saying everyone had stood up wasn't quite accurate—there was one person in the whole bar who was still seated at the counter, brim of her baseball cap pulled down to hide the quiet laughter beneath it.

"What do you think you're doing?" The shar-pei-faced bartender held up a bottle, looking ready to smash it down as a weapon at any moment. "You walk in here with an Artifact in active state—what exactly is that supposed to mean?"

Sydney Ginn looked around at everyone, then glanced down at the half-empty soda can in her hand, then looked back up at everyone again—and it dawned on her.

"Oh, this—no, it's not—"

She panicked. She was just about to set the soda down when someone barked another "Don't move!" at her, and of course she froze again, left with no choice but to explain: "I'm not trying to hurt anyone with it—I did use it—but it has nothing to do with any of you, I wasn't going to use it on you! I just forgot I was holding it and carried it the whole way here."

Even if Artifacts were nearly indistinguishable from ordinary objects in appearance, when one was placed in front of experienced Hunters, it would scratch at something like a sixth sense—especially an Artifact in an active state.

It occurred to Sydney Ginn, belatedly, that what she'd just done was probably about on par with charging into an airport carrying a gun.

"...She's a regular," the bartender said, hesitating, setting down the bottle and addressing the room.

"Someone actually forgot they were holding an Artifact?" A middle-aged man sounded unconvinced.

It was at this point that London Moon finally deigned to lend her support.

She swiveled her stool around unhurriedly and said, "It's true. When she was buying the Artifact, she ran out of money and actually asked a complete stranger standing nearby to lend her some."

"How would you know?" A woman slowly moved her hand away from her waist, not yet sitting down.

"I was the stranger." London Moon gave Sydney Ginn a loose, casual wave. "Come on, pay me back."

Under the eyes of a bar full of Hunters, Sydney Ginn slunk over to the counter in a few quick, sheepish steps—but the matter wasn't quite over yet.

A few Hunters who still weren't reassured drifted closer, surrounding her at varying distances, eyes on her and the soda can. "How does that Artifact work? What does it do?"

It wasn't out of the question that some of them already knew and were simply testing whether she'd tell the truth.

But Sydney Ginn hadn't been planning to lie anyway.

"After you drink a few big mouthfuls and your mouth has taken on enough of the grape flavor, you blow a breath at the target's face as quickly as you can."

"And then?"

"Then the target turns into grape soda." Sydney Ginn said it plainly. She sat down on a barstool, lifted one foot—clad in a rain boot—and pointed at it. "I figured you'd need a huge amount, so I even wore rain boots specially—see, look. Turns out it's only about one or two cans' worth."

"You just...killed someone?" a Hunter she didn't know asked.

"Watch what you say." Even in a room full of Hunters, Sydney Ginn wasn't about to admit to that in public. "I said I blew a breath at a target. I never said anything about killing anyone."

The moment she put it that way, several of the other Hunters actually seemed to relax a little; a few pairs of eyes drifted toward the soda can, a faint gleam flickering in them.

"If they turn into soda, wouldn't someone see?" an old man asked.

Sydney Ginn raised one finger and said, "No. After you blow the breath, it takes effect in the first moment the target isn't being watched by any human eyes. It's over in an instant."

Clothes, shoes, phone—nothing was left behind. But that particular detail wasn't something she could say outright either.

"How much is left?" Someone took two steps closer. "And what's the expiration?"

"About half left, and the expiration—" Sydney Ginn suddenly understood what was happening. "You want to buy it?"

Everyone present was an expert; even though the purple soda was an Artifact making its first known appearance, assessing its function and value took no more than ten or so minutes.

Considering the expiration was less than three hours away—and the longer they haggled, the less she'd get for it—Sydney Ginn simply sold the remaining half-can to the first Hunter who decided to buy. Whatever else could be said about it, she'd at least come out three or four thousand less in the red.

"I never drank any of it myself," she said warmly, pocketing the money. "Drink away with confidence! It tastes pretty good—might be a little flat by now, though."

The Hunter gave her a look, an expression on his face that defied easy translation, then took the soda and hurried out the door.

"I hope the rest of what you owe me, you're not planning to scrape together on the spot," London Moon said from beside her.

"Of course not," said Sydney Ginn. She turned around, though she couldn't quite bring herself to meet London Moon's eyes, and dug around in her bag with her head down, producing an envelope. "Twelve thousand—count it."

The hand that took the envelope had long, slender fingers with short, rounded, clear nails.

"...Do you have strong objections to electronic transfers?" London Moon tapped the envelope lightly and asked.

"I haven't found anyone willing to help me launder money yet, so it's all cash at home." Sydney Ginn watched that hand of hers, which seemed to carry a certain strength. "If you know someone suitable, put in a word for me."

She didn't know why, but London Moon always seemed to be laughing—at their first meeting, she had assumed London Moon was someone of few words.

Sydney Ginn had also assumed London Moon was the type to pocket money without so much as glancing at it, but to her surprise, London Moon tipped all the bills out onto the counter and slowly tucked them back into the envelope one by one.

"What are you doing?"

London Moon, her cap now removed, turned her eyes toward Sydney Ginn without warning—those eyes were an astonishing blue, like a sky frozen beneath Arctic ice and snow, like a sea burning in extreme cold, so clear they seemed never to have fallen into the mortal world at all.

All worldly things—even something as fundamental as gender—seemed to have nothing to do with London Moon; and yet here she was, holding up a banknote.

Only after she had looked it over carefully and set it aside did she say, "...Seven. Of course I have to look properly. How am I supposed to know you haven't slipped in any counterfeits?"

Where would anyone even get counterfeit bills these days.

Sydney Ginn simply ordered her a drink and let her serve as a bill-checker in peace; London Moon smiled and said to the shar-pei-faced bartender, "By the way—this is her. She's the one who personally encountered the Vulture."

Hm? Vulture?

The bartender nodded and said to Sydney Ginn, whose attention had just sharpened, "Just a few hours ago, a House Faction put out a message to me asking for information about the Vulture. You can call and talk to them—what kind of compensation you're after is something you can negotiate."

He wrote something on a slip of paper and handed it to Sydney Ginn.

"Chase Monroe?" She thought it over and said, "Never heard of them. Are they a Hunter? Which House Faction?"

The bartender stared at her for a second or two. "No, not a Hunter... You don't know who Chase Monroe is?"

"Should I?" Sydney Ginn was even more at a loss than he was.

"Well, you don't have a House Faction," the bartender said, graciously finding a reason on her behalf, waving a hand. "No need to keep track of people inside the factions anyway. Just make sure you speak properly when the time comes and don't get on their bad side. If Chase Monroe is reaching out in person, this must be important—otherwise it's usually a Key House Faction Hunter who contacts me."

"Key House Faction," London Moon put in, though her tone gave nothing away. "...Thirty-one."

Important... Sydney Ginn turned the word over in her mind.

The Vulture Resident's behavior had been strange, and had become more dangerous, but in terms of importance, it didn't seem to quite rise to the level of requiring a major faction figure to come forward and personally ask around—let alone someone who, from what the bartender was implying, was second-in-command of Key House Faction.

What was it that made the Vulture matter so much?

Sydney Ginn glanced at the time on her phone—those hundred-plus messages had long since been deleted, vanishing along with any trace of Anthony's existence—it was now November 18th, 10:23 PM.

She had encountered the Vulture Resident in the early hours of yesterday morning, and already today a House Faction was asking questions.

Marveling at how well-informed the major House Factions were, she thought to herself that there must be more behind the Vulture than she knew.

Had something happened recently in the Hunter community?

Sydney Ginn pondered for a while, then tried to probe the bartender with some indirect questions, but everything he could tell her was something she already knew—"Something recent? Nothing especially worth mentioning. The biggest thing has been Wellesley dying. You were right here the day it made the news, weren't you."

...Wellesley?

Sydney Ginn stood frozen with both hands wrapped around a glass of plain cola she'd just ordered, mouth half-open, momentarily unable to believe she had let such a glaring anomaly slip right past her.

Well—she had just barely escaped from the whole ordeal of the true-and-false Sydney Ginn with her life, and her nerves had still been rattled, her mind unsettled; overlooking something was perfectly understandable...

When she had woken up on the museum floor, that Resident had been watching history inside the candle.

To be precise, what it had been watching at the time was the history inside the candle concerning Wellesley.

But once it had copied her form, when it touched the candle, what appeared should have been Sydney Ginn's history—so why had Wellesley appeared?

And it must have been important, because the Resident had been completely absorbed in it.

What connection did she have to Wellesley? What could Wellesley possibly have to do with her?

She'd have to go back and look at the candle to find out, wouldn't she?

"What's wrong?" London Moon glanced at her. "You suddenly look very despairing."

"I... I might have to make another trip into the Nest," said Sydney Ginn, and just thinking about having to jump off a building again, she could practically hear the blood draining from her face.

Isn't there any way to do this without going back into the Nest, she thought desperately, pressing her fingers hard against her temples.

That history the Resident had been watching at the time... it seemed to have been from May.

Right—she remembered how a long stretch of candle had melted into what looked like a lake of candle tears; and there, in that "lake" not far from the Resident, was the moment from the night she'd met Anthony—the fragment where a bodyguard had reversed a car into the back door of the bar.

That was a new piece of history, brought about by the Resident's own actions, and also the only version of that history that had actually come to pass.

Sydney Ginn snapped her head up.

She grabbed her phone and quickly found Amber in her contacts list. After a few rings, Amber picked up on the other end: "Hello, Sydney?"

"The incident in May where a car crashed into the bar—you remember that, right?" Sydney Ginn got straight to the point. "Did you hear anything afterward about that bodyguard motorcade?"

Amber paused and didn't answer immediately. "Why are you suddenly asking about this?"

"...You already know," Sydney Ginn realized.

"No—I wouldn't say I know." Amber sounded somewhat reluctant, and said, "Well... I wasn't trying to keep it from you forever. I mentioned what happened that night to the House Faction, just briefly—I didn't think it was any big deal myself—but after a while, our House Faction's Hunter Director came to find me."

Amber took a breath and continued: "He told me to keep that night's events confidential and not to breathe a word to anyone. Even though I didn't know much, and I couldn't see why secrecy was even necessary... but that was the House Faction's wishes, so I had no choice but to go along with it."

This was the single most important reason Sydney Ginn had no desire to join a House Faction: her own actions would be dictated by others. On what grounds?

She didn't even know who the second-in-command of Key House Faction was, so she naturally had no idea who the Morgan House Faction's Hunter Director might be, and simply asked: "Who's your Hunter Director?"

"Taylor Ford," Amber said.

Her tone was utterly flat, which for a moment left Sydney Ginn unable to tell whether Amber was simply used to it or actually didn't know how renowned a name "Taylor Ford" was in Hunter circles.

...Since when had Taylor Ford joined Morgan House Faction?

While Sydney Ginn was still in shock, Amber seemed to misread her silence and said, "You're not thinking of going to Taylor Ford about this, are you? He won't tell you anything. Besides, our House Faction is in complete chaos today—everyone's running around—he's about to lead a team into the Nest very soon..."

"What happened?" Sydney Ginn instinctively asked, following the thread.

"A squad our faction sent into the Nest last week somehow got completely wiped out—not a single one has come back yet. The squad leader, someone named Jonah, is only known to still be alive, but he needs emergency rescue, and if it waits any longer it'll be too late... A woman who had just come out of the Nest—I forget her name—came and told our faction."

Friends, this chapter is going up early today because I need to take my cat to the vet soon—she's been losing fur in a strange way lately, which has me worried...

Didn't expect that before I could even squeeze out a bonus chapter, it's already time to go live. Yes, tomorrow—the 29th. I really can drag things out...

May I trouble all you dear readers to spread the word about the launch (!) I'm planning to try my best and aim for 20 first-time subscribers to start. Our biggest virtue is that we're not greedy.

I'll subscribe one myself, rally my editor into subscribing one, and then family and close friends—hmm, that still leaves 17 people to win over...

Once I get back from the vet (!) later, I'll write a launch message—there's quite a bit of rambling I actually want to ziang a ziang about.

Chapter 48 — It's on the shelves, and here I am perched on one of them, with some feelings to share.

Think about it — it's only been forty-some days since Artifact launched, just over a month.

I actually never expected that I'd be riding such a rollercoaster...

Ensemble writing is at least three times harder (I calculated this in my white lab coat, repeatedly pouring green liquid in a laboratory), and the audience is at least three times smaller (same methodology — very scientific), and I'd actually mentally prepared myself for all of that.

Or rather, I thought I had mentally prepared myself for it.

Right when I first launched the story, I was still living under the hallucinations and momentum left over from my last novel, and when I looked out, it was like I could still see a garden in full bloom — ghosts of it, anyway.

(I know that one wasn't exactly a massive hit either, just comparatively speaking, it had a much broader audience.)

Aside from that brief moment at launch when everyone came out to show support — and it really did bloom for a little while — after that, as the story unfolded, I started facing cold, hard reality: wait, I knew you were niche, but this niche?

It felt like all the readers had come over from my last novel, dropping off one by one along the way, and my reserves were slowly dwindling — who wouldn't panic? Watching the backend numbers fall lower and lower, I was indeed pretty anxious for a while.

See, no matter how resolute you are when you make a decision, when you slam headfirst into reality, it still hurts. Hit it hard enough, and you'll need a cast.

So there I was, head wrapped in plaster, watching (don't ask me how, I could just see it) a new novel growing colder and more neglected by the day, slowly grinding my way through the writing — I was on Chase at the time, an unpopular character even within an already obscure story — and then somewhere in all that grinding, my mindset suddenly settled.

How to put it... I suddenly had this feeling of: oh, this is actually the state I should be in.

When I first started writing this book, I set out with the mindset of treating it as though my last novel never existed — as if this were the very first book of my life. So when the outside world wasn't buzzing, wasn't flying flags and putting on a parade, wasn't that exactly right?

The more niche and obscure the story, the more it deserves a quiet, niche environment to be written in — otherwise it's too easy to get dazzled by other things. "Environment," whether internal or external, counts either way.

So when I said I was aiming for twenty first-day subscribers — even though that was a joke — looking back, if it really had been just twenty, that wouldn't be something I couldn't accept. Where you come from, that's where you return to; it's not that the road was walked for nothing, it's more like... seeing the mountain as a mountain again, seeing the water as water again.

I chose a road less traveled, so naturally I have to walk it step by step in the quiet, watching the mountain ranges shift through pale mist and cloud, and every now and then the veil lifts, and I catch a glimpse of the hidden landscape I've been searching for.

All of that to say — thank you, all of you, for being willing to walk this road to the very end with me in the dark. Just so you know, I didn't bring a flashlight (.

PS: Oh right! My editor reminded me to mention the Wild Deer Convenience Store more often, worried that some people still don't know I've been keeping a short story side piece (not really). My editor has been so actually loyal to me — practically one step away from putting on a mask and grabbing people off the street to read the story — so I absolutely must holler about it a few more times: Wild Deer Convenience Store, Wild Deer Convenience Store!

Short reads, perfect with a meal, with a sweetness that lingers long after!

After reading Wild Deer Convenience Store, the kids got better grades on their exams, grandma's legs stopped aching — as told by local resident, Ms. Liu.

"Wild Deer Convenience Store is a shop I'd happily visit again and again," — excerpt from a Wall Street Journal review, fabricated out of pure wishful thinking.

Chapter 49 — The Secret Behind Qidian Author's Fake-Gathering of Money, Unfilial for Over a Month

Hello, my grandmas. My leave-of-absence note got taken down by Qidian — I still don't know if it's because I said j*, or because I said m*n*.

Perfectly normal words to begin with, but the moment they get turned into **, somehow they feel twice as sinister — isn't that right? A real case of lifting a rock and dropping it on everyone's feet.

Anyway, it got taken down. My chapters are limited-edition — blink and they're gone (lol).

Now the leave note is nothing but a dream in the rearview mirror, fading into the distance. Look — those who managed to catch a glimpse of it are truly blessed and should run downstairs to buy a lottery ticket right now (tap tap, there's a chestnut tree to the west).

The last time I posted a thank-you chapter was back on May 7th — at that point, only five days had passed since the deaths of the Bronx brothers.

Over a month has gone by without thanking my grandmas — what a monstrous act of filial impiety. What, pray tell, is the reason behind it?

First, because I've reserved whatever little real estate I have in the author's notes for my own rambling; and second, because saving them all up for one big thank-you makes it go on and on and on, which creates the pleasant illusion that the Artifact Report is especially popular (lol).

Even though it's probably the same crowd of grandmas — sponsoring me every month just like giving your kid their living allowance (lol).

First to take the stage: your daddy laughing brightly, 划框框, 九五, 妖妖 and 麟麟, 不问花开几许, and 庞小丫 — six high-shine grandmas. Let me lie down and be your red carpet...

Grandmas, what are you all doing — your tips are actually way too much. We've reached the point where I'm too embarrassed to just give you a shoutout and have no choice but to write extra chapters... We're all this close, so why bother? Next time just save it and give a like, m*n* and all~

(I am absolutely testing the limits of what's banned — what are you going to do about it)

But seriously — a few of you tipped right when I posted my rant, trying to comfort me, didn't you? I just looked at the dates and nearly cried. Leave me a message? Extra chapters or a character appearance — or if you want something else, just tell me. Qidian, I did not say s*usage, please don't ban me.

Sure, our readership isn't huge in total numbers, but every one of you keeps me in the lap of luxury with a genuine heart — I do love living off your generosity (lol).

Next up, the regulars you can spot just about every month: 海涅斯姥 and 铁甲白棠... honestly, what's going on with you two — either leave a supplementary card with me — no wait, that's not what I meant — it's just, I feel rather embarrassed.

The Artifact Report Field Research Fund has grown, thanks to: 书友20190620111919738 (let's change that name — you've tipped twice, and after typing out two strings of numbers I realized it's the same grandma), 九日小怪兽 (a new reader perhaps? Surely not? Or are you?), 墨鸢读作黑鸟 (your username has brainwashed me to the point where I can no longer recognize the characters 墨鸢),

and b1111111111 (transit card received — is there a three-day pass? Saving money), 村上的卡夫卡 (how polite?), Joiiii (tipping without forgetting to watch the game — a spirit that truly moves the heart), 二十四的QD (I feel like if I keep saving these up I could sign over my soul).

Let me do the math — not counting accommodation, I think this might be enough for me to stay alive and do three days of field research? I've actually never experienced New York prices firsthand — I've heard a single breakfast roll costs seven kuai, though luckily I don't eat breakfast.

Next, the first tier of the rolling gratitude list: 三酒愛吃紅豆糕嗎 (yes, I'm the one shaking down first-year high schoolers for protection money), 林三酒的狗勾, 非食用类小猫软糖 (you tip more punctually than I update), 永远站在鸡蛋那一边 (I get it), vitang (oh hey, we meet again)

New line, let everyone's eyes take a breath: thanks to 醉里倒拔屋一柳 (put him down for a second, would you), 近江沁水, Emmy酱, 饲养员k, Ciel秣, 啊啊啊怎么肥事, 莹珑想吃龟苓膏 (eat it), 咪阿嗷 (meow), 孟买的福晋 (what are you doing over there)

Continuing on — thanks to 吴衙, 颖佑, 我是阿云的玩偶呜呜呜呜呜 (that username doesn't get banned?!), 涉江不在 (I feel like you and 近江沁水 are part of the same series), 东歇 (grandma, you seem to be in remarkably good health?), 美狄亚家的绵羊

This next row I know every single one: MARGINAL鱼, 云中仙盟小天使, 狐婴, 月琢喜欢冒险故事 (excellent in both comments and tips), 山东在逃挖掘机 (thank you, and I will definitely not tip off Blue Xiang), 一杯白日梦不加糖, 十万伏特i — see, this is the upside of having a small readership: I know every single one of you

Oh my, business is booming — still have to thank: Erikakoo, 小孙带你飞, DStorm, 春日惊蛰, 小酒杯, 落梅踏雪来 (an unfamiliar face — possibly a new reader, I don't dare say for sure), 阿七家的小姑娘, 杜子若, 瑾芜, _E_Stella_, 书友20230503221938575 (see, there's no recognizing a string of numbers), 好运七宝

Looking at it all laid out like this — what a long and sweeping chapter of thanks. Someone who didn't know better might think I was a top-three tipper's favorite.

But a person can't live in delusion forever — I'll have to thank my grandmas promptly going forward. I don't dare go this long being unfilial again.

Chapter 50: Some Q&A on the World-Building of the Artifact Report

Setting

Since I've seen several similar questions come up in the VIP chapters, I've decided to open a separate chapter before the paid content to address them.

If it makes sense to you, feel free to read on — subscribing won't be a loss. (Of course, if the story turns out to be bad... well, there are no refunds.)

The main question is: why hasn't the government gotten involved in Hunter affairs — or rather, why doesn't the government regulate them?

I'd like to break this question into two parts: first, whether they **can**; second, whether they **want** to.

1. Can They?

A passage is a completely random, rare, and finicky thing.

Whether a person ever discovers they have a passage is entirely a matter of luck — government power is completely useless in this regard.

Because the government can't possibly mobilize citizens across major cities and have them test it one by one by jumping off buildings or crashing into TVs... The very nature of the passage fundamentally prevents the government from forming a national team, because it is deeply personal and cannot be controlled by any external force.

With no national team, there's no way to enter the Nest; and being cut off at the source — with no knowledge of what gets brought into the human world — makes regulating the circulation of Artifacts impossible. (This doesn't rule out the occasional Artifact ending up in official hands.)

So what about organizing or regulating existing Hunters?

First of all, the Artifact Report world draws on the American political environment. Any attempt at regulation would require a whole series of steps: bills introduced to Congress, legislative votes, congressional appropriations, the establishment of a regulatory body, public oversight...

But 99.9% of humanity has no idea that Nests, Artifacts, and Hunters even exist.

If you were a senator, how would you explain to your constituents why you voted for a proposal that sounds like complete nonsense — and why you spent enormous amounts of tax money on "something that doesn't exist"?

How would you make sure your political opponents don't use it as ammunition against you?

Of course, you might argue that intelligence agencies could quietly arrest or surveil Hunters — and technically speaking, that is indeed possible.

But that's only possible under the premise that you know who the Hunters are.

The randomness with which passages are discovered means that, as a regulatory body, you can never know who might become a Hunter tomorrow — and there are no warning signs in advance.

On top of that, Hunters aren't stupid. The moment something like that starts happening, they'll go further underground to protect themselves — and might even use Artifact powers to fight back. So what's the benefit? (This gets into the question of **wanting** to, which I'll cover in the second part.)

And from the Hunter's perspective: when you've risked your life to obtain an Artifact and can sell it for a high price, what are the odds you'd hand it over to the government, get recruited, and settle for a civil servant salary of a few thousand dollars a month?

Not to mention that the Nest itself is a lawless place. Only those who come out alive know what happened inside. If a national team went in and never came back out, then what?

Government power is, at the end of the day, made up of people — and when over 99% of people are shut out from the Nest and Artifacts, that means the government is shut out too.

2. Do They Want To?

Short answer: no.

Let's assume the government did have the ability to regulate Hunters and the Nest: Party A takes office, establishes the Artifact Bureau, nearly eliminates civilian Artifacts, and now all Artifacts are in government hands.

Then Party A loses reelection, and Party B takes over.

When Party A becomes the opposition and can no longer touch a single Artifact, don't you think they'd feel like they'd shot themselves in the foot? (This kind of power competition exists

within parties too.)

What if, at that moment, an Artifact appeared out of nowhere that could keep the ruling party in power forever — or keep the opposition permanently out? Would Party A really be willing to exit the stage of history for good?

Not to mention that the political environment this story draws from is the United States, where money politics ultimately comes down to money.

Would the donors behind the senators want legislation that regulates this? Once regulation takes hold, their own access to Artifacts shrinks and becomes less convenient. Even if a particular candidate is willing to give you a back door, would that candidate's political rivals play along?

As a donor, would you fund a candidate who, once elected, raises your taxes?

If not, then you certainly wouldn't fund a candidate who, once elected, cuts off your access to Artifacts.

Would a candidate, even for the sake of political donations, bother pushing something this thankless and unrewarding?

Look at real-world examples: American commercial health insurance doesn't just profit off suffering — it profits directly off people's lives. So why won't either party push to reform it, even to win votes? Because insurers are major donors.

So, to sum up:

1. The vast majority of people are unaware;
2. Regulation would face enormous obstacles;
3. Hunters just want money — pay enough and they'll hand over the Artifacts they're holding;
4. Letting Hunters freely enter and exit the Nest benefits everyone — including senior government officials themselves;
5. The consequence of regulating could be losing political donations and handing your opponents a gift.

Something that's almost entirely burdens and downsides, with no real upside — if you were the one in power, why would you bother?

Chapter 51: Mai Minghe Can't Get Home

Mai Minghe couldn't get home.

She walked barefoot through the streets of Blackmoor City in the small hours of the morning, chilled to the bone, especially her toes, which felt as though they'd been glued on and might drop off at any moment.

At first, she could still feel a layer of grime on the soles of her feet, and whenever she stepped on something suspiciously sticky, she would scrape and slap her soles vigorously. But after walking for a while, Mai Minghe gave up caring—the streets of Blackmoor City were hardly what anyone would call clean, and worrying about it was like trying to put out a fire with a mouthful of spit; if she kept fretting over it, she'd never make it home by dawn.

Before she'd crashed into the screen, Jonah had grabbed her shoulder one last time, and it was still burning like fire now; never mind that the boy had been taken over by some bug—his grip was no joke.

She had assumed that the hardest part of getting home from the Nest would be shaking Jonah off.

She had slammed into the screen just before Jonah could grab her, and she had indeed returned to the world of the living—but to her surprise, the place she'd tumbled out into was not her own home.

All her life, she never imagined that in her old age she'd still find new ways to suffer.

Mai Minghe sighed inwardly as she walked past a group of drunks on the roadside, their wolf-whistles washing over her without so much as a flicker crossing her face—"Hey, sweetheart! Why are you walking around in your pajamas? Boyfriend won't let you stay the night?"

Rationally, she knew that being a young woman alone on the streets of Blackmoor City at this hour was actually dangerous.

But emotionally, Mai Minghe couldn't muster the energy to feel afraid.

"Hey!" One of the drunks actually came after her, reaching out to grab her arm, slurring, "We're calling you, lady... don't walk away, walking barefoot must hurt. Come with me... we'll give you money."

Mai Minghe stopped, her gaze drifting past him to the building behind.

"Whatever happened to the pharmacy here?" she couldn't help asking. "It was open for decades—when did they tear it down? How did it turn into a real estate agency? I don't even recognize this building..."

The drunk turned to look, dazed. "...Huh?"

"The old man who ran that pharmacy, raising his granddaughter all by himself, life wasn't easy for him. I imagine he's long gone by now..." Mai Minghe shook her head and kept walking. "I haven't walked this far in seven or eight years. Strange to think I've lived here my whole life, and now I barely recognize the place..."

The drunk stood rooted to the spot, watching her walk away, and did not come after her again.

If he really had caught up, Mai Minghe would have liked to have a chat with him—she always felt that saying things out loud was the only way to sort them out properly, one by one.

For instance, she had been turning things over in her mind as she walked, and had concluded that the rules for entering and leaving the Nest worked like this: if she walked into a screen, she fell into the Nest; if she walked into a screen again while inside the Nest, she fell back into Blackmoor City.

But the spot she landed in wasn't necessarily where she had entered the Nest to begin with, nor did she have to come out through a screen—just now she had dropped out of thin air onto the lid of a trash can outside a residential building, and when she'd rolled off and looked around, she was still a kilometer from home.

It seemed the passage wasn't precise—it just put you back somewhere close enough.

In the time it had taken her to walk home, she wondered what had become of that young man called Jonah. How could anyone let a perfectly good child be taken over by some bug?

Besides, a person couldn't stay in the Nest for more than seven days, and Jonah was running out of time.

She had to find a way to reach the Morgan House Faction... they had that thing now, oh right, the internet—or she could go to the library and ask the librarian to look it up on the internet for her.

She was deep in thought, walking along, when she caught sight of the low-rent apartment block she had lived in for decades—and stopped dead in her tracks.

A police car was parked in front of the building, its lights painting the wall in alternating flashes of red and blue.

Never mind that it was the dead of night—a sparse cluster of onlookers had gathered nearby, some of them neighbors from her building, others idle passersby from the surrounding area.

This neighborhood had poor public safety—lots of immigrants, lots of low-income residents—so seeing a police car in the middle of the night was nothing unusual. But Mai Minghe spotted someone in the crowd at once: the middle-aged woman who lived downstairs from her, a tremendous busybody, though also a warm-hearted one.

"...The two of them climbed down the fire escape in the middle of the night, fumbling around outside the window—scared me half to death!" Mrs. Smith had seized the police officer by the arm and refused to let go. "They said they were looking for someone, but I don't buy it. I know the old lady on the second floor—she hasn't gotten out of bed or left the apartment in years. Is she supposed to have sprouted wings and flown off in the middle of the night?"

"What do you mean by that?"

The female nurse aide's face had gone white with fury. "We're legitimate nurses—you think we came here to rob you? We came because we received an emergency call, but the old lady just quietly disappeared on her own. Can we not look for her?"

The male nurse aide was concerned with an entirely different matter.

He had come around to the other side of the police officer and was making his case repeatedly: "...This is absolutely not a failure on our part. Please make sure to note that clearly, and make sure to explain it to our hospital as well. Her grandson was watching her at the time—we were already getting ready to leave. The duty of care was no longer ours. If you find that the old lady actually fell from the building..."

Right—Mai Minghe only now thought of something she should have considered sooner.

The thief was without question an Artifact Hunter, or at the very least had some connection to the Hunter trade.

He knew she had entered the Nest through a passage—but the other two nurse aides present had no knowledge of the Nest whatsoever, just as she herself had not, until very recently.

All they knew was that an old woman had been in the room one moment and had simply vanished the next—how on earth was that to be explained away?

Thinking about it, it was actually rather remarkable: so many Artifact Hunters, so many of their clients, and yet they managed to keep the existence of the Nest and its Artifacts completely hidden from the world, without a whisper leaking out.

Countless ordinary people went about their daily lives, striving from one day to the next just to get by, with no idea that beyond the everyday world there existed another—dark and fantastical.

"All right, all right, Mrs. Smith, is it? Go on home. This is a misunderstanding—nobody's here to steal anything from you."

The police officer finally managed to extract himself from their midst, pulled open the car door, and said to the male nurse aide, "The family member has already said they won't be holding you responsible. See how he contacts you to sort things out. A living person doesn't just vanish—my guess is the old lady got confused and wandered off somewhere. We've already filed the report, and more officers will be on the way shortly to have another look around... All right, all right, everyone go on home."

"Family member"—that would mean the thief, wouldn't it?

Mai Minghe thought of her convenient grandson, craned her neck to look around, but saw no sign of him.

She watched the police officer get into the car, and the rest of the onlookers drifted away one by one; in the blink of an eye, the roadside was left with only Mai Minghe.

The police car drove past her, and the officer inside glanced over at her—Mai Minghe's heart gave a sudden lurch, as though she were the one who had done something wrong—but then the officer immediately looked away, picked up his phone, glanced at it, and pressed it to his ear.

Mai Minghe let out a breath.

Of course—there was no way they could have guessed that this young woman who looked to be in her twenties was the very old lady they couldn't find no matter where they looked.

When she passed Mrs. Smith's door, she moved with careful, silent steps, then turned and headed up the stairs.

All Mai Minghe wanted was to get home as quickly as possible, wash her feet, and change her clothes—rescuing Jonah would have to wait until dawn, when she could ask someone to help her make inquiries. In the middle of the night like this, the library wasn't even open.

But her path home came to a halt just a few steps short of her own door.

The front door, which had been pried open, now stood half-ajar, not fully shut.

Through the gap, she heard a set of footsteps moving around inside; when they occasionally crossed the wooden floorboards in front of the kitchen, there came a creak-creak sound. Amid those footsteps, the thief's voice sounded distinctly—a quiet "mm."

Mai Minghe froze where she stood, caught between advancing and retreating.

"You're gone?"

The thief's voice carried through the door, clear in the silence of the night. "The nurse aides left too? What did you tell them?"

Who was he on the phone with?

The room fell silent for a few seconds, and then the thief let out a breath. "Lucky you were there to handle the aftermath in time. Mm, yes, my main worry was those two nurse aides..."

Mai Minghe's curiosity and urge to investigate surged all at once, and she quietly stepped forward.

Something the person on the other end of the line said seemed to set the thief at ease, and his voice relaxed somewhat: "You're right. If it weren't for the woman downstairs insisting on calling the police, I could tell those two nurse aides also wanted to sweep the whole thing under the rug—they probably wouldn't have pushed for an investigation. Yes, you handled the aftermath professionally... just like the real thing. If I weren't the one who made the call, I'd have been worried myself."

A wave of goosebumps broke across Mai Minghe's skin, and she suddenly understood who was on the other end of the line—just moments ago, she had seen that person herself.

"Yes, send the invoice to our House Faction..."

The thief seemed to have heard a thorny question, and paused before continuing, "Mm? No, I don't know how the old lady could have just stumbled onto a passage out of nowhere..."

He was lying.

Whatever that tube of his was, the moment he put it on a person, it made them see a vision of their own passage opening.

Mai Minghe turned the scene over in her mind, and everything became perfectly clear: the thief had intended to use the vacuum device to steal her passage, but while the vacuum device was working, it had also shown her for the first time how to open her own passage.

Like an answer to a summons, she had been called to the television set by her passage, and had fallen into the Nest.

While she was thinking, the thief's next words arrived half a second late, breaking through her thoughts and entering her mind.

"...Wait, there's someone outside my door."

Mai Minghe started sharply, and instinctively looked down—there in the light of the corridor, she saw her own hazy shadow stretching across the floor, falling right in front of the door.

She had to move—

But before she could turn around, the door was already being yanked open by the thief; as she looked up, the two of them were staring directly at each other.

Aside from the faint sound of traffic drifting from his phone, silence stretched between them.

In that split second, Mai Minghe felt as though another version of herself had taken over her reactions: she gave him a blank look first, then seemed to collect herself and smiled at the thief.

"I just went to throw out some trash," she said quietly. "Did you just move in?"

The thief's brow knitted slightly as his gaze swept across her face a couple of times.

She gave him no time to think further—the words were barely out before Mai Minghe lifted her foot and walked on, as though her apartment lay somewhere further down the corridor.

Even with her face decades younger and her pajama jacket gone, she still didn't dare let the thief's eyes linger on her any longer than necessary—as she passed her own front door, she could almost physically feel his gaze slide across her dirt-caked feet.

Two steps out, Mai Minghe still hadn't heard the sound of the thief going back inside; she turned to look, and sure enough, met those eyes again.

"What is it?" She frowned too, and added, "Oh, by the way—you left your door open just now."

"Huh? Oh—thanks."

The thief startled slightly, apparently realizing that staring at a young woman in the corridor in the middle of the night was indeed not quite appropriate; a trace of suspicion still lingered on his face, but under Mai Minghe's unwavering gaze, he finally pulled back—and this time, he shut the door.

The moment the door clicked shut, Mai Minghe spun around and ran.

She had no time to worry about whether her footsteps would wake Mrs. Smith—she thundered down the stairs; and just as she reached the landing at the bottom of the first-floor stairwell, she heard a door upstairs slam open with a bang, crashing against the wall.

Immediately after, a second set of footsteps rang out in the hallway.

The thief might not have realized he'd grown young again; but he must have noticed enough telltale signs to arouse his suspicion—this home, it seemed, was somewhere he couldn't return to for the time being.

Mai Minghe burst out through the building's entrance, but didn't keep running along the road; she slipped sideways and ducked into the narrow alley behind the building, crouching down behind a waist-high trash bin.

After about ten seconds, she heard footsteps, just as she'd expected; stealing a glance from behind the trash bin, she saw the thief's silhouette on the road, looking around in both directions, before choosing one way and walking off into the distance.

Several minutes passed, and the road was empty again.

Not daring to make a single sound, Mai Minghe slowly rose, hunched low, and retreated step by step under the cover of the trash bins. She was afraid the thief might still be nearby; once she stepped on a piece of cracked hard plastic, the pain made her clamp her lips shut—but she didn't make a sound.

Following the narrow alley behind the building, she slowly, little by little, put distance between herself and her home.

When the sky brightened to a pale gray-white, Mai Minghe stood blankly in the street, with no idea where to go.

As long as she waited patiently, the thief would give up sooner or later—he couldn't possibly move into her home. But in the time before he left, where was she supposed to go?

As for finding the Morgan House Faction, that goal seemed even further away now.

The most pressing matter at the moment seemed to be finding herself a pair of shoes first.

Come to think of it, there was one place that would suit her perfectly: not only could she find shoes there, she could also get a change of clothes and eat a few pieces of bread—near the Brooklyn Community College, there was a charity relief station where homeless vagrants often went to collect aid supplies.

Wasn't she a homeless vagrant right now?

The relief station wasn't close, but Mai Minghe had no other choice, and could only push her bare feet forward.

She had no watch and didn't know the time, but by the time she was finally almost there, daylight had long since broken fully, and the heavy traffic of the morning rush hour had thinned out again and returned to its normal flow.

Mai Minghe didn't see the moment the black Mercedes suddenly swung its door open.

By the time she noticed a tall figure leap up in the road and stride away toward the subway station across the street, the black Mercedes—its driver gone—had already lost control; it lurched crookedly up onto the sidewalk and, with a thunderous crash, slammed headfirst into a tree just a few steps in front of her.

A woman inside the car with purple dreadlocks appeared to have taken quite a hit from the impact; she struggled to push the door open while muttering bitterly to herself: "...When I get back to the House Faction, I am definitely revising my contract!"

Today's chapter ran really long—even I didn't expect to write this much. Consider it a celebration of the launch!

Seriously, I couldn't save a single word in reserve...

The timelines of the (current) three main characters are finally almost synced up!

P.S.: My cat is fine!

The vet asked me, does your cat have fleas? I said confidently, no, she never goes outside—then the vet took a little comb and ran it through her fur a few times, and the fleas on that comb outnumbered my confidence by a mile...

No wonder my poor girl has been shedding so badly—turns out she's allergic to fleas!!!!

I've got a huge project ahead of me when I get home—spray everywhere, strip all the fabric and wash it, steam-mop all the floors...

Truly, never a shortage of things to fill the time...

Chapter 52: Mai Minghe Cannot Be Found by Morgan House Faction

What happened next came on like a tornado—so fast there was no time to react.

In the blink of an eye, more than ten police cars arrived with sirens wailing, surrounding the crash site on all sides; onlookers sprouted up out of nowhere like mushrooms after rain, gathering at a distance on the nearby streets—even the buildings alongside had their windows thrown open, with blurry faces peering out.

Did they really have to be that efficient?

Couldn't they have left her even two minutes to ask the purple-haired woman about the House Factions?

Having lived more than eighty years, this was the first time Mai Minghe had ever complained that the police arrived too quickly—she watched helplessly as the purple-haired woman was surrounded by officers, unable to ask her anything, yet unwilling to leave; what surprised her was that after just a few exchanges with the purple-haired woman, the officers holstered their guns.

"The ambulance is almost here," one of the officers said, "can you stand up?"

Squeezed in among the crowd of onlookers, Mai Minghe caught snippets here and there—things like "came barreling through in a car," "kidnapped a woman," "suspect not yet apprehended"...

Kidnapped? How did it end up as a kidnapping?

That purple-haired woman seemed to be connected to Artifact Hunters, and Hunters were supposed to be capable people; and judging by her tone earlier, she even seemed to know the man who had been driving.

Mai Minghe couldn't make sense of it, and tried several times to strike up a conversation and ask what was going on—but whenever anyone caught a glimpse of her, they all pretended not to see her and casually stepped away.

She couldn't blame them. The state she was in right now was indeed a little pitiful.

Her bare feet were so dirty the original skin color was no longer visible, and here she was, broad daylight in the morning, still wearing her pajamas.

Years of being bedridden meant her hair had never been properly trimmed, and now that it had grown back thick, it was all the more disheveled; when she ran a hand over her face, she found a dried layer of vomit still stuck to it.

Mai Minghe singled out a kind-looking woman and, regardless of how the woman kept backing away, persistently sidled up to her—the end result was that the woman stuffed two bills into her hands and fled in a hurry.

...Well then, she'd discovered a side hustle.

Being someone everyone avoided did have its advantages: leveraging the one benefit of nobody being willing to get near a vagrant, Mai Minghe clutched her two bills and made her way smoothly to the very front of the crowd, watching the whole process of the police leading the purple-haired woman away with perfect clarity.

"Yes—yes, he held a gun to my head and forced me into the car... Where did I get in? Ugh, I can't remember, my head hurts so much..."

The purple-haired woman's steps were unsteady and faltering, supported on each side by a police officer as they walked her toward the ambulance that had just arrived.

Her hands were bound in front of her with zip ties, and she spoke in a muddled voice: "He tied me up, but then made me read the map for him... Oh, no, he didn't hurt me. But I'm very dizzy, a little nauseous..."

Watching her, Mai Minghe couldn't shake the feeling that from the moment the police arrived, the purple-haired woman had suddenly grown considerably weaker, her mind considerably more foggy—when just moments ago she'd been cursing someone out with a loud, clear voice.

Could this also have something to do with the Nest or Artifacts?

Forget it. Whatever she and her companion were planning to do, one thing was perfectly clear: if she wanted information about Morgan House Faction, the best approach was to ask a Hunter.

But the only person before her with any connection to Hunters was being helped along and walking further away, climbing into the ambulance—and the ambulance door shut with a thud.

She watched as the Mercedes was towed away, and the ambulance set off in a grand procession accompanied by a convoy of police cars; Mai Minghe looked down at her feet and let out a long sigh.

She was exhausted and starving, her whole body aching; it felt like her feet had been cut open too.

"Sorry to put you two through this," she said to this pair of hard-won young bare feet, "the shoes are gone, but we've still got a little more walking to do."

In her lifetime, she had encountered more uncomfortable, painful, and unpleasant situations than she could count; Mai Minghe had long since developed her own way of processing and adapting to them—for instance, she had just now given her feet names in her head, one called Little Left and one called Little Right.

To add a bit of fun, she decided that Little Left was the right foot, and Little Right was the left foot.

Mai Minghe had company now; Little Left and Little Right led her forward together, toward the nearest hospital.

When they passed by the charity relief station, Little Left wanted to turn and go in—to get a bite to eat and find a pair of shoes first; but Little Right was the sensible one and laid out the situation for it:

The purple-haired woman looked, at most, like she had a concussion—and she was probably faking even that.

She didn't need a large, fully equipped hospital, so the ambulance would certainly take her to the nearest Clayton Hospital emergency room. Under normal circumstances, the police would also follow to take an immediate statement; so for the next hour or so, the purple-haired woman would be at Clayton Hospital.

On top of that, she didn't appear to be a suspect, nor did it seem like she'd be detained, so as long as Mai Minghe walked to Clayton Hospital and waited at the entrance for a while, she should be able to catch the purple-haired woman when she was discharged.

But if Mai Minghe went to the relief station now and lost time, she wouldn't know how to find another Hunter in the vast expanse of Blackmoor City.

Compared to one meal and one pair of shoes, a human life was worth more, wasn't it?

Little Left was convinced, and together with Little Right, the two of them dragged the exhausted Mai Minghe step by step all the way to Clayton Hospital.

The moment she caught sight of the hospital entrance, Mai Minghe nearly collapsed to the ground like a crumbling building—since fleeing her apartment building, she had been walking continuously for at least four or five hours, and since the previous night, she hadn't had a single drop of water or a morsel of food; even a young person couldn't have held up under that.

"Thank you," she said to Little Left and Little Right, "you two rest for a bit. All we have to do now is wait."

Mai Minghe was very patient.

She thought back to not long ago, when she had been lying in bed all the time. Back then, Mai Minghe had lost most of her interest in the news, always feeling it belonged to another world—one that had nothing to do with her, one she was about to be left behind by.

She had preferred watching a lively reality show featuring a family of more than ten people—lying in bed, motionless, watching the daylight shift outside the window, waiting for the reality show to begin amid the sound of the news broadcast, her consciousness sometimes clear, sometimes hazy.

Life was like a pearl necklace—along a long thread of waiting, moments that easily slipped away were strung one by one.

Mai Minghe was too exhausted, and didn't notice the purple-haired woman walking out through the main entrance.

It wasn't until the woman was already standing by the road with her phone, waiting for a ride, that Mai Minghe jolted awake and quickly called out to her: "Hey, hello there."

The purple-haired woman turned around, revealing a face that was pleasant-looking but worn with fatigue.

Understandably—anyone who had gone through a morning like hers would be exhausted.

"Hmm? Oh, hold on," the purple-haired woman felt around in her pockets, "I think I have some change..."

"I'm not asking for money," Mai Minghe clarified.

The purple-haired woman stopped, and looked at her.

From her appearance, you really couldn't tell she was a Hunter—except for her compact, toned muscles and clothing suited for easy movement.

When it came to the critical moment, Mai Minghe found herself suddenly a little unsure, but with no other options, she steeled herself and went straight to the point: "Could you tell me how to find Morgan House Faction?"

"You're asking for directions? Morgan—"

The purple-haired woman glanced to the side, then suddenly caught herself, and her gaze snapped back to Mai Minghe, as she asked slowly: "...You mean Morgan House Faction?"

Hunters couldn't possibly go around killing everyone who knew about them just to silence them, could they?

Mai Minghe was actually startled by her own thought.

If knowing about them was dangerous, then of course there was only one most logical solution.

"Yes. I'm a Hunter too. But I've always gone into the Nest on my own—I've never joined a House Faction, and I don't know anything about them." Mai Minghe said as she spoke, hoping there really were Hunters who didn't join House Factions. "I want to join Morgan House Faction now... do you know how to find them?"

The moment the word "Nest" left her lips, the purple-haired woman's expression shifted subtly; as if "Nest" were a key that unlocked the façade of her as an ordinary citizen, revealing beneath it another layer—something tougher, more removed from the everyday world.

"You... how did you end up in this state?" She looked Mai Minghe up and down. "I've never seen a Hunter doing this poorly. And how did you know I was one?"

"I was right there when your car crashed," Mai Minghe said, a little embarrassed herself, rubbing her hair vigorously a couple of times.

"Oh, you saw Chase. He's pretty hard to miss." The purple-haired woman nodded, as if she'd received a satisfactory explanation.

If "Chase" was that tall figure, then Mai Minghe had at most seen only a glimpse of him—though she was rather pleased with the pun she'd come up with in her head, she held herself back and said nothing.

"House Factions aren't something you can just join at will, you know. You have to pass their screening criteria..."

The purple-haired woman spoke, then looked again at her sorry state, and seemed to feel a measure of sympathy for Mai Minghe. "Hmm, though when you've got nowhere else to turn, giving it a try isn't a bad idea... at the very least, they should be able to give you a meal."

"So what should I..."

"You're in luck—I was just recruited into Key House Faction," the purple-haired woman said, as if she'd brought up something to be proud of, and smiled. "Before I joined Key House Faction, I'd collected contact info for HR at several House Factions. Morgan House Faction's happened to be among them."

...HR?

Hunter House Factions had a human resources department?

It was a human resources department, right? Not some new term young people were using?

Mai Minghe kept her face neutral, hiding her confusion, and watched as the purple-haired woman took out her phone; the woman looked up and met her eyes.

The two stared at each other in silence for a few seconds before the purple-haired woman finally spoke: "Why are you looking at me like that? Get out your phone and save it."

Mai Minghe rummaged through her pockets and pulled out two crumpled bills. "Do you have a pen," she said, a little awkwardly, "I only have these... I'll write it down on here..."

"You don't have a phone?"

She only had a landline—and one old-person's mobile phone that she hadn't used in years. But Mai Minghe sensed that saying so would do more harm than good.

"In the Nest... I lost it," she said haltingly.

The look the purple-haired woman gave Mai Minghe had shifted from sympathy to something more like a funeral farewell.

"Ah," she wiped her nose, seeming to have something she wanted to say but struggling to get it out. "Well... hmm, no wonder you want to join a House Faction. You'll need to remember in future—personal belongings must not be left in the Nest, you absolutely must do your utmost to avoid that."

From her expression, it seemed like she was barely stopping herself from adding, "If you have a future, that is."

The purple-haired woman really did have a remarkably kind heart.

"I'm with Key House Faction now, so it wouldn't be appropriate for me to contact other House Factions' HR anymore. You know how it is—you always have to avoid any appearance of impropriety in the workplace. How about this: find a... find a payphone and give them a call. Tell them Kingsley Roselyn sent you."

She dug out a pen from her bag and wrote down the contact number on the bill. "Keep this money—once they give you an address, take a cab over."

If Jonah really could be saved, at least half of that would be owed to Kingsley Roselyn's momentary act of kindness.

Mai Minghe thanked her repeatedly, and even as Kingsley got into her car, she waved vigorously several more times, watching her go—who said young people these days were cold and indifferent? Hadn't she just met a good-hearted one?

But what Mai Minghe hadn't anticipated was that even after she'd managed, more or less smoothly, to get the contact information for a Hunter House Faction, the next thing she needed turned out to be even harder to find than Morgan House Faction itself: a payphone booth.

Hadn't they used to be everywhere?

But nowadays you could walk for half a day without seeing a single public phone booth; and when you finally did find one, you'd step inside and see not a telephone, but the word "WI-FI"—with a little umbrella shape drawn beside it in three curved arcs.

What on earth was that supposed to be for?

Mai Minghe spent at least thirty minutes wandering the streets before she finally accepted the truth: public phone booths had apparently been left behind by the times.

She rested for a moment, feeling truly at her wit's end, and with a mind to try her luck, stepped into a small Chinese restaurant that looked like it had been around for years—sure enough, behind the counter she spotted a familiar old-fashioned telephone.

"Could I borrow your phone for a moment?"

Mai Minghe was almost giddy with relief; she also knew she looked a sorry mess, and afraid of being turned away, quickly added, "I'll order a plate of fried noodles too."

"You got money to pay for the noodles?" The owner eyed her with suspicion. "One dollar per minute."

Thank goodness for Kingsley Roselyn's money... she'd have to find that kid somehow, pay him back, and write a thank-you note.

Mai Minghe pressed her ear to the receiver and listened to the dial tone ring out, feeling as though the past day and night had been a strange, shadowy theatrical play that was now drawing slowly toward its curtain call.

Through her clothes, she felt for the Serpent Band.

She had long since grown used to its presence; if she didn't touch it, she could almost forget that an Artifact had been coiled around her body this whole time.

She had not, of course, forgotten that the Serpent Band was Morgan House Faction's target.

So Mai Minghe had no intention whatsoever of showing herself; keeping out of Morgan House Faction's sight was the safest option.

"Hello?" A woman's voice came from the other end of the line.

"Hello," Mai Minghe glanced at the owner not far away, then turned her back, cupped her hand over the receiver, and said quietly: "Is this Morgan House Faction?"

"Who are you?"

"Someone gave me a little money just now and asked me to call you and pass along a message."

The person on the other end immediately grew guarded. "Who exactly are you?"

Mai Minghe paid no attention and continued: "She told me she'd just come back from a place called the Nest, and that she'd seen one of your people there—a young man named Jonah. She asked me to tell you—are you listening?"

The other end of the line stayed silent; yet somehow Mai Minghe kept feeling that the silence was taut, as though it were pressing down over a great deal of movement and sound, unnaturally so.

"I'm listening," the woman's voice came, accompanied by a sudden swell of background noise; then, just as quickly, the line went dead quiet again.

Had Mai Minghe been more experienced with mobile phones, she would have known that the person on the other end had pressed mute.

But she lacked that kind of experience.

"She asked me to tell you: Jonah is at St. Louis Hospital and needs emergency rescue."

Just saying that much might not be enough—maybe she should explain Jonah's condition in a bit more detail... otherwise, what if they brought that worm back with him?

While Mai Minghe was thinking it over, the woman on the other end asked a few more questions, none of them particularly important; she didn't find anything strange about them and answered each one.

But the next thing the woman said made every hair on her body stand on end.

"I know your address now," the woman said—and with a sharp click, hung up.

How are both of these chapters so long! If I can keep this up, maybe I actually have a shot at perfect attendance?

Thank you all for coming out to support me on launch day—even the readers who've been stockpiling chapters showed up, and I'm truly touched! Indeed, more than 20 (you didn't hold back on dragging people in off the street for me, hehe)! The friends who said first-chapter subscriptions could hit a thousand were a little too optimistic, but that's fine—data is essentially just noise; what matters is that I write this story the way I want to write it.

As promised, as a thank-you gift for first subscribers, I'm giving out cats—specifically the fleas on them. Come on, everyone line up, collect your fleas one by one.

PS: There was a writer who, at the end of a letter to a friend, included an apology: "I'm sorry—I was short on time, so I couldn't write you a short letter; I could only write a long one."

I actually feel the same way. If I had more time to write each update, I think I could trim the word count down further...

Chapter 53: Mai Minghe Rides the Tiger

And just like that, they'd found out where she was?

Had caller ID gotten so advanced it could even display your address?

Mai Minghe's heart pounded like a drum, and she panicked for a moment: if Morgan House Faction found her, the only thing standing between the Serpent Band Artifact and their Hunters would be the thin layer of clothing on her back.

Once they realized she was the last person to have had any dealings with Jonah...

No—she had to run.

Unless she was unlucky enough that Morgan House Faction happened to live directly above this Chinese restaurant, it would take them some time to get here. Right, she had to get out before they arrived—better to leave while she still could.

Mai Minghe quickly slammed the receiver down, slapped some loose bills on the counter, and turned to walk out—but to her surprise, she didn't move.

Because someone had grabbed the back of her collar.

"And just where do you think you're going—"

Before she could react, the restaurant owner started hollering behind her: "Your fried noodles are already in the wok! You haven't paid, and now you want to walk out on me? I had my eye on you the whole time—good thing I stayed alert!"

She'd completely forgotten about that—her mind had been so busy turning over Artifacts and Hunters that it had no room left for fried noodles.

Caught between panic and irritation, with a touch of reluctant amusement, Mai Minghe coughed twice as her collar dug into her throat and quickly said: "Let go of me—can't I just pay you?"

The owner leaned half his body out over the cash register like a bald owl fixing its gaze on a mouse, not quite trusting Mai Minghe.

"Sixteen fifty," he said flatly. "Card or cash?"

"That much? It's just fried noodles!" She was taken aback, glanced at the menu, and immediately regretted her order. "Prices have gotten this high?"

"Do you even have the money?"

Mai Minghe felt her scalp going numb: with every precious second of escape time ticking by before Morgan House Faction arrived, she was here scraping together noodle money, bill by bill.

When she finally managed to pull the money together, the owner took it and still complained: "Sixteen fifty and it takes you this long to count it out? Ugh, fine, fine—you want it to go or are you eating here?"

They'd already told her they knew her address—they might show up any minute—what was she doing even thinking about eating—

Mai Minghe had just opened her mouth when she stopped.

She stared at the owner's bald head and thought for a moment, then changed her answer: "... To go."

The owner had no desire to have someone who looked like a vagrant eating inside his restaurant—that was probably the first thing she'd said that actually suited him, because he turned and headed straight for the kitchen.

Mai Minghe stood by the cash register, her thoughts drifting into a daze. The small restaurant was quiet and empty, business slow—just her, the murmur of a TV news program from the corner, and the dim, greasy smell of years of stale cooking.

...Why had the person from Morgan House Faction said "I know where you live" before hanging up?

Thinking about it now, this was a matter of life and death—Morgan House Faction couldn't possibly just take some unknown caller's word over the phone and send people into the Nest to rescue someone; they would definitely verify the source first...

If they suspected she had something to do with Jonah's accident and wanted to come after her, they certainly wouldn't warn her in advance—that would just be tipping her off to run.

If she were the one from Morgan House Faction, would she have immediately suspected the caller of being involved in Jonah's accident?

Maybe. Maybe not.

"I know where you live" was, in itself, a perfectly neutral statement.

They hadn't said what they intended to do with her—only implied that someone was coming to find her.

If Mai Minghe had a guilty conscience and bolted the moment she heard those words, she would have sent Morgan House Faction a very clear signal: I have something to hide—come get me.

In her current condition, she would never outrun a search by a House Faction's Hunters with all their strength and numbers.

But what if she really was just some vagrant who'd been paid to pass along a message? Would she have even taken those words to heart?

They were testing her—and Mai Minghe had no choice but to play along, even if it meant showing herself to Morgan House Faction.

She'd only come to realize it now, late in life: existence was strange—things that could be had without the slightest risk were rarely worth having; and so it seemed that keeping the Serpent Band Artifact would also require taking a risk.

She had the restaurant owner to thank for that—if he hadn't held her up, she wouldn't have had the chance to think any of this through, and she'd already have run.

And besides, if he hadn't stopped her, who knows how long she would've gone on starving—right?

These were the thoughts drifting through Mai Minghe's mind, close to contentment, as she sat on the ground against the outer wall of the Chinese restaurant, shoveling fried noodles into her mouth in great, hungry bites.

Her appetite had been ruined for years—nothing would chew right, nothing would go down, eating had lost all taste—but now, in this moment with the storm about to break, the hot, fragrant, oil-slicked noodles in her hands seemed to anchor her, actually and truly, in this second chapter of her life.

Whatever came next, she had a meal in her stomach right now, and that was more happiness than anything else.

That was just how she was—no matter what happened, she could always find something good in it.

A sleek grey car pulled up in front of the Chinese restaurant just as Mai Minghe was picking the bean sprouts out of her noodles.

She despised bean sprouts most of all—earlier, in the grip of real hunger, she'd been shoveling everything in without thinking; now that her belly had something in it, the bean sprouts seemed especially offensive, as if they had taken advantage of her starvation.

Mai Minghe looked up at the car, steadied her heartbeat, kept her expression as neutral as she could, and lowered her head to keep picking.

A man and a woman got out of the car. The moment they approached the entrance, the restaurant owner poked his head out, pointed at Mai Minghe against the wall, said "That's her," and ducked back behind the door.

Mai Minghe wasn't the least bit surprised.

She'd heard the phone ring inside the restaurant while she was eating her noodles.

"Was it you who called?" the man asked—his gaze indeed fell on the pair of dirty bare feet she'd deliberately stuck out, and his brow gave a small twitch.

"Yes," said Mai Minghe, wiping her mouth with her hand—which left it dirtier than before. "Which one of you is Morgan?"

Neither answered—instead the woman took out her phone and called someone, issuing a quiet order: "We've found her. Stand by where you are for now."

The moment she spoke, Mai Minghe recognized her—she was the one who had answered the phone earlier.

Which meant... there were others nearby besides these two, weren't there? Morgan House Faction probably had eyes on every street within a few blocks—if she'd run, she wouldn't have gotten far.

The woman ended the call and turned to Mai Minghe: "What did the person who asked you to pass the message look like?"

Her guess had been right—it seemed they weren't suspicious of her.

"Ugh, well,"

Mai Minghe ducked her head and scratched vigorously at her scalp, as though she had fleas—the man stepped back half a pace. "Talked kind of nonsensically, very odd... I couldn't really tell how old, maybe twenties or thirties, maybe thirties or forties, under fifty. Wore a hat and glasses, had a scarf wrapped tight around the lower half of their face, couldn't make out much."

The two exchanged a glance.

"How tall?"

"I was sitting on the ground—couldn't tell."

"...What ethnicity?"

"Either a light-skinned person of color, or a white person with a tan."

"And their accent?"

"Oh, very refined," Mai Minghe said approvingly. "Could be on the radio."

The woman's jaw tightened.

"What else did she say?"

"It was strange—see if you can make sense of it." Mai Minghe cleared her throat, set the takeout container down on the pavement tiles, and said: "Jonah looks normal on the outside, but a Resident has already gotten inside him."

The two of them couldn't help the slight shift in their expressions.

Good—so they understood. That meant when they went into the Nest to rescue him, they'd also know what to watch out for.

Mai Minghe let out a quiet breath of relief inwardly.

From the look of things, Morgan House Faction seemed to be quite a formidable House Faction.

She still had no idea what a House Faction actually was, but then there were plenty of new words she didn't understand—one more didn't make a difference—and if they were that formidable, surely they could bring someone back?

"What are you smiling about?" the man asked without warning.

Mai Minghe startled, then realized—she must have let a smile slip through.

Helping someone felt so good—how could she not smile?

You'd think the one being helped should be the happy one, but honestly, helping someone else brought its own kind of swelling, tingling pleasure—someone had explained it to her once, something about human evolution—but she couldn't very well say that.

"She gave me money and I got to eat," Mai Minghe held up the noodles and said. "Good things like that don't come along often."

"Watch her," the woman said to her partner, and stepped to one side to call Taylor Ford.

She waited for the person on the other end to pick up. After a few seconds, she said quietly: "Taylor? We found the one who called—it's a vagrant who took money to pass along the message."

Mai Minghe listened as her own fabrication was solemnly repeated back, word for word, from the woman's mouth.

But every word about Jonah's condition was true—and as the woman's expression grew more and more grave, the knot in Mai Minghe's chest drew tighter and tighter.

By the time the woman ended the call and came back, even her partner looked a little tense—he watched her in silence without a word.

"This is serious. He may come himself and lead a team into the Nest," the woman said to her partner, then tilted her chin toward Mai Minghe. "But before he goes, Taylor Ford wants to meet her first."

She then crouched down—as if speaking to a small child—and smiled pleasantly at Mai Minghe: "Our director has some questions for you. Come with us—we won't treat you badly, you can ask for whatever you want."

Now it was Mai Minghe's turn to be at a loss.

For a vagrant, this was an opportunity that came once in a lifetime, and there was no reason to refuse—but how could she dare go back to Morgan House Faction with these two?

"Well—I—" she couldn't think of an excuse, and finally blurted: "It's not that I don't want to, it's just—I have fleas—"

"That's fine," the woman said, her expression a little pained but unwavering. "Come to our place—to our offices—and get cleaned up."

The man took a step forward, visibly and thoroughly reluctant, but moved to stand right beside Mai Minghe anyway.

He bent down and said: "Are you getting in yourself, or do you want my help?"

See, this is proof that I write each chapter fresh every day with no stockpile—I mentioned fleas just two days ago, and now fleas have made their entrance with quite a substantial role...

How about this: those of you who've tipped, pick between a bonus update and a stage appearance—the bonus update is a bit of a wait, but for a stage appearance I'll definitely give the fleas the treatment they deserve...

P.S.: Wrote pretty quickly today, but I have a feeling tomorrow I'm going to hit a wall.

Chapter 54: The Correct Response of a Homeless Person Named Mai Minghe

The show was already halfway through—it was too late to back out now.

There was no other option but to steel herself and keep playing the "homeless person" to the end.

Mai Minghe replayed her own words and behavior in her mind, and felt that she probably hadn't given herself away.

Nothing else aside, the state she was in—wretched and filthy—wasn't something that could be faked in a short amount of time; and moreover, she had carefully weighed what to say and what not to say, and felt she hadn't slipped up.

The Morgan House Faction people wouldn't suspect a homeless person for no reason, would they?

Whatever they asked beyond what she'd already told them, she would simply say she didn't know—it wasn't as if they could read minds.

There was only one thing she absolutely could not let them discover: the Artifact on her body.

That was exactly what Mai Minghe was worried about right now.

Sitting in the back seat of the car, she kept fearing that her clothes might ride up or press tight against her skin, revealing the outline of the Serpent Band Artifact; so she kept shifting her posture and tugging at her clothes.

The more she fidgeted, the more uneasy the two people in front became.

"Are you itchy?" The woman glanced at Mai Minghe in the rearview mirror and scooted her seat a little further forward. "Our company has a shower room—you can go get cleaned up first when we arrive."

It sounded as though Taylor Ford was a fairly important figure, and the two of them were reluctant to bring him a walking flea bag.

A shower was out of the question—a foot rinse at most; she wouldn't take her clothes off even if you poured blood all over her—but of course Mai Minghe didn't say any of that aloud.

"How does a company have a shower room?" she asked, just making conversation.

The man driving muttered, "...Nosy."

Mai Minghe had assumed they simply didn't want to say "House Faction" and were calling a manor a "company." A shower room in a manor made perfect sense, didn't it?

But she hadn't expected that the car would ultimately pull into the underground parking garage of an actual office building—and not just any office building, but a modern one with full security and complete facilities, where the man and woman even had to swipe their work badges before the elevator button for the upper floors would light up.

As the elevator doors opened, Mai Minghe was led into a bright, clean, off-white reception area.

Several sofas were scattered across a round rug; in the corner stood a potted plant, its clusters of lush, broad leaves pressing up toward the ceiling. A screen on one wall was playing a promotional advertisement; on the wall behind the reception desk, in simple, clean lettering, was the company name—"Morgan & Morgan."

What surprised Mai Minghe most was that beneath the company name, in smaller text, was a line that read: Financial Consulting & Property Management.

What was going on?

Wasn't "Morgan" a Hunter House Faction?

Her side hustle was begging—theirs was financial consulting?

The young woman sitting at the reception desk saw the group step off the elevator and immediately bent down to pick up a paper bag, then hurried over to meet them: "Sister Jane, I just got back with everything—it's all here."

The woman addressed as "Sister Jane" didn't even look at it, and gestured for Mai Minghe to take the bag, then instructed, "Take her to get washed up first."

It was a brown bag printed with "ZARA." Mai Minghe felt she'd seen the brand somewhere before; she opened it with curiosity and found a set of clothes and a pair of shoes inside.

When they'd asked for her shoe size earlier, she'd already guessed as much, and now she couldn't help but think Morgan House Faction was quite thoughtful—though no matter how thoughtful they were, they still weren't getting the Artifact.

"That brand name is something you don't see often," she said with a word of thanks, running her hand along the bag. "Is it expensive? You really didn't have to spend money on my account."

The others looked at her, and no one said a word.

"Um, Sister Jane..."

The receptionist didn't move; instead, she gestured to the man and woman to step aside with her, and after moving a few paces away, said something in a low voice—indistinct, but with what seemed to be the name "Taylor Ford" woven somewhere inside it.

Mai Minghe pretended to look at the clothes while straining her ears far harder than any antenna.

"...What?"

Jane Lynch's voice was also kept very low; only a few words, pushed up by emotion, were barely caught by Mai Minghe. "About to... at such a critical moment... who gave him..."

...Great. Not a single informative word had gotten through.

The receptionist said something else in a low voice, and Jane Lynch fell silent.

After a few seconds, she let out a helpless sigh and returned to a normal volume. "Anyway, take her to get cleaned up first. Taylor Ford just said he wants to question her, but we can't have her go in looking like this... honestly, no wonder he insisted I bring a filthy person over. What's gotten into him."

What happened? What did any of this have to do with her?

Having only caught scattered fragments, Mai Minghe was actually more nervous than before; but knowing that even if she asked, no one would take her seriously, she had no choice but to play ignorant and follow the receptionist.

A financial services and property management company that actually had a shower room.

The shower room was for single use, divided into two sections: the inner part had the shower head, and the outer part had a changing area.

Mai Minghe set the bag down on the chair in the changing area and pushed open the door to the shower stall—the next second, she stumbled back half a step, as though she'd taken a punch.

The sharp smell of sodium hypochlorite disinfectant almost made her think she'd walked back into a hospital. No—stronger than any hospital.

Standing in the shower stall, Mai Minghe understood.

She turned her head, and it was as if she could see a Hunter, drenched in blood, walking in and turning on the shower—mucus, bodily fluids, blood... all the unspeakable things brought out of the Nest, rushing in torrents down into the drains of the human world.

Morgan was indeed a Hunter House Faction.

A Hunter House Faction had no aversion to blood.

An Artifact that could restore youth—even a fool knew how precious that was; at the very least, far more precious than the life of a dying old woman.

...If she never walked back out of this office building, no one in the world would come looking for her.

Mai Minghe leaned against the tiled wall, arms wrapped tight around her abdomen; through the fabric of her clothes, the Serpent Band pressed slightly outward against her arms.

This was her lifeline.

The moment she walked out of that shower room, a shadow war to defend that lifeline would begin.

In this war, her greatest advantage was that Morgan House Faction didn't know the person before them was their adversary. Which meant she didn't need to attack—she only needed to not make mistakes.

...If I were Taylor Ford—a director of a Hunter House Faction—what would I ask?

How would I probe the other party, draw out information?

Lost in concentrated thought, Mai Minghe had, without noticing, finished washing her hands, feet, face, and neck. She pushed her exhausted, cold, aching feet into the shoes, then pulled the new clothes on directly over her pajamas.

It was an autumn-winter hoodie. Adding another thick layer of cover over the Artifact settled her nerves a little.

She also borrowed a comb from the receptionist and carefully combed her hair neat before stepping out—like a warrior fully armored and ready to march into battle.

"No, no, don't bother returning it,"

the receptionist waved her hands frantically, keeping the comb at arm's length, "Keep it, really, you keep it."

She paused and looked Mai Minghe over. "You're actually quite good-looking once you've cleaned up. How did you end up on the streets?"

"Bad luck, I guess," Mai Minghe smiled at her and tucked the comb into her pants pocket. "Who am I going to see next?"

"One moment," the receptionist picked up the phone. "Sister Jane? She's done... yes, yes. Oh? Alright, I'll bring her over now."

It was an entirely ordinary exchange—just a matter of taking someone to see a superior—yet that "Oh" seemed to carry a hint of surprise that didn't quite fit the moment.

Could it be related to their whispered conversation from before?

Mai Minghe wet her lips, steadied herself, and followed the receptionist as calmly as she could manage, turning no fewer than four or five corners before arriving at the door of a private office.

"Mr. Ford?" She knocked on the door.

"Come in," a steady male voice answered.

As Mai Minghe entered, she happened to see a man standing before the floor-to-ceiling window, turning his head toward her.

She hadn't known what an important figure in a Hunter House Faction was supposed to look like, but seeing him now, she felt it should be exactly like this.

The man wore a suit—immaculate and sharply pressed—with a square, stern face; though already middle-aged, it was still easy to see that in his youth this had been a decidedly compelling face—only time had inevitably won out, and his jawline had softened and sagged, making him look a touch slack. Just a touch, not much more.

"Sit," Taylor Ford directed, and took his own seat on the other side of the desk.

Mai Minghe sat down in the visitor's chair.

The office looked as though it wasn't often used—almost no personal items, like an interior design template for what an office should look like; which made sense, really. A Hunter shouldn't be spending all his time sitting behind a desk.

The one sign of actual use was a few small dishes of snacks on the table—Taylor Ford tilted his chin toward them and said, "Help yourself."

Mai Minghe was full, but she had to keep playing the homeless person convincingly.

The moment he finished speaking, she tossed a grape into her mouth; then, thinking it over, she simply picked up the dish and swept the few pieces of cheese and all the thin crackers into her pocket, and since the last small bunch of grapes wouldn't fit, she grabbed those in her hand too.

Pretty good acting, she complimented herself. Evidently, Taylor Ford had to restrain himself not to frown.

"When did you see that woman?" he asked, getting straight to the point.

"This morning," Mai Minghe had already rehearsed answers to many questions he might ask. "I don't have a watch, so I don't know what time."

"Where?"

Mai Minghe gave a location quite far from the Chinese restaurant.

"I know you said she had her face covered. But think back—was there anything about her that stood out to you?"

"Ah... well..." Mai Minghe furrowed her brow and pretended to think for a moment. "She was very generous with money."

Taylor Ford stared at her, his expression growing even more stern—clearly not amused in the least.

"You remember everything she said to you pretty clearly." He leaned back slowly against his chair, fingers tapping the desk, one beat at a time.

"Ha, don't even bring it up." Mai Minghe had been prepared for this. "All those strange things she said—I didn't know if it was some kind of code or what—but I didn't remember it at first. She made me memorize it, repeat it back twice, before she'd give me the money."

"And she trusted just like that that you'd actually make the call?"

This was a question Mai Minghe had also thought through.

"She said it was a matter of life and death. Either way, she gave me the money and asked me to make the call—she'd done her part. If I didn't call and someone died, that death would be on my conscience, not hers."

As she said this, she tapped her face and chest a few times and made a sign of the cross. "I'm not about to have someone's death on my hands. God is watching—if I didn't make that call, I'd never get into Heaven."

Taylor Ford fell into thought and said nothing, but Mai Minghe still couldn't relax.

The conversation had been circling around the "mysterious woman" the whole time, which meant he suspected the person who'd passed on the information, and wanted to know who the source really was.

Kept being pressed about a person who didn't exist—even though she'd come prepared, she didn't dare let her guard down, and her palms were growing a little damp with sweat for fear of slipping up somewhere.

It was maddening—they already knew where Jonah was, so why not just go rescue him—if she weren't afraid of blowing her cover, Mai Minghe would have loved to give them a good talking-to.

"Why don't you sit with us for a bit," Taylor Ford said with a low, heavy smile. "You can leave when we say you can leave."

Mai Minghe's heart lurched, but she made every effort not to let anything show on her face.

"Why is that?" She scratched at her hair with one hand and asked, "I want to leave, and now I can't? That's kidnapping."

"Legally speaking, yes, it's kidnapping. So what?"

Taylor Ford was completely unbothered. "I can also tell you why," he said. "If you're willing to sit tight, all the better. That place you mentioned should have surveillance cameras nearby—and even if it doesn't, we can track down people who were in the area."

"A woman bundled up head to toe, standing on a busy street talking to a homeless man for that long—she'd naturally draw attention. All we need to do is pull the surveillance footage, or

find an eyewitness, and once we've confirmed your story checks out, you're free to go. I'd even personally give you money and see you out the door."

Mai Minghe didn't catch that last part at all—she sat there in a daze, her mind a complete blank.

Right, it seemed like so many places had these cameras installed now...

She hadn't thought of that at all.

It wasn't her fault. For most of her life, "surveillance camera" hadn't even been a concept to her.

She couldn't remember how old she'd been the first time she heard the term; she only remembered that the last time she'd noticed a camera, she'd been in the hospital, her body already in steep decline.

"No problem with that?" Taylor Ford's eyes stayed fixed on her as he asked.

What could she do but nod?

Get through this obstacle first—she could always look for a chance to run later.

"Good. I'll have—"

Taylor Ford hadn't finished the sentence when someone rapped urgently on the door—heavy, hurried knocks; and this time, without waiting for him to respond, the door was pushed open and Jane Lynch strode into the room.

"Mr. Ford, something's come up," she said, not sparing a single glance at Mai Minghe as she walked over to Taylor Ford and lowered her voice. "Jonah, he—"

Jonah?

Mai Minghe jolted; but in the very instant she looked up toward Jane Lynch, she suddenly realized something.

While Jane Lynch was speaking, Taylor Ford's eyes had stayed nailed on her the entire time.

...As if waiting to see her reaction.

Look, I've been updating every day recently with longer chapters, and earlier than before—not like the old days when I'd groan and complain with every word I typed...

It's because I really love ensemble stories, and I love the world of Blackmoor City and the Nest even more, so every day I write with real enjoyment—I can't pry myself away from the computer; and even when I'm not writing, it's always on my mind.

This kind of state makes me really happy. Writing (when it's going well) is such an interesting, absorbing process.

Honestly, I started writing because I loved it in the first place—I never thought about making a living from it.

Of course, this mindset has its downside too: when I'm not in that happy state, updates aren't guaranteed. Not even money can get this donkey moving.

What can I say—I'm not a professional web novelist. I'm in it for the joy.

Chapter 55 — Mai Minghe and Taylor Ford's Interrogation

In that split second, Mai Minghe knew she could not hide it.

The only option was to keep playing along.

"...Jonah?"

A cold sweat broke out across her back, and her facial muscles felt leaden. Mai Minghe had no idea whether she had managed to pull off a look of "curiosity"—but she tried.

"The Jonah I mentioned when I passed along the message?"

She pretended not to notice Taylor Ford's gaze and looked only at Jane Lynch. "The one whose life was in danger? What happened to him—is he all right?"

Without waiting for either of them to answer, Mai Minghe made the sign of the cross in front of her.

"God bless him," she murmured. "It's not because I called too late, is it? Surely God won't blame me..."

Jane Lynch glanced at her superior; Taylor Ford furrowed his brow, waved a hand, said "she's religious," and finally shifted his gaze away from Mai Minghe's face.

Inwardly, Mai Minghe let out a quiet breath of relief.

Of course it was normal for her to react to the name Jonah—it was a name that had come out of her own mouth several times, after all...

It seemed, for the moment, she had slipped through.

"This has nothing to do with you," Jane Lynch said to Mai Minghe first, then did not continue in front of her. She picked up a pen and paper from the desk, quickly wrote something, and handed it to her superior to read.

A muscle in his face visibly twitched.

"Understood."

He shot to his feet from behind the desk, crumpled the note in his fist, spared Mai Minghe not another glance, and strode toward the office door. Just before stepping out, he tossed back a single

line: "I'll handle it. Get her out of here fast—through the back."

What had happened?

What Jane Lynch had come in to say just now wasn't only meant to test her—something had actually gone wrong?

Mai Minghe was full of questions, yet she understood one thing: due to whatever sudden development, the Morgan House Faction's attitude had shifted in an instant; she was free to go now.

Whatever the emergency was, if she could leave, why would she hesitate for even half a second?

She leapt to her feet and immediately followed Jane Lynch; as they left, the two of them did indeed take a different route from the one they had come in by, and there was no telling what was happening on the other side of the company floor.

Jane Lynch's mind was elsewhere entirely, with no attention to spare for Mai Minghe, and no matter what Mai Minghe asked her, she answered only with "it has nothing to do with you."

She led Mai Minghe through two quick turns across the sprawling office floor, then stopped, jutted her chin toward the corridor ahead, and said: "Take the stairs down from over there. Once you're down, have the security guard let you out. Don't wander—it's not safe. Get going."

With that, she turned and hurried away, so fast she was nearly running.

In no time at all, Mai Minghe was alone again.

The short corridor was perfectly still; the soundproofing in the Morgan House Faction's offices was excellent, and straining her ears from here, she couldn't make out what, if anything, was happening up ahead.

Right then—whatever was going on, she needed to leave.

The area seemed entirely deserted, with only the sound of her own footsteps rebounding back and forth between the walls of the short corridor—which was why, when that voice dropped into the air, Mai Minghe gave a small start.

"Hey, big sis?"

Oh, that wasn't for her; the last time anyone had called her "big sis," her parents had still been alive.

...Mai Minghe had already taken another step forward before it occurred to her that "big sis" might actually be directed at her.

She followed the sound and looked: at the far left end of the short corridor, a bright and tidy break room opened off to one side. The break room was spacious, with a scattering of long tables, chairs, and sofas, and curled softly into one of the sofas was a kid.

A boy who looked at most seventeen or eighteen—wasn't that a kid?

The boy was sprawled against the sofa back as though every bone in his body had been removed, half his face buried in his arm.

One hand hung at his side, a cigarette held between his long fingers, thin white smoke curling around them like silk.

The boy's eyelids were half-lowered, and when he spoke, his voice was light and loose and drifting—like a white cloud in the high autumn sky, that would float away at the slightest cut. "... Big sis, are you good at chemistry?"

Mai Minghe blinked. "What?"

"I don't like chemistry," the boy said, still in that cloud-soft voice edged with the suggestion of a smile, languid and indistinct. "Would you help me look over my homework?"

Sure enough, there was paper and a homework assignment on the table. But with escape her most pressing concern, she could hardly stop to look over anyone's homework—which Hunter had such a carefree heart that they'd even brought their kid to work?

"I'm in a hurry, I'm sorry," Mai Minghe said, and quickly moved away from the break room doorway.

A moment later, she came back and poked her head in.

"Um... do you know where the stairs are?" Mai Minghe asked, a little sheepish, keeping her voice low. "Someone from the company just told me to take the stairs down from around here, but..."

During the few minutes she had spent looking for the stairs, the boy seemed not to have moved at all; only now did he slowly raise his head, revealing a face with a hazy, unfocused expression—and amid that haze, lips so red and moist they glowed, like the reflection of a sunset in still water.

Even after living a long life, she rarely encountered a child this beautiful.

In that moment of distraction, Mai Minghe caught the faint yet heavy scent hanging in the room. She glanced at the cigarette in his hand and understood: "Wait—what you're smoking—"

"So? It's not illegal." The boy said it lazily, and took a long, slow drag. The white smoke curled out, hazy, as though blurring the edges of reality.

It was legal now?

The last time Mai Minghe had been in her twenties, hippie culture had been in full bloom, and she was long past being shocked by such things—yet this still caught her off guard.

But right now, the priority was getting out of the Morgan House Faction's building.

"Mm... the stairs—I can just take you there."

He seemed to sense her urgency. The boy rose from the sofa and came closer, his body as though made of smoke or cloud—he moved without a sound, like a cat. "I'm Taylor. What's your name?"

"...Mai Minghe."

Facing the boy, she felt there was little point in giving a false name; real name, false name—either way, it was a name no one in this world would recognize.

The boy's eyes were a deep, watery red; if not for the cigarette in his hand, Mai Minghe might have thought he had been crying. When she thought about how she hadn't helped him with his homework and yet he was still willing to show her the way, she felt a pang of guilt, and said: "Thank you. Don't worry, I won't tell anyone."

"Oh? About this?" The boy seemed to only just remember the cigarette between his fingers, glanced at it, and smiled at her. "It doesn't matter. Nobody cares what I do."

This kid—when he grows up, he'll break so many girls' hearts, Mai Minghe thought to herself. He glanced at the cigarette, and somehow it made her feel, without any reason at all, that the cigarette had gotten its money's worth just by existing.

"Shall we go, then," she said, mindful of leaving soon. "I'm in a hurry."

"Why? Do you have a date?"

Was this really how kids talked these days?

"I have something to take care of at home," Mai Minghe said dismissively. "Which direction are the stairs?"

The boy tilted his head with that hazy look, revealing a small red mole on his neck. He watched Mai Minghe for a few seconds—long enough that she was beginning to grow impatient—and then suddenly smiled: "Oh, I nearly forgot. There's a lot of food and drinks in the break room—wine, too?"

"Or you could just point me to the stairs and I'll go myself."

Mai Minghe knew there was no use getting impatient with someone in this state; their reactions were usually half a beat slow. "I really am in a hurry."

"Don't be so quick to ditch me," the boy said with a short laugh, and quite familiarly took hold of Mai Minghe's wrist. "Come on, the stairs are over that way—you walked right past them. Are you sure you don't want to check my homework?"

"I really don't have the time," Mai Minghe said.

"Everyone else says they don't have the time either." The boy said it with a small pout. "Because Jonah just came back from the Nest with a Resident, and they ended up right here in the building."

Before Mai Minghe had registered what she'd heard—before she had any chance to stop herself—she had already come to a sharp halt, shock written plainly across her face.

Every piece of the puzzle snapped into blinding clarity all at once.

A Resident had gotten in? No wonder Jane Lynch had been in such a panic just now, no wonder she hadn't let her stay; with that thing along, Jonah had—

No. Wait.

This boy...

She turned her head, and caught the boy smiling softly at her again.

Still that same hazy, weightless smile—yet as Mai Minghe looked at him, a sharp, prickling cold sweat rose across her back.

Even time seemed to have been poured full of mercury, slowly suffocating in the space between them.

Perhaps, having seen her here at the Morgan House Faction's offices, he assumed she was a Hunter too, and had spoken without thinking...

"I'm sorry, big sis."

The boy lowered his head, one hand still holding hers, the other raising the cigarette to his lips for a slow drag. "I tend to lie a lot. Girls don't like that about me."

Mai Minghe felt as though she were watching a car crash—powerless to stop it, able only to stare.

"Jonah hasn't come back," he said, almost soothingly. "I haven't gone into the Nest yet. No one's brought him back, so how would a Resident end up here? Don't be afraid—there's no Resident here."

Mai Minghe thought she could hear, somewhere beyond the turn in the corridor, the faint sound of footsteps.

Were they coming for her?

"Big sis, you're not exactly a vagrant, are you? You really went to a lot of trouble to look like one... When you came in, I saw you, and thought to myself: probably nothing to get out of her. Eight chances out of ten."

His voice was soft and blurred, barely above a murmur.

"So why didn't you just tell us you're a Hunter?"

The boy paused, then gave a quiet laugh.

"My guess is—either you're connected to what happened to Jonah and you're afraid Morgan House Faction will hold you responsible; or you're connected to whatever Jonah was chasing, and you were afraid of walking straight into a trap."

Mai Minghe had an illusion: it felt as though the Serpent Band had already left her, and she could feel the pain of it tearing away—like skin being stripped from flesh.

His fingers rested lightly around her wrist, as though she could pull free with a single jerk.

But then what?

In the Morgan House Faction's building, surrounded by Hunters—where would she go? What would she do?

Mai Minghe's voice came out hoarse. "You're..."

"I didn't give you my real name just now—please don't hold that against me."

The boy's eyelids were still half-lowered, his expression like someone caught between sleeping and waking. "My surname is Ford... I'm Taylor Ford. Hunter Director of the Morgan House Faction."

Heh heh heh, heh heh heh heh, heh heh heh heh heh heh heh.

rubs hands together So, how's everyone doing? Did you all get cake for Children's Day?

You might be wondering why I love writing beautiful characters so much—it's because I am the number-one appearance-obsessed person of this century.

If the main characters aren't beautiful, writing them feels completely flat to me, because when I write, I'm basically translating the visuals in my head into words.

If the people in my head aren't good-looking, what's even the point of writing them.

Anyway, a beautiful person—regardless of gender—just has to smile, and I'm gone.

Can you imagine what I'm like when I see Li Xiaoran and Zhang Yuqi?

That feeling—I suddenly understand King You of Zhou completely. King You of Zhou has clocked back in. I'm going to go light the beacon fires right now. So what if the lords have to make a few trips? Let the beauty smile!

Chapter 56: Taylor Ford and the Morgan House Faction Contract

For the average student, school is the last place they'd set foot in if they could help it—but for Taylor Ford, it was the closest thing to a vacation he had.

He still lounged lazily in his seat; the students from the previous class had long since cleared out.

He had no idea where his next classroom was, because he had no idea what his next class even was.

This winter had been especially long. March was drawing near, yet outside the window, the trees—some pale, some nearly black—still stretched their bare branches into the grey sky, each one laced with thin lines of snow.

He could sit quietly like this, watching the desolate colors of the world, for an entire morning. Even if the next class started, no one would come to hurry him.

The whole school knew he was nothing more than a spectator on the shore, standing apart from rules, coursework, and ordinary life—and when the bell rang, it might as well shatter the reflection he cast on that still pool of water.

He was already in eleventh grade, yet he never thought about his GPA, nor had he looked at materials for a single university.

Classes were something he could take or skip as he pleased; his father had already spoken to the school—whenever he felt like it, he could stand up and walk out, and no one would ask him a single question.

Exactly how that arrangement had been made, Taylor had never asked, nor had any interest in knowing.

Even the decision to fulfill enough credits to graduate was something he'd decided on a whim; if Taylor chose never to come to school again, his father would raise no objections whatsoever—if anything, he would be more pleased.

What was it he'd said?

Oh, right.

"The world plays favorites. Some people are born with talents that others could never reach no matter how hard they worked their whole lives," his father had told him more than once. "Taillan, you are exactly that kind of lucky one—no, you're the best among the lucky ones. Your time and energy should be spent on things with the highest return. That's the only way to do justice to your gifts."

Taylor had no desire to sit through the rest of the day's classes, but as if in a kind of protest, he had stayed at school and seen the whole day through anyway.

He followed the stream of students leaving school down the front steps, and unsurprisingly spotted that familiar SUV again—he silently breathed a quiet sigh inside.

"Taillan, is your dad picking you up again? Why does he worry about you so much?" A girl waved at him with a smile. "Bye—you have to come to school tomorrow, okay?"

Taylor could name fewer than three people in the entire school by name. But that didn't stop people from noticing him and striking up conversation; all he had to do was be polite, nod, and say "hi" or "bye."

It wasn't arrogance on his part.

The more time you spent in the Nest, the thinner and sparser the outside world seemed when you returned—even its colors felt grey and washed out.

Especially right after coming back: people who had nothing to do with the Nest barely had faces to him, impossible to remember; whatever happened, it all felt distant. It was as though this place didn't deserve to be called "reality," because everything felt weightless and drifting, without substance.

Sometimes he felt that the center of gravity in his life was the Nest—and the Nest was a black hole.

In general, after spending some time in the outside world, the normal feeling would slowly return.

But even when the feeling came back, the mental habits he had formed could not be undone—even if he could see colors again and recognize faces again, none of it had anything to do with him.

Taylor went around to the right side of the car, opened the rear door, and tossed in his flat, empty backpack.

"How was today?" His father turned and smiled at him. "Did you have a good time at school?"

He had a square, stern face—probably not bad-looking in his youth. But now, edging toward middle age, the line of his jaw had gone soft and slack, giving him an air of weakness and indulgence, until his appearance had finally caught up with his character.

It was fortunate that he didn't look much like his father.

"Drive," Taylor said, getting into the car, too tired to answer him, tilting his chin toward the front. "Why did you come to pick me up again?"

Before his father could answer, he had already guessed.

"Got two new offers today."

Han Ford drove and explained earnestly: "You've gone nearly half a year without entering the Nest. I didn't understand why at first, but Dad gets it now. The biggest House Factions in Blackmoor City don't just lack talent themselves—they're also afraid of someone like you ending up on a competitor's side. They're all fighting over you. Without you, they don't know what to do with themselves.

"The price looks right to me now. So—how about you pick one you like and take it? If you wait any longer, they might lose heart, and that would be a real shame to miss out on..."

Taylor pulled out a cigarette; the lighter snapped—click—and he held the flame, drawing in a long, deep breath.

His father considerately cracked the window open a sliver, and the cold March air came rushing in—he liked cold air, the colder the better.

Taylor waited until that soft, warm sensation smoothed out the creases in his mind and loosened his thoughts, before he murmured distantly, "...Who is it this time? What kind of contract?"

"One of them is a per-mission contract. Dad knows you like that—more freedom."

"Don't talk in half-sentences," Taylor's voice grew muffled and soft, somehow draining the words of any edge. "Keep it short. Explain it clearly."

"Ahem, you really are impatient, kid. I read that contract carefully—the per-mission pay isn't bad, but apart from the pay, there's nothing else. No share of the Artifacts, no entry-and-exit

guarantees or death benefits—of course, Dad knows nothing will happen to you, so that doesn't really matter—and as for perks, allowances, equity shares, you can forget about all of that. Honestly, it's no different from hiring an ordinary solo operator Hunter."

Han Ford seemed displeased, and gave the steering wheel a light tap. "Do they even know who they're negotiating with? How rude."

Taylor smiled soundlessly. "How much per Nest run?"

Han Ford hesitated a moment, then admitted himself: "The price isn't bad, actually... five hundred thousand per run."

"How many runs?"

"Four."

"Is there a time limit?"

"...No."

That was the crux of the matter.

A House Faction that contracted Taylor on a per-mission basis would never send him on tasks that an ordinary Hunter could handle.

Only when they had confirmed intelligence on a rare Artifact they couldn't secure on their own would they send Taylor into the Nest—and opportunities to pull chestnuts out of the fire like that were naturally few and far between.

His father understood perfectly well: if Taylor took on these four contracted runs, he would not enter the Nest even once more before the contract was complete.

In other words, if the opposing House Faction took five years to use up all four opportunities, then Taylor would bring in not a single yuan beyond two million over those five years.

"Artifacts keep emerging one after another, but truly rare, powerful ones are very scarce."

His father—who had never once set foot in the Nest—was explaining the current situation to him.

"During the time you're not going in, those Artifacts could be found and taken by other Hunters. Isn't a per-mission contract just a waste of your talents? Letting people with less talent

than you take the Artifacts and pocket the money is one thing—but it builds their names up, as though they could actually compete with you!"

Taylor extended the half-smoked cigarette toward the front seat; his father, mid-sentence, reached back and offered up an ashtray.

He didn't take it—only ground out the ember against the rim, pressing down so that Han Ford's hand dipped again and again.

"What about the other contract?"

"It's from Morgan House Faction." In the rearview mirror, his father's expression visibly brightened. "The terms they're offering are actually impressive. Looking at all of Blackmoor City, I can honestly say no Hunter has ever been offered a contract like this before. As your agent, Dad is really quite proud to have negotiated these terms for you..."

In truth, this kind of conversation was hardly their first.

Taylor had long known where these conversations always ended up, and he was quite tired of the back-and-forth—but he simply refused to let Han Ford get what he wanted so easily. Even when he didn't mind running the Nest, he would still say: "Not signing."

"You haven't even heard their terms yet—"

"House Factions aren't free."

But this time, his father didn't rush to argue. Instead, he smiled—a knowing smile.

"You're wrong. This contract is different. The position they're signing you for is Hunter Director. Other than reporting to the board, the entire House Faction's Hunters fall under your command. How a mission is run, you have final say—the so-called CEO in charge of operations doesn't carry any weight in front of the Hunter Director. If that's not freedom, what is?"

He paused, then added: "You're still young. You don't understand. Only power can bring freedom."

Occasionally, he managed to say something that caught Taylor off guard.

"Besides, you don't know the annual salary they're offering."

The figure his father named next gave even Taylor pause—it was so absurd that for a moment he thought he'd misheard.

"No, that's exactly the number."

Han Ford spoke in a tone that made it seem like he was about to float right out of the driver's seat: "And that's just the base salary—the most basic part of it. There are also various incentive structures, profit shares, equity stakes, and other terms... Once this ten-year contract is done, we can both retire—you and me."

Taylor felt as if a bucket of cold water had been dumped over him. "How many years?"

"I know, ten years sounds like a long time. But if you don't sign this contract and just take ordinary work, ten years from now you might still be running the Nest over and over."

At that, his father suddenly let out a long breath.

"Do you think I can rest easy watching my own child go into such a dangerous place, again and again? Every time you're in the Nest, I don't sleep a single night—the anguish of it, I'd take your place if I could. Do ten years, and after that, we're done for good. Your mother is gone. In this world, it's just the two of us, father and son. Dad doesn't want to outlive his own child."

Taylor was silent in the back seat for a moment.

"...Their terms are too good. It doesn't make sense."

After a long pause, he said quietly: "I'm not some three-headed, six-armed super being. If it's just going into the Nest and finding Artifacts, no Hunter in the world is worth that price. Morgan House Faction must have other motives."

"What else did they say—outside the contract?"

Han Ford had seemed ready to argue back, but at those last words, he suddenly stilled.

"They did say one thing: if you're interested in accepting the contract, they'd want to speak with you privately. Whatever they need to discuss would be confidential, of course... I didn't think much of it at the time. Why don't you go talk to them?"

Even with a blood parent involved, when it came to certain Hunter matters, the House Faction would only disclose things to Taylor directly.

Taylor thought it over.

"Set up a time with Carter Morgan," he instructed his father. "Whatever can't be put in the contract—have him tell me in person."

When the timelines of all four characters converge, that is when the main storyline will surface.

Chapter 57: What Taylor Ford and Wellesley Know

Carter Morgan was approaching fifty, the brown curls atop his head beginning to thin, though they were still combed smooth and neat, spiraling against his pink scalp.

Just as Taylor Ford had anticipated, his every move carried the unhurried ease of a man who had long since turned privilege into habit—and he knew it himself, knew that his standing was different.

Perhaps it was precisely that self-awareness that made Carter's warmth and enthusiasm feel slightly unmoored and slippery; as though that air of familiarity, when practiced by him, sat just a little ill-fitted and overly intimate.

"I've heard so much about you,"

he said—and unlike most people, he didn't miss a beat when he first laid eyes on Taylor Ford; as he rose to his feet, Carter's face held only an expression of measured admiration: "I've long wanted to meet the finest Hunter in Blackmoor City today. Now that I have, I can say the trip was well worth it."

Taylor Ford glanced at the outstretched hand, lazily sank into the sofa, and only then raised his hand halfway into the air.

"Flatter me like that and I might actually believe it. Last time I checked the mirror, I still wasn't Superman."

Carter Morgan took it in stride, leaned down to shake his hand, and laughed instead: "To an ordinary person like me without a passage, you're close enough to Superman."

Taylor Ford gave him a sidelong glance.

Carter was the second generation of the Morgan family—unlike the founding generation before him, he had no passage.

But he had no desire for one either; he was perfectly content to be a director and major shareholder of a Hunter House Faction in the world of men—Taylor Ford knew perfectly well that for all his polite words, whether it was Hunters, financial analysts, or racehorses and racing dogs that made money for him made little difference to Carter Morgan.

A passage was valued simply because it could generate profit, like anything else in the world.

If you were already born into a class that lived off returns, who would willingly open a passage and enter the Nest, hanging by a thread in darkness and blood?

"I've already seen your contract—Han Ford showed it to me."

Taylor Ford curled his legs up on the sofa and said unhurriedly, "I told him the same thing: under normal circumstances, there isn't a Hunter in the world worth the price you're offering. I'm curious—once you sign me, what exactly do you plan to use me for?"

"I love talking to someone who gets straight to the point."

Carter Morgan said as he poured him a glass of whiskey. "Your father told me you're already inclined to sign, you just need to clear up a few doubts first—is that right?"

At this point, going back and forth over whether to sign seemed pointless.

Even if he turned down the Morgan House Faction, Han Ford would find him the next one—the Roselyn family, the Martin family, some other family—forget it. Ten years was all it was.

Ten years from now, at twenty-seven, he would never have to enter the Nest again.

Taylor Ford stared at the clear amber liquor in his glass and felt a faint urge to laugh.

He was seventeen now, not yet the legal drinking age, but no one would so much as blink at that—nor would anyone object to whatever he smoked or did—simply because, compared to any ordinary seventeen-year-old, he was worth more.

Money was the unit by which everything was measured.

Even the power that could bring freedom—when people possessed it, they would surely use it to get money. What else in the world could be any different?

Taylor Ford drained the glass in one go, then said: "Yes."

Carter Morgan's expression brightened slightly.

"Good, then we're on the same side." He took a sip of his drink, savored it slowly, and said: "...What I'm about to say is known only to you, me, and Wellesley himself."

Taylor Ford tilted his head—he hadn't expected to hear that name. "Wellesley? The one on the wealth rankings? What does he have to do with this?"

Carter turned toward the floor-to-ceiling windows of the high-rise, taking in the unobstructed night view of Blackmoor City and the distant sea still tinged with a faint, lingering crimson, and

deliberated for a moment before finally speaking.

"Wellesley has a piece of critical intelligence in his hands.

"He's kept every Hunter in Blackmoor City in the dark about it. As for me—I've only sensed that this intelligence exists, but I don't know its actual contents."

"Then how do you know he has it?"

"When a man has something to gain, he acts accordingly."

Carter Morgan smiled, revealing a row of closely set teeth. "It was precisely his increasingly frequent moves lately that piqued my curiosity, so I made a few discreet inquiries...and arrived at this theory."

Taylor Ford turned the words over in his mind and asked, "What did you find out?"

"You know that Wellesley himself has no passage, right?" Carter asked, catching him off guard.

Seeing Taylor Ford nod, he continued: "He and I are the same kind of person—I know very well neither of us is cut out to be a Hunter. But I've heard that he recently plans to quietly put out an anonymous request into Hunter circles through an intermediary—he wants a passage.

"When I first heard it, I was taken aback. Isn't a passage something you're born with? You either have one or you don't. And on top of that, he doesn't want anyone to know that the one seeking a passage is him personally...I honestly don't know how to make sense of it."

Carter shook his head and said, "But the fact that Wellesley has had this thought perhaps suggests that acquiring a passage after birth isn't entirely impossible."

"What does he want a passage for?" Taylor Ford asked.

Honestly, what did it matter to him whether the richest man wanted a passage or not?

But facing his future employer, he had to ask a question or two, just to show he was paying attention.

Carter smiled and said, "I don't know. That alone is strange enough—would Wellesley entering the Nest not be walking into his own death? But beyond that, there's something even stranger."

Before responding, Taylor Ford first reached into his pocket and pulled out a small plastic zip-seal bag.

He slowly tipped the curled green leaves wrapped around crystal fragments inside onto a rolling paper and said, "Don't mind me—I like the rolling process."

Carter nodded and smiled.

"When I was your age, I had to do it on the sly. Times were different back then—there were no dispensaries everywhere like now. Getting hold of it was a real ordeal; you had to ask a friend to find someone, and after paying a fortune, you'd get it home only to find it was padded with shredded newspaper."

Taylor Ford smiled for the first time that day, and found that Carter actually had a bit of an ordinary person's touch about him.

He lit the roll, took a drag, and asked: "...What's the even stranger thing?"

Carter adjusted his posture and said, "He just placed a commission with the Morgan House Faction. Once you start, it'll be your job—I may as well tell you now ahead of time..."

"Wellesley has commissioned us to enter the Nest on the 13th of every month and search for an Artifact related to 'time' in the areas corresponding to St. Louis Hospital, Broom Street, and Blackmoor University Law Department."

Taylor Ford slowly raised his head and fixed his gaze on Carter, as though only now did something finally come into focus before him.

"...Impossible," he said quietly, then paused. "How does he know?"

"Exactly."

Carter seemed actually pleased to have finally caught his interest: "You're a Hunter—you know better than anyone that once you enter the Nest, where you go and what Artifacts you encounter are beyond human control or prediction.

"And yet Wellesley behaves as if he knows exactly when and what the Nest will produce—he only needs a Hunter to follow the map and retrieve it for him.

"He's not a Hunter. He once tried to build his own Hunter team, but it didn't go well, and eventually came to nothing.

"So you've hit on the key question: how did he come to know this intelligence?"

Carter hadn't finished.

"What's more, the commission he placed with the Morgan House Faction isn't the only one. From what I know, he previously placed another commission with someone else as well...but what exactly that one was for, I don't know. What does he want these two things for?"

Taylor Ford was silent for a moment, thinking.

The information Carter had provided was still very vague—enough to let one dimly make out a rough outline—but even just the outline was sufficient to convince anyone that Wellesley indeed knew something no one else did.

"Analyzing it by normal logic, I can assume that Wellesley has some kind of...let's call it 'intelligence.' After acquiring it, he formed a purpose.

"To achieve that purpose, he needs a passage and at least two Artifacts. Through some means, he has learned when and where these two Artifacts will appear from within the Nest...is that right?

"Looking at it this way, the crux of the matter is: what exactly can a passage and Artifacts bring him—that, apart from himself, no one in the world currently knows."

"Talking to you is a relief," Carter said, refilling both their glasses.

"So what do you want me to do?"

"Why, to fulfill Mr. Wellesley's wishes, of course," Carter laughed out loud.

Then he leaned forward, looked Taylor Ford in the eyes, and said slowly: "...And then take whatever he's truly after—and put it in our hands."

This wasn't something that could be done without entrusting it to the most capable Hunter.

That was what Carter told him, hand on his shoulder, with no shortage of praise; but Taylor Ford honestly didn't know whether he could call himself a capable Hunter, let alone the "most" capable.

It was just that the world sometimes seemed as though it had already been written and arranged by some unknowable, inscrutable force—and the role scripted for him was that of a "star Hunter."

For instance: less than two months after Taylor Ford took over the Morgan House Faction's Hunter affairs, and without having gone looking for it, the next lead about Wellesley came to him

from a finance worker with no passage—he hadn't even been trying to find one.

"Yes, it just happened. I came here to drink with a friend..."

The finance worker was a young woman named Amber, who, upon meeting Taylor Ford for the first time, was no exception—she faltered for a moment. Having already started speaking, she still looked as though she couldn't quite believe it and confirmed again: "You... you're really the new Hunter Director our House Faction hired?"

"Why would I lie to you? I never lie to girls."

Taylor Ford sat on the street outside the bar, tilting his face up toward her with a smile. "Do you drink often?"

"Not really," said Amber, still faintly flushed from the alcohol: "It was to celebrate something... My friend likes drinking even less than I do—she stepped out for some air partway through. In those few minutes, the last SUV in a convoy suddenly lost control, almost as if someone had shoved it, and drove straight into the back door, nearly hitting my friend. Look—the door's bent now, won't close properly."

Taylor Ford looked over at the back door of the bar.

By the time he arrived at the scene, the car had already been towed; but judging from the marks, the manner in which it had lost control was indeed very unnatural.

"And your friend is?"

"Oh, she's not a Hunter from our House Faction—she goes into the Nest on her own, runs small jobs. Her name is Sydney Ginn. She's still inside the bar right now, probably chatting with someone—she ran into a guy who seems to quite like her."

Women, regardless of age, seemed unable to stop themselves from exchanging a few extra words with Taylor Ford—though he didn't know whether it would prove useful, he committed the name "Sydney Ginn" to memory.

"The person who got out of the car was a bodyguard."

Amber described the convoy's immediate reaction at the time, as well as the details about the bodyguard, and then added: "I felt like I'd seen him somewhere before—after a moment, I suddenly remembered: he'd come to our company once before—as Wellesley's personal bodyguard."

When Wellesley commissioned Morgan House Faction, he came in person—at that time, Taylor Ford had not yet taken over as Hunter Director, but she was aware of it.

Amber tucked her short hair behind her ear, revealing one pointed, slightly elfin ear.

"I recognized him, but he didn't recognize me—he never noticed me standing to the side watching. Later a colleague came to meet him, and I heard with my own ears the colleague say, 'The boss is going to pick something up.' Right then I thought, no wonder that convoy was so heavily guarded—was Wellesley about to collect an Artifact? If so, maybe I should say something to Jane Lynch..."

Taylor Ford glanced at the time on her phone screen.

According to Amber, the crash had happened twenty minutes ago—fortunately she and Jane Lynch were close; and Jane Lynch's instincts happened to be sharp enough that she'd notified her in time.

There was still time...

A convoy that had just been given a scare not long ago would need to confirm whether the situation had truly changed; they probably wouldn't have managed to complete their original plan in such a short amount of time.

"This matter... have you told your friend about it?"

Amber shook her head.

Taylor Ford rose quietly to her feet and lifted her chin toward Jane Lynch, who was waiting to one side; she understood at once, turned immediately, and went to get the car.

"Sister Amber," he said lazily, flashing Amber a smile and speaking softly, "do me a favor, would you?"

Even the tips of Amber's ears turned red. "What kind of favor?"

"Just head home tonight—give your friend a chance to chat more with that guy."

Taylor Ford said this, then tilted his head and thought for a moment.

"This matter is a little sensitive where House Factions are concerned. If your friend asks about it, just tell her I was the one who told you not to say anything... and that it was after you came into work on Monday, when I came to you for information, that I told you not to tell anyone. Say it that way—can you do that?"

Amber glanced over at the bar.

"Since you're the Hunter Director of a House Faction, this is the House Faction's decision... I understand." She nodded, adding: "Sydney probably doesn't know yet that this convoy has any connection to Wellesley."

Ah, there's always so much chatter to share while I'm writing, but by the time I actually post, I've forgotten it all...

Wait! Just remembered one piece of chatter.

While writing this, I've been racking my brain to push the "sense of realism" to the absolute limit. It's not that I'm padding the story—it's that I feel if a world is fantastical in every corner, money and banknotes lose any sense of weight or reality...

But money is the main driving force of the Artifact-report world, which means I need to do my best to make everyone feel the magic of money (as if that's something that needs reminding).

So here's the problem.

How does a broke person write about a life of glittering excess?

I'm hoping we can crowdfund a way for the author to experience the high life—otherwise I might end up writing a scene where some CEO points at a rack of clothes and says, "Take down both of these rows for me."

Chapter 58: Taylor Ford Isn't the Only One Playing the Waiting Game

Jane Lynch rested one hand on the steering wheel, and as Taylor Ford climbed into the car, she glanced at him out of the corner of her eye.

That brief, cold look vanished without a trace the moment she dropped her eyelids—she was a consummate professional, and even if she had doubts and reservations, she wasn't about to let them show on her face in front of a new superior.

Jane Lynch only leaned forward to glance at the road ahead, then said, "Mr. Ford, there are no surveillance cameras in this area. Without cameras, how are we supposed to know which way they went?"

"Don't call me Mr. Ford—I'm not one."

Taylor Ford opened the map on his phone and replied, "Even if there were cameras, by the time we pulled the footage it'd be too late. We were never counting on that anyway."

"Then, can I call you 'Taylor?'" Jane Lynch paused, and finally couldn't hold back the barb, adding, "...and reserve 'Mr. Ford' for your father?"

An eleventh-grader who had parachuted into the position of Hunter Director on nothing but a name—and had even brought a father along when he joined the House Faction. Taylor Ford was young, not stupid; he knew perfectly well what people were saying behind his back.

"Call him whatever you like."

Every second passing was precious, yet Jane Lynch made no move to drive. Instead, she dropped a question at his feet: "So where are we going?"

Though not much time had passed since the incident, tracking Wellesley as he went to collect the Artifact was still an exceedingly thorny matter—to say nothing else, the moment the unexpected happened, his convoy had instantly scattered in all directions, precisely to prevent anyone from tailing them.

Moreover, beyond knowing that "Wellesley had been on the road twenty minutes ago," they had no other intelligence whatsoever. Where would they even begin to give chase?

"We don't know his destination; we don't know who he's handing off to or when..."

Jane Lynch ticked through the disadvantages one by one, stopping just short of saying "catching up with them is impossible." "I don't understand why we absolutely have to tail him while he picks up the Artifact. If we're discovered, it'll cause serious offense."

Carter Morgan's plan naturally wouldn't be broadcast throughout the House Faction—what was remarkable was that Jane Lynch, without knowing Carter's intentions, had still managed to report tonight's events to Taylor Ford in a timely manner.

She was a highly capable and perceptive person—no wonder she wasn't a Hunter herself, yet had risen to Hunter HR; and no wonder she had been watching Taylor Ford with such cold scrutiny all along.

Taylor Ford looked at the map.

Jane Lynch's point was actually fair; by ordinary means, there was simply no way to determine which direction Wellesley might have gone.

"Didn't you recently interview a Hunter who can detect Artifacts?" he asked out of the blue.

Jane Lynch started slightly, glancing at him.

"Yes—her name is Kingsley Roselyn. Because her detection range is too broad and too imprecise, I met with her once, but nothing's been finalized yet."

"A wide range has its advantages," Taylor Ford closed the map and said, "Call her. Whatever terms she wants, it doesn't matter—have her come over right now."

Jane Lynch frowned and didn't move.

"Ford—well, Taylor, we can't possibly drive her around block by block looking for Artifacts. Without knowing the destination, that's no different from searching for a needle in a haystack."

"Who said anything about going block by block?"

Taylor Ford didn't press her to make the call; instead, he picked up his own phone and checked a text message that had just come in—it was from Carter Morgan.

"Finding out where Wellesley is— isn't that simple enough?"

"How?" Jane Lynch stared steadily at him.

Taylor Ford already had the phone pressed to his ear; when the call connected, he gave Jane Lynch a smile and gestured for her to listen in.

"...Mr. Green?"

He reclined his seat, half-lying with his legs curled up, and said into the phone, "This is Taylor Ford, Hunter Director of Morgan House Faction. Mr. Morgan should have already reached out to you just now. Could you transfer me to your boss? I have an urgent matter and need to speak with Mr. Wellesley immediately."

Jane Lynch's eyes went wide—Taylor Ford had put the call on speaker.

"What kind of matter?" Green, the secretary on the other end, hesitated slightly, but did not say that Wellesley was not nearby.

"Tell him it concerns the matter of 'time.'" Taylor Ford added, "It's urgent."

While waiting for Secretary Green to connect the call, Taylor Ford had just pressed mute when Jane Lynch immediately asked, "What are you planning to do? You don't mean the way you're going about this is—"

"Exactly—if we don't know where he's headed, why not just ask the man himself?" Taylor Ford said, as if it were the most natural thing in the world.

Wellesley had no idea that Carter Morgan was quietly plotting to play the mantis-and-the-sparrow game on him.

Jane Lynch stared at him blankly. "This... isn't this too reckless? What information about a 'time' Artifact do we even have?"

She was quite straightforward—the truth, sometimes, might not be convenient to state; but making up some so-called urgent piece of intelligence was entirely up to his imagination, wasn't it?

Wellesley couldn't very well go into the Nest himself to verify it.

If he had any particular talent, Taylor Ford thought it was probably his ability to make something completely made-up sound utterly convincing. Even Wellesley—who was at this very moment on his way to collect an Artifact—couldn't help but be drawn into hesitation after hearing him out: "...Right now? I'm on the road right now, it's not convenient."

"That's fine,"

Taylor Ford said with great consideration: "Why don't you give me a location, and I'll go wait there. As long as Mr. Wellesley can stop on his way back and spare me five minutes, that'll be enough for us to determine our next move."

The last half of that sentence, at least, wasn't a lie.

Wellesley was indeed very cautious—even with a cooperating Hunter House Faction, he hadn't let slip his current whereabouts; perhaps it was because one of his escort vehicles had come under an inexplicable attack earlier, putting him on high alert.

But even having been given that scare, he was still dead set on completing this transaction tonight, which said a great deal about how important that Artifact was.

"I'll have Green send you an address. Thirty minutes from now,"

Wellesley got that far, when someone nearby seemed to murmur something to him in a low voice, and he corrected himself: "No—one to two hours from now, I'll be there."

Taylor Ford had the impression that the person in the background had said something like "needs to be verified."

Verify what?

The only thing that seemed to need verifying was the Artifact he was about to get his hands on.

In other words, he hadn't yet taken possession of the Artifact, so he was leaving time to verify it—and the time needed for that verification might very well turn out to be longer than Wellesley had initially estimated. Much longer.

As long as they had an address, the rest wouldn't be difficult.

"Use this address as the center, with a radius of thirty minutes' drive in every direction—send a helicopter up right now to do a few sweeps, look for his security convoy, look for wherever there's heavy security presence. We'll drive over too."

Taylor Ford's instructions were swiftly carried out by Jane Lynch this time—even though she still didn't fully understand why the Hunter Director wanted to tail a client.

"And what about Kingsley Roselyn?" After dispatching the helicopter, Jane Lynch this time proactively picked up her phone and asked, "I'll call her now. How should we arrange her?"

"She's just a backup option—just have her come."

When Taylor Ford said this, he hadn't yet foreseen that he was making a mistake. "Even if we don't need her tonight, the House Faction will need someone like her in the future."

Jane Lynch quickly got through to her and relayed Taylor Ford's words in full, even making a point of adding, "It's our House Faction's Hunter Director—he has high expectations of you"—after all, flattery is a universal solvent.

"Mm? Yes, whatever terms you name, we can meet them... Right. We can even double it."

Jane Lynch continued, emphasizing, "But our requirement is that you get to us within thirty minutes from now—there's a situation that may require your help."

Over the car's speakerphone came Kingsley Roselyn's voice, which always seemed cheerful. "What's the address?"

Jane Lynch glanced at Taylor Ford; he thought it over and nodded.

She gave the location, and after two seconds of silence on the line, Kingsley spoke up: "Ah, I'm sorry—I can't make it over there."

Jane Lynch immediately frowned—she gave a sharp honk at the car ahead before saying into the phone, "Where are you right now? I can send a helicopter to pick you up."

"Ah, I'm sorry, I really can't get away right now," Kingsley paused, as though actually regretful, "...does joining up really have to be tied to tonight?"

Just before Jane Lynch could speak again, Taylor Ford placed a hand on her arm.

She turned her face toward him; Taylor Ford shook his head and mouthed silently: "Hang up."

"What is it?" Jane Lynch quickly ended the call and asked.

Any Hunter who had survived the Nest had to possess the ability to glean warnings and hints from the faintest of clues—a skill that, having begun as conscious analysis, had long since been refined into pure instinct; the more exceptional the Hunter, the less they would ignore even the most hair-thin sense of something being off.

"Someone's with her," Taylor Ford said, with a certainty that left almost no room for doubt.

Jane Lynch paused. "...How do you know?"

That was hard to say.

Intuition is an elusive, hazy thing—like mist, it disperses at a touch, and it's difficult to pin down in words, let alone pull apart and analyze piece by piece.

It could have been that Kingsley paused before both of her answers; it could have been that she hesitated for a moment and didn't reveal her location.

It could also have been that Taylor Ford heard the faint rustle of her collar as she turned her head—as though she were looking at someone—but taken together, these phantom-like clues, however subconsciously caught, would sound a bit like grasping at straws if brought out into the open.

"...Because I'm very good at lying," Taylor Ford finally offered this as his answer, "so I could tell she wasn't being straight with us either."

Whether that persuaded Jane Lynch, he didn't know; but she accepted the explanation for the time being.

"So what do we do next...?"

"It's fine—keep going."

Taylor Ford remained curled up in his seat like a large cat, his voice loose and unhurried: "Having someone with her doesn't necessarily mean anything. Let alone people in our line of work—anyone alive in this world never knows what's happening out there in the great wide world at any given moment, or what might come knocking and turn their life upside down. But none of that matters. Whatever comes, we deal with it."

Jane Lynch was quiet for a moment, then gave a wry laugh: "You... don't seem like someone your age at all."

"Is that so?"

Taylor Ford looked up and smiled at her profile. "They say the brain doesn't fully develop until you're twenty-five—maybe I'm still a fool right now. Do you want to see what I'm like at twenty-five? If you do, then you can't quit on me."

Nearly two months into the job, it was the first time he had seen Jane Lynch laugh from the heart.

"You know," she said, eyes on the road, "I actually have a passage too."

"Oh?"

Jane Lynch said in the easy tone of a friend chatting, "But I'm not like you. I only took one look at the Nest, and I knew—I can't be a Hunter. I fear the Nest, I loathe the Nest, and I have no

confidence that I'd make it back alive the next time, which is why I chose to work only within Blackmoor City.

"...This world is strange," she mused. "Something like a passage doesn't necessarily find its way to the people suited for it."

Taylor Ford found himself thinking of Wellesley—and of the bounty he had not yet put out, the standing offer to acquire passages.

Whatever Carter Morgan's plans were, Wellesley remained Morgan House Faction's most important client — and in Blackmoor City, the last person anyone should think of crossing.

Even if he located Wellesley, that didn't mean Taylor Ford could make a move on the transaction, let alone cut it off — the timing was far from right.

But finding out what he'd bought, and what that thing was for, was not entirely out of reach.

Getting to the bottom of it didn't even require disturbing Wellesley himself.

After all, there were two people in the know in any transaction.

"Found him,"

the helicopter pilot's reply came through Taylor Ford's earpiece a little over ten minutes later — fast enough to catch him off guard. "Where Wellesley went is a private dock where his cruise ship is moored."

If word of tonight's deal hadn't leaked in a way that felt almost as if someone had given it a push, the transaction site would have been perfectly safe and convenient — nearly forgot: billionaires inhabit a world of their own.

"No need to keep following," Taylor Ford checked the time on his phone and said: "The deal should be taking place on the cruise ship. Post a few people on the road outside the dock and watch for whoever goes in after him — get me the license plate and model."

Barring the unexpected, the other party to the transaction should be the first to leave the cruise ship as well.

In other words, as long as Taylor Ford waited outside the dock, he would get to see the Hunter who left after completing the deal with Wellesley — and once he confirmed that person's identity, he could get there ahead of them to the location Wellesley had arranged, and keep spinning stories for the billionaire.

Taylor Ford got out of the car, pulled the hood of his hoodie up, and let the shadow fall over half his face.

He sat on the hood of the engine, gazing across the water at the undulating skyline and lights of Blackmoor City, white smoke curling from between his fingers before dissolving into the dark.

Now it was just a matter of waiting.

But Taylor Ford hadn't expected that the first person to show up would be someone he hadn't anticipated at all.

When another black Mercedes slowly pulled to a stop in the middle of the road beside him, Taylor Ford only turned to glance over — he hadn't even had time to make out the face of the person pushing open the car door — yet something like a physiological instinct of revulsion hit him like a current, making his brow twitch.

A tall figure in a suit straightened up outside the car door and slammed it shut with a bang.

Chase Monroe stood in the darkness, gazing toward the distant dock, not sparing Taylor Ford so much as a glance, and slowly broke into a smile.

This chapter's going up pretty early, right! That's because I was grinding away at it until midnight last night. I have no idea how people manage daily updates over ten thousand characters — four thousand is already killing me.....

Yesterday's author's note got me a subway ticket and a bubble tea, and I'm planning to save them all up into a "Artifact Report Field Research Fund," so that by the time the story wraps up, I can actually go out and gather some inspiration (not really).

Chapter 59: Taylor Ford and the Other — Lying in Wait

Taylor Ford was still sitting on the hood of the car. He glanced at the newcomer, then turned his head away and didn't get down.

"...Don't tell me the people on that boat are yours?"

"Don't say stupid things."

Chase Monroe seemed entirely unbothered by the fact that his car was sitting in the middle of the road — though there weren't many cars on the stretch leading to the private dock ahead, and it was the dead of night besides; Taylor Ford's fleeting hope that a patrol car might happen to pass and write him a ticket had to be quietly set aside.

"If the ones making the deal with Wellesley were us, do you think I'd let you sit here?"

"Then where would you have me sit? In Ronan Key's chair?"

Taylor Ford fired back with his mouth, but inside he couldn't stop the irritation gnawing at him.

...How did he know?

The fact that Wellesley had a deal tonight had been kept from all of Blackmoor City.

Taylor Ford had only learned of it less than an hour ago — acting on intelligence that had come to him by chance — and had improvised his moves one step at a time, barely arriving here himself. So where exactly had this man picked up the scent and followed him here like a hyena?

He very much wanted to know, but he was even less willing to ask.

He kept a stony expression. After a moment of silence, Taylor Ford let out a cold laugh. "... So it was Kingsley Roselyn. Someone was actually willing to board that sinking ship of yours? She'd better never think about jumping ship again."

"Oh? Figured that out yourself?" Chase asked. "Without a tutor?"

There was actually one part he hadn't figured out — for instance, even if Kingsley Roselyn knew their location, how had Chase known that Wellesley was dealing with a third party — but there was no way Taylor Ford would ask about it now.

Besides, this man was the type who, the moment he got even a scrap of a lead, would clamp down and never let go. He'd gone into the wrong line of work — he should've been a snapping turtle.

Taylor Ford only bothered with one question: "Happy being your godfather's dog?"

Chase didn't get angry; he smiled, a flash of white teeth in the dark.

"Happier than having a real father who's a dog."

"...Hunter business has nothing to do with you. You don't understand it. Go home."

"How could I do that? Someone has to be the adult who cleans up after you make a mess." Chase fixed him with a look, then glanced down with a quiet smile. "...You're used to that by now, aren't you."

Taylor Ford had never paid attention to the color of Chase's eyes; but right now, in the darkness, Chase's eyes were like a pair of hard, polished obsidian stones, sunk deep beneath his brow, as though they were swallowing the surrounding night.

Compared to a human being, he sometimes seemed closer to a Resident — here he was, standing in Blackmoor City, and yet it was as if he cast a long Resident's shadow on the ground.

Perhaps because that feeling had taken root in him, Taylor Ford found his own body growing tenser with every step Chase took toward him.

Though he hadn't made any conscious effort, he had almost imperceptibly been shifting his angle, positioning himself to face Chase as squarely as he could, every muscle coiled and ready to spring at a moment's notice.

Jane Lynch was handling the deployment of personnel at the rear section of the road; here, Taylor Ford was alone.

If a confrontation broke out with Chase here...

"Relax. If I wanted to move on you, bracing yourself wouldn't help." Chase lifted his chin toward Taylor Ford's hands. "Just need a light."

"Don't have one."

Cursing under his breath, Taylor Ford looked down at the burning paper roll in his hand — feel free to try rubbing sticks together. "You should get out of here."

"Oh?"

"The people who made the deal with Wellesley haven't come off the boat yet,"

Taylor Ford threw the paper roll on the ground, exhausting what little patience he possessed in the name of overriding his adolescent temper, and said: "Your car's sitting in the middle of the road, sticking out like the Loch Ness Monster. What do you need a light for — to fire a signal flare and warn them not to come out?"

Most Hunters in Blackmoor City, if they happened to be driving in the middle of the night and suddenly saw a Chase in their headlights, knew trouble was coming.

"Afraid I'll ruin things for you?" Chase turned to look down the road toward the dock. "I'm a very reasonable person."

Taylor Ford swallowed a retort.

"If I knew what I might be ruining for you, I certainly wouldn't still be standing in the middle of the road."

...As much as he didn't want to admit it, Chase Monroe had no passage, yet he'd gotten where he was in the Hunter world today not purely because he was willing to be his foster father's dog.

As Carter Morgan had put it, "Where there's something to gain, there's something to do"; and once a person acts, they leave traces.

Chase had used his innate turtle-like talent to sniff out something different from the usual in Morgan House Faction's movements tonight — in other words, his target wasn't only Wellesley's trading partner; he was also probing into Morgan House Faction's intentions and plans.

If you thought about it deeper, he might even have had Morgan House Faction in his sights for some time already.

He would indeed have made a good Hunter.

Which was exactly why he absolutely could not have a passage.

"This matter has nothing to do with Key House Faction."

Taylor Ford's expression went cold. "Someone's been poaching Morgan House Faction's business. We're cleaning up the trash — it's a private house matter. You'd better think carefully about whether Key House Faction really needs to stick their hand in tonight."

"Nonsense."

Chase looked out toward the distant dock. "When you saw me just now — first thing you asked was whether the people on the boat were from Key House Faction, wasn't it? Which means you don't know who's on the boat either."

Taylor Ford wasn't the type to be caught by something like that.

"Is this your first time out here? If someone dares to cross us, obviously they have someone backing them up. The moment I followed, you just happened to show up here." He let out a cold laugh. "Nothing in this world happens that conveniently. Of course I was going to ask."

Chase looked at Taylor Ford with an expressionless face — as if there was something he himself couldn't quite be sure of.

"That's a fair point."

But after a pause, Chase's next words were: "Too bad — even if you told me you were a human being, I'd need to see an autopsy report before I believed you."

Taylor Ford instantly jumped down from the hood, walked around Chase, and yanked open the driver's door.

"Then stand there all you like," he said. "I'd like to see what you manage to get out of it."

The car door slammed shut with a bang, cutting off whatever response the other man might have had.

Though Chase was now an added variable, tonight's situation was still in Morgan House Faction's control.

For one thing, with Taylor Ford keeping watch, Chase couldn't snatch away the trading partner.

For another, even if the trading partner spotted Chase and turned back, the Hunters and helicopter Taylor Ford had deployed in the area could keep tailing them and identify who they were — more complications, yes, but it would also draw things away from the dock, making it less likely to alert Wellesley.

Even if Wellesley grew suspicious afterward, everything could be pinned on Key House Faction... even the trading partner themselves would assume it was Key House Faction chasing them.

So from another angle, Chase's appearance was actually a good thing: he had become a cover for Morgan House Faction.

That said, asking a seventeen-year-old boy to swallow that kind of frustration without complaint was actually asking a lot of Taylor Ford.

He looked out through the half-lowered car window.

Chase had walked back to the middle of the road — his tall silhouette was leaning against the hood of that black Mercedes, arms crossed, apparently set on turning tonight into a hand of shuffled cards.

Whatever he was planning to do next, both of them could only wait for now.

The night settled back into silence, the distant lights on the water a faint glimmer far away.

After a while, Taylor Ford instinctively reached into his trouser pocket — then remembered that his last hand-rolled cigarette was the one he'd just thrown on the ground.

He hesitated, which was rare for him: going out to pick it up seemed a bit undignified.

But not picking it up and just sitting there dumbly in the car, motionless, not even able to look at his phone — that felt unbearable too. He was still only seventeen, after all; even knowing he'd likely be fighting for his life before long, if he was bored now, he was bored.

Taylor Ford craned his neck to look out the car window again.

Did middle-aged people somehow not get bored?

Chase hadn't moved in so long that Taylor Ford was beginning to wonder if he'd fallen asleep — then, just at that moment, Chase stood up, walked around to the side of the car, and reached through the window with one hand.

When he straightened up again, he was holding what looked like a heavy rod with a T-shaped top; at the same moment, music started playing from inside the black Mercedes.

Chase smiled at Taylor Ford without a sound — as though tearing a wound open through the dim nothingness.

He swung the T-bar idly in one hand, pacing through the night to the vocals that spread like mist in the dark, and leaned against the hood again.

The night paused for a beat, then a wind-on-the-highway rhythm came rushing in, strong enough to feel like it could blow your hair back.

I've been dreamin' about the West Coast

Where the people take it real slow

Chase's silhouette remained still as a carved statue; only if you watched carefully would you notice that the toe of his shoe was quietly nodding along with the beat, just slightly.

Taylor Ford held it back, then couldn't — a short sound escaped through his nose, half a sneer, half something almost like amusement.

If even a middle-aged man had started listening to music, picking up one little cigarette was hardly a big deal.

Taylor Ford pushed the car door open and set one foot on the road; and it was at exactly that moment that a car swung out from around a corner up ahead, its headlights cutting bright and sharp through the dark.

...Was this it?

Taylor Ford swept one arm up and snatched an iron chain he'd prepared earlier from the car roof; he didn't turn his head, but heard a muffled thud, and in the corner of his eye the tall figure had already leaped onto the car hood.

The moment it finished turning the corner, the oncoming car lurched as if startled, swerving sharply off the road. In a screech of tires that seemed to strike sparks from the night itself, the car veered wildly off the road as though its driver had lost all composure — Taylor Ford's mind had barely formed the thought "did they see Chase?" before he realized something was wrong.

They were too far away. The driver shouldn't have been able to make out Chase clearly, let alone be frightened enough to swerve like that.

That person must have spotted something else —

The thought hadn't finished forming when, from a low, dark, silent building by the road, a tremendous blast tore open the night; the darkness collapsed inward, and a ball of fire bloomed.

The next second, the car was hurled high into the sky like a toy flung by a child's hand, riding the fireball and the shockwave up into the dark above.

All I wanna do is fly

Take me where the sun shines

I've been sleeping badly lately, staying up until the small hours every night — it's been rough...

I think I finally understand why I write so slowly. I'm just an amateur web novelist, but I've somehow developed the delusion that I'm a film director. I'll be writing along, and then I absolutely have to go find background music — I spent half an hour digging through playlists before deciding that "West Coast" was right and I had to get it into the chapter.

The lyrics fit perfectly — very fitting, very ironic, and they suit Chase's background. The rhythm is a little fast, maybe, but it works. This scene isn't long; it's just a few shots (lol).

Went to the gym yesterday and spotted a familiar-looking incredibly handsome guy — I barely came up to his shoulder, he must be at least 2.1 meters? I couldn't help sneaking a few extra glances, and he caught me — so awkward. I immediately told myself: someone that good-looking is definitely gay. Instant peace of mind, completely calm, no more awkwardness.

What's wrong with me looking a couple times, honestly.

Chapter 60: Taylor Ford, This Matter, and Its Connection to Key House Faction

...Should it be said that he was shocked at this moment?

Yes, surprised he certainly was — the person who should have fallen into his hands at that very moment had, together with the car, suddenly gone flying high into the sky. Anyone would have been surprised.

But Taylor Ford found that even as the shock hit him, there was a simultaneous sense of calm — as though this was not entirely unexpected: the surprise surged up, and then, as the car crashed thunderously down in the distance, it was already a done fact.

Because when he thought carefully about it, this was almost destined to happen, wasn't it?

He just hadn't expected it to happen so fast, so violently, so recklessly.

As if the person who had made the decision to kill understood perfectly well that the laws and rules governing Blackmoor City did not apply to him — and that he had no intention of letting them restrain him.

The weapon that had sent the car flying — Taylor Ford had seen it with his own eyes before.

A single kiss from a bazooka rocket launcher had caused the car to explode on the spot, like a blossom of steel fireworks opening in midair; the flames spread along the spilled gasoline, burning half the road a blazing red — after a strike like that, no one inside the car could have survived. It was already too late for everything.

The person who had fired the shell from inside the building — due to the limited field of vision caused by the angle of the road — likely hadn't noticed the two cars on the road behind.

So the most important thing now was to leave the scene immediately...

He had only just thought this far when, from the low building beneath the night sky, a rapid succession of shots rang out — "bang, bang, bang" — much sharper and crisper than the sound of the bazooka earlier, seemingly from a rifle.

Strange —

In that instant, Taylor Ford suddenly understood.

Just as he immediately turned and sprinted off the road, a dark figure also gave chase from behind.

"...Is that Wellesley?"

In the blink of an eye, Chase had already lunged to his side — even though he'd been half a road's length behind Taylor Ford a moment ago — and his breathing sounded completely unhurried.

So this one had also figured it out, Taylor Ford cursed inwardly. A real bastard, just as expected.

Hit dead-on by the bazooka, both the car and the driver had been reduced to smoldering wreckage — not even a god could have escaped; yet the sniper had still switched to a rifle and fired several shots into the night. There was only one explanation for that.

Someone had jumped out of the car before the bazooka flipped it.

Which meant that if he went over there right now, he might still find a living witness — or at worst, a clue to the dead person's identity. But running toward where the car had tumbled and crashed was the same as running straight into the sniper's crosshairs.

In case the sniper hadn't yet left, both men, without a word between them, began threading through the gaps between the nearby walls, warehouses, and other man-made structures, crouching low as they closed the distance.

Taylor Ford considered his own skills to be quite good, but Chase's were nearly "inhuman" — and to keep Chase from reaching the scene before him, Taylor Ford had no choice but to squeeze out enough breath to speak as he ran: "...If it wasn't him, could it have been you?"

"Interesting," Chase replied, just those two words.

He crouched behind a low wall and waited two seconds; seeing that the low building across the road remained completely silent, he suddenly sprang up and lunged forward.

Taylor Ford was shorter than him and couldn't match his stride, but being slower had its advantages: as long as he followed in Chase's wake and traced his exact path, he could stay out of the sniper's line of sight from the building across the road — and within a minute or two, the two of them, one ahead of the other, had drawn close to the section of road burning in fierce flames.

The night was set flickering by the fire, its face shifting between light and shadow; the buildings around the dock were dragged out of the darkness by the firelight one moment, then pushed back into the night the next, as though they were taking turns watching the spectacle.

Even the air was distorted by the heat. Taylor Ford stood behind a piece of cover, sweeping his gaze again and again across the shifting light and shadow, until at last, in the darkness cast by an overhanging eave, he spotted a pair of legs lying limp and motionless — he had barely jumped up when he saw Chase lunge toward the same spot at the same moment.

The person was lying face-up on the ground, covered in blood, impossible to tell where exactly they'd been hit.

In truth, a single glance was enough to see that there wasn't much time left — there was no saving them: tears clouded their eyes, their mouth hung half-open, and as the two men's shadows fell across their face, a wet, gurgling sound rose from their throat — blood and air bubbles churning together.

"You just made a deal with Wellesley, didn't you?" Taylor Ford crouched down beside the person and said quietly: "The ambulance is on its way. Hold on — answer me."

Chase lifted his eyes and glanced at him.

Taylor Ford leaned closer and called out to the injured person again: "Hey, listen to my voice, don't close your eyes. Did you just make a deal with Wellesley?"

The man seemed to be barely held in place by the sound of a human voice; from between his half-parted lips, a breath escaped — and it sounded, just possibly, like a single word: "Yes..."

"What did you sell him?"

Even with Chase right there listening, he had to get this information — because the dying Hunter before him was, aside from Wellesley himself, likely the only person in Blackmoor City who knew about this transaction.

This wasn't Wellesley's first time doing business with a Hunter, but it was the first time he had killed to silence someone afterward.

What kind of Artifact would make him willing to move against a Hunter?

Wellesley had also placed a commission with Morgan House Faction, but he couldn't possibly silence one of Blackmoor City's largest House Factions afterward — the shockwaves from that

would be far too great, tantamount to a localized war.

In other words, the Artifact traded tonight had one fundamental difference from every other Artifact that had been traded or was about to be traded — but what was it?

Why was Wellesley unafraid to let people know he possessed other Artifacts, yet unwilling to let anyone know he possessed this particular one?

The dying Hunter's mind seemed to have already begun to scatter; Taylor Ford had no idea whether he had understood at all.

His eyes stayed fixed and unmoving on Chase's face, and from deep within a throat full of blood, he said faintly: "Key... Key House..."

Taylor Ford was startled, and immediately shot a glance at Chase.

Unexpectedly, Chase's expression looked as though he had just been struck across the face — caught completely off guard, he instinctively asked: "What?"

That momentary daze made Taylor Ford freeze as well.

Chase actually appeared more surprised than he was, as if he had never expected the words "Key House" to come from a dying Hunter's lips.

The world truly was strange — always twisting and turning, each link connected to the next. Originally, Taylor Ford had thought Chase's appearance here tonight was an aggravating complication; if he could turn back time, he would never have made that call to Kingsley Roselyn.

Yet at this very moment, it was precisely because Chase was here in person that Taylor Ford had been able to catch his first, unguarded, unmasked reaction — and turn it into a critical clue.

"Key... Key House..."

The dying Hunter seemed to want only to release the last word from his chest back into the world; he could no longer hear their shock and confusion, and had no strength left to explain.

But how could this matter possibly be connected to Key House Faction?

If it was, how could even Chase not know?

Wait — Key —

Taylor Ford's heart suddenly gave a lurch, and his mind lit up in a flash of clarity; he immediately bit down hard on his lip and dropped his gaze to the dying man on the ground, so

that he wouldn't let anything slip that Chase might catch.

He understood now what the man meant.

What he had said was not "Key House" (Keys), but "key" (key).

It was only because he was at death's door, blood flooding his windpipe, that his voice had grown muffled and ragged with a hissing wheeze — making the two sound virtually indistinguishable.

Had Taylor Ford not already known that Key House Faction had no business being part of this, he too would have been misled.

But this had not yet been noticed by Chase.

As the saying goes, concern breeds confusion — being part of Key House, suddenly hearing the faction's name spoken from a dying man's mouth, it was obvious Chase's thoughts had been led down the wrong path; he was already pressing: "What about Key House? What does it have to do with your deal?"

But the Hunter gave no more answers.

He stared wide-eyed, looking through both of them as if they weren't there, as if he had already passed beyond them and was gazing at the vast sky above.

Taylor Ford stood up.

He had lingered long enough — Wellesley's people would be arriving soon to clean up, and he needed to leave this place of trouble as quickly as possible.

But before leaving, there was still one thing he had to do: he could not let Chase keep thinking, could not give him the chance to piece it together.

After all, once the answer was revealed, it was actually quite simple — what he had to work with was nothing more than a misunderstanding.

So Taylor Ford needed to distract Chase, and then drive that misunderstanding deep into his mind, making him see only one side of the picture, letting it take root as a first impression — that way, even if Chase figured it out later, he would already have secured the advantage.

"As I thought... I always knew tonight's business couldn't be separated from your Key House Faction. What are you so surprised about? Don't tell me even you didn't know what was going on behind the scenes? That makes sense, I suppose — after all, you're not his real son."

He knew he was walking a tightrope right now.

The best way to lower someone's intelligence was to enrage them. But the other party was, after all, someone whose height, speed, and strength utterly outclassed his own...

Taylor Ford tightened his grip on the chain in his hand and smiled: "When I keep a dog, I don't brief it on every family affair either."

From within the blazing red night, Chase's shadow slowly rose, cutting off the wall of fire behind him.

Chase turned his face; his gaze landed on Taylor Ford.

That gaze had weight and texture — like sunken sand, like a dry and withered wind, like something seen through the glass of an old black-and-white photograph, drained of life; it felt as though neither the one looking nor the one being looked at belonged to this world.

The moment Taylor Ford knew he had successfully enraged Chase, something also tore away a chunk of his left chest — for one instant, he lost all feeling there, as if a black void had opened up right next to his heart.

Had a piece of flesh been ripped away?

The thought crossed his mind, but he dared not look down — because Chase would not give him another chance to raise his head.

If Taylor Ford had not twisted sideways in time just then, the place that now throbbed with a pain so fierce it had gone almost numb — that cold draft bleeding through the void — would have been his heart.

"While Han Ford is busy selling you out for money, he should also spend some on teaching you manners."

Only then did Taylor Ford see clearly that what had just struck him in the chest was the T-bar, which had somehow slipped back down into Chase's hand without his noticing.

He should have just brought a gun tonight —

Taylor Ford leaped sideways, swinging the chain in his hand in a sweeping arc across Chase's midsection; it rang out crisply in the air, like a whip made of hard sinew and bone. Chase neither dodged nor sidestepped — instead he dipped slightly forward, raised an arm to block, and when the chain came down with a sharp crack against his back and shoulder, he seized it with a reverse

grip and began to wind it around his arm, the chain coiling around him loop by loop like an obedient snake.

This was bad.

Those two words had barely surfaced in his mind when, before Taylor Ford could let go of the chain, Chase gave a sharp sideways yank and dragged him clean off the ground.

"You didn't bring a proper weapon tonight?"

Chase grabbed him by the chest, slammed him into the ground, and looked down at Taylor Ford with a grin. "Don't worry — if you die, I'll send your dad a little something in condolence."

The back of Taylor Ford's head hit the ground hard; he was rattled half-senseless by the impact, but still managed to force his knuckles up and swing a fist at Chase's eye — yet before it could connect, Chase caught his arm, gave a heave, and flung Taylor Ford away as casually as one would toss aside a blanket.

Taylor Ford tumbled and rolled several steps; as he pushed himself up on his arms to stand, his hands met something wet and soft. He looked back and found that he had landed squarely on top of the corpse.

The moment he realized he shouldn't have looked back, he also understood clearly that unless he rolled over the corpse, there was likely no avoiding the blow now bearing down on the back of his skull.

Taylor Ford's judgment was timely—by the time he gasped his way up from the ground, he was drenched in the dead man's blood, but at least none of it was his own; the back of his skull remained intact as well.

From the distant sky came a massive roar that wound and twisted through the night, and within a few breaths it had closed in from afar, pressing down over the two of them; sand and debris flew, and wild wind churned.

"When it comes to brute force, I can't match you,"

he said, eyes fixed on Chase as he stepped over the corpse, laughing as he slowly backed away: "...perfectly normal—how could a man ever beat a gorilla? But look, you don't have time to kill me tonight."

A brilliant column of light from the helicopter swept back and forth over the two of them several times; the cabin door opened, and someone shouted something indistinctly down toward them through the deafening roar of the rotors.

There was no need to make out exactly what was said, nor to look at the gun the person had trained downward—from the tone and sharpness of it alone, the warning was unmistakable. Chase glanced back at the helicopter, then raised one hand to gather his wind-tossed black hair back behind his head.

"Called the adults to take you home so soon?" he said, almost evenly. "Go on, then—next time you head out, don't forget to bring a babysitter."

Chase seemed entirely unconcerned that the person in the helicopter would shoot him in the back as he turned and left—though Taylor Ford indeed found it difficult to suppress that temptation.

But in the end he did not order Jane Lynch to act: tonight had already seen far too many unexpected turns, and Wellesley must have spotted this helicopter as well—he could not afford any further complications.

"I heard cannon fire and knew something had gone wrong. Fortunately, I wasn't too late."

Jane Lynch closed the helicopter door again, and as they gained altitude and left the scene, she studied Taylor Ford and asked, "What happened? Are you hurt?"

"Jane, I'm in so much pain I could die."

Taylor Ford pointed at his own chest, his face creased with misery. "Took a hit from a pole, smacked my head on the ground, and rolled around in blood. Though—it's not entirely bad news."

As he said this, he pulled a blood-soaked wallet from the pocket of his hoodie.

"Look—the man who was making the deal with Wellesley was quite considerate, leaving a wallet on him for me to find."